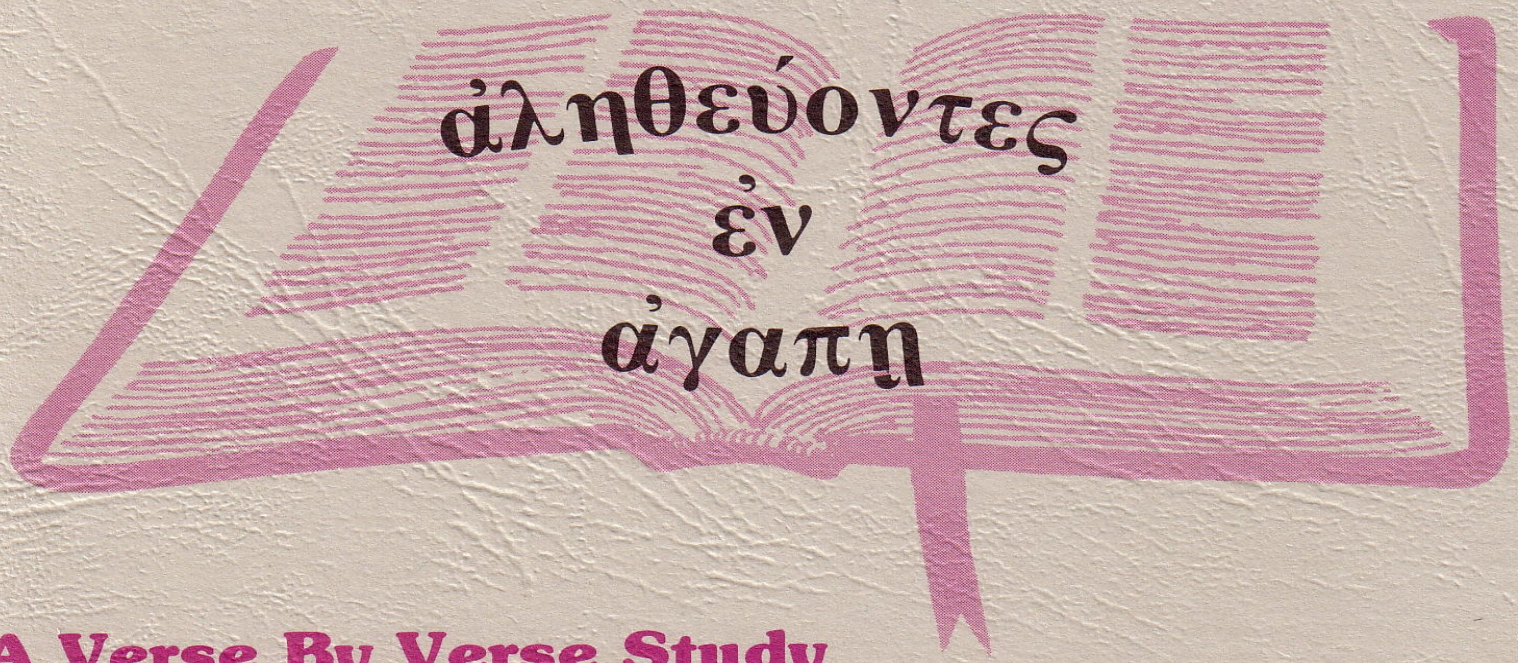
A Commentary Of

ROMANS

Chapters 1 - 8

Volume 1

Based On The Greek New Testament



A Verse By Verse Study

By

Ernest R. Campbell

ROMANS
Volume 1

Ernest R. Campbell, Th. D.

President, Canyonview Bible College & Seminary

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Ernest R. Campbell was born at Michigan, North Dakota, in 1915. His farm environment instilled in him the importance of hard work, gave a breadth of experience, and encourage independent thinking and initiative. He moved to Oregon in 1933. For four years he worked in the electrical and radio broadcasting fields.

He received his B. A. degree from the University of Oregon. His major was in English literature, which has strengthened his ability in Biblical interpretation. His B. A. also included a major (hours beyond B. A.) in psychology and two years of classical Greek. He earned his B. D. and Th. D. degrees from Northern Baptist Theological Seminary. His major Greek New Testament was under the renowned Greek scholar, Dr. Julius R. Mantey.

He has taught New Testament Greek at North Park College. He was Dean of the faculty at the Detroit Bible Institute where he taught beginner through advanced New Testament Greek. He has been the pastor of the Salem Bible Church for thirty years during which time his ministry has been based entirely on the Greek New Testament. Simultaneous with this he had taught private Greek classes prior to the beginning of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary.

The author was one of the founders of an evening school in 1973, which became the forerunner of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary. At this time he introduced a new natural method of teaching New Testament Greek, which is now enabling Canyonview students to teach directly from their Greek New Testaments.

As the president of Canyonview Bible College & Seminary the author's supreme burden is to equip students to literally teach the books of the Bible in a verse by verse manner. He is convinced that the ability to teach from the Greek New Testament is the most important single factor in accomplishing this end in an interesting and authoritative manner.

The author realistically recognizes that it is not possible for all Bible teachers to acquire competency in New Testament Greek. This is why he has written this commentary, the Second in a series on Paul's epistles, that the English reader may more fully share in the treasures of the Greek text!

PREFACE

If we affirm that the Bible is the inspired, infallible and authoritative Word of God, then we should teach it in a manner which will accurately convey what it says.

The New Testament consists of 27 letters and treatises written to churches and individuals. Each of these systematically presents what God the Holy Spirit says on various subjects.

When we receive a letter or an article from someone our natural procedure is to begin with page one and consecutively read each page until the end. We know that only this approach will enable us to accurately follow the author's train of thought.

If we need to take this approach in our private mail, follow the order in which it was written, shouldn't we take the same approach in studying what God has written to us in His word? Isn't it logical and reasonable to concentrate on that which God has written to us members of the Body of Christ, and to do it in a consecutive, verse by verse manner?

We are convinced that the expository, verse by verse method of studying and teaching the Scriptures is both logical and superior to all other methods. We trust that after you consider some of the advantages you will also enthusiastically adopt this most effective manner of teaching and preaching the Word!

First, to the greatest possible extent it *eliminates human c*ontrol of the Word of God. Other methods, wherein the teacher picks and chooses what he wants from the Bible, leave one at the mercy of the conglomerate passages assembled by the teacher. Prior to this picking and choosing, the teacher's human mind *determines* the topic and the Scriptural fragments which will be used to support it. Moving through the various epistles in an orderly consecutive manner allows God to determine both what is taught and the supporting evidence.

Second, the verse by verse method *keeps the teacher in the context*, an imperative for accurate teaching. The exact meaning of Greek words and phrases is inseparable from the contexts in which they are used. The flow of thought of the entire context suggests the specific meanings of its parts. Consecutive, expository teaching subordinates the meaning of each verse to the comprehensive thought of the surrounding context.

Third, as the teacher begins with the writer and successively follows verse by verse, he will be in the best possible position *to flow with his train of thought.* Any interruptions, such as even undue cross referencing, can cause one's hearers to lose the main thought of a passage. Furthermore, excessive knit-picking, which unduly slows the tempo of exegesis, tends to divert attention from the author's main point. Identification with the author, in a verse by verse manner, at the proper rate, will enable a teacher to be one with him in thinking.

Fourth, truth which is taught in an expository verse by verse manner will be *remembered better*. Individual truths, which are associated with a larger context, are remembered as an integral part of that context. For example, a context relates a story which contains many important truths - these are retained as parts of the story. This principle is properly called learning and remembering by association.

Fifth, consecutive expositional teaching produces *a Biblical balance*. As the Apostle Paul aggressively preached the Gospel of God's Grace, sinners were saved and churches were established. The Jews, who had previously been under the Law for some 1400 years, worshipped in synagogues. Ideally speaking, their Biblical balance was in the truth which God had specifically given to them, the Mosaic Law. Christians today, who are under Grace, worship God in local assemblies, extensions of the Church. God's purpose is that all who constitute the Church should be Biblically balanced in the specific Truth which He has given to the Church, the Gospel of God's Grace (Acts 20:24), commonly designated as the Mystery (Eph. 3:2-9). This Biblical balance is maintained by teaching the epistles written to the New Testament churches verse by verse.

Sixth, teaching in an orderly, expository manner enables a teacher to cover the *entire spectrum of truth for the Church*. Those who teach topically tend to limit what they teach to their own whims, personal preferences and to what they think will be most popular. For example, some properly emphasize the Truth of the Mystery, but on the other hand, they never teach the sovereignty of God as it relates to how God saves sinners (Rom. 8:28-30). Apart from successively teaching all the epistles written to the churches, we will fail to teach all the counsel of God written to Christians (Acts 20:27).

Seventh, exposing the literal-intended meaning of the Scriptures in a verse by verse manner *directly confronts hearers with what God says.* Whereas topical teaching involves assembling statements which seem to support a particular subject, still there remains the problem of credibility, because this process is vulnerable to human error. The hearer can justifiably retort: That is what *you* say. On the other hand, the verse-by-verse teacher can confidently affirm: This is what God says - to obey or disobey is a matter between you and God. When one is directly confronted by the clear, black and white meaning of God's Word, and obeys it, he is Divinely and not humanly convinced (John 4:42). He is one who unequivocally stands on what God and not man has said, and has the confident zeal of a first generation Christian.

Eighth, literal verse by verse teaching enhances unity between believers by diluting sectarianism. If all believers followed the literal-intended meaning of the Word of God written to the New Testament churches, there would be no room for sectarianism. The vicious promulgator of divisions and sects is the *following of what certain men say the Bible teaches* rather than what it actually teaches. The two major factors which produce sectarianism are: (1) failure to distinguish between *the different ways* God relates to His people, hence, the mixing of Law and Grace; (2) failure to accurately exegete and teach the Truth revealed for the Body of Christ, the Church, in the light of the original language. There is only one

viable solution to the manifold divisions which plague God's people: the expository, verse by verse teaching of the epistles written to the New Testament churches, the heart of which are those written by the Apostle Paul.

Ninth, teaching the Word in a consecutive verse by verse manner *enables the hearers to examine the accuracy of what is being taught.* If one is rapidly and glibly teaching topically, citing widely scattered evidence, the hearer is not able to examine the validity of these citations in their contexts. On the other hand, as one moves along in the context verse by verse, the listeners are able to evaluate what is being said (1 Cor. 14:29). Even though a teacher may be very reliable, the fact that others are scrutinizing what he is saying will tend to make him a more careful exegete.

Tenth, approaching an epistle in an orderly, successive manner *makes it possible for the listeners to study it by themselves*. In retrospect, they can review what has been taught (2 Tim. 2:7). Looking forward, they can study what will be taught and be prepared to more intelligently listen. The fact that verse by verse teaching encourages believers to study the Word for themselves is a real plus for it.

Eleven, teaching the various books of the New Testament consecutively, according to the time they were written, *throws light on the principle of progressive revelation.* For example, as we wend our way through the Book of Acts and Paul's epistles, we observe that the Truth of the Mystery was progressively revealed unto him. Manifestations of the sign gifts are still apparent in epistles written during the Acts period; however, when the nation of Israel is finally laid aside they disappear (Acts 28:28). There are no sign gifts mentioned in the perfection epistles written after the close of the period covered by Acts (1 Cor. 13:10). When one teaches the Pauline epistles in their chronological order, observing the development of the Truth for the Church, then the physical sign gifts associated with Israel are seen disappearing in favor of God's spiritual purpose, the Church.

Twelve, as a teacher consecutively identifies with the author from the beginning to the end of an epistle, he will be *forced to systematically study the literal-intended meaning* (Eph. 3:4). For example, one may teach topical messages from the Book of Romans. Teaching topically, he could even violate the context to the extent of teaching that salvation is by works (Rom. 2:7), but at the same time have a very foggy idea of what it really teaches. The one who benefits most from successive expositional teaching is the teacher himself. As he recognizes this benefit, enjoying more fully the provisions of God's Grace, he will be stimulated to become a more competent Bible expositor.

Thirteenth, teaching through a given epistle in an orderly, verse by verse manner *avoids wasting time selecting topics*. The average teacher or preacher wastes untold hours trying to decide what topic to speak on and how to word it. As one systematically expounds the Word of God, both he and his hearers know exactly what will be taught the next time.

Fourteenth, expository, verse by verse teaching *quietly changes lives in favor*

of Jesus Christ. Topical teaching and preaching, with the contents arranged to solicit certain psychological-spiritual results, may well have a more flashy, emotional appeal, but that which is based on emotions and feelings is transitive whereas that which is based on the Word is eternal. As a result of Adam's disobedience his progeny are enemies of God in their thinking, in their minds. Since the problem is in the mind it must be counteracted by feeding the Truth of God's Word into the mind. As God's message of Grace is taught in a verse by verse manner, even as the Holy Spirit originally wrote it, He quietly applies it to the minds of both the lost and saved, dynamically changing their thinking and living (John 16:8).

May God help you, apart from human traditions, to begin teaching God's Word for the Church in an expository verse by verse manner (Col. 1:25-26; 2 Tim. 2:2).

EDITOR'S PREFACE

to Romans

To enable you to more fully enjoy this commentary on Romans, we would like to preface it with an explanation of some of the features.

First, you will see all verse quotations set in ***bold italic***. If the quotation is from the Old Testament it will be set in **regular bold.**

Second, the verse *translation* is that of Dr. Campbell. Any difference with the accepted translations is not an attempt to be different or add to confusion, but to clarify the Greek meaning. Any similarity with other translations is a matter of coincidence.

Third, whenever cross references are noted and the book reference does not appear, the chapter and verse refers to Romans.

Fourth, at times you will notice the word "grace" capitalized. We have chosen to do this whenever "grace" refers to the dispensation of *Grace*. Just as we capitalize "Law of Moses" when referring to the dispensation of the Law, we will capitalize "Grace" and any synonyms (mystery, church, or body of Christ) when they refer to the particular dispensation.

Fifth, you may see some unusual hyphenated word combinations. This is the author's attempt to convey the meaning of one Greek word and its tense in a literal way with one English, hyphenated word.

Sixth, it must be remembered that in the original manuscripts all the letters were upper case; no words were capitalized because all the letters were capitals. Therefore, in this commentary, pronouns which refer to Deity are not capitalized in the translation, even when the relationship to Deity may seem obvious. At times the connection between the pronoun and its antecedent are not obvious and capitalization becomes a matter of interpretation rather than translation. Therefore, in order to avoid interpretation in our translation, none of the pronouns will be capitalized. The author will deal with the pronouns in the body of the commentary.

INTRODUCTION

In this introduction we will consider the *purpose* for which this epistle was written. In order to most accurately grasp Paul's purpose, through that which he has written, we will give a synoptical resume of each paragraph in each chapter. Information pertaining to the most probable date of writing will be examined.

PURPOSE

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER ONE is to explain that he is an apostle of the gospel, which concerns the Son, unto the Gentiles (1-7). He wants them to know that he is thanking God for their faith, praying that he might see them soon, and that his previous attempts to preach the gospel in Rome were foiled (8-15). He wants them to understand his attitude toward the gospel, that it is the power of God unto salvation, for it reveals the righteousness of God (16-17). He desires that they know why the wrath of God is revealed against the wickedness of men, because when He revealed Himself to them via creation they did not glorify Him as God (18-23). He wants them to know that God abandoned those who did not glorify Him as God to a downward spiral of corruption and depravity (24-32).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER TWO is to warn the one judging those doing the above things, and doing the same himself, that he is self-condemned and will face the wrathful judgment of God regardless of whether he is a Jew or Gentile (1-11). He informs the Jews, who have the law, and the Gentiles, who are a law to themselves, that they will be judged and perish due to their failure to keep the law (12-16; cf. 3:9). He points out to the Jews that by the inconsistency between their profession and transgression of the law they dishonor God (17-24). He explains to the Jews in their midst that flesh circumcision had value only in conjunction with the law, and that only Spirit circumcision benefits under Grace (25-29).

Paul's purpose in writing CHAPTER THREE is to declare that God gave to the Jews certain unrevokable advantages, the primary one being that He entrusted His Word to them (1-4). He tells them that God is just in condemning sinners even though their sin commends His righteousness (5-8). He has proved, confirming it by Scripture, that both Jews and Gentiles are totally depraved sinners (9-18).

He wants them to know that the purpose of the law is not to justify sinners, but to make them guilty and aware of their sin (19-20). He wants them to understand that God has manifested His righteousness through the perfect faithfulness of Jesus Christ consummated on Calvary. God's gracious provision of this righteousness, epitomized on the Cross, enables Him to be just and at the same time to justify believing sinners (21-26). He wants both Jews and Gentiles to recognize that they are justified by faith apart from the works of the law, which excludes all boasting (27-31).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER FOUR is to show them that Abraham's faith was counted for righteousness, a truth which David also confirms (1-8). He explains to them that this faith righteousness is available to both Jews and Gentiles, to all those believing (9-12). He wants them to see that the law had nothing to do with the promise given to Abraham, it was through the righteousness of faith, and it applies to all who are faith-children of Abraham (13-17). He explains to them how Abraham, against all odds, believed God unto righteousness, which was written for the sake of future believers (18-25).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER FIVE is to emphasize that through faith in Christ we are justified, stand in grace, and boast in the hope of the glory of God (1-5). He explains that if while we were weak, ungodly sinners, God's magnanimous love sent Christ to die for us, how much more we will be saved through Him from the coming wrath (6-11). He wants them to know that sin had its inception in Adam resulting in the death of all men (12-14). He informs them that Adam's sin brought condemnation and a reign of death, whereas, Christ's gift of grace brought justification and a reign of life through Jesus Christ (15-17). Adam's one trespass resulted in universal condemnation, made many sinners and sin reigned in death, whereas, Christ's one righteous act (the Cross) made justification available to all and grace reigned through righteousness unto eternal life (18-21).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER SIX is to explain that believers, who have been baptized into the death of Christ, have died to sin, and are now to walk in newness of life (1-4). He tells them that our old man has been crucified with Christ; therefore we are no longer to serve sin. Even as Christ died to sin once, and now lives for God, likewise we are to reckon ourselves dead to sin and living for God in Christ (5-11). He does not want the Romans to let sin reign in their mortal bodies, instead they are to make themselves available to God as out-from-the-dead living ones (12-14). He explains that grace liberates from sin and death, replacing them with obedience and righteousness (15-19). He reminds them that when they were slaves of sin their lifestyle was unto death, but now, having been enslaved to God, they have fruit unto sanctification, the end of which is eternal life (20-23).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER SEVEN is to inform them that even as a woman is freed from her husband by his death, likewise, they have been put to death to the law through the body of Christ, and they are now free to be joined to Him and bear fruit to God (1-6). He shares with them the fact that the law is holy, but instead of giving him life it revealed his sin, which resulted in his spiritual death (7-12). He says that his experience verifies the fact that the law was holy; it agreed with his will, but what he actually did was contrary, exposing that indwelling sin was controlling him (13-20). He gives them a glimpse into his subjective battle, how the law of sin in his members was warring against the law of his mind and bringing him into captivity, but he saw victory on the horizon through Jesus Christ (21-25).

Paul’s purpose in writing CHAPTER EIGHT is to make it clear that those in Christ are not condemned, for the law of the Spirit has freed them from the law of

sin and death, because God condemned sin in the flesh via Jesus Christ (1-4). He says that those in the flesh think on the things of the flesh, on death, and hatred of God and are not able to please God. Those in the Spirit think on the things of the Spirit, on life and peace (5-8). He explains that those in the Spirit are the ones who have the Spirit of God dwelling in them, who shall make alive their mortal bodies (9-11).

He emphasizes that by means of the Spirit they are to put to death the practices of the body, and that those who are so led by the Spirit are sons of God (12-14). He says that in contrast to the spirit of bondage and fear under the law, they have received the Spirit of sonship, who bears witness with their spirit that they are the children of God (15-17). He points out that the present sufferings they are enduring cannot be compared with the glorious revelation of the sons of God, the redemption of their body, for which they patiently wait (18-25). He explains to them that in our weakness we do not know what we ought to pray for; therefore the Spirit intercedes on our behalf according to the will of God (26-27). He implies that they know that God works all things for good on behalf of those called according to His sovereign purpose, beginning with foreknowing them and culminating with glorifying them (28-30). He tells them that since God is for us as believers, who can be against, indict or condemn us, for God has given His Son for us, He has justified us and Christ is interceding on behalf of us (31-34). Finally, Paul affirms that no person nor thing will be able to separate believers from the Love of God in Christ (35-39).

PLACE OF WRITING

After Paul left Ephesus he crossed over into Macedonia, and having spent some time there exhorting the Macedonian believers (Philippians, Thessalonians and Bereans), he went south to Greece (Acts 20:1-2). He spent three months there (Acts 20:3). Since no church is mentioned in Athens, and the Jewish plot against his life was apparently in the Cenchrean area, Paul obviously spent the three months in Corinth. This is corroborated by the fact that his host was Gaius, one of the early Corinthian converts whom he baptized (Rom. 16:23; 1 Cor. 1:14). Also, Erastus, the treasurer of the city, whom Paul associates with Corinth, is with him (2 Tim. 4:20). In the light of these facts we can confidently affirm that the Epistle to the Romans was written while Paul was at Corinth.

DATE OF WRITING

The general consensus is that the Epistle to the Romans was written between A.D. 56-58. With additional information available to Bible scholars, the trend has been to favor earlier dates for most of the books of the New Testament. In view of all that transpired after Paul left Corinth and arrived in Rome, we tend to favor the earlier date mentioned. Keep in mind that after Paul left Corinth he took the long way through Macedonia and down the Asian coast to Jerusalem. He spent time in Jerusalem, two years or more in Ceasarea (Acts 24:27), and the trip to Rome was unexpectedly long and tedious. Considering the common dating of Ephesians, Colossians and Philemon, and often of Acts, it appears that approximately A.D. 56 would synchronize better.

Chapter 1

1. ***"Paul a slave of Christ Jesus, called an apostle, having been separated unto the gospel of God,"***

Paul refers to himself here as a slave who belongs to Jesus Christ. He has been called to fulfill the office of an apostle (αποστολος), one who is sent forth with the gospel (cf. 11:13; 1 Cor. 9:1, 2). As a slave of Christ and an apostle, Paul has been set apart unto the gospel of God. The phrase "the gospel of God" (ευαγγελιον θεου) is used only in Paul's early epistles (cf. 15:16; 1 Thess. 2:2, 8, 9). It is also interesting to observe that it is used in Mark 1:14. As used in the context here it seems to refer to the gospel of salvation, the good news that "Christ died on behalf of our sins according to the scriptures" (1 Cor. 15:3).

2. ***"which was previously announced through his prophets in the holy scriptures,"***

The gospel referred to here is one that had been previously announced, or previously promised, through the Old Testament prophets. It is the prophesied good news that the Saviour would "be wounded for our transgressions" and "bruised for our iniquities" (Isa. 53:5). Since the fall sin has been man's number one problem. God has both promised and provided a remedy for man's sin, and this remedy is found in the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ: "the one not knowing sin, He made sin on behalf of us, in order that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him" (2 Cor 5:21). The issues of sin and redemption are universal, they are common to all dispensations, and the remedy is the gospel of God, good news prophesied in the Old Testament and pertinent to sinners in all economies. This gospel is not to be confused with Paul's "gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the mystery which has been kept silent for times eternal" (16:25). The gospel of God is revealed in the Old Testament; the gospel of the mystery is not revealed in the Old Testament, but was hidden from the ages (cf. Eph. 3:8, 9). Paul's later references to the gospel, the gospel of Christ, our gospel, etc., include both the concept of salvation and the mystery truth of the Church.

3. ***"concerning his son, the one born out of the seed of David according to the flesh,"***

The gospel of God centers in a Person; it concerns the Son of God. Isaiah wrote, "A virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel [God with us]" (Isa. 7:14). The angel told Mary, "The Holy Spirit shall come upon you, and the power of the highest shall over-shadow you, wherefore also the one born shall be called holy, the Son of God" (Lk. 1:35). Early in the Old Testament we have the revelation concerning the Son of God unfolding, and with increased momentum it moves on through the entire New Testament. The particular revelation concerning the Son here is His redemptive work; the theme of Romans is how God makes a sinner righteous through the death of Christ (1:16, 17; 3:21-

26).

The Son of God, who became in human flesh, is identified as a descendent of David in the flesh. An abundance of Old Testament prophecy declares the Redeemer and coming King to be of the lineage of David (cf. Isa. 9:6, 7, etc.). Matthew's genealogy states the fact that Jesus Christ is the "son of David, the son of Abraham" (Matt. 1:1). Luke's genealogy traces Jesus back as the son of David to Adam, the direct offspring of God (Lk. 3:31, 38). Jesus Christ's right to the throne of David, to reign as King over the prophesied Kingdom, required that He be a descendent of David. In the New Testament the Holy Spirit meticulously points out that Jesus Christ the Redeemer has every credential for being Jesus Christ the King!

4. ***"who has been designated the Son of God with power according to the Spirit of holiness by his resurrection out from the dead, Jesus Christ our Lord,"***

Jesus Christ was designated (ορισθεντος), declared, and appointed the Son of God. Next, this designation as the Son of God was in the sphere of power (locative case), or by means of power (instrumental case), according to the working of the Holy Spirit. The powerful working of the Holy Spirit in raising Jesus out from the dead was evidence that He is the Son of God. It is our conviction that the power (δυναμει) should be associated with the Holy Spirit's part in raising Jesus Christ from the dead. Paul confirms this in Philippians 3:10, where he says that his desire is "to know Him and the power of his resurrection . . .." In Ephesians 1:20 we see God's exceedingly great power "energized in Christ when He raised Him out from the dead." The power of God, released through the Holy Spirit, produced the resurrection of Jesus Christ; this attests to the fact that He is the one ordained the very Son of God!

5. ***"through whom we received grace and apostleship unto obedience of faith among all the Gentiles on behalf of his name."***

Saul of Tarsus, in his ignorant rage against the early believers, received grace on the road to Damascus (cf. Acts 9:3-6; 1 Tim. 1:13-16). In Galatians 2:8 Paul says that the one who "energized in Peter unto the apostleship of the circumcision energized also in me unto the Gentiles" (cf. Rom 11:13). Paul's apostleship was unto the end that the Gentiles might hear and obey the Gospel (εις υπακοην πιστεως), i.e., obey the message of faith. In Romans 16:25-26 Paul speaks about his gospel, the mystery, which has been made manifest "unto the obedience of faith unto all the Gentiles having been made known." In other words, Paul's gospel was revealed unto the Gentiles to the end that they might have an opportunity to hear it and obey its message.

Lastly, we observe that Paul's apostleship was on behalf of (υπερ) His name, i.e., on behalf of the Person of Jesus Christ. In Second Corinthians 5:20 Paul says, "Therefore on behalf of [υπερ] Christ we do the work of ambassadors [a verb], as though God were beseeching through us; we beg you on behalf of [υπερ] Christ, be reconciled to God." Paul considered himself a slave of Jesus

Christ, one bought with a price, totally committed to his Gentile apostleship *on behalf of* the name of Jesus Christ.

6. ***"Among whom also you yourselves are called ones of Jesus Christ,"***

This statement implies that the majority of believers in Rome were probably Gentiles who had been called from among (εν οις) the Gentile world. Since Jesus Christ (Ιησου Χριστου) is in the genitive case denoting possession, the thought is that, as those who have been called, they now belong to Jesus Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 1:1). In First Corinthians 3:23 Paul says, "you belong to Christ, and Christ belongs to God." As those who are called out of darkness, believers now belong to Christ and God.

7. ***"to all the beloved of God, called saints, in Rome, grace and peace to you from God our Father and our Lord Jesus Christ."***

Paul addresses this epistle to the beloved of God (τοις αγαπητοις θεου), to those who are the recipients of God's love living in Rome. These believers are also "called saints" (κλητοις αγιοις), i.e., they have been called to a position of saints. This refers to one aspect of God's sovereign purpose: He first foreknows, foreordains, and then calls through the Holy Spirit to a position of justification (Rom. 8:29-30). Because they have been called to be saints according to God's eternal purpose, now they are designated as "called saints," - a proper name applied to them.

Paul desires that God will give to them grace (χαρις), favor, and beneficence; furthermore, that they might have peace (ειρηνη), tranquility, and an undisturbed and calm mind from God the Father and the Son (cf. 2 Tim. 1:2).

8. ***"First, I indeed thank my God through Jesus Christ for all of you, because your faith is being announced in all the world."***

The first thing Paul wants to share with them is the fact that he continually (present tense) thanks his God (the Father) for all of them. It is important to note that Paul addresses his prayer of thanksgiving to God the Father through the personal agent, Jesus Christ (cf. Rom. 7:25; Eph. 5:20; Col. 3:17). We need to accurately follow the Scriptures and address all prayer to God the Father through the agency (δια with the genitive case) of Jesus Christ, or in the name (εν with the locative case) of Jesus Christ.

The reason Paul thanks God for them is their faith (πιστις), which was seen in their faithfulness. It is our conviction that the Greek word "πιστις" does signify the idea of faith, trust, and confidence; however, this is inseparable from faithfulness and trustfulness. Intrinsically faith involves faithfulness. The fact of their faith in Christ and faithfulness to Christ was announced (καταγγελλεται), set forth, and proclaimed in all the world (cf. Col. 1:23; 1 Thess. 1:8). It is obvious that Paul uses the phrase "in all the world" (εν ολω τω κοσμω) to refer to the inhabited earth reached by Roman commerce.

In speaking of the extensive working of the gospel, Paul says that "in all the world it is bearing fruit and increasing" (Col. 1:16). The extent of Paul's own

personal ministry was as far north as Illyricum, southern Europe, and he desired to go as far west as Spain (cf. Rom. 15:19, 24, 28). The only limit we can place on the extent of the ministry of the Roman believers is the limit of Roman commerce and travel at that time.

9. ***"For God is my witness, whom I serve in my spirit in the gospel of his Son, how unceasingly I make mention of you,"***

Paul constantly remembered the Roman believers, and he prayed that he might be able to go to Rome and see them, but up to this time he had been hindered from going. Since some of them may have begun to wonder if Paul really cared about them, Paul calls upon God to bear witness to his genuine concern for them, and how he had petitioned God to go to them. No other human being knew the burden of Paul's heart and mind for these believers in Rome, but God did, and He was able to convince them of Paul's concern for them. This is a good example of Paul's desire to be known as one who cared and was concerned about fellow members in the Body of Christ!

The God upon whom Paul calls to bear witness is the God Paul serves (λατρευω) and worships. The word " λατρευω" may denote the rendering of service to God (cf. Heb. 13:10), or to worship God (cf. 2 Tim. 1:3; Heb. 9:9; 10:2). In most of the passages in the New Testament where this word is used, it may be translated either to worship or to serve. The implication is that to worship God is to serve God; worshipful adoration of God is to serve and glorify Him.

In speaking of his relationship to God, Paul says, "Whom I serve [worship] in my spirit in the gospel of His Son." First, observe that it was in the sphere of, or by means of, his human spirit that he worshiped and served God. In Philippians 3:3 Paul affirms that true believers worship and serve God by the Spirit of God. The implication is that the Holy Spirit, working in conjunction with the human spirit, produces true spiritual worship and service (cf. Rom. 8:4-5, 26; 1 Cor. 2:11-15; 12:3). Second, the Greek word for worship and serve (λατρευω) is in the present tense, which indicates that the believer is to continuously worship and serve God (cf. Phil. 3:3 present participle; Heb. 9:14 present infinitive). The believer, moment by moment, in the Spirit, is to worship and serve God!

Paul's worshiping and serving God was in the sphere of "the gospel of His Son." In other words, Paul's worship and service centered around the "good news" of Jesus Christ, i.e., the gospel that belongs to Him. Paul got his gospel from Jesus Christ; it was the message of Christ given to Paul by direct revelation (Gal. 1:12). The heart of this gospel was the fact that Christ had died for our sins, that He had been buried, and that He had been raised on the third day (1 Cor. 15:3-4). Furthermore, it included the mystery truth about Christ and His Church (Eph. 3:3). Paul's total worship and service centered in Christ as Redeemer and Head over the Church! He was occupied with the Person of Jesus Christ.

10. ***"praying that somehow already once I shall be given a prosperous journey in the will of God to come to you."***

The grammatical construction of the Greek in this verse is very difficult. The

use of the present participle suggests that Paul continually prayed to go to Rome. The phrase "ει πως" in the Greek is used in three other instances in the New Testament, in which it is best translated that somehow (Acts 27:12; Rom. 11:14; Phil. 3:11). The word "ηδη" is consistently translated already in the Greek New Testament. The particle "ποτε" is consistently used by the Apostle Paul to mean once. Our above translation, "praying that somehow already once," is accurate according to the meaning of these phrases and words in other contexts (cf. Phil. 4:10).

The Greek word translated "I shall be given a prosperous journey " (ευοδωθησομαι) comes from a combination of two Greek words, which means to be given a good journey, a prosperous journey, or just the idea of being prosperous or successful (cf. 1 Cor. 16:2; 3 John 2). Either the translation I shall be given a prosperous journey, or I shall be caused to prosper, is acceptable and both have the same basic meaning. Paul's prayer is that it might be in the sphere of God's will for him to have a prosperous journey to them. Looking back, we know that it was not God's will at that time for Paul to go to Rome; however it was His will some three years later, and at that time as a Roman prisoner (cf. Acts 23:11; Rom. 25:12).

Now that we have the grammatical facts of the entire verse before us, let us interpret the difficult language Paul uses here. First, let us look at the literal language of this verse again - Paul is continually praying that somehow already once (or, once already) he might have a prosperous journey in God's will to go to the Roman believers. The word already (ηδη) refers to *past time*, to that which has already taken place. The word once (ποτε) conveys the idea of once in relation to *time*, hence *at one time* (cf. Rom. 7:9; Gal. 1:13). The most feasible interpretation is that Paul was praying that somehow (in some manner or way) already as an accomplished fact) at one time (at a given time) he might be given a prosperous journey (passive voice - by God in His will) to go to them. Paul's prayer is that *already, now*, he might have a "green light" for a *future prosperous journey* to Rome.

11. ***"For I long to see you, in order that I might impart to you some spiritual gift, unto the end that you might be established,"***

In this verse Paul states the reason for his *longing* (επιποθω), desiring, and wanting to see the believers at Rome. He uses "rva" *with the subjunctive* to clearly express his purpose - that he might *impart* (μεταδω), distribute, and share with them some spiritual gift. The Scriptures make it obvious that Paul as a person did not actually impart unto them any gifts, for the use of the word *spiritual* (πνευματικον) implies that these are Holy Spirit gifts. ALL gifts have their origin with God and are distributed or effected through the Holy Spirit (cf. Rom. 12:6; 1 Cor. 7:7, 11; 2 Tim. 1:6).

Since all gifts originate with God and are given through the Holy Spirit, what does Paul mean by imparting some spiritual gift? First, we need to recognize that the word gift (χαρισμα) can be used in a very *general sense*. It is used with reference to righteousness (Rom. 5:16), eternal life (Rom. 6:23), and ministry,

teaching, exhorting, sharing, and ruling (Rom. 12:7-8). Second, it may be used with reference to certain miraculous gifts associated with the *Kingdom*, such as gifts of healing, working of miracles, prophesying, and tongues and their interpretation (1 Cor. 12:9-10). Third, it may be used with reference to gifts applicable to the *Church*, such as the foundational gifts of apostles and prophets (cf. Eph. 2:20), and the continuing gifts of evangelists, pastor, and teachers (cf. Eph. 4:11).

Since it was not Paul's prerogative to give spiritual gifts, not even for the Church (cf. Eph. 4:8, 11), by no stretch of the imagination can we interpret the language used here to mean that Paul had the power to distribute gifts, which is the exclusive ministry of the Spirit of God (cf. 1 Cor. 12:11). First, we acknowledge that the purpose of the gifts is for the *upbuilding of the church* (Eph. 4:12). Second, the basic gifts that accomplish this purpose have to do with *communication of the Truth,* such as evangelists and teachers; and the *sharing of burdens*, such as pastors (Eph. 4:11). Paul's instructions regarding spiritual gifts, and how to conduct their local assembly so these gifts could be developed, are essentials involved in the impartation of these gifts. Unless one knows what gifts Christ has given to His Church, and there is an *opportunity for the exercise* of these gifts in the 1oεa1 assembly, there can not be an intelligent manifestation of the gifts!

The purpose of Paul's going to Rome was that they might exercise the correct spiritual gifts, unto the end that they might be *established* (στηριχθηναι), made stable, and firmly fixed in the faith. The *Truth of Paul's gospel* is that which establishes believers (cf. Rom. 16:25). Paul is confident that the Lord will establish the Thessalonians in the Truth he commanded them (2 Thess. 3:3-4). Only the inst*ructional gifts* and the *pastoral gifts* establish believers and make them firm in the Truth for the Church! The spectacular sign gifts, associated with Israel and the Kingdom, emphasize the credentials of the Messiah, but *do not establish* (cf. John 2:23-25; 19:15).

12. ***"that is, to be encouraged together with you through the faith in each of us, both yours and mine."***

In the previous verse Paul has been speaking about his desire to see them that they might be *established*. With the introductory phrase that is (τουτο δε εστιν), Paul goes on to more fully explain what is involved in being established.

First, it involved mutual *encouragement* (συμπαρακληθηναι). This word may also be translated *exhortation* and *comfort*. When used in contexts such as this we believe this word most accurately conveys the idea of *encouragement based on exhortation*, i.e., through exhorting and teaching the Scriptures, we encourage one another.

One of the key ingredients involved in the mutual encouragement of Paul and the Roman believers was the *faith* (της πιστεως) of both of them. There are three possible interpretations of της πιστεως. First, it may refer to the *faith*, belief, and trust that Paul and Roman believers had in the Lord. Second, it may refer to their

faithfulness, fidelity, and trustworthiness resulting from their faith in the Lord. Third, it could refer to a *body of truth*, that which is believed, or to the Gospel of Christ. The first two interpretations are inseparable; the extent to which believers have faith in the Lord will be seen in their faithfulness to the Lord.

Summarizing we make the following observations: (1) establishing believers involves *encouraging them by exhortation*; (2) *faith and faithfulness* are vital factors producing encouragement; (3) this faith must be *mutual, reciprocal* (αλληλοις), in one another. It was not enough for just Paul to have faith, but they likewise needed faith, and the interaction between their faith prompted encouragement. Paul emphasizes their mutual faith by referring to it as *both yours and mine*; faith and faithfulness that belonged to both Paul and the Roman believers. The implication is that through *mutual dialogue*, grounded in their faith and faithfulness in the Lord, the result would be encouragement and establishment in the truth.

13. ***"And I do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, that often I purposed to come to you, and I was prevented until now, that I might also have some fruit among you, even as also among the rest of the Gentiles."***

In his previous communications with the Roman believers, Paul had apparently told them that he planned to visit Rome relatively soon. A considerable period of time had transpired, perhaps several years (15:23), and he still had not been able to visit them. He is afraid that the Roman believers may misinterpret his absence as a *lack of concern* for them. This is why he does not want them to be ignorant, but to know why he had not visited them as yet. He informs them that *often* (πολλακις), many times, and on several occasions he planned to go to them, but he was always hindered.

The Greek word translated purposed (προεθεμην) literally means *to place beforehand, to set forth*, or *to determine* to do something. The use of the middle voice indicates that many times Paul purposed in himself to go to Rome; however, up until the time he was writing he had been prevented (εκωλυθην), restrained, and hindered from going. The use of the passive voice here indicates that someone or something *beyond himself* had restrained him from going. At this time the Lord had not given Paul any clear revelation that he was to go to Rome, as He had is the case of Macedonia (Acts 16:9-10), and when Paul determined in himself to go, he was apparently prevented by circumstances.

Paul does not consider his being prevented from going to Rome as something bad or evil. In fact, it is just the opposite; it is an *extension of time* for the Roman believers to allow the Spirit to *produce some fruit* in them. Apparently, in comparison to the rest of the Gentile converts, they had been lacking in spiritual fruit, and Paul sees the purpose of his delay in going to them as *providing more time to prove themselves in fruitbearing.*

14. ***"I am obligated to both Greeks and Barbarians, to both the wise and the foolish;"***

Paul felt obligated to proclaim the Gospel to all men. The Greek word for

obligated (οφειλετης) is a noun, and refers to a *person who owes* or *who is in debt*, i.e., who has a responsibility to fulfill. Paul looked at himself as having a debt to pay, an obligation to meet, or as being responsible to do a certain job. The emphasis in this verse is on *those to whom* Paul was indebted and obligated. Paul uses Greek terminology, which was clearly understood by the Roman believers, to express the fact that he had a debt to pay to all men.

First, Paul recognized that he was obligated to reach the *Greeks* (Ελλησιν), i.e., those from Greece and of Greek origin and background. In a wider sense many of those who came under the influence of the Greek language and culture as a result of the Macedonian conquests undoubtedly considered themselves Greeks. Those who were referred to as Greeks were widespread, such as at *Antioch* of Syria (cf. Acts 11:20), *Iconium* (cf. Acts 14:1), in *all Asia* (Acts 19:10), and Paul's use of Greek oriented terminology suggests that many of the believers at *Rome* may have considered themselves Greeks. From the Jewish point of view all who were not Jews were spoken of as Greeks (cf. John 7:35; Acts 20:21; Rom. 3:9).

Second, Paul recognized that he was also obligated to reach the *Barbarians* (Βαρβαροις), i.e., all who were neither Greeks nor Jews. The natives on the Island of Malta were called Barbarians (Acts 28:1-2). Paul's use of the word in this context suggests that some of the believers in Rome were Barbarians. Those who speak a foreign language are referred to as Barbarians (cf. 1 Cor. 14:11). The new man in the Body of Christ, where Christ is all things and in all, is no longer designated as a Barbarian, a Jew, or a Greek (cf. Col. 3:11). From the Jewish point of view both Greeks and Barbarians were Gentiles.

Third, Paul recognized that he had an obligation to reach the *wise* (σοφοις), those who were knowledgeable, intelligent, and learned. Paul is obviously using this word here with reference to the wisdom of this world. In the area of worldly philosophical wisdom the Greeks had made the greatest advances (cf. 1 Cor. 1:22); however, in contrast to the true wisdom of God, it was insignificant foolishness (cf. 1 Cor. 1:25-27; 3:10). Regardless of whether men were or thought they were wise in the wisdom of this world, Paul was obligated to reach them for Christ (cf. 1 Cor. 9:19-23).

Fourth, Paul recognized that he had an obligation to reach the foolish (ανοητοις), literally, those not thinking, the unintelligent, the unlearned, or the unwise. The Greeks, as they relished in their worldly wisdom, looked on the Barbarians as being in this category (cf. Acts 17:21, 32). Paul uses this word to describe the foolish, unintelligent, and illogical actions of the Galatians (cf. Gal. 3:3-4). As he writes to Titus, who had the responsibility of organizing the local assemblies among the once foolish Cretans, Paul reminds him that they also were foolish before they were saved (cf. Titus 3:3).

15. ***"so as much as is in me, I am ready to preach the gospel also to you who are in Rome."***

The Greek idiom translated *so as much as is in me* (ουτος το κατ' εμε)

conveys the idea of according to that *in* me, in keeping with that *in* me, or with respect to that *in* me (cf. Acts 24:5; 27:2). In these passages the Greek preposition κατα used with the accusative case has the idea of in similar to the locative case (cf. Rom. 16:5; Philemon 2). In Romans 14:22 it speaks of the *degree* of faith *in* believers; and in Ephesians 1:15 it speaks of the *degree* and *extent* to which in-believer-faith is in the Lord Jesus. The passages cited support the idea that Paul was ready to preach the Gospel to the degree that it was *in him* to do so.

In several passages this idiom is used to depict the general circumstances surrounding the Apostle Paul. In Acts 24:22 Felix speaks of the *things concerning Paul*, in Acts 25:14 Festus places before King Agrippa the *things pertaining to Paul*, and in Ephesians 6:21 Paul used it with reference to his circumstances and what he was doing (cf. Phil. 1:12; Col. 4:7). In the light of its usage in these passages we can say that Paul was ready to preach the Gospel *to the extent that his circumstances permitted*. The degree to which it was in Paul to preach the Gospel to the Romans was closely related to the circumstances and involvements surrounding him.

The Greek word translated *I am ready* (προθυμον) comes from the Greek words "προ" and "θυμος," and literally means a prior mind-set; hence to be *ready, prepared*, and *willing*. To the extent of Paul's physical and mental ability, and as far as the circumstances surrounding him permitted, he was ready, prepared, and willing to preach the Gospel also to those in Rome. As we have already seen, on several previous occasions Paul had purposed to go to Rome, but Divinely directed circumstances had hindered him; they needed more time to bear fruit, but now he feels that he will soon be able to go to them (cf. v. 13).

What is the essence of the Gospel that Paul was ready to preach at Rome? First, observe that the Greek word translated *to preach the Gospel* (ευαγγελισασθαι) literally means to preach or proclaim a *good message,* a *good pronouncement,* or *good news*. The heart of the Gospel which Paul preached is briefly summed up in First Corinthians 15:3-4: ". . . That Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, and that he was buried, and that he was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures." The good message is that the perfect Person of Jesus Christ, "Who knew no sin was made sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him" (2 Cor. 5:21). The good news is that He was *made sin for us on the cross*, that we might be forgiven according to His rich grace (Eph. 1:7), and be clothed in His righteousness!

16. ***"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one believing, to the Jew first and the Greek;"***

In the previous verse Paul used the Greek word ευαγγελισασθαι to express that which he desired to do. This is a verb; it emphasizes action. His supreme priority was preaching the Gospel. In this verse Paul declares that he has no negative feelings about *the Gospel* (το ευαγγελιον). This word is a noun, and refers to the essence and substance of the Gospel, i.e., that which constitutes the Gospel, and the truth contained in the gospel. The word translated Gospel is

derived from the Greek words ευ and αγγελος, which literally mean a *good message, good news,* or *good tidings*. The implication is, if there is such a thing as good news, there must also be such a thing as bad news. The bad news is that (Rom. 3:9-19), and as utterly depraved sinners in their very nature, they are impotent to alter their state (Eph. 2:1-3). The good news is that Jesus Christ has made it possible for men to be delivered from their sin (cf. Matt. 1:21; Rom. 6:23).

There is only one way for men to be delivered from their sinful dilemma, and that is through the shedding of Perfect Blood (Heb. 9:22). The only one who can meet the requirement of a perfect blood sacrifice is *Jesus Christ*, who is true God incarnate in true human flesh (2 Cor. 5:21; Heb. 4:14). The good news is that Jesus Christ *has provided redemption and forgiveness of sins* through His Own Blood (Eph. 1:7). Also, the good news is that the Blood of Jesus, God's Son, continuously cleanses believers from every sin (I John 1:7).

According to the record that we have in the New Testament, no man suffered as much as Paul did for the sake of the Gospel; however, in spite of this, he was never ashamed of the Gospel. The Greek word for *ashamed* (επαισχυνομαι) comes from the two words "επι" and "αισχυνομαι," and seems to have the literal idea of being ashamed *on the basis of something,* i.e., Paul was not ashamed on the basis of the Gospel, or the *Gospel was not the basis* for any feeling of shame on Paul's part. Likewise, Paul admonished Timothy not to be ashamed of the witness (Gospel) of the Lord (2 Tim. 1:8). Also, even though Paul had been put in prison for his bold proclamation of the mystery of the Gospel, he was not ashamed (cf. Eph. 6:19-20; 2 Tim. 1:12), but continued to boldly preach it!

The reason Paul gives for not being ashamed of the Gospel is that it is the *power of God unto salvation* to every one believing. The Greek word translated power (δυναμις) conveys the thought of *strength*, *might*, and *force*. It transliterates into English as dynamite. It is the strength, might, force, and dynamite of God (θεου), that *belongs to God*. In other words, since God is the source of the power of the Gospel, for Paul to have been ashamed of the Gospel would have meant he was ashamed of God.

Now observe that the power of God released through the Gospel is unto salvation (εις σωτηριαν). The preposition εις used with the accusative case expresses the idea of *unto the end of*, i.e., the object of the power of God is to save sinners. The word salvation (σωτηριαν) is used against a background of sin. The power of God, on the basis of the good news that Christ died for sinners, saves from both original sin and the power of sin in one's daily life (cf. Rom. 3:23-24; 6:12-14).

The Gospel, as the power of God unto salvation, is limited to certain individuals, namely, *every one believing* (παντι τω πιστευοντι). The present participle used here comes from the basic word πιστευω, which means to have *faith in*, to *put trust in*, or to *rely upon* Jesus Christ for salvation. This faith is a part of the grace given to men; it originates with God and is exercised by those called by God (Rom. 8:29; Eph. 2:8). The exercise of faith and belief in Jesus Christ's finished work on Calvary is God's method of identifying sinners with the

Saviour!

Does any race or nationality have an advantage when it comes to experiencing the power of God unto the end of salvation? On the surface, the statement *to the Jew first and the Greek*, could be interpreted to mean that the Jews have a priority. We do not believe that this statement has anything to do with "first" in the sense of privilege, but rather "*first" in the sense of time*. Historically speaking, the Gospel was first proclaimed to the Jews. When up at Antioch of Pisidia, Paul and Barnabas preached the Gospel in the Synagogue; however, when the Jews spoke against that which Paul was teaching, Paul and Barnabas said: "It was necessary to speak the Word of God to you first; but since you reject it and judge yourselves as not being worthy of eternal life, behold we turn unto the Gentiles" (Acts 13:46; cf. 18:6; 28:24-28). According to the Truth of the Mystery, the Gospel of the Grace of God, there is no such thing as a privileged race in this Church Age (cf. Eph. 3:2-9). We have the responsibility to teach the Gospel equally to both Jews and Gentiles!

17. ***"for the righteousness of God is revealed in it out of faith unto faith, even as it has been written, The righteous shall live out of faith."***

We have already observed that Paul was not ashamed of the Gospel, because it was the power of God unto Salvation. Now we observe a second reason why he was not ashamed of the Gospel, namely, because the *righteousness of God is revealed in it.* The Greek word translated *righteousness* (δικαιοσυνη) means that which is right, that which is just, and that which is fair and equitable. The use of the genitive case indicates that the righteousness we have here *belongs to God;* it is a standard of righteousness *which God possesses*; it is absolute Divine righteousness based upon who God is.

Paul says that this righteousness is *revealed in the Gospel*. Jesus Christ, as God, embodied this righteousness, for Paul says that He "was made for us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30). The Gospel reveals the fact that Jesus Christ was perfectly faithful unto death. His faithful obedience including the cross *is the righteousness of God* (cf. Rom. 3:22; Gal. 2:16; Phil. 3:9). Since Christ is the very righteousness of God, and we are in Him, it follows that in our identification with Him we are clothed in the righteousness of God (cf. 2 Cor. 5:21).

Now let us examine the statement that the righteousness of God is revealed in the Gospel *out of faith unto faith*. The phrase "out of faith" (εκ πιστεως) consists of the preposition "εκ" with the ablative case, and as such, it indicates that *faith or faithfulness is the source* of the righteousness. It appears to us that Paul is using the Greek word "πιστεως" here with reference to the *faithfulness of Christ*. The source of righteousness is the faithfulness of Jesus Christ, the Cross, and not the works of the Law (cf. Phil. 3:9). The phrase *unto faith* is best understood to mean unto the end of *faith in Christ*; i.e., the righteousness that comes from the faithfulness of Christ is obtained by *faith in Christ* or *by believing* (cf. 3:22; Gal. 2:16; 3:22).

We interpret Paul's quotation from Habakkuk 2:4 as having a secondary predictive reference to the faithfulness of Christ which culminated at Calvary's cross. This same quotation is used by Paul in Galatians 3:11, where he uses it in conjunction with Christ having been made a curse for us on the cross, as the basis for justification rather than the works of the Law (cf. Heb. 10:38). In summary, we see two important truths in this verse: (1) The Gospel reveals that the source of God's righteousness is the *faithfulness of Christ unto the death of the cross* (2) This righteousness of God is obtained *by faith in Christ and His death* (cf. 3:25).

18. ***"For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men who restrain the truth in unrighteousness,"***

The subject of this verse is the wrath of God. The Greek word translated "wrath" (οργη) may also be translated as *anger, indignation, passion,* etc. The genitive case indicates that this wrath *belongs to God,* i.e., God reveals His own wrath, an anger peculiar to Him, against man's sinful characteristics.

The word translated "reveals" (αποκαλυπτεται) comes from the two Greek words "απο" and "καλυπτω" which mean to *take a cover from, to uncover* hence may also be translated is *unveiled, manifested*, and *appears*. The use of the present tense suggests that with the onset of man's sin the wrath of God begins and continues against it (cf. Jn. 3:36). In addition to this there is a *final day of wrath* when God's anger will be consummated against all sin (cf. 2:5; 1 Thess. 1:10).

Observe that the place from which the wrath of God is revealed is "from heaven" (απ' ουρανου). Since the normal place of God's abode is in heaven (cf. Eph. 6:9; 1 Pet. 3:22), and since the wrath Paul is talking about is a direct expression of God's anger, it naturally follows that it comes forth from where God is, namely, from heaven.

Now let us observe that the wrath of God is revealed "against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men." The Greek word translated "ungodliness" (ασεβειαν) speaks of *impiety* or a *lack of reverence and respect toward God.* The word translated "unrighteousness" (αδικιαν) speaks of sinful man's *injustice, wrongdoing,* and *wickedness*. This word stands for the opposite of that which is right, hence, that which is wrong.

According to the genitive case the above mentioned ungodliness and unrighteousness represent man's sin, that which he has produced, and as such that which *belongs to him*. It is important to observe that God's wrath is "against" (επι), *upon the ground of, on the basis of* the impiety and injustice practiced by men. The wrath is not directed against men themselves, but against their sin. The language used here could be interpreted to mean that God's wrath is revealed on the *ground or basis* of their ungodliness and unrighteousness, i.e., their sin is that which has elicited the wrath of God.

Paul describes these men who are practicing ungodliness and

unrighteousness as those "who restrain the truth in unrighteousness." The word "truth" obviously refers to the Divinely revealed truth of the Word of God (cf. John 17:17; Col. 1:5). The Greek word translated "restrain" (κατεχοντων) is derived from the two words "κατα" and "εχω" which combined literally mean to *hold down, suppress,* and *hinder.*

Thus we see that those who are engaged in ungodliness and unrighteousness are men who are continuously (present tense) holding down, suppressing, and restraining the truth of the Word of God. The same word is used here for "unrighteousness" (αδικια) as used earlier in this verse, which conveys the idea of *injustice, wrongdoing, and wickedness.* The thought is that these men continuously hold down the truth *in the sphere of* (locative case) unrighteousness, injustice and wrongdoing. Speaking frankly, they bury the truth under the rubbish of their wrongdoing.

Men practicing ungodliness and unrighteousness are rampant today. They are vigorously endeavoring to suppress the truth of God's Word, which emphatically condemns them, under their corrupt teaching of evolution, sexual permissiveness, and their performance of murderous abortions! As they shake their fists against God, Paul says that they are not going to get away with it, "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men who restrain the truth in unrighteousness."

19. ***"because that which is known of God is manifest in them, for God manifested it to them."***

This verse states the fact that these ungodly and unrighteous men did have a basic knowledge of God revealed to them. The Greek phrase translated "which is known" (το γνωστον) is commonly used with reference to *knowing persons* (cf. John 18:15-16). Even as they knew people and had a knowledge of them, they knew God and had a knowledge of Him. The thought is, as indicated by the genitive case, that what "is known of God" is that which *belongs* to God or *pertains* to God.

Paul says that this knowledge of God "is manifest in them." The word "manifest" (φανερον) means that this knowledge is *clear, plain*, and *visible* in them. The preposition "in" (εν) is followed by the locative case, which expresses the idea of *location*, and may be interpreted to mean either "in" or "among." The following context states that this knowledge was revealed through what God had created around them; therefore, the preferable interpretation is that this knowledge was visible "among them." The thought is not that God gave them an inner subjective knowledge of Himself, but that He objectively revealed Himself through that which He created!

Paul now strongly affirms the fact that this knowledge had been made available to them, for he says, "for God manifested it to them." The verb translated "manifested" (εφαν) has the same basic meaning as the previous noun, i.e., that God had made it clear, plain and visible "to them" (αυτοις) The emphasis here is that God had *personally made Himself visible and known to*

them through Divine creation (cf. John 1:3; Acts 17:24; Col. 1:16). *This is called "natural revelation" in contrast to what God has said in the Scriptures, which is called "special revelation."*

20. ***"For the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, both his eternal power and deity, unto the end that they are without excuse;"***

In the previous verse the *fact* was stated that God manifested a basic knowledge of Himself to them. We pointed out that this is more accurately translated "among them," i.e., this knowledge was obvious in the very *midst of them*. It was objective knowledge revealed through that which surrounded them. This verse explains the *manner* in which this knowledge of God was made a part of their environment.

Paul uses the phrases "that which is known of God" and "the invisible things of him" as synonymous. The basic knowledge of God, which Paul has reference to here, involved the invisible things relating to him. The word "invisible" (αορατα) means that which is *not seen*, that which *cannot be seen*, or that is *unseen*. This word is used to depict God as being invisible (Col. 1:15; 1 Tim. 1:17; cf. Heb. 11:27). God, and the things which characterize Him, are invisible spiritual entities (John 1:18; 4:24).

Paul's argument here is that God can be known *by what He has done*. This means that men have had access to a basic knowledge of God ever since the creation of the world, the epitome of His doing. For this reason Paul says that the invisible things of God are capable of being known "from the creation of the world" (απο κτισεως κοσμου). Prior to the creation of man God had created the universe and most of what was in it (Gen. 1:1-25); therefore Adam, apart from God specially speaking to him, had a basic knowledge of the invisible God and was doubly without excuse!

The statement "the things that are made" needs to be carefully examined. The two words translated "the things that are made" (τοις ποιημασιν), a plural article and noun form of "ποιεω," appear to have intrinsic, present tense significance. We are not pointing this out to support the diabolical, hypothetical, and unfounded humanistic theory of evolution, but to *leave room* for alterations in the earth's surface as a result of the Flood and other Divinely controlled forces. God through Christ has both created all things and continues to sustain all things (Col. 1:16-17).

Now let us turn our attention to the thought that the invisible things of God are "being understood by the things that are made." The Greek word translated "being understood" (νοουμενα) is a present passive participle and speaks of "the things that are made" *stimulating the mind, exercising the intellect,* and *giving comprehension* of the invisible things of God. The passive voice suggests that *God is using* "the things that are made" to feed into the minds of men truth pertaining to His invisible Person.

As a result of the mental understanding men gain through observing "the

things that are made," the invisible things of God "are clearly seen" (καθορατται). This Greek word is derived from two words which combined literally mean *to look down upon, to accurately see*, or to have mental insight, perception, and comprehension of the invisible things of God. Since both the participle "νοουμενα" and the leading verb "καθορατται" are in the present tense, Paul is saying that while the invisible things of God are being understood by creation *simultaneously* these things are clearly seen. God gives instantaneous insight as men impartially observe creation, *understand* its relation to the Creator, and *clearly see* Who He is through it!

According to Paul's brief statement in this verse *what aspects* of God's Person are clearly seen? The answer is "both his eternal power and deity." The Greek word translated "eternal" (αιδιος) means always existing and lasting forever. It is used only twice in the New Testament, here and in Jude, verse 6, where it refers to fallen angels being kept in *eternal* bonds unto the great judgment day. The fact of creation, the very existence of all things, is an incomprehensible manifestation of the "power" (δυναμις), *ability, might* and *strength* of the Eternal God (cf. Rom. 9:17; Heb. 1:3).

The second aspect of God's Person which is clearly seen through creation is His "deity" (θειοτης), *divinity* and *Godhead*. One great enough to create the universe would have to be Divine, the Triune God, and the sole Deity. The source of the tremendous power required to make all things cannot be explained apart from Deity. The power involved in creation points to *One Who is God* (2 Peter 1:3). On the other hand, God, the one and only Deity, must be posited as the only one who could display such power.

God has manifested a basic knowledge of Himself to men, His eternal power and Deity are clearly seen, "unto the end that they [men] are without excuse." The Greek phrase translated "unto the end that" (εις το ειναι) consistently conveys the idea of *the object or purpose being*, *as a result of*, or because of which they are without excuse. The ultimate object and final reason for which God revealed His eternal power and the fact that HE IS GOD is that men who reject Him might *have no excuse*.

The Greek word translated "without excuse" (αναπολογητους) is derived from a combining of three words which literally mean *not a word from*, to have *nothing to say*, to be *inexcusable*. Paul uses this word only one other time, in Romans 2:1, where he says that the Jews are also without excuse. Both the Gentiles and Jews are without excuse before God on the basis of natural revelation. The Jews also had special revelation which meant that God placed higher demands on them. Failure to keep these demands made them doubly inexcusable (cf. Rom. 3:19). May God the Holy Spirit indelibly impress upon our minds the fact that *every man is responsible before God on the basis of natural revelation* (vv. 19-20). *Divine election does not absolve men from this responsibility.*

21. ***"wherefore having known God they did not glorify or give thanks to him as God, but they were made vain in their reasonings and their senseless heart was darkened."***

The participle translated "having known" (γνοντες) is in the aorist tense and refers to the *knowledge which they had* of God's eternal power and deity. The aorist participle always points to action *prior* to that of the main verb or verbs, which means that they *possessed* this knowledge of God, but in spite of this, they did not glorify or give thanks to Him as God. The principle involved here is that they had a knowledge of God, they knew the eternal power and deity of His Person, but *they refused* to act in accordance with this knowledge; *they deliberately declined* to glorify and give Him thanks, therefore they were without excuse. To know who God is, to fail to respond to God, is to be without excuse before God.

Let us consider the significance of the statement: "They did not glorify or give thanks to him as God." The Greek word order is "having known God not as God they glorified." The key word we need to observe is "as" (ως) which may be translated *even as, like as*, as fits, etc. The implication is that those who know who God is should respond to Him *as God, as it befits God, and in a manner appropriate to God.*

According to this verse the appropriate response is to *glorify and thank God.* The word "glorify" (εδοξασαν) means to *magnify, praise, and extol* God. The word translated "give thanks" (ηυχαριστησαν) is derived from the words "ευ" and "χαρις" and literally means to express good grace, hence, *gratefulness and appreciation* to God. Thus we see that fitting response to God, the Creator of this universe, is to *glorify, magnify* and *praise* Him and to express *thanks, gratitude* and *appreciation* to Him.

Instead of having the positive response of glorifying and thanking God, "they were made vain in their reasonings and their senseless heart was darkened." The strong adversative conjunction "but" (αλλα) indicates that their response was negative instead of positive; God was totally *ignored, disregarded* and *unnoticed*. As a result of this passive but complete neglect of God, "they were made vain" (εματαιωθησαν) *empty, purposeless* and *ineffective* in their reasonings (1 Cor. 3:20; 1 Peter 1:18). The word "reasoning" (διαλογισμοις) conveys the idea of *inner thoughts, deliberation* and *doubts.* We have pictured here minds that were emptily and purposelessly cogitating on that which was *useless* or on their doubts.

Another result of their ignoring God was that "their senseless heart was darkened." The Greek word translated "senseless" (ασυνεrof) is derived from the three words "α," "συν" and "ιημι" and basically means *not to bring together*, hence, *without understanding*, and *unintelligent*. The word "darkened" (εσκοτισθη) speaks of a *blackout, morally unable to see, little or no comprehension,* and *spiritual opaqueness.* The thought is that in as much as their mind was without understanding, as seen in their failure to both glorify and thank God, their heart was *darkened* and *incapacitated* in its ability to receive spiritual light (Rom. 10:19; 11:10). Rejection of the light of natural revelation, the eternal power and deity of God, precluded their comprehending any further revelation. None of these people, left to themselves with a darkened heart void of

understanding, would be interested in Jesus Christ (John 3:19-20).

The word translated "they were made vain" (εματαιωθησαν) and the word for "was darkened" (εσκοτισθη) are both in the passive voice and the aorist tense. The passive voice indicates that the *subject is acted upon,* i.e., these people *"were made vain"* or empty, and their senseless *heart was darkened*. Having totally ignored God an outside person took over and produced emptiness and darkness in their lives. They were not on a self-produced downward spiral, but were the victims of external downward pressure. We know that this emptiness and darkness was the *result of their ignoring God*, a failure to glorify and thank Him. But, *who* was producing this emptiness and darkness in them?

Three times in this chapter we have the statement that "God gave them up." The word translated "gave up" (παρεδωκεν) means to *give over, hand over, deliver over,* and *betray*. To the casual reader it might appear that God was the one who produces this emptiness and darkness in them, but the language used does not convey this thought; it only says that *God gave them over, delivered them over, or abandoned them*. Paul uses the same word in First Corinthians 5:5, and in First Timothy 1:20, in describing the *deliverance of certain men to Satan*. Those whom Paul describes in this first chapter of Romans volitionally ignored God, not glorifying or thanking Him as God. Therefore, He gave them over and abandoned them to Satan.

Again, we emphasize, the passive voice makes it crystal clear that an outside person was producing an emptiness and darkness in them; however it is extremely important that we attribute this to the *right person.* If in Adam they volitionally ignored both what God had said and who He is, His eternal power and deity, as a result of their obedience to Satan, then it follows that he *would continue to make* their mental processes empty and spiritually darken their minds (1 Cor. 11:3; 2 Tim. 3:8).

We must keep very clearly in mind the *difference* between God giving men up, abandoning them to Satan's influence, as over against His actually hardening them. Since men have rebelled against God in Adam, they are sinners by nature (Eph. 2:3) and are under the degenerative darkening and hardening process of Satan.

We must jealously maintain that men, on the basis of their *free-will volition in Adam and Eve,* sinned and are hardened and calloused in their sin by Satan whom they originally obeyed. The pivotal point between God being a participant in the sin of the human race or not being a participant *is the free will of Adam and Eve*. God created them perfect, they had *true free will*. God gave them the choice to obey or not to obey, and of their own free volition they chose not to obey, thus committing sin (Rom. 5:12-14).

The fact that Adam and Eve had true free-will, and *out of this free-will sinned against God,* totally does away with the thought that God was a participant in their sin because He had created them. Even as in the case of original sin, likewise, in the case of men having their minds more deeply darkened by this sin, we need to take great care before we attribute this to God lest we find ourselves

making God a participant in sin!

22. ***"Professing to be wise ones they were made fools,"***

This is a continuing history of the degradation of the human race. The Greek word translated "professing" (φασκοντες) is a present participle and speaks of those who were *claiming, affirming* and *alleging* that they were wise (cf. Acts 24:9; 25:19). The word translated "wise ones" (σοφοι) is a nominative plural noun and means that they considered themselves to be *skilled, to have expertise* and *to be learned.* In the New Testament this word is used with reference to those who had *fleshly wisdom* (1 Cor. 1:19, 27), *a wisdom contrary* to the wisdom of God (1 Cor. 1:25; 3:19-20), and the wisdom of God (Eph. 5:15; cf. 1 Cor. 2:6-7). The use of the present tense indicates that as those who had rejected God they *continuously asserted* that they were the wise ones, the intelligentsia, and those who possessed all knowledge.

The statement "they were made fools" is a translation of the Greek verb "εμωρανθησαν" which is in the aorist tense and passive voice. The obvious meaning of the aorist tense, as used here, is that while they were professing to be wise they were actually *being made fools*. Paul looks back on the process of their being made fools as a *completed transaction*. The passive voice suggests that they were made fools *by one outside of themselves*, i.e., by Satan.

Now bringing these facts together, and considering the fuller meaning of "εμωρανθησαν," Paul is saying that even during the time they were alleging to be intelligentsia Satan was deceptively making them foolish, involving them in folly, and making their thinking insipid and blah (cf. Matt. 5:13; 1 Cor. 1:20; 3:19). This is certainly an accurate picture of the insufferably crass, material-energy humanist of today who repudiates the Divine Laws governing the universe!

23. ***"and they exchanged the glory of the incorruptible God for the likeness of an image of corruptible man and of birds and of four-footed beasts and of creeping things."***

If we are going to accurately follow Paul's thought here, we need to grasp the meaning of the word translated "exchanged" (ηλλαξαν). This word is derived from "αλλος" which means *another* or something *other*. It has the implied meaning of alteration so as to be *like another thing even to the point of being exchanged for it.* As used in the New Testament it conveys the idea of changing the form of something so as *to become something other* than what it was or *to replace it with another thing* (cf. Acts 6:14; 1 Cor. 15:51-52; Heb. 1:12). This context favors the translation *exchanged*; i.e., they replaced the glory of God with mundane images.

Through natural revelation they knew God's eternal power and deity but refused to glorify Him as God (vv. 20-21). Verse 21 infers that there is a *special glory* with which God is to be glorified. This verse clearly speaks of "the glory of the incorruptible God." The use of the genitive case makes it evident that Paul is speaking of the *unique glory that belongs to God* who is "incorruptible" (αφθαρτου), *not subject to corruption or decay,* hence*, imperishable and immortal*

(cf. 1 Tim. 1:17). This distinct, special, and unique glory which belongs to the immortal God is not something that is changeable; however, it is that which could be exchanged or replaced by something else such as corruptible images.

Now let us consider that for which they exchanged the glory of God. On the one hand we have in this verse the *glory of God* and on the other hand a *description of what replaced it*. Paul says that it was exchanged "for the likeness of an image of corruptible man and of birds and of four-footed beasts and of creeping things." The Greek word for "likeness" (ομοιωματι) means *that which has been made like,* to *resemble,* or to *be similar to something else*. The word "image" (εικονος) depicts a physical *figure, effigy, or statue* of something. Instead of relishing in the glory of the incorruptible God they were relishing in physical images of "corruptible" (φθαρτου), *perishable*, and *deteriorating* beings. The contrast Paul is depicting here is their leaving the *incorruptible and imperishable God* for images representing corruptible and perishable creatures.

Paul mentions four different forms of physical life of which they made images and statues. First, they worshiped the images and statues of *corruptible man* (ανθρωποω; cf. Dan. 3:1-7; Acts 14:11-15). Second, they worshiped the images of *birds* (πετεινων), i.e., of flying or winged birds and creatures. Third, they worshiped *four footed beasts* (τετραποδων), beasts or animals with four feet (cf. Exodus 32:4-6; Rev. 13:14-15). Fourth, they worshiped *creeping things* (ερπετων), that which creeps or crawls, hence, serpents or reptiles (cf. Acts 10:12).

Summarizing, this gives us a picture of the *gross idolatry* men were subjected to after they refused to glorify God as God (cf. Acts 17:16). For those who are rejecting God today the idolatry is *just as gross*, more hedonistic, very erotic, and utterly self-centered as they blindly worship at the material energy shrine of chance.

24. ***"Wherefore God gave them over in the lusts of their hearts unto uncleanness to dishonor their bodies among themselves,"***

Because they had exchanged the glory of the incorruptible God for an image of corruptible man, birds, beasts, and reptiles, "God gave them over in the lusts of their hearts." The little Greek word translated "wherefore" (διο) is derived from the words "δια" and "ο" and literally means *on account of which* or *because of*. The thought is that on account of or because of their exchanging God's glory for idols of corruptible beings God gave them over. The Greek word for "gave over" (παρεδωκεν) comes from the words "παρα" and "διδωμι" and basically means *to give beside, to give up, to abandon, or deliver up.* This word indicates that God abandoned and left these men to the consequences of their actions.

Now let us look at the statement that "God gave them over in the lusts of their hearts." The phrase "in the lusts" (εν ταις επιθυμιαις) is in the locative case and means *in the sphere of the lusts* or *in the place and location of the lusts*. The Greek word "*lusts*" (επιθυμιαις) may equally well be translated *desires, longings* and *cravings*. Now let us observe that these lusts and desires were "of their

hearts" (των καρδιων αυτων), i.e., *they belonged to* and were *owned* by their hearts, by their *minds*, and their *inner beings*. Bringing these thoughts together, Paul is saying that God gave them over and abandoned them in the place or location of lusts and desires which belong to or are owned by their hearts. Graphically speaking, God abandoned them in the refuse dump resulting from the excrement and offscouring of corrupt hearts (v. 21; 2:5; Eph. 4:18).

Paul says that God's abandoning them in the lusts of their evil hearts was "unto uncleanness" (εις ακαθαρσιαν). This word is sometimes used of general moral uncleanness (Matt. 23:27; 1 Thess. 2:3), but it is most frequently used in contexts dealing with sexual uncleanness (2 Cor. 12:21; Gal. 5:19; Eph. 5:3; Col. 3:5). What follows in this verse and context clearly indicates that Paul is using this word with reference to gross, sexual uncleanness. The end of their having been abandoned in the lusts and cravings of their evil hearts is sexual uncleanness causing them "to dishonor" (ατιμαζεσθαι), *disgrace* and *insult* their bodies among or between themselves.

25. ***"who exchanged the truth of God for the lie, and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator, who is blessed forever. Amen."***

With regard to these ungodly men who are restraining the truth (v. 18), Paul says that they have "exchanged the truth of God for a lie." It is very important that we carefully consider the meaning of the word translated "exchanged" (μετηλλαξαν). This word is derived from the two words "μετα" and "αλλασσω." The latter word used by itself quite consistently means *change* (Acts 6:14; 1 Cor. 15:51-52; Gal. 4:20), whereas the preposition "μετα" prefixed to it alters its meaning to *exchanged* as in the aorist tense used here. This word is used only one other time in the New Testament (v. 26) and in this instance may also be readily translated *exchanged*.

Now let us look at what they exchanged for what. Paul says that they "exchanged the truth of God for the lie." Since the words "of God" (του θεου) are in the genitive case they clearly refer to the truth as that which *belongs to God, which is God's*, and, as we have it in this context, *which God has given to men* (vv. 18-20; 3:7). That for which they exchanged the truth which God had given to them was "for the lie" (εν τω ψευδει).

Since we are certain that the meaning of the verb in this clause is *exchanged*, it follows that the best English translation for this Greek phrase is *for the liee*. Here Paul is using the preposition "εν" and the dative case with the meaning of *for*. Another possible translation would be to consider "εν" with the locative case and to look at the exchange as being *in place of the lie*. The Word for "lie" (ψευδει) means *that which is false, a falsehood,* or *an untruth*. It is the opposite of that which is true (Eph. 4:25; 1 John 2:21, 27). Truth is of God; likewise, the lie is of the devil (John 8:44; 2 Thess. 2:9). They literally exchanged the truth of God for the lies of the devil (Gen. 3:4-6).

Bereft of the truth, wallowing in lies, and dominated by the devil, Paul says,

they "worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator." The Greek word for "worshiped" (εσεβασθησαν) is in the passive voice and aorist tense, which means that Satan *caused* them to *worship, adore* and *venerate* the creature, i.e., to make idols in the likeness of the image of corruptible man (v. 23).

The word translated "served" (ελατρευσαν) is commonly used in the New Testament to depict rendering service, homage, and offerings to God. As used in this verse it speaks of rendering the service due God to the creature, i.e., to idols of corruptible man. The preposition translated "beyond" (παρα) is commonly translated *above* or *more than* when used with the accusative case in comparative clauses. Where we have the idea of *exchange*, such as in this verse under consideration, it appears that "παρα" must be translated *rather than,* i.e., they "worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator." The obvious meaning of this context demands a *total exchange* from worshiping and serving God to worshiping and serving the creature.

Paul ends this verse by exalting God, the one "who is blessed forever. Amen." The Greek word for "blessed" (ευλογητος) is derived from the two words "ευ" and "λογος" and means *one who is spoken well of, one who is worthy of praise,* or *one who is to be lauded*. The words translated "forever" (εις τους αιωνας) literally mean unto the ages. This is a phrase which has *no end*, hence that which is endless, forever, and eternal. Living in the midst of a humanistic generation our sense of the *sovereignty* and *greatness* of God has been dulled. Now we need to pore over His Word, to see His Majestic Person, and out of the depths of our being join Paul in exalting Him as the one who is blessed forever!

26. ***"For this reason God gave them up unto passions of dishonor; for their females exchanged the natural use for that contrary to nature,"***

The phrase translated "for this reason" (δια τουτο) relates back to what has preceded for the *cause or reason* of that which is to follow. It is commonly translated *because of this* or *on account of this*. The thought is that because they had exchanged the truth of God for the lie, and because they had worshiped and served the creature beyond the Creator, "God gave them up unto passions of dishonor." The phrase "God gave them up" (παρεδωκεν) indicates that God acted as the subject, they were acted upon as the direct object, and the aorist tense implies that this action took place at a given point of time in past history.

The Greek verb for "gave up" (παρεδωκεν), as we have already observed, is derived from the words "παρα" and "διδωμι" and basically means that God *gave them beside, gave them up, delivered them over,* and *abandoned them*. This verb is used three times in this chapter, all in the aorist tense, to emphasize that the Gentile's refusal to acknowledge God as God (v. 21), and the subsequent apostasy, *caused God to abandon them* to the lusts of their depraved minds and hearts.

In this verse Paul says that God specifically abandoned them "unto passions

of dishonor." The preposition "εις" suggests that God gave them over *unto the end of* fulfilling the *feelings, longings,* and *passions* of dishonor. The word translated "dishonor" (ατιμιας) basically means that which is *without value*, that which is the *opposite of glory* (1 Cor. 11:14-15; 15:43), hence, *inglorious or disgraceful*. Since the word for dishonor (ατιμιας) is in the genitive case, indicating possession, the thought is that God abandoned them to the *passions and sensuous feelings belonging to or associated with what is inglorious, disgraceful and dishonorable.*

Having declared that God abandoned them unto the category of dishonorable passions, Paul now explains the nature of some of these passions. Speaking of the Gentile world, he says, "For their females exchanged the natural use for that contrary to nature." The Greek word translated "females" (θηλειαι) literally means this in contrast to the males of verse 27. It is interesting that Paul singles out the females first in delineating the inordinate expressions of passions among the Gentiles. It appears that this order of presentation provides a more natural flow into the gross sins of the males.

The Greek word translated "exchanged" (μετηλλαξαν) is derived from the words "μετα" and "αλλασσω." The latter word alone means to *change* or *alter*, but with the preposition "μεrα" prefixed to it, the meaning is to *exchange one thing for another thing, α reciprocal giving and receiving*, hence, in the aorist tense, *exchanged*. The thought is that the Gentile females exchanged the "natural use" (φυσικην χρησιν), *the use according to creation, the use for which their bodies were designed*, for a use contrary to nature. The Greek used here brings out the idea that they were giving over their bodies *unto the beside or beyond nature use* (εις την παρα φυσιν), i.e., they were using their bodies in a manner *opposed to their natural purpose and that for which they were created.* Paul is undoubtedly referring to lesbianism here, which is also implied by the word "likewise" (ομοιως) in the following verse.

27. ***"and likewise also the males, having left the natural use of the females, they burned in their lust toward one another, males with males working lewdness, and receiving the penalty in themselves required by their error."***

Here we see that "likewise" (ομοιως), *in the same way*, as the females were involved in homosexuality, the males were deeply engrossed in the same. Paul says that "the males, having left the natural use of the females, they burned in their lust toward one another." The aorist participle translated "having left" (αφεντες) means that *after* or *following* their leaving the natural use of the females, "they burned in their lust toward one another." Nothing is said or implied as to whether or not "the natural use" (την φυσικην χρσιν) of the females was exclusively for the purpose of procreation.

The Greek word translated "burned" (εξεκαυθησαν) is from "εκ" and "καιω" and means to *hotly burn* or to *excessively burn*. Having left the females, those who are to provide for the natural needs of the males *within the marital rela-*

tionship (1 Cor. 7:9), they excessively burned in lust toward each other. According to what Paul says in the total context this rampant homosexuality was the consequence of their being abandoned by God unto dishonorable and disgraceful passions (cf. Eph. 4:17-19).

Now that we have observed the excessive sexual vigor of these depraved Gentile males, let us consider how it was expressed, namely, through their "lust toward one another." The Greek word for "lust" (ορεξει) means that they were *stretching and reaching out, longing for,* and *craving* homosexual relations with one another. The use of the preposition "εις" with the reciprocal pronoun "αλληλους" implies that these males mutually longed for and craved *unto the end to reciprocally engage in detestable sodomy with* one another.

Lest there be any misunderstanding as to what he is talking about, Paul adds, "males with males working lewdness." The present participle indicates that they were continuing to practice "lewdness" (ασχημοσυνην), literally, that which is totally *unfashionable, unbecoming, indecorous* and *unseemly* in the light of God's standards.

As a result of this outrageous sexual conduct, Paul says, they were "receiving the penalty in themselves required by their error." The Greek word which we have translated "penalty" (αντιμισθιαν) is so designated for the sake of clarity of thought. It is derived form "αντι" and "μισθος" and basically means to receive *wages* or *a reward in place of* or *in lieu of something that has been done.* Paul is affirming here that they *were receiving* the necessary return wages, retribution, and recompense for their *wanderings and going astray* into gross sexual perversion. The language used here makes it obvious that they were being inflicted with the *penalty due their perversion*, a penalty that was "in themselves" (εν εαυτοις), which is apparently syphilis, gonorrhea, herpes, or a similar venereal disease.

In summary, we need to recognize that we live in a universe which is governed by a Moral God. Every thought and every act will be *justly requited* either directly or indirectly, either presently or in the future, or both. The Old and the New Testaments clearly inform us that *God will not tolerate sexual sins*. These sins have the potential of calling forth the immediate judgment of God against those who commit them, such as venereal disease, mental stress and derangement, illegitimate births, etc.

Paul says in this verse that God will mete out the penalty *which is necessitated* (ην εδει) by the sexual error committed. Beyond the immediate judgment against those engaged in these sins, there is also the future judgment of sinners. Those who are saved out of a past life of sexual corruption, washed from these sins by the Blood of Christ, may continue to be afflicted with the immediate consequences of these sins, but *sheltered in Christ they will not be judged with the world.*

28. ***"And even as they did not prove God, to have in perfect knowledge, God gave them over unto an unproved mind, to do the things not fitting,"***

What Paul says in this verse elaborates on what he has already said in verses 19-24. God had manifested a knowledge of Himself among men, namely, His eternal power and deity, through that which He had created. Even though men knew that the Creator was God, they did not glorify Him as God, wherefore He gave them up to the lusts of their hearts.

In this 28th verse Paul says that they were given up because "they did not prove God." Many translations have veered away from the literal meaning of the Greek word translated "prove" (εδοκιμασαν); however, on the basis of the predominant meaning of this word, as used in the Greek New Testament, there is no justification for deviating from its literal connotation. This word basically means that they *did not prove God by trying and testing Him.* When God made Himself known to them, instead of responding by inclining toward Him and proving His Deity, they were ungrateful (v. 21; cf. Rom. 12:2; Eph. 5:10). This same principle of acquiring knowledge through doing God's will, i.e., through testing and proving God's will, is set forth in John 7:17; (cf. 9:31).

Now let us consider that the failure of these men to prove God prevented them from having Him "in perfect knowledge." The Greek noun translated "perfect knowledge" (επιγνωσει) is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "γινωσκω" and conveys the idea that as a consequence of not proving God they did not come into the sphere of a *full and complete knowledge* of God. The implication is that it is necessary to first prove God, to believe that He is (Heb. 11:6), before one can have a perfect knowledge of Him (cf. Rom. 8:8). When these men had a knowledge of God given to them, when they clearly saw His eternal power and Deity, if they had proved His reality by believing that He is, a whole new vista of knowing God would have opened up to them (Col. 1:10).

Instead of these men beginning with the limited knowledge they had through natural revelation, and positively launching out to prove and affirm that God is, they negatively did not glorify Him, were unthankful, and therefore are without excuse. On account of this "God gave them over unto an unproved mind." As we have already noticed, "to give over" comes from "καρα" and "διδωμι" and basically means that God *gave them up, delivered them up,* and *handed them over* unto an unproved mind. Paul uses this verb in verse 24 to indicate that God gave them over to the sphere of the lusts of their hearts; in verse 26 he says that God gave them over unto passions of dishonor; and for the final time in this verse, God gave them over unto the end of an unproved mind.

In view of the varying translations we need to consider the exact meaning of the adjective which defines the kind of a mind to which they were delivered. The Greek word translated "unproved" (αδοκιμον) is derived from "α" and "δοκιμος," which is used as an adjective form of the above verb "δοκιμαζω" with a negating alpha prefixed to it, and literally means that they were given over to an *untested and untried mind* or to a *failed-the-test mind,* hence, to an *unproved or unapproved mind.* There is an interesting relation between their refusal to prove God and their subsequent deliverance over unto an unproved mind. Failure to utilize and build upon the knowledge of God given to them resulted in a "mind"

(νουν), *intellectual faculty,* and *seat of reasoning* which had flunked the test and was incapable of rational thinking approved by God (2 Tim. 3:8; Titus 1:16).

Having been given over to an unproved mind they "do the things not fitting." The Greek infinitive translated "to do" (ποιειν) is in the present tense which indicates that they *continuously do*, i.e., their course in life is one of unfitting practices. The Greek participle rendered "fitting" (καθηκοντα) comes from the preposition "κατα" and the verb "ηκω" and basically means to *come down, reach,* and *extend to*. In actual usage it has the meaning of that which is *fitting, becoming*, and *proper*. The only other time it is used in the New Testament is in Acts 22:22, where it obviously has this connotation. Extra-biblical Koine Greek attests to this meaning. Summarizing, as these men repudiated the knowledge of God given to them, God gave them over to an unproved mind, which in turn caused them to practice unfitting and unbecoming things according to His standard.

29. ***"having been filled with all unrighteousness, wickedness, covetousness, evil; full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, malignity; whisperers,"***

After God gave them up unto an unproved mind, they began to do "things not fitting," some of which Paul delineates in this and the following verses. He groups these things into two categories. First, he uses four words to describe what they became in the very *essence* of their being. Second, he uses seventeen words and phrases to express *how* their depraved nature *manifested* itself.

Paul uses the perfect passive participle translated "having been filled" (πεπληρωμενους), which may also be rendered *having been pervaded,* or *having been infused,* "with all" (παση) or *with every* unrighteousness, wickedness, covetousness, and evil. The perfect tense and passive voice point back to the time when God gave them over, *when Satan took possession*, and filled them with his diabolical characteristics. The passive voice makes it clear that these characteristics were not self-generated, but rather were implanted in them by the arch-enemy of God, namely, Satan (Eph. 2:1-3).

Now let us examine the four things which Satan infused into their void-of-God beings. First, he filled them with all "unrighteousness" (αδικια). This word speaks of that which is *contrary to what is right and just*, hence, not to be right is to be filled with *wrongness* and not to be just is to be filled with *unjustness*. In Second Thessalonians 2:12 Paul confirms that this is the state of nonbelievers, for he says, they "had pleasure in unrighteousness" (cf. Rom. 3:5; 1 John 5:17).

Second, Satan filled those who refused to acknowledge God with all "wickedness" (πονηρια). This word portrays the idea of *badness, rottenness,* and *unsoundness.* Paul uses it in Ephesians 6:12 with reference to "the spiritual forces of wickedness in the heavenlies." This statement definitely associates it with the badness and rottenness of Satan. Jesus uses a cognate form to describe bad or rotten fruit (Matt. 7:17-18).

Third, Satan filled those who rejected God's eternal power and deity with all

"covetousness" (πλεονεξια). This Greek word means *a desire to possess over and above others, greediness, extortion, and overreaching.* In Ephesians 4:29 Paul corroborates the fact that this was an unsaved Gentile characteristic, for he says, "They gave themselves over to lasciviousness to work all uncleanness in covetousness." This literally means that their working was for gain *in the sphere of covetousness* (cf. Col. 3:5; 2 Peter 2:14).

Fourth, Satan filled those who deliberately rebelled against God with all "evil" (κακια). This word is often used with a broad general meaning to depict that which is the *opposite of what is good and virtuous* (Matt. 6:34; 1 Cor. 14:20). It may be used with reference to a *malicious mind-set* (Acts 8:21-23). Sometimes it appears to include the thought of a *vicious and injurious attitude* toward others (Eph. 4:31; Col. 3:8; Titus 3:3).

The above are *general characteristics*, infused by Satan, which depict the depraved nature of all unregenerate Gentiles. Some manuscripts contain a fifth word in this list, namely, *fornication* (πορνεια); however, in view of its absence from some of the best manuscripts and incongruity in this context, we prefer the above as an accurate replica of the original.

As those whom Satan had filled with all unrighteousness, wickedness, covetousness, and evil, Paul now speaks of them as being "full of envy, murder, strife, deceit, malignity; whisperers." In this category he is giving a resume of the specific ways in which their depraved nature manifested itself. He refers to them as being "full" (υεσΤους), *replete*, and *completely occupied* with the doing of certain things.

First, they were full of "envy" (φθονου). This means that they were *jealous, begrudging,* and *vindictively rivalling* one another. Envy motivated the religious leaders to deliver Jesus to Pilate (Matt. 27:18). Envy is listed as one of the works of the flesh (Gal. 5:21). Prior to being saved all believers lived in a state of envy (Titus 3:3).

Second, they were full of "murder" (φονου). This means that they were *homicidal, killing and slaughtering*. As a result of having been given over by God, and being infused with a satanic mind-set, their hearts bred homicides (Matt. 15:19).

Third, they were full of "strife" (εριδος). This indicates that they were *contending, quarrelling, and wrangling* with each other. Paul associates striving with the flesh and natural man (1 Cor. 3:3; Gal. 5:20). Titus is commanded to circumvent quarreling, particularly about the law (Titus 3:9).

Fourth, they were full of "deceit" (δολου). Possible English equivalents are *fraud, guile, and craftiness*. It has the basic idea of catching with a snare, hence, *trickery*. Paul uses this word to describe Elymas the sorcerer, a son of the devil, on the Island of Cyprus (Acts 13:10).

Fifth, they were full of "malignity" (κακοηθειας). This word is derived from

"κακος" and "ηθος" and means an *evil frame of mind, an evil character, and a malicious attitude.* This is the only time it is used in the New Testament.

In setting forth the previous five things they were doing, Paul says that they were *full of them*, i.e., envy, murder, strife, deceit, and malignity. As he proceeds from this point on he designates *them* by the noun which describes what they were doing. Those who were whispering are called "whisperers" (ψιθυριστας). This Greek word refers to those who *secretly attack, slander, and malign a person's character.* This is the only time this particular form is used in the New Testament.

30. ***"backbiters, God-haters, insulters, haughty, boasters, inventors of evil, disobedient to parents,"***

In this verse Paul continues to speak of those whom God had given up, those whom Satan had filled with all unrighteousness, wickedness, covetousness, and evil, as he goes on listing the specific sins in which they were engrossed. Beginning with the last item mentioned in the previous verse, namely, "whisperers," he starts naming them on the basis of the sins they were committing. In other words, *their names designated what they were doing*, and the first such designation is that they were *whisperers*, i.e., those who were attacking, slandering, and maligning the characters of others.

Second, this verse begins by calling them "backbiters" (καταλαλους). The Greek word is derived from "κατα" and "λαλεω," and in the verbal form literally means to *speak against, to verbally downgrade*, hence, character assassinators. This is the only time this noun form is used in the New Testament; however, the verb is used five times. Peter uses it with reference to the unsaved Gentiles who *speak evil* of believers as evil doers (1 Peter 2:12).

Third, they are described as "God-haters" (θεοστυγεις). This Greek word is derived from "θεος" and "στυγεω" and literally means one who *hates, detests*, and *expresses enmity and hostility* against God. This is the only time this compound word is used in the New Testament; however, on the basis of etymology, its meaning is obvious. The noun form of the last part of this word is used by Paul to describe what all men were before they were saved, namely, *haters* (στυγητοι; Titus 3:3).

Fourth, Paul speaks of them as "insulters" (υβριστας). The verb form of this Greek word means to act *outrageously, atrociously, insolently, insultingly, despicably*, etc. The only other time this word is used in the New Testament is in First Timothy 1:13, where Paul says of himself, "One formerly being a blasphemer and persecutor and *insulter* (υβριστην)." In view of this noun's association with other words in these two contexts, we prefer to translate it as *insulters* or *insolent persons.*

Fifth, these men are depicted as "haughty" (υπερηφανους). To bring out the Greek thought most accurately this noun might be better translated *haughty ones*. This Greek word is derived from "υπερ" and "φαrνω" and literally means to *appear above,* to make a *super appearance*, hence, *haughty* and *arrogant*

persons. This noun is used four other times in the New Testament. In Second Timothy 3:2, Paul uses it to describe the supercilious attitude of men in the last days.

Sixth, these men are called "boasters" (αλαζονας). It is not easy to lay hold of the basic meaning of this noun, but it appears to speak of those who are *ostentatious*, who *draw attention to themselves*, and who *crave the vain glory and admiration of men*. The only other time it is used in the New Testament is in Second Timothy 3:2, where it is used in conjunction with the above word translated *haughty* (υπερηφανοι). The English clause, *boastful self-exalters*, seems to come close to the meaning of the Greek.

Seventh, these men are designated as "inventors of evil" (εφευρετας κακων). The Greek noun translated *inventors* is a combination of the preposition "επι" and "ευρισκω" and literally means *to find or come upon, to discover, to or invent or devise*. This is the only time it is used in the New Testament. The word for "evil" (κακων) speaks of that which is *bad, foul,* and *wrong*. As though there weren't enough ways to express evil in the world, these men find, discover, and invent more ways to manifest what is bad and foul.

Eighth, Paul describes them as a "disobedient to parents" (γονευσιν απειθεις) people. The Greek noun rendered "disobedient" (απειθεις) comes from "α" and "πειθω" and basically means that they were *unpersuaded*, hence, *uncompliant* and *not obedient* to parents. Paul uses this same clause to depict those living in the last days (2 Tim. 3:2). Obedience to parents is a *universal Divine requisite* for all economies.

31. ***"without understanding, covenant-breakers, without natural affection, unmerciful,"***

Continuing from the previous verse - ninth, Paul says that they are men "without understanding" (ασυνετους). This Greek word is derived from "α" and "συνετος." The latter of these is a combination of "συν" and "ιημι" which basically mean to *send-with* or *send-together*, hence, it has the idea of joining together that which produces *understanding, comprehension*, and *perception*. The prefixed alpha (α) negates this meaning, making it just the opposite, hence, these men are *void, without*, and *do not have understanding* nor *comprehension* of knowledge and truth pertaining to God.

Tenth, Paul describes these men as being "covenantbreakers" (ασυνθετους). This Greek word is derived from "α" and "συνθετος," the latter being a combination of "συν" and "τιθημι" and basically means to place with, hence, has the idea of *making a covenant, an agreement,* or *a promise.* The prefixed alpha (α) gives it the opposite meaning, namely, these men are those who *dishonor and break covenants, repudiate agreement,* and are *faithless in keeping promises.* This is the only time this word is used in the New Testament.

Eleventh, these men are characterized as being "without natural affection" (αστοργους). This word comes from "α" and "στοργους." The latter word is

commonly used to express the love and affection that *naturally exists* between parents and children and vice versa as well as between a husband and wife. In other words, it speaks of the natural, inborn love, affection, and caring common to a family. Again we observe, the prefixed alpha (α) turns what is natural inside out. These men are *void of the last vestige of human affection and concern* with which man was originally created in the likeness and image of God. The only other time this word appears in the New Testament is in Second Timothy 3:3, where Paul uses it to describe the characteristics of men in the last days.

Twelfth, Paul affirms that these men whom God had given up are "unmerciful" (ανελεημονας). This Greek word is derived from "ανα" and "ελεος" and basically speaks of those who are *void of mercy, pity,* and *compassion,* hence, those who are *merciless, cruel,* and *brutal*. This is the only time this particular form is used in the New Testament; however, in James 2:13, we have the basic form "ανελεος," where James says, "For judgment is *unmerciful* to the one not practicing mercy." This verse certainly paints an accurate picture of man's degradation as recorded in history and currently in the practicing of murderous abortion.

32. ***"who having perfectly known the righteous acts of God, that those practicing such things are worthy of death, not only do them but also are pleased with those practicing them."***

The relative pronoun translated "who" (οιτινες) is a combination of the pronouns "ος" and "τις." It appears that the Apostle Paul uses it to call attention to *a particular person or group*, i.e., to *a certain person or persons.* In this verse Paul is specifically referring to those who had the privilege of knowing the righteous requirements of God (vv. 19-20), but who in their rejection of Him were given up (vv. 21-24, 26, 28).

The Greek phrase translated "the righteous acts of God" (το δικαιωμα του θεου) is unnecessarily confused in several translations. The Greek word "δικαιωμα" has the common meaning of a *right, just,* and *equitable act or work*. This meaning is well substantiated by the way Paul uses this word in the rest of this epistle. In Chapter 2:26, he says, "If therefore the uncircumcision keeps *the righteous acts* of the Law." In Chapter 5:18, we note that as one trespass resulted in the condemnation of many, "this also through the *righteous act* of one (Christ) is unto justification of life." Paul's use of this word in these verses certainly verifies our translation, *righteous acts* (also cf. 8:4; Heb. 9:10).

The aorist participle translated "having perfectly known" (επιγνοντες) is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "γινωσκω," and gives it the meaning of *I perfectly know*. Since the aorist participle denotes time prior to that of the leading verb, we have fully translated it *having perfectly known* the righteous acts of God. The thought here is that in the past these men have perfectly known the righteous acts of God. They have known that those who practice such things as mentioned above are worthy of death; notwithstanding, they continue to practice them. We must keep in mind that the righteous acts of God include both *present and future judgment of sin,* which is certainly made

clear in that they receive the necessary recompense in themselves for the error (v. 27).

One might think that it is bad enough for these men to *continuously practice* (present tense) the above mentioned sins, but we are told they *go beyond this*, "they are pleased with those practicing them." The verb translated "they are pleased with" (συνευδοκουσιν) is derived from "συν" and "ευ" and "δοκεω" and, inverted, means they *take-pleasure-with*. We recognize that this verb may be translated they consent with and give their approval with, but we feel that the context requires a stronger assent to evil; they didn't just go along with it, but *experienced pleasure in being joined with* those doing these things. This verb conveys the idea that these men were *subjectively involved with others* in the temporal enjoyment of sin. For further insight into the meaning of this verb compare First Corinthians 7:12-13.

Chapter 2

1. ***"Wherefore you are without excuse, O man, every one judging; for in that which you judge the other, you condemn yourself, for the same thing you, the one judging, practice."***

The Greek word translated "wherefore" (διο) is derived from combining the preposition "δια" and the pronoun "ο" and literally means *on account of which, because of which,* and *therefore*. The reason for what Paul is about to say is on account of what he has said in the previous verse, i.e., that the one practicing what he judges another for doing is without excuse. The Greek word translated "without excuse" (αναπολογητος) literally means *one cannot give a word or reason* from himself, *he cannot defend his actions*, hence, the inconsistency between what he says and does is *inexcusable*.

The Greek word rendered "O" (ω) is an interjection with exclamatory significance. It may also be rendered Oh! used together with the generic noun for "man" (ανθρωπε), in the vocative case, the case of *direct address*, it may well be translated *Oh man!* Paul is emphatically singling out and addressing the inconsistent hypocrite. He is described as "every one judging" (πας ο κρινων), *exercising censorial power*, or *passing judgment* on the practices of others.

Speaking to this hypocrite, Paul says, "For in that which you judge the other, you condemn yourself." The Greek phrase translated "in that which" (εν ω) may also be rendered *in the thing which* you judge, decide against, and censor, you condemn yourself. The Greek phrase rendered "you condemn yourself" (σεαυτον κατακρινεις) literally means that you *judge down* or *judge against* yourself. Paul goes on to explain the reason he makes this retributive statement. He says, "For the same things you, the one judging, practice."

We have already observed that the opening word of this verse, *wherefore*, referred back to the previous verse. The relative pronoun translated *that which* also has its plural antecedents in verses 28 and 32. Furthermore, the last phrase in this verse, *the same things* you practice, also refers back to these verses (28, 32). Those to whom Paul is referring in this second chapter were condemning the practices of the godless Gentiles listed in the first chapter; therefore, since they themselves were involved in some or all of these same practices, they were condemning themselves, self-condemned, and without excuse.

2. ***"And we know that the judgment of God is according to truth upon those practicing such things."***

The Greek verb translated "we know" (οιδαμεν) is built on a perfect form, but has primarily a present meaning. In contrast to knowledge gained through experience, it speaks of knowledge which was acquired through Divine revelation. In view of what Paul says in chapter 1, verses 18-20, and 32, the Gentiles knew about this judgment; it is also a part of the revealed truth in the

Old Testament, and was reaffirmed to the Apostle Paul as a part of his Gospel (v. 16).

The Greek noun translated "judgment" (κριμα) conveys the thought of *the sentence, the penalty,* or *adverse decree* which God passes upon those practicing such things. This judgment is not according to the humanistic relativism of men, but "according to truth." The Greek preposition rendered "according to" (κατα) means that God's judgment *conforms to, is in keeping with,* and *is in proportion* to truth. This means that the standard by which God metes out judgment is "truth" (αληθειαν), that which *conforms to the facts, reality,* and *absolute Divine decrees.* There is nothing hypothetical, theoretical, nor relativistic about God's premise for executing judgment. God in essence is the embodiment of right and wrong. His judgment is absolute, equitable, and inevitable against those practicing the above sins (cf. v. 3; Gal. 5:10).

Paul speaks of this judgment as being "upon those practicing such things." Since the basic meaning of the Greek preposition translated "upon" (επι) is *upon, on,* and *on top of*, Paul is literally saying that the judgment of God *comes upon* or *falls upon* those "practicing" (πρασσοντας) *continuously doing, performing,* and *fulfilling* such things. The present participle indicates that this was their perpetual lifestyle; they volitionally and unceasingly wallowed in these sins. The Greek phrase translated "such things" (τα τοιαυτα) refers to *like things, things of the same quality,* or *of the same kind and sort*. This means that the judgment of God falls upon *every sin in the same category* as the things they were practicing (cf. Gal. 5:19-21).

3. ***"And do you consider this, O man, the one judging those practicing such things and doing the same, that you shall escape the judgment of God,"***

Paul couches this verse in the form of a question to incite them to recognize that they will be judged for their blatant hypocrisy. The inconsistency between what they say and do leads to self-condemnation. There is a Divine principle that one will be judged on the basis of the judgment he metes out to others (Matt. 7:1-2).

The verb Paul uses to get them to stop and reflect on their hypocrisy is "consider" (λογιζη). As used here this verb means that they are to *think upon, take account of,* and *ponder* the consequences of their actions - the inevitable judgment of God. He refers to the person he is directing his remarks to as "O man" (ω ανθρωπε), using the vocative case of address. Since the Greek noun "ανθρωπε" is a generic term, it includes every man and woman. In the forepart of this second chapter Paul is apparently addressing those who are self-righteous, both Jews and Gentiles afflicted with this obnoxious disease (vv. 9-10; 5:7).

Paul now goes on to describe the man he is addressing, "the one judging those practicing such things and doing the same." The Greek participle translated "judging" (κρινων) is in the present tense, indicating that he is habitually judging others; it is a way of life with him. Paul specifically points out the ones he is

judging, "those practicing such things" (τους τα τοιαυτα πρασσοντας). In the last verse in the preceding chapter, this identical statement is used, clearly indicating that he is judging those practicing the abominable deeds mentioned in verses 24-31 of that chapter. Certainly, it was proper that he should judge these deeds as evil, but it was very improper for him to be "doing" (ποιων), continuously committing, and following the same course in his own life.

Having observed that self-righteous men were also involved in the orgy of sin delineated in 1:24-31, we are forced to recognize that these abominable practices were not limited to the depraved Gentile world, but, at least to a limited extent, penetrated Israel. This verse implies that the judgment of a holy and righteous God will necessarily fall upon those practicing such sins, and that it is folly for the self-righteous person, regardless of whether he is a Jew or Gentile, to think that he will escape this inviolable judgment. The Greek verb rendered "escape" (εκφευξη) means that he must not delude himself into thinking that he can engage in these things and *flee from* or *run away from* the judgment of God (v. 2; Acts 24:25; Heb. 6:2).

4. ***"Or do you despise the riches of His kindness and forbearance and longsuffering, not knowing that the kindness of God leads you unto repentance?"***

In the previous verse Paul dealt with their flippant attitude toward the judgment of God, while in this verse he deals with their seeming ignorance of the purpose of God's kindness. We have translated the leading verb in this verse "despise" (καταφρονεις), which literally means *to think down, to think disparagingly of,* hence*, to scorn and despise.*

First, Paul asks the question, "do you despise the riches of His kindness?" The Greek word translated "kindness" (χρηστοτητος) is used nine times by the Apostle Paul in the New Testament. According to usage its prevalent meaning is definitely best expressed by our English word *kindness* (11:22; Gal. 5:22; Eph. 2:7). There are two other Greek words which basically mean *goodness* (αγαθος and καλος). Behind the meaning of the word "χρηστοτητος" is the idea of that which is *useful* and *beneficial*, which means that the kindness of God has intrinsically given men that which is useful and beneficial for them. For the self-righteous to despise and look down upon the kindness of God is to scoff at that which He has provided for them by His grace. In other words, to scorn the riches of His kindness is to scorn that which His kindness has provided: the riches of His grace (Eph. 1:7; 2:7).

Second, Paul asks the question, "do you despise . . . His forbearance?" The Greek word translated "forbearance" (ανοχης) is derived from "ανα" and "εχομαι" and basically mans to *hold up, sustain,* and *support.* We see this word as having a positive rather than negative meaning, i.e., Paul is asking them, "Do you despise God's *holding up and sustaining*?" The translation *forbearance* conveys the thought, "Do you despise God's putting up with you?" The manner in which Paul uses this word verifies the meaning of hold up and sustain (Eph. 4:2; Col. 3:13; cf. 1 Cor. 4:12, where when persecuted Paul's response was to hold

up).

Third, Paul asks the question, "Do you despise... His longsuffering?" The Greek noun rendered "longsuffering" (μακροθυμιας) is derived from the two words "μακρος" and "θυμος" and very literally means to be *a long time* or *slow in becoming passionate or angry,* hence*, to be longsuffering, to forbear a long time,* and *patience*. This is a common characteristic of God the Father and Son (Rom. 9:22; 1 Rim. 1:16), and is to be present in the lives of believers (Gal. 5:22; Col. 1:11; 3:12).

As Paul comes to the end of this verse he raises the question: "Can it be that you despise God's kindness, sustaining, and longsuffering because you do not know [αγνοων], or because you are *ignorant* of the fact that the kindness of God leads you unto repentance?" The Greek verb for "lead" (αγει) most literally means *lead*, but may also be translated *brings* and *conducts* you unto the end of (εις with the accusative) repentance. The Greek noun translated "repentance" (μετανοιαν) is constituted of the two words "μετα" and "νοια" and literally means that the object of God's kindness is to lead you *to change your mind, to change your thinking,* or to alter your mind-set. We note that grief and sorrow also work repentance (2 Cor. 7:9-10). As used in this verse, the phrase "the riches of His kindness" seems to include God's sustaining and longsuffering; the total has the ultimate object of leading unto repentance.

5. ***"But according to your hardness and unrepentant heart you store up for yourself wrath in the day of wrath and revelation of the righteous judgment of God,"***

In verses 3-4, Paul warns evildoers of the judgment of God, and that they should not misread his slowness to judge as laxness, for it is God's kindness giving them more time to repent. Instead of repenting during this extended grace period, Paul says, "but according to your hardness and unrepentant heart you store up for yourself wrath." The preposition translated "according to" (κατα), as used with the accusative case in this verse, conveys the thought of *in keeping with, conforming to,* and *in proportion* to their hardness and unrepentant heart, they stored up wrath.

The Greek word rendered "hardness" (σκληροτητα) speaks of their *harshness, callousness,* and *obstinateness*. This describes the state and condition of their being; they were hard, obdurate, obstinate persons void of compassion. Paul binds this hardness to them; he says it is "your" (σου) hardness, that which *belongs to you* in your estranged-from-God position (cf. Acts 7:51; 19:9). This is an accurate description of all men in their fallen Adamic state, obdurate sinners by nature (2:1-3). Apart from the Grace of God, wherein God takes the initiative, this hardness cannot be broken (Acts 16:14).

The Greek phrase translated "unrepentant heart" (αμετανοητον καρδιαν) attributes to the noun "heart" (καρδιαν) a meaning which verges on the general meaning of the word "mind" (νους). Paul often uses the word "heart" (καρδια) *almost synonymously* with the word "mind" (νους) in contexts in which the

intellectual aspect is prominent (Rom. 1:21; 10:9-10; 2 Cor. 9:7). The word for "unrepentant" (αμετανοητον) is derived from three Greek words "α" and "μετα" and "νοεω," and literally means *not to change the mind*, hence, in the noun form here it speaks of a *nonrepentant, non-changing,* and *impenitent* heart, i.e., *a mind which obstinately refuses to change*, that is impervious to the kindness of God (Titus 1:15; Heb. 3:8).

As a result of this hardness and impenitent mindset, Paul says, "You store up for yourself wrath." The Greek verb translated "store up" (θησαυριζεις) means that they were *gathering and laying up, heaping up,* and *accumulating* wrath to their account. The Greek word for "wrath" (οργην) has the thought of *anger, indignation,* and *displeasure* exhibited and manifested in the form of *punishment* and *judgment* (v. 16).

Speaking to those to whom he is writing, Paul says, "you store up for yourself wrath in the day of wrath and revelation of the righteous judgment of God." Note, they store up this wrath *in the sphere of the time of the day of wrath* when the righteous judgment of God shall be revealed. We need to keep in mind that the day of wrath takes place simultaneously with the righteous judgment of God. The day of wrath points to a *definite future time*; whereas, the righteous judgment of God describes what God will do at that time, namely, judge righteously (2 Thess. 1:5; Heb. 9:27; 1 John 4:17).

6. ***"who will recompense each one according to his works,"***

The previous verse affirmed that God will judge righteously. This verse explains the basis on which God judges, namely, *works*. The Greek verb translated "recompense" (αποδωσει) comes from combining the preposition "απο" and the verb "διδωμι" and it basically means *to give from*, hence, *to render back, to render that which is due,* or *to requite.* The apparent meaning is that God will repay each one on the basis of the works he has done, whether they be good or evil (vv. 7-8). Each individual will be held responsible for that which he/she has practiced; there will be no room for excuses, alibis, nor shifting the blame (cf. 1 Cor. 3:13-15; Gal. 6:4; 2 Tim. 4:14).

As observed, the Greek verb for "recompense" (αποδωσει) implies equitable repayment on the basis of works, but in addition to this, the preposition rendered "according to" (κατα) indicates that God's righteous judgment is *in proportion to one's works*. This preposition, when used with the accusative case, as noted above, makes it clear that God's judgment and punishment are commensurate with one's "works" (εργα). This same verb and preposition are used in Second Timothy 4:14, where Paul is speaking about Alexander the coppersmith, whose punishment will correspond to his evil works.

7. ***"to those according to the patience of good work, seeking glory and honor and incorruption, eternal life;"***

In the preceding verse Paul declared that God is going to repay "each one according to his works." In the verse before us he describes what those involved in "patience of good work" will receive. This phrase is a literal translation of the

Greek, even follows the Greek word order, combines readability with the literal meaning, but is difficult to understand. The problem is in the Greek text, it in itself is elusive, and we have allowed this problem to come over in the translation. Instead of inculcating our interpretation of the Greek into a free modified translation, we prefer to translate it as it is, thus enabling the English reader *to do his own interpreting*. What the Greek text says is *the Word of God.* We have the solemn responsibility of accurately transferring its literal-intended-meaning into English.

Now let us look at the meaning of the phrase "patience of good work." The Greek noun translated "patience" (υπομονην) comes from the preposition "υπο" joined to the verb "μενω" and it basically means to *remain under*, hence, *to bear up under, endure,* and *be patient*. This noun is used with the phrase "good work" (εργου αγαθου) in the genitive case. The thought is that *the patience belongs to the good work, it is a good work.* James ties these two together, for he says, "and let patience have a perfect work" (James 1:4). Paul is apparently referring to *those who have patience and endurance as their good work* (singular).

To those striving for good work characterized by patience, and seeking glory and honor and incorruption, they will be rewarded with eternal life. The present participle translated "seeking" (ζητουσιν) depicts those who are *pursuing, chasing after,* and *endeavoring to obtain* glory, honor, and incorruption.

Now let us take a brief look at the meanings of the three words, glory, honor, and incorruption, as used in this context. In seeking "glory" (δοξαν) they are searching for *respect and praise* from God. Their endeavor to obtain "honor" (τιμην) is a desire to have God account them as *worthy and valuable*. Seeking "incorruption" (αφθαρσιαν) is a reaching out to God for that which is *incorruptible, imperishable*, and immortal. We must keep in mind that it is one thing to seek and search for these three things, and something else to actually obtain them. We certainly recognize that there were many devout Jews under the Law who were honestly endeavoring to do everything Paul is speaking about here, but they never reached their goal because of the weakness of the flesh. (Rom. 8:3).

Taking literally what Paul says in this verse, in the light of the entire context, if those Paul is speaking about here had perfected the good work of patience and endurance, and if they had sought and obtained glory, honor, and incorruption fully pleasing to God, they would have been rewarded with eternal life. This would be irrefutable evidence that natural men can earn eternal life through doing good works. On the other hand, *Paul clearly refutes the idea that men can earn eternal life or make themselves righteous* (Gal. 3:21; Eph. 2:8; Phil. 3:9). Eternal life is obtained through a joint-relation with Jesus Christ, it is *totally a gift from God*, and is dependent upon the perfectly faithful Person of Jesus Christ consummated at the Cross (1 John 5:11-12; Gal. 2:16; Col. 1:20). To attempt to single out this verse and use it to support religious humanism is to manifest gross ignorance of the context in which it is found.

8. ***"but to those out of contentiousness and disobedient to the truth, and to those obeying unrighteousness wrath and indignation,"***

As we approach this verse we need to remind ourselves again that Paul is illustrating how God will repay each one according to his works (v. 6). The subjects he uses for his illustration are those in the category of "contentiousness and disobedient to the truth" and "those obeying unrighteousness." The Greek phrase translated "those out of contentiousness" (τοις εξ εριθειας) refers to those who *come out of the source or the background* of "contentiousness" (εριθειας), i.e., *who have a party spirit, are factious,* and *given to sectarianism*.

It is interesting that in selecting examples to illustrate how evil is repaid with wrath and indignation, that Paul should cite contentiousness, disobedience to the truth, and submission to unrighteousness. Apparently he considered that these are three categories which encompass the most noxious sins. The phrase, "disobedience to the truth" (απειθουσι τη αληθεια), literally speaks of those who are *unpersuaded*, hence, those who *do not obey or comply* with the truth. The noun translated "truth" (αληθεια), as used in this context, is used in a general biblical sense. The truth for the Jews prior to the Cross was the Mosaic law. The truth for members of the Body of Christ is the specific truth given to the Church. Paul's examples obviously refer to those who were disobedient to the specific truth given to them.

When men refuse to obey the truth, it is not surprising that they end up obeying "unrighteousness" (αδικια). This Greek word literally means *that which is not right, that is wrong, or unjust*. To be obedient to the truth of God is to be *synchronized* with all that God has created. Disobedience to God's moral laws, a lifestyle which aligns with immorality and unrighteousness - these result in self-destruction (cf. Rom. 1:21-23, 24, 26, 28, 32). Out beyond this self-destruction the disobedient have waiting for them *the judgment of God* - His wrath, anger, indignation, and vengeance as payment for their evil works (v. 6).

9. ***"tribulation and distress upon every soul of man doing evil, of the Jew first and also of the Greek;"***

This verse continues the thought of the preceding verse - emphasizing the punishment which will accrue to the man doing evil. The first word Paul uses to describe this punishment is "θλιψις" which has the basic idea of *squeeze, press upon, to use pressure on, hence, to afflict* or *bring tribulation upon*. The second word that describes the nature of this punishment is "στενοχωρια." It is derived from "στενος" and "χωρα" and literally means a *narrow place, to be cramped, to be in straits,* hence*, distress and anguish*. Note, both of these words give us pictures of squeezing, pressuring, impinging upon, and forcing into a narrow place both mentally and physically.

Paul pronounces this judgment "upon every soul of man doing evil." This makes it clear that no evil doer will be able to escape the impending judgment of God. The Greek participle translated "doing" (κατεργαζομενου) depicts the man as *working down, practicing,* and *producing evil*. This judgment will come upon the soul of every man. First, historically speaking, upon the soul of the Jew, and second, upon the soul of the Greek (the Gentile). This judgment will be impartial, based upon works.

10. ***"but glory and honor and peace to everyone doing the good, to the Jew first and also to the Greek;"***

The sentence, of which this verse is a part, began in verse 3 and continues through verse 11. The basic thesis of this context, which is a part of a larger context, is that God will recompense each one according to his works (v. 6). To the one who is "doing" (εργαζομενω), *working,* and *accomplishing* that which is good, God will give glory, honor, and peace. It is important to note that there is an article before the Greek word translated "good" (αγαθον), which phrase we have literally rendered "the good" (το αγαθον). Paul is not speaking about that which is good in the eyes of men, but that which is *good according to God's standard* (Mk. 10:18; John 5:29; Rom. 12:2; 16:19; Eph. 2:10). It is impossible for the natural man, who is dead in trespasses and sins (Eph. 2:1), to do anything which is good according to God's standard (Rom. 8:6-8; Eph. 2:3).

Everyone who does that which is good will receive "glory and honor and peace" from God. The Greek noun for "glory" (δοξα) seems to refer to that which is *magnificent in appearance and glorious in manifestation* (John 1:14; Phil. 4:19). The Greek noun for "honor" (τιμη) implies that God will esteem the one who does good as *valuable, precious,* and *of great worth*. The Greek noun for "peace" (ειρηνη) suggests that God will give the doer of good inner *tranquillity, composure,* and *harmony*. Paul states a principle - doing good will be rewarded with glory, honor, and peace. Since no sinner does that which is good (3:12), no one receives the reward of glory, honor, and peace.

Finally, Paul says that God will compensate "the Jew first and also the Greek." The nouns "Jew" (Ιουδαιω) and "Greek" (Ελληνι), as used by Paul, constitute the whole human race. He affirms that the Jewish segment of mankind will be first both in judgment (v. 9) and in receiving rewards. Since the Gospel was first proclaimed to the Jews, historically speaking, they are first in judgment if they reject it, and first in rewards if they receive it.

11. ***"for there is no respect of persons with God."***

The Greek word translated "respect of persons" (προσωπολημψια) is derived from "προσωπον" and "λαμβανω." It means that God *does not receive a person's face, countenance,* or *external appearance*. There is no partiality. Regardless of whether one is Jew or Gentile, both are treated equally in this age of grace (Eph. 6:9; Col. 3:25; James 2:1).

12. ***"For as many as have sinned without the Law will also perish without the law; and as many as have sinned in the law will be judged through the law;"***

This verse more fully explains the thought presented in the previous verses, namely, that God is not a respecter of persons. Whether the Gentiles, who are not under the law, have sinned or the Jews, who are under the law, have sinned, the consequences are the same, both are condemned unto death (6:23).

The phrase "as many as have sinned without the law" refers to the Gentiles.

The Greek word translated "as many as" (οσοι) basically speaks of quantity, and is most accurately rendered *as many as* or *all who*. Paul is looking at the whole human race, which consists of two as many as (οσοι) groups, *all* the Gentiles and *all* the Jews (v. 9; 3:23). This must not be erroneously interpreted to mean that some of the Gentiles and some of the Jews have not sinned. The first three chapters of this epistle utterly repudiate such a thought.

Now let us look at the significance of the Greek word translated "without the law" (ανομως). This comes from "α" and "νομος" and literally means *without law, void of law,* or *not subject to Law*. The adverb form, used only in this verse, implies that while they were *without the Law they sinned*. The noun form of this word is used by Paul to depict the Gentiles who were not under the Mosaic law (1 Cor. 9:21).

Even as the Gentiles, who had no relation to the Law, sinned, likewise, with no relation to the Law they will perish. The Greek verb translated "perish" (απολουνται) means they *will die, be destroyed,* and *brought to nought.* The reason they will perish is not because they did not have the Law, but because they had sinned (Rom. 5:12).

Speaking with reference to the Jews, Paul says, "as many as have sinned in the law will be judged through the law." Here he describes the Jews as being in an *in-law* (εν νομω) position. The literal meaning is that they are *in the sphere of the Mosaic Law*, surrounded by and subject to the Law (Gal. 3:11; 5:4). Even as the Jews, those surrounded by the Law, sinned, likewise, through the same Law they will be judged (1 Cor. 5:13; 1 Peter 1:17). This judgment is unto condemnation unto the end that they perish (Rom. 2:1; 5:16). Summary, God is not a respecter of persons, all the Gentiles without the law and Jews in the Law have sinned, and they will all perish.

13. ***"for not the hearers of the Law are just before God, but the doers of the Law will be justified."***

This verse stipulates the condition which must be met for Jews to be justified through the Mosaic Law. Those who are merely hearers of the Law tend to assume an arrogant, selfrighteous air like the Pharisees of Jesus' day (Luke 18:10-12). This is the only time Paul uses this particular Greek noun for "hearers" (ακροαται). James uses it three times in a given context (James 1:22-25). It is sparsely used in the classical and papyri Greek. The classical Greek uses it to designate *hearers, listeners, pupils,* and *readers*. As used in this verse and in the Book of James, it means the opposite of doers (ποιηται). Expanding the above translation, Paul is saying, for not the hearers, listeners, and readers of the law are just before God.

The big issue here is that it takes more than just hearing the Law of Moses to make men "just" (δικαιοι), *righteous*, and upright before God. The Greek phrase translated "before God" (παρα τω θεω) literally means *beside God*; i.e., mere hearers of the Law are not just as they stand in a position *beside* or *in the presence* of God. According to the standard of God's court it takes *more than* just

hearing, listening to, and reading the Mosaic Law to be declared a just person. It is one thing to be judged *beside men*, in their apostate religious courts, and to be declared OK. It is something else to stand beside the God of this universe, one who judges according to the absolute truth of His Word, and hear the verdict, *depart from me you unjust who are only hearers of the Law.*

Having made it crystal clear that those who are merely hearers of the Law are *unjust ones* according to God's standard, Paul says, "But the doers of the law will be justified." The Greek conjunction translated "but" (αλλα), α strong antithesis, emphasizes that what is to follow is the opposite of what has preceded. Whereas only hearing the Law accomplished nothing with God, the very opposite, doing the Law, will result in justification. The noun translated "doers" (ποιεται), as used in this context, refers to those who *perform, act in accordance with,* and *fulfill the requirements of the Mosaic Law*. Paul is affirming here that the philosophical basis of the Law is that doing it will result in being justified before God.

The Greek verb translated "justified" (δικαιωθησονται) is in the future tense and passive voice. This makes it clear that God is the one who will *justify, declare righteous,* and *approve as perfectly upright* the doers of the law. What Paul says here agrees with what he says in the tenth chapter: "For Moses writes regarding the righteousness out of the Law, that the man who has done it will live in (by) it" (v. 5). In both of these verses the promises are: (1) doers will be justified; and (2) men who have done the Law will live (have righteousness). The hitch in both of these verses is : (1) there are *no doers* of the Law, hence, none are justified; and (2) there are *no men who have done* the Law, hence, who have received life through it. The law utterly failed to make men just and righteous due to the weakness of the flesh (Rom. 8:3; Gal. 3:21-22).

14. ***"For whenever Gentiles who do not have the Law do by nature the things of the law, these not having the law are a Law to themselves;"***

Twice in this verse Paul affirms that the Gentiles are a people "who do not have the law" (τα μη νομον εχοντα). Over 430 years after the promises were given to Abraham and his seed, the Law was given to the descendants of Abraham at Mt. Sinai (Exodus 12:40; Gal. 3:17; Exodus 19:3-20:21). For a Gentile to be under the Law he must first become a proselyte according to the stipulations in the Old Testament (Exodus 12:48-49). One who claims that the Gentiles are under the Mosaic Law thereby manifests gross ignorance of the Scriptures (Eph. 2:11-13; 4:17-19; Col. 1:21).

Now let us look at the statement, "For whenever Gentiles . . . do by nature the things of the law." The Greek conjunction translated "whenever" (οταν) has a hypothetical meaning in this verse. Paul is not affirming, but merely setting forth an hypothesis, i.e., in case the Gentiles do by nature the things of the Law, they act as a law unto themselves. The Greek noun rendered "nature" (φυσει) implies that if they do certain things of the Law it is because they have an *inherent, native instinct* that it is right (1 Cor. 11:14).

Granting that Gentiles do certain aspects of the Law, such as they do not kill

one another, Paul says that they are a "law to themselves" (εαυτοις εισιν νομος). The reflexive pronoun rendered *themselves* means that *within, in the sphere of*, and as *an inborn trait* they are a self-contained law. Paul is apparently referring to the basic morality essential for survival, which kept the Gentiles from utterly destroying themselves (Acts 14:16-17; 17:25-26).

15. ***"who show the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience bearing witness with, and between each other the thoughts accusing or else defending,"***

Having pointed out in the previous verse that the Gentiles, who do not have a law are a law unto themselves, Paul continues to elaborate on the same subject in this verse. The relative pronoun translated "who" (οιτινες) refers back to *certain ones*, the specific Gentiles who were α law unto themselves. These particular Gentiles, a *hypothetical*, minimal group of so-called good men (Rom. 5:7), were *showing* (ενδεικνυνται), *pointing out,* and *manifesting* the work of the law written in their hearts.

In contrast to the Jews who had their law written in stone tablets (2 Cor. 3:3), Paul says that certain Gentiles show the work of the law *written in their flesh hearts* (2 Cor. 3:3). The Greek word translated "written" (γραπτον) is only used here in the New Testament; however, on the basis of its use in the classical Greek, it conveys the thought of that which is *written, scratched,* and *engraved* in their hearts. Paul is obviously using the Greek word translated "hearts" (καρδιαις) comparable to the *mind* (νους) in this verse. Figuratively speaking, these Gentiles show "the work of the law" (το εργον του νομου), not the law itself, written in their minds and hearts. To the extent that their actions conform to the law of Moses, the principles which motivated them were written in their inner mental processes.

Paul now adds to the work of the law that is in their hearts the fact that their conscience bears "witness with" (συμμαρτυρουσης), *testifies together with*, i.e., *both bear a joint witness*. The in-dwelling work of the law and their conscience provide a dual witness. The reciprocal pronoun translated "each other" (αλληλων) and *one another* implies that these two witnesses interact in a reciprocal manner to produce thoughts which either accuse or defend. The Greek word for "thoughts" (λογισμων), *reasonings,* and *computations* suggests that, between the *work of the Law* and *the conscience*, information is fed into the brain computer. When this information is processed, it either "accuses" (κατηγορουντων), *incriminates,* or *blames,* or, on the other hand, it *defends* (απολογουμενων), *protects,* and *guards*.

We must keep in mind that what Paul says in this verse is *hypothetical* when evaluated in the light of what he says in all his epistles. There was no merit in just having or hearing the Mosaic Law, but in doing the principles of the Law. Even though the Gentiles, who were a law unto themselves, may have done minor aspects of the law, their awareness of breaking the law and their conscience would, in the final analysis, accuse them. In chapters 1-3, of which this context is a part, Paul's main burden is *to prove that all men are sinners,* both Gentiles and

Jews, and in doing this he uses certain hypotheses as illustrations (3:9-18, 23; 1 Cor. 12:2; Eph. 2:11-12; 1 Thess. 4:5).

16. ***"in the day God will judge the secrets of men according to my gospel through Jesus Christ."***

This verse points forward to a definite day in which God will judge the secrets of men. The Greek verb translated "will judge" (κρινει) may be interpreted as a *future*, which we prefer, or as a *present*, i.e., God judges. The thought is that God will do this judging "through Jesus Christ" (δια Ιησου Χριστου). God the Father, behind the scene, effects this judging "through" (δια) His personal agent, Jesus Christ (2 Tim. 4:1; John 5:22, 27).

Now let us observe *what* God is going to judge through Jesus Christ, namely, "the secrets of men" (τα κρυπτα των ανθρωπων). The Greek noun rendered "secrets" (κρυπτα) refers to the *things which men hide and conceal.* In Luke 12:2, Jesus says, "There is nothing . . . secret which shall not be made known." In First Corinthians 4:5, Paul instructs believers not to judge until the Lord comes, "who will also bring to light the secret things of darkness and manifest the counsels of the hearts." In Second Corinthians 4:2, Paul describes these hidden things as being "the secret things of shame," which believers are to refuse and renounce.

Paul says that these secrets are "of men" (των ανθρωπων). The genitive case indicates that they are secrets which *belong to men*. We raise the question: to what kind of men do they belong - to the saved or lost? The context which surrounds this 16th verse strongly suggests that Paul has in mind *a general judgment of the lost* (Acts 24:25; Rom. 2:2-3; Heb. 6:2; 9:27; 10:27). All that the lost have to look forward to is eternal judgment. On the other hand, the expectation of believers is ultimate salvation (Heb. 9:28) and eternal glory with Christ (Rom. 8:30; Phil. 3:21).

Paul says that the standard by which the secrets of men will be judged is "according to my gospel" (κατα το εϖαγγελιον μου). Three times he designates the gospel which he preached as *my gospel* (16:25; 2 Tim. 2:8), three times as our gospel (2 Cor. 4:3; 1 Thess. 1:5; 2 Thess. 2:14), and three times as *the gospel preached by me* (1 Cor. 15:1; Gal. 1:11; 2:2). His point is that *the work of the Law engraved in Gentile hearts and their conscience* will accuse or defend them in the day when they will be judged according to the truth of this gospel. Paul's epistles contain both the *fact* that this judgment will take place plus the *criteria* governing it.

Summarizing the first sixteen verses in this chapter, they are directed toward those judging the ones practicing the things mentioned in chapter one, particularly, those practicing the same things. It appears that Paul primarily had judgmental Jews in mind, however, what he says applies to both Jews and Gentiles. Regardless of whether they are under or without the Mosaic law, each one will be recompensed according to his work (v. 6). To tear fragments from these verses in an effort to prove that salvation is by works is inexcusable wresting of this epistle (2 Peter 3:16). This section is an intermediate dialogue in

which Paul is contending that all men are depraved sinners (3:9, 19, 23).

17. ***"But if you are named a Jew, and rest upon the law, and boast in God,"***

This verse introduces a discussion which is exclusively directed toward Jews. The Greek conjunction translated "if" (ει) may be rendered *since* in this context. The Majority Text has the translation "behold" (ιδε). The thought is *since you are named a Jew* or *behold you are named a Jew.* Paul commonly called the descendants of Abraham by the name "Jew" (Ιουδαιος). They are distinguished from the Gentiles (9:24). To be "named" (επονομαζη) a Jew means to have the name *placed upon one*.

To "boast in God" (καυχασαι εν θεω) is to *brag, glory,* and *exult in Him.* As used in this context, it appears that Paul is speaking of their *hollow, legal* boasting springing from the flesh (v. 23; 1 Cor. 1:29; Eph. 2:9). On the other hand, it is a commendable thing for believers to *truly* boast in God (Rom. 5:11; 1 Cor. 1:31).

18. ***"and you know the will, and prove the things differing, being instructed out of the Law,"***

As we have already pointed out, the conjunction which introduces this series can be translated either *if* or *since*. It appears that Paul is writing to a group of haughty, professed-Law-keeping Jews, whose knowledge was not reflected in their living. There is no question about it, they were resting in the Law, they *were* boasting in God in a "not according to knowledge" manner (10:2), and they *were* confident that they knew the will. In view of the attitude of those to whom Paul is writing, the expanded thought of this verse is - *since you know the will and since you prove the things differing.*

We have literally translated "το θελημα" as *the will*, because the pronoun "His" (αυτου) is not associated with it; however, since the name "God" (θεω) is used in the preceding phrase, the implication is that this refers to *the will of God* (Heb. 10:10). These Jews were convinced that they knew God's will, which God had given to them in the Mosaic Law for some 1400 years. True, they wrested, twisted, and nullified portions of this Law through their erroneous interpretations (Matt. 15:3-6), but the big problem Paul had with them was that they did not recognize that the Law *had passed away*. The Law was the will of God for them up to Calvary, revealing the sinfulness of sin (3:19-20; Gal. 3:19, 22, 23-25). The total Law, however, in both its moral and ceremonial aspects, had been fulfilled by Jesus Christ (Matt. 5:17; Rom. 10:4; Heb. 8:13). Their knowledge of God's will according to the Law, which had been replaced with Grace (6:14), was not "according to perfect knowledge" (10:2), the Truth regarding the Mystery (Col. 1:9).

Next, Paul asserts that they "prove the things differing." The Greek verb translated "prove" (δοκιμαζεις) means to prove through *testing, trying,* and *examining*. The Greek phrase translated "the things differing" (τα διαφεροντα) is derived from the preposition "δια" prefixed to the verb "φερω" and basically

means *to bear or carry through,* hence, *the things differing* or *that are excellent.* Since the basic etymological and usage meaning is *differ*, and *excellent* is a secondary meaning, we very definitely prefer to translate this phrase as *the things differing*. The Law was the standard by which they tested, tried, and examined everything. If a given thing or practice met the test of the Law, was in alignment with the stipulations of the Law, *it was approved*, i.e., something they could do. In addition, proving the things differing involved distinguishing between significant and less significant truth (Matt. 23:23).

We may recast the last part of this verse to read: "while being orally instructed out of the law, prove the things differing." The present passive participle, which we have translated in the above verse "being instructed," basically means *to sound in the ears*, hence, *to orally teach or instruct.* This literal rendering brings out more clearly the Jew's responsibility to test all things by the Law *while* being orally instructed in it. This means that the Jew under the Law was to listen discerningly while it was taught, and as a consequence, he was to conform his practices and priorities to it. The tragic thing was that some 25 years after the Law had passed away, when Paul was writing to the Romans, the Jews were still futilely trying to keep it.

19. ***"and have confidence that you yourself are a guide of the blind, a light of those in darkness,"***

The verb translated "have confidence" (πεποιθας) is in the perfect tense, which means that the Jew *had and continues to have confidence, to be persuaded,* and *convinced* that he is a competent guide of the blind. The noun rendered "guide" (οδηγον) basically means one who *leads the way*, hence, *a leader, guide,* and *instructor*. The noun translated "blind" (τυφλων) depicts *those who cannot see physically* (Matt. 11:5) and *spiritually* (Matt. 23:16). In this verse Paul is speaking of a Jew who confidently believed that he was a capable guide, leader, and instructor of those languishing in spiritual blindness. The folly of the Jew is evident in that he was endeavoring to guide the blind by the law in the present dispensation of Grace, truly, a picture of the blind leading the blind (Luke 6:39).

The phrase "a light of those in darkness" is in apposition with the phrase "you yourself are a guide of the blind." There is no conjunction between these phrases, signifying that they apply to different persons, but the implication is that the second phrase elaborates on the first. In this phrase the guide is described as "a light" (φως) and the blind are described as "those in darkness" (των εν σκοτει). The Jew is very confident that he has the light in the Law of Moses, a light which is able to dispel spiritual darkness. According to Paul the Law was never an instrument of light, *but of death* (2 Cor. 3:6-7). Light and life are distinct features of the present dispensation of Grace (John 1:4; Eph. 5:8; 1 Thess. 5:5).

20. ***"a discipliner of the foolish, a teacher of babies, having the form of the knowledge and of the truth in the Law."***

The Greek noun translated "discipliner" (παιδευτην) may also be rendered *a chastiser, corrector,* and *instructor*. The noun translated "of the foolish" (αφρονων) basically means those *without mind*, mindless, hence, *those who are not using their minds, stupid,* and *insipid.* Paul is speaking to the Jew who thinks he is able to discipline and train those who are mentally and spiritually stupid and foolish. The Jew manifested this stupidity by his erroneous interpretation of the law which was dissolved at Calvary (7:6; Eph. 2:15).

Paul confirms what the legalistic Jew claims, he is a teacher of babies. The Greek word "διδασκαλον" is best translated *teacher*. The Greek noun rendered "babies" (νηπιων) basically means ones who are *nonspeaking*, hence, *infants, young children,* or *minors*. Paul commonly gives this word a *metaphorical* meaning, using it with reference to *spiritual babies*, as he obviously does here (1 Cor. 3:1; Eph. 4:14). The Jew engrossed in the traditional approach to the Law was confident that he was able to teach spiritual infants. He exuded a misplaced confidence, however, for he failed to grasp the spirit of the Law and the fact that it had been annulled at the Cross (Matt. 27:51).

Finally, concluding verses 17-20, Paul describes the person named a Jew as one "having the form of the knowledge and of the truth in the law." The meaning of this verse hinges on the Greek word translated "form" (μορφωσιν). This word is used only twice in the New Testament, both times by Paul, with reference to that which is *external, which is in appearance only,* or *a religious shell void of substance* (2 Tim. 3:5). A casual look at this Jew would give the impression that he was clothed in the knowledge and truth contained in the Mosaic Law; however, this knowledge and truth was not integrated into his own lifestyle. Summarizing, Paul had two problems with this Jew: (1) he was α formal, empty religionist who professed but did not apply the Law to his own life, and (2) he was injecting the Law into the dispensation of Grace (6:14).

21. ***"Therefore, the one teaching another, do you not teach yourself? The one preaching that one should not steal, do you steal?"***

In verses 21-24, Paul is calling the professed-law-keeping Jew's attention to the inconsistency between what he says and does. He very adroitly poses several questions designed to stimulate the legal Jew's thinking about his possible hypocrisy, but at the same time avoids direct accusations. We logically assume that Paul raises these questions because some or all of these Jews were involved in these practices.

First, Paul presents the question, "The one teaching another, do you not teach yourself?" During the 1400 years that the Mosaic Law was God's method of governing His people, the Levites had the responsibility of teaching it to the people (Neh. 8:1-9). Jesus says that the Law taught by the scribes in His day was to be practiced (Matt. 23:3). There was nothing wrong with teaching the Law in the proper time-slot, prior to the Cross, but to be teaching it some 25 years after the death of Christ had replaced it, this was a *major problem*. Paul's main point here, however, is their inconsistency. They teach the Law to others, but their lives show no evidence that they have taught themselves. Their traditions

and empty formalism tended to destroy even the intended meaning of the Law, namely to sensitize sinners to sin (5:20).

Second, Paul asks the question, "Do you who are preaching that one should not steal, do you steal?" If one was even superficially "preaching" (κηρυσσων), *proclaiming*, and inculcating the Law in minds, he could not escape declaring, "Thou shalt not steal" (Exodus 20:15). This commandment is also reaffirmed as a part of Church truth, universal truth for all dispensations (Eph. 4:28). The language used here does not point a finger at anyone and condemn him for stealing, but the fact that Paul raises the question suggests that he may have been aware of at least one Levite engaged in stealing. The key thing he is confronting them with is the *inconsistency* between what they preach and practice.

22. ***"You saying, one should not commit adultery, do you commit adultery? You who detest the idols, do you rob temples?"***

Third, Paul challenges the person who says "one should not commit adultery" with the question, "do you commit adultery?" The Hebrew word used in the Ten Commandments in Exodus 20:14, covers the entire gamut of illicit sex sins, which in the Greek are portrayed by the two words "μοιχευω" and "πορνευω." The Jew who had the responsibility of teaching the Law during the time Israel was under it, had no alternative but of "saying" (λεγων), *speaking*, and *relating* the fact that adultery is prohibited by the Law. The grammar used implies that this person was not persuasively forbidding adultery, but perfunctorily saying what the Law said, since he himself may have been involved in it (Matt. 5:28; 15:19). Keep in mind, the main thing Paul is emphasizing here is their *inconsistency*; they say what the Law says but do the opposite (Ma1. 2:4-8).

Fourth, Paul points out their inconsistency in the area of idolatry, recognizing how they detest idols, but at the same time "rob temples." The Greek participle translated "detest" (βδελυσσομενος) has the thought of looking at idols as something *abominable, abhorrent,* and *repugnant.* The Ten Commandments forcefully prohibit idolatry (Exodus 20:3-5). Disobedience to the commandment on idolatry led to the captivity of Israel and Judah (Isaiah 10:11). The captivity cured the Jews of idolatry. Since that time, as observed in the verse before us, they have detested and abhorred idolatry. On the other hand, they have been *inconsistent* in that some, at least, have robbed temples. The Greek verb translated "rob temples" (ιεποσυλεις) is a compound word which basically means *to seize from, strip,* and *plunder* temples. They were inconsistent in that they *simultaneously* abhorred idols as such, and stripped temples for the value of the material from which they were made. They were thereby indirectly *worshiping the substance* of which idols were constituted (Col. 3:5).

23. ***"You who boast in the Law, through the transgression of the Law, do you dishonor God?"***

Fifth, Paul questions their inconsistency of boasting in the Law and breaking the Law; doesn't it dishonor God? The Greek verb translated "boast" (καυχασαι)

means *to brag, glory,* and *exult* in the Law. This verse is *spoken to the person* "who" (of) is simultaneously boasting in and breaking the Law. While the Jews were under the Law, prior to Christ's ultimate fulfillment of the law on Calvary, there was nothing wrong with his boasting in the Law if he obeyed it. During that time it was God's purpose for Israel, and to boast in the Law was to boast in the Word of God given to them (2 Cor. 10:17).

Now let us examine the statement, "through the transgression of the law, do you dishonor God?" The Greek word translated "transgression" (παραβασεως) is α compound word derived from "παρα" and "βαινω." It basically means *to step or go beside*, hence, it speaks of *deviation from* and *violation of* the Law. Paul confronts them with the question: "Don't you through [δια] your actions, deviating from and violating the Law, dishonor God?" The verb rendered "dishonor" (ατιμαζεις) means that they were *slighting, debasing,* and *disgracing* God (John 8:49). Willfully or unwillfully, every Israelite under the Law deviated from it due to the weakness of the flesh (Rom. 8:3), and thereby dishonored and disgraced God. It was bad enough for them to do this when they were locked up under the Law (Gal. 3:22-23), but to drag their legal-defeatism into this present dispensation of Grace, characterized by the power of the Spirit, was too much for the Apostle Paul. He comes down hard on their inconsistencies!

24. ***"For the name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you, even as it has been written."***

Sixth, Paul affirms that their inconsistent lifestyle is causing the Name of God to be blasphemed among the Gentiles. What is said in this verse revolves around "the name of God" (το ονομα του θεου). We must keep in mind that *polytheism*, belief in many gods, was rampant among the Gentiles when Paul wrote this epistle. On the other hand, the Old Testament opens with the indisputable fact that there is *One Sovereign God*, the Creator of the universe and all that is therein (Gen. 1:1-2:23). In speaking to Israel through Moses, this Sovereign God says, "I am Jehovah your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. You shall have no other gods before me" (Exodus 20:2-3, cf. vv. 4-7). God is jealous for a good Name among all peoples (Exodus 20:5).

Israel should have exalted God's name among "the Gentiles" (τοις εθνεσιν); instead, they blasphemed and profaned it (Ezek. 36:20-22). This is sad in view of the fact that Israelites esteem the name of Jehovah too holy even to pronounce. Their blaspheming it was due to the weakness of their flesh (Rom. 8:3), which in turn resulted in their breaking the Law, which showed that *the underlying purpose of the Law was to reveal the sinfulness of sin* (Rom. 7:13).

The main reason Paul cites this Old Testament quotation is to *reaffirm* the inconsistency between their boasting in the Law and breaking it. Their inconsistency caused the name of God to be blasphemed among the Gentiles.

25. ***"For indeed circumcision profits if you practice the law; but if you are a transgressor of the Law, your circumcision has become uncircumcision."***

In this and the following verses Paul introduces a hypothetical discussion involving the legal rite of circumcision. Circumcision in itself, apart from practicing the Law, has no value. As he moves from the Law to hidden spiritual realities, he says that circumcision is not something which is overtly seen in the flesh, but it is that which is wrought by the Spirit on the heart.

Since the Greek word translated "circumcision" (περιτομη) is the key noun in this verse, we need to understand what it means. This word is derived from the preposition "περι" prefixed to the verb "τεμνω" and basically means *to cut around*, hence, *circum-scission, the removal of the prepuce or foreskin* from the male. This was originally given to Abraham as *a sign*, *a seal* of the faith-righteousness which God gave to him (4:11). Stephen refers to this as a covenant of circumcision (Acts 7:8). Circumcision was incorporated into the Mosaic Law (Exodus 12:48-49; Lev. 12:3).

In this context Paul is using the word "circumcision" in its relation to the Mosaic Law, with the exception of verse 29 where he uses it in a spiritual sense. He says that "indeed circumcision profits if you practice the law." The Greek verb rendered "profits" (ωφελει) means that circumcision *helps and benefits* if you practice the Law. This profit was *contingent* on the Jew practicing (πρασσης), *doing and observing* the precepts of the Law (Gal. 5:3). The value of keeping any part of the Law depended upon keeping the entire Law. For the rite of circumcision, a part of the Law, to be of spiritual benefit, the whole Law must be *perfectly observed*. To break one aspect of it *resulted in its curse* and annulled any profit which may have accrued to keeping any part of it (Gal. 3:10). Since no one ever perfectly practiced the Law, no one was made righteous by the Law; instead, all came under its curse, and were locked up under it until the time that faith was revealed (Gal. 3:23).

If the Jew under the Law was a transgressor of the Law, Paul says, "Your circumcision has become uncircumcision." This means that any spiritual value it may have had, if he perfectly fulfilled the law when it was in effect, was wiped out and abolished. Spiritually speaking, if the Jew under the Law broke the Law, his physical circumcision has *no value* whatsoever in recommending him to God.

26. ***"Therefore if the uncircumcision keeps the righteous acts of the law, will not his uncircumcision be counted for circumcision?"***

In this verse Paul is laying the foundation for *diminishing* the significance of physical circumcision with its legal, spiritual overtones. He does this by bringing in a hypothetical example of uncircumcised Gentiles who are keeping the righteous acts of the Law. He is not saying that this uncircumcised group is keeping the Law of Moses, *but if they were*, certain consequences would follow.

In contrast to the designation "circumcision" (περιτομη) for the Jews, Paul commonly designates the Gentiles as the "uncircumcision" (ακροβυστια). This word is derived from "ακρον" and "βυω" and basically refers to those who have *the tip or end covered with the prepuce or foreskin.* The noun uncircumcision is in the singular, it has a singular verb, and may refer to a *single Gentile*. On the

other hand, this same noun may refer to the *Gentiles collectively*.

Now let us examine the statement, "if the uncircumcision keeps the righteous acts of the law." The Greek phrase translated "the righteous acts" (τα δικαιωματα) conveys the idea of the *right decrees, stipulations,* and *commands* which belong to the Law. We interpret that this refers to the moral rather than the ceremonial aspects of the Mosaic Law. For example, Paul says that if the Gentiles "keep" (φυλασση), *guard,* and *watchfully observe* the moral commands of the Law, won't their "uncircumcision be counted for circumcision?" The Greek adverb "ουχι" indicates that this is a rhetorical question, a positive answer is anticipated, their uncircumcision will be "counted" (λογισθησεται), *reckoned*, and *calculated* unto the end of circumcision.

Since circumcision is a part of the ceremonial Law, and since Paul postulates the uncircumcised Gentiles as keeping the Law, it follows that he is limiting the Gentiles' keeping of the Law to its moral aspects.

What Paul says in this verse forces us to recognize that it is a *hypothetical example*. It is absurd to think that the Gentile, steeped in paganism, would surpass the Jew in keeping the Law. The hypothesis is, however, that if the Gentile did keep the moral law, then this would be counted for circumcision. Originally, circumcision was given to Abraham as an external sign and seal of the internal faith-righteousness given to him (4:11). Is Paul implying here that *if* the Gentile kept the Law, which of course he did not, that it would be counted for the real essence of circumcision, namely, righteousness (cf. 10:5)?

27. ***"And the by-nature circumcision, the one fulfilling the Law, will judge you, the one who through the letter and circumcision is a transgressor of the law."***

As a result of what he said in verses 25-26, Paul hypothetically depicts the uncircumcised Gentile, who is fulfilling the Law, as judging the Jew who is a transgressor of the Law. The Greek phrase translated "the by nature circumcision" (η εκ φυσεως ακροβυστια) may be more literally translated "the out of nature circumcision." The phrase rendered "out of nature" emphasizes the fact that the one sitting in judgment of the trespassing Jew is *a native Gentile by birth.* For a Jew to be told that he was a transgressor of the Law, and that a despised, native Gentile who was doing the Law would be his judge - this must have been a very abhorrent thought.

Paul speaks of the native Gentile as "the one fulfilling the law" (τον νομον τελουσα). There is no if in the Greek text as some translations imply. In this verse, which presents a conclusion based upon a hypothesis, Paul is *assuming*, for the sake of argument, that this Gentile is "fulfilling" (τελουσα), *completing*, and *carrying out* the righteous acts of the moral Law.

Now let us examine what Paul says about the Jew who is being judged. He is one who "through the letter and circumcision (is) a transgressor of the law." The Greek noun translated "letter" (γραμματος) conveys the thought of *that which is written, the Scriptures,* or *an epistle.* In this verse Paul is using the noun

"γραμμαrof" with reference to *writing the Law* with black ink upon stone tables or engraving it in stones (2 Cor. 3:3, 7). The Jew was stressing the letter of the law, that which kills by revealing sin (2 Cor. 3:6; Rom. 7:9-11). He was also stressing circumcision, which was profitless if he did not keep the entire Law (v. 25).

In this verse Paul uses a hypothesis, in which he fictitiously elevates a Gentile to be a judge of a Jew, who is inconsistently breaking the moral precepts of the Mosaic Law. This verse takes *a very hard slap* at the Jew who was resting upon the law, but was simultaneously a transgressor of the Law. It gives us a picture of a Gentile pointing a condemning finger at the Jew, declaring, *you are a sinner* (3:9-18). We must keep in mind that this verse is part of a larger context (vv. 17-29), the burden of which is to prove that the Jews, through their breaking the Law, *dishonor God and cause His name to be blasphemed* (vv. 23-24).

28. ***"For the Jew is not one in appearance, neither is the circumcision in appearance in the flesh;"***

So far in this epistle the name "Jew" (Ιουδαιος) has been used to designate an Israelite in the flesh (1:16; 2:9-10, 17). In this verse, without denying the fact that there is a Jew according to the flesh, Paul uses this same name to connote *another kind of Jew*. He describes this Jew as "not one in appearance." The Greek word translated "appearance" (φανερω) conveys the thought that he is not one who is *visible, manifest, nor apparent to the eyes*. This Jew is one who cannot be identified by his external appearance, visage, or looks (9:6).

In the last part of this verse, Paul affirms, "neither is the circumcision in appearance in the flesh." The Greek word rendered "circumcision" (περιτομη) may refer to *the fact of circumcision*, the removal of the foreskin, or it may refer to a special *circumcised group, the Jews*. Since these two blend together, and those who are circumcised constitute the Jews, the important thing to observe is that the circumcision mentioned here is *not visible, manifest, nor apparent* in the bodies of Jews. In contrast to the physical Jew and physical circumcision, this verse emphasizes a nonphysical, nonvisible Jew and a nonphysical, nonvisible circumcision.

29. ***"but the Jew is one in secret, and the circumcision is of the heart by the Spirit and not by the letter whose praise is not out of men but out of God."***

The previous verse told us what the Jew and the circumcision *is not.* He is not one who is distinguished by his appearance and scars in his flesh. This verse begins with the strong adversative "but" (αλλα), which emphasizes the antithesis between the physical Jew and circumcision and the nonphysical Jew and circumcision. The nonvisible Jew is described as "one in secret." The Greek word translated "secret" (κρυπτω) basically means that which is *hidden* or *concealed*. We interpret this to mean that the name "Jew" (Ιουδαιος), as Paul is using it here, refers to a person who has characteristics which are hidden and concealed from other men, but which are known to God and conceivably to himself. The fact that one was named an according-to-the-flesh Jew does not mean that he was

an in-secret Jew. In the light of the contextual evidence, all the Jews were breaking the Law, *proving themselves to be sinners before God,* and unworthy of being called in-secret Jews (9:6).

Having declared that the Jew is one is secret, Paul goes on to say, "and circumcision is of the heart by the Spirit and not by the letter." In contrast to circumcision being of the flesh, Paul says that it is "of the heart" (καρδιας), *belongs to the heart,* and it is *an operation upon the heart.* In contrast to handmade circumcision (Col. 2:11), which was circumcision conforming to the letter of the Law, this circumcision is effected by the Spirit. The Greek phrase "εν πνευματι" may be translated either *by the Spirit* (instrumental case) or *in the Spirit* (locative case). As opposed to the operation of circumcision by the letter of the Law, this circumcision involves an operation performed by the Spirit upon the heart (2 Cor. 3:6).

With respect to the secret Jew, who has had his heart operated upon by the Spirit, Paul says, "whose praise is not out of men but out of God." The implication is that the circumcision of the flesh, by human hands, elicits "praise" (επαινος), *applause*, and commendation from men. On the one hand, the secret, heart-circumcised Jew will receive no plaudits from men, but on the other hand, he will receive *praise, approval,* and *commendation from God.* The use of the Greek conjunction "αλλα" (but) emphasizes the antithesis, the opposition between simultaneously receiving praise from men and praise from God. The suggestion is that praise from men and God are mutually exclusive, i.e., you cannot have both at the same time.

In conclusion, we must maintain *absolute fidelity to the context* of which this and the preceding verses are a part. In our above comments we have endeavored not to go beyond what was written (1 Cor. 4:6). Recognizing that some may have questions about the identity of the secret Jew and Spirit produced circumcision, we make the following observations. First, Paul may have in mind *the invisible spiritual significance of the name Jew* when it was originally given to the seed of Abraham (cf. Gen. 32:28; 2 Kings 16:6). Furthermore, since the Jews were the people of God, created in the image and after the likeness of God, *a true Jew may be viewed as a replica of what God created him to be* (Gen. 1:26; cf. Col. 3:10).

Second, regarding invisible circumcision, Paul may have in mind *the relation to God, based on faith-righteousness,* of which external circumcision is a sign. Also, he could be referring to a Jew who looked forward to having a *new heart, the work of the Spirit,* something looked forward to in the Old Testament (Psa. 51:10; Ezek. 36:26).

Chapter 3

1. ***"What then is the advantage of the Jew, or what is the profit of the circumcision?"***

Our translation follows the Greek text, looks at these two clauses as a single question, and places the question mark at the end. In the previous context Paul has been rough on the inconsistent, law-breaking Jews. He even uses two hypothetical examples involving Gentiles to humble and sizedown the Jews to the fact that *they are sinners* (2:14-15, 26-27; 3:9). In view of the tough stance he has taken against the self-righteous Jews, it is appropriate that he bring things into balance by citing some of their advantages.

In spite of all the problems the Jew has, when compared to the debased Gentiles in chapter 1, he has some very distinct advantages. The Greek noun translated "advantage" (περισσον), as used here, means that the Jew has something o*ver and above and out beyond* the Gentiles? The second part of this question is an integral part of the first, namely, "what is the profit of the circumcision?" The phrase "the circumcision" (της περιτομνς) is merely another way of saying *the Jew.* Both phrases, even though in the singular, *refer to the Jews as a group.*

In the second aspect of this question, Paul asks, what is the "profit" (ωφελεια), *help,* and *benefit* of belonging to the circumcision, i.e., of being a Jew? Merging the two parts of this question, he is asking, *what is the advantage and profit of being a Jew*?

2. ***"Much in every way. For indeed first, because they were entrusted with the oracles of God."***

The phrase "Much in every way" may also be translated *great in every way or respect*. The thought is that they have *many advantages* (9:4-5). The "first" (πρωτον), *chief*, and *most important* advantage is that God has entrusted to them His "oracles" (λογια), that *which He has spoken, His words,* or His message. In each of the four times the word oracles is used in the New Testament it depicts *words revealed by God* (Acts 7:38; Heb. 5:12; 1 Peter 4:11). That God has entrusted His oracles with Israel is a confirmed historical fact (Deut. 4:7-8; Psa. 103:7; 147:19-20).

Why did God reveal His Word to Israel? We cannot answer this apart from asking another question, why did God call Abraham, the father of Israel (Gen. 12:1-4)? The answer is not in Abraham but *in God*, the one who sovereignly chose him to be the progenitor of a new nation, Israel, the Jews. God's choice of Abraham, the father of His special people, the Jews, is the reason he has entrusted His Word with them. God revealed His Word to Israel because *it was the good pleasure of His will.*

3. ***"For what if some did not believe? Will their unbelief nullify the***

faithfulness of God?"

Having declared that the Jews have advantages and benefits beyond the Gentiles, the chief being that He entrusted to them His Word, he now proceeds to affirm that these advantages are *still in effect*. Some Gentiles were apparently saying that these advantages were taken away from the Jews on account of their unbelief (cf. Matt. 21:43). Paul's answer to this false assertion was in the form of two questions. First, "what if some did not believe," has this changed God's fidelity to all the Jews? Second, "will their unbelief nullify the faithfulness of God," i.e., cause God not to honor the promises and privileges which He gave to them (9:4; 15:8; 2 Cor. 1:20)? The Greek grammar makes it clear, faithlessness on the part of some Jews *does not affect God's faithfulness* in keeping His promises to Israel.

Now let us more closely examine the grammatical construction behind these two questions. The Greek pronoun rendered "some" has the thought that certain ones did not believe. Paul looks at these as being neither true Israelites, children of the promise, nor called ones according to God's elective purpose (9:6-12). The "unbelief" (ηπιστησαν) and *lack of faith,* on the part of these, has not affected the advantages and benefits God has bestowed on the Jews. In other words, the faithlessness of some Jews has not influenced God's "faithfulness" (πιστιν) and *trustworthiness* to all the Jews. He will not "nullify" (καταρησει), *abrogate*, and *cease* being faithful to them just because some of them have been faithless.

4. ***"Absolutely not, but let God be true, and every man a liar, as it has been written, That you may be justified in your words, and you will prevail when you are judged."***

This verse reaffirms the fact that God *will remain faithful* to Israel even though some Jews did not believe. As far as God breaking faith with the Jews, Paul says, "Absolutely not" (μη γενοιτο), *let it never be, away with the thought, this is utterly absurd!* He follows this with the statement, "but let God be true, and every man a liar." Regardless of what men may do, God will continue to be faithful, trustworthy, and "true" (αληθης), i.e., *veracious and credible* (John 3:33; 7:18; 8:26).

The clause, let every man be a "liar" (ψευστης), *a corrupter of the truth, a false speaker,* and *a prevaricator* is used in contrast to let God be "true." The phrase "every man a liar" refers to the unbelievers mentioned above. Since God is true it follows that those who reject what He has said are liars (1 John 2:22; cf. 1:10; 5:10). Also, this phrase may include those who were saying that Israel no longer had any advantages or benefits, that they had been forfeited through their disobedience (cf. v. 8). God is faithful and true to His covenant people, the Jews, and anyone who disbelieves or repudiates this truth is a liar.

The main point of this verse is that *God is true*. Paul cites evidence from Psalm 51:4 where David, against his own background of sin, says to God, "That you may be justified in your words, and you will prevail when you are judged." We need to recognize that Paul is quoting from the Septuagint translation of the

Hebrew Old Testament. The issue is not whether this is a minutely close rendering of the original Hebrew, but that the *Septuagint Greek expresses the Holy Spirit's thought through Paul*. This means that we must esteem the literal-intended-meaning of the Greek in such quotations as equivalent in importance to the surrounding Greek text. With this perspective in mind, let us exegete this Septuagint quotation.

The statement, "That you may be justified in your words," conveys the idea that God is justified *in the sphere of His words* or that He is justified *by means of His words*. Regardless of whether we interpret this phrase as being locative or instrumental, the passive voice clearly indicates that what God speaks *justifies* (δικαιωθης), *vouches that He is true and just*, and that He can be trusted not to default in His promise to Israel. The latter part of this quotation, "and you will prevail when you are judged," means that in a scene in which God is being judged, he will "prevail" (νικησεις), *overcome, conquer,* and *be the victor.* Summarizing, in spite of the sin of David and some of the Israelites, God remains *faithful and true* to His covenant people, the Jews.

5. ***"But if our unrighteousness commends the righteousness of God, what shall we say? Is God unjust who inflicts with wrath? I speak as a man."***

This verse introduces a very important theological concept, namely, that our appreciation of the righteousness of God is proportionate to our recognition of our own unrighteousness. The thought here is that our unrighteousness "commends" (συνιστησιν), *recommends,* and *favorably sets forth* the absolute righteousness of God. The preceding context affirms that God is faithful and true to His covenant with Israel, and this verse adds to the list the fact that *He is righteous*.

It is one thing for a person to be "righteous" (δικαιοσυνην), *to do that which is right, equitable,* and *just* when things are going his way, when there is no opposition. On the other hand, we don't really know how real this righteousness and justness is *until it is tested under adverse circumstances.* The Apostle Paul knew that time after time God's people had failed to believe Him, they had rejected and disobeyed His Word, but through it all He remained righteous. As Paul reflected on the past unrighteousness of Israel, and particularly on his own, he was convinced that what men do does not alter God's righteousness, but rather proves, commends, and recommends that it is *absolute*. On the basis of God's unchanging righteousness, Paul knew that the Jews, in spite of the unbelief of some, still had advantages and benefits before God.

Granting that our unrighteousness tests and proves the genuineness of the righteousness of God, hence, has positive value in that it verifies the immutability of His righteousness, why does God inflict wrath upon the unrighteous? First, we need to recognize that our unrighteousness does not contribute anything to the basic nature of God's righteousness. Second, if men would have believed the naked Word of God, what He says about His absolute righteousness, no further verification would be necessary. Third, our unrighteousness merely reinforces

what was already true, *doubly impressing upon the minds of sinners* what God has already said about Himself. It is evidence initiated by sinners, which reverts back to them attesting that God is righteous. Sin is sin, and regardless of the effect it may have on the sinner, it must be judged and punished with wrath (1:18; Eph. 5:6).

As Paul raises the question, "Is God unjust who inflicts with wrath?" (οργην), literally, who *brings wrath upon* the unrighteous, he says, "I speak as a man." It was ridiculous to postulate, even for the sake of argument, that God might be unjust, therefore, Paul explains that he is *speaking* as a human being, not an inspired apostle, when he raises this question pertaining to God's justness.

6. ***"Absolutely not; for then how will God judge the world?"***

In the previous verse Paul raised the question, "Is God unjust who inflicts with wrath?" He begins this verse by answering his own question, "Absolutely not" (μη γενοιτο). This phrase may also be translated *let it never be, away with the thought,* or it is *absurd to think that God could be unjust.* God himself is the standard, the one who determines what is just, and it is *impossible* for Him to be unjust.

Having strongly affirmed that God is not unjust when He punishes sinners, for what commends His own righteousness, Paul adds that if He was unjust, then *how will He be able to judge the world*? The fact is stated that God "will judge" (κρινει) the world, something which only one who is just can do, therefore, *He cannot be unjust*. The argument is that what God does *requires Him to be righteous, demands His justness, and precludes His being unjust* (9:14; Heb. 6:10).

7. ***"For if the truth of God by my lie abounded unto his glory, why am I also still being judged as a sinner?"***

In verse 5 we observed that our unrighteousness commended *the righteousness of God.* In this verse we note that the lie of Saul of Tarsus causes *the truth of God* to abound. In both instances, against a background of our unrighteousness and Saul's lying, the righteousness and truthfulness of God stands out in bold relief.

Now let us examine the meaning of the phrase "the truth of God" (η αληθεια του θεου). According to the Greek grammar used, this refers to *the truth which belongs to God*. In the light of the immediate context it refers to God's characteristics of *faithfulness* (v. 3), *truthfulness* (v. 4), *righteousness* (v. 5), *impeccability*, and *immutable integrity.* The conjunction rendered "if" (ει) in verses 5 and 7, as used in this context, has the meaning of *since*. Paul says that since "the truth of God by my lie abounded unto his glory, why am I also still being judged as a sinner?" He is using the Greek word for "lie" (ψευσματι) in a broad sense to depict his *lying, falsifying, deceiving,* and *moral delinquency* when he was still Saul of Tarsus.

Since this deceptive lifestyle caused the truth of God to "abound" (επερισσευσεν), *to go out beyond,* and *to increase* unto the "glory" (δοξαν),

praise, and honor of God, Paul asks the question, "why am I also still being judged a sinner?" In as much as the Greek verb translated "abound" is in the aorist tense, it indicates that his lying-deception was prior to his conversion, when he was still Saul of Tarsus (1 Tim. 1:13-15). The greatness of "the truth of God" was the *difference* between the depth to which Saul had sunk and the height to which God exalted him (Eph. 2:1-6; 1 Tim. 1:12).

Just because Saul's sin provided a backdrop for the revealing of the truth and grace of God, this did not mitigate the fact that he had sinned against God. It is an inviolable fact that the wages of sin result in death and judgment (6:23). No secondary value, such as setting the stage for God to manifest His superabounding grace, can soften the blow of this death and impending judgment. The only thing that could change Paul's "being judged as a sinner" was the transference of his sin and its consequences to another person, namely, to Jesus Christ. This is exactly what took place on the Damascus Road; for according to God's sovereign grace Jesus Christ was made his sin-substitute (2 Cor. 5:21), and assumed his judgment (John 5:24; 16:8-11).

8. ***"And is if even as we are being blasphemed and as some report that we say, `Let us do evil that good may come?' Whose judgment is just."***

In translating this verse we have not put certain words in a parenthesis, but have adhered to the nonparenthetic Greek text. We have translated the Greek phrase "και μη καθως" rather freely in order to convey the literal-intended-meaning to the English reader. The grammatical construction suggests that it should be treated as a rhetorical question which expects a negative answer, i.e., Paul was not guilty of what some were blasphemously saying he taught. Since this appears to be the only time the negative particle "μη" precedes "καθως" in the New Testament, we have translated this verse as though it was a question.

The negative particle "ου" precedes "καθως" four times in the New Testament, always expressing the opposite of what has preceded or will follow. Granting that the negative particle "μη," as used in this verse, may have a similar meaning to "ου," we may translate it, "and not as we are being blasphemed and as some report that we say, `Let us do evil that good may come.'" This means that Paul was not teaching what he was blasphemously accused of - "Let us do evil that good may come." Regardless of whether we cast this verse in the form of a question or a definite statement, the meaning is the same; Paul repudiates the lie that some were peddling regarding what he taught.

Speaking with reference to those by whom he was "being blasphemed" (βλασφημουμεθα), *slandered*, and *reviled*, and those who were falsely reporting what he said, Paul affirms, "whose judgment is just." The Greek noun rendered "judgment" (κριμα) speaks of their impending *sentence* and *punishment*. The Greek word for "just" (ενδικον) conveys the thought that their judgment is according to what is *right, fair,* and *equitable*. Paul is apparently referring to those who are enemies of the Cross and of the Grace of God (Phil. 3:18; Rom. 2:2; Heb. 2:2). When men evilly treated Paul he did not recriminate in like manner, but turned them over to God to whom vengeance belongs (12:17-19).

9. ***"What then? Are we better than they? Not at all, for we have previously charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin;"***

The Greek phrase translated "What then" (τι ουν) may be rendered *what therefore*. The thought is that in view of what has been said, what are we to conclude? Paul throws out in the form of a question one possible conclusion: "Are we better than (προεχομεθα) they?" This Greek verb is derived from "προ" and "εχω," and is used only here in the New Testament; however, its meaning is clear in the classical Greek. Prodding their minds, Paul asks: Are we Jews *held before, do we have preference,* and *are we superior* to the Gentiles? His terse answer is "Not at all" (ου παντως). The only other time this same Greek phrase is used in the New Testament is in First Corinthians 5:10, where it may be translated *not at all, not altogether,* or *not entirely.* In view of the way this phrase is used in this passage, it could be interpreted to mean that the Jews did have an edge over the Gentiles, *which was not altogether* but limited to the promises and covenants (vv. 1-2; 9:4-5).

In continuing to answer the question which he has posed, Paul says, "we have previously charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin." This statement makes it clear that the Jews are no better than the Greeks (Gentiles) with respect to the issue of sin. This means that the entire human race, all men, are "under" (υπο) the *influence and domination of sin* (7:14; Gal. 3:22). With regard to the sin issue, the Jews were *certainly no better than the Gentiles*, they were all dominated by sin as children of wrath (Eph. 2:1-3), but when it came to the promises made to Abraham they were definitely better off (vv. 1-2; 9:4-5; Eph. 2:12).

10. ***"as it has been written that, There is none righteous, not even one,"***

Having declared that the entire human race is under the domination of sin, Paul corroborates this fact by citations from the Old Testament. The Greek verb translated "has been written" (γεγραπται) is in the perfect tense. It emphasizes that what the Old Testament *has said and continues to say* about man's sinful condition is true. The anthropological affirmations of the Old and New Testaments are the same - man is a totally depraved sinner in his nature (Psa. 51:5; Isa. 64:6; Eph. 2:3).

We recognize that the following citations have been taken from the Greek Septuagint, a Greek translation of the Hebrew Old Testament. The issue is not how accurately this Greek version conforms to the original Hebrew text, but the fact that the Holy Spirit Himself, through Paul, chose these quotations *to express what He wanted to say*. God the Holy Spirit is the One who makes the Bible authoritative, the inspired Word of God. The *source* of the truth He has put into the Bible is not the key issue, *but the nature of the truth*, that which expresses the will of God. We will treat these quotations with the same preciseness as the truth revealed directly to Paul.

The Greek clause translated "There is none righteous, not even one," may

also be rendered "There is not a righteous person, neither one." The following is an amplified rendering: there is not a "*righteous*" (δικαιος), *upright*, and *just man*, "not even" (ουδε) *a single one*. In this verse Paul doubly denies that there is such a thing as a righteous person in the world (John 16:8; Rom. 3:23; 6:17; 7:14, 17-20).

11. ***"There is none who understands, there is none who seeks after God."***

The Greek participle translated "understands" is derived from the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "ιημι" and literally means to *send* or *go with or together*, hence, the ability to combine the parts into *a meaningful whole, to comprehend,* and *intellectually grasp*. The thought is that there is no one who has spiritual insight into the mind, will, and purpose of God (11:34; 1 Cor. 2:16). All men are void of spiritual understanding in their natural state (Acts 28:26).

Now let us examine the statement: "there is none who seeks after God." The Greek participle translated "seeks after" (εκζητων) is derived from the preposition "εκ" and the verb "ζητεω" and literally means *to earnestly seek out, to diligently seek after,* and *to reach out toward.* This verse says that it is not in the nature of any man to diligently seek for a relationship with God (John 3:19-20). Since al1 men are born into this world dead in trespasses and sins, alive only in the physical sphere, it follows that *they will not and cannot seek God* who is in the spiritual sphere (John 4:24). God alone can elevate the natural man into a spiritual man who will seek Him (John 6:44).

12. ***"They have all turned aside, together they have been made useless; there is none doing good, not so much as one."***

The Greek verb translated "turned aside" (εξεκλιναν) is derived from the preposition "εκ" and the verb "κλινω" and means that "all" (παντες) *turned away from, bent or reclined away,* and *shunned* that which is good and profitable. This turning away from what was profitable resulted in that "together" (αμα), *at the same time*, they were made "useless" (ηχρεωθησαν). The use of the passive voice suggests that when they turned away, Satan made them *useless, unprofitable,* and *unfit* (1:18-24).

The statement, "there is none doing good," conveys the idea that no person is engaged in "doing good" (ποιων χρηστοτητα). This Greek word basically refers to providing that which is *necessary* to meet spiritual and physical needs. True goodness and kindness is expressed when one ministers to the needs of others apart from selfish motives. Paul says that no one of the depraved human race does this, "not so much as one" (ουκ εστιν εως ενος), or *not even until one.* Whereas the natural man is bereft of goodness and kindness (χρηστοτητα), God is rich in it (2:4; Eph. 2:7).

13. ***"Their throat is an opened tomb, they deceive with their tongues, the poison of asps is under their lips,"***

First, their "throat" (λαρυγξ), *larynx, upper windpipe,* or *esophagus* is likened

to an opened tomb. The Greek participle translated "opened" (ανεωγμενος) is in the perfect tense and literally means that their throat has the characteristics of a *has-been-opened grave, tomb,* or *sepulcher.* Since the Greek word for "throat" (λαρυγξ) is transliterated into English as *larynx*, and in view of the context from which this quotation is taken (Psa. 5:9), this apparently refers to their foul and odoriferous speech (Eph. 5:3-4).

Second, Paul says that all men "deceive with their tongues." The Greek noun translated "tongues" (γλωσσαις), as used here, means *talk, speech,* and *language*. The thought is that by means of the vehicle of speech they "deceive" (εδολιουσαν), *beguile, entrap,* and *defraud.* Men used this same deception and guile in their efforts to entrap Jesus (Matt. 26:4; Mark 14:1). Paul says that the corrupt Gentiles were full of it (Rom. 1:29). He tells the Corinthians that the false apostles are deceitful workers (2 Cor. 11:13). Deceptive and defrauding speech is *par among men in the flesh*.

Third, Paul declares that "the poison of asps is under their lips." Not only is their larynx like an open grave, and their tongues speaking guile, but there is also poison under their tongues. This figure of speech is apparently from Psalms 140:3, David's description of wicked men who are pursuing him. It is a picture of deadly poisonous speech hidden under the lips of sinners (Prov. 10:18).

14. ***"whose mouth is full of cursing and bitterness;"***

Here we have a picture of mouths which are chock-full, ready to express cursing and bitterness. The Greek word translated "cursing" (αρας), as used here involves *praying that evil may come upon a person, to curse,* or *to invoke an imprecation against one.* The Greek word rendered "bitterness" (πικριας) conveys the thought of *harsh, sharp,* and *acrid* speaking manifesting *an attitude of animosity*. Verses 13-14 confirm, through the four organs involved in speaking, that *all natural men are depraved sinners* (James 3:5-8).

15. ***"their feet are swift to shed blood,"***

In this verse Paul uses the word "feet" (ποδες), that which gives movement and propulsion to a person's body, to depict the fact that all men are sinners. The feet of natural men in the flesh "are swift to shed blood." The Greek word translated "swift" (οξεις) basically means *sharp, cutting,* and *keen*, but it may also be used metaphorically with the idea of swift or hasty. We could also interpret this verse to mean that their feet are sharp and piercing causing the "shedding" (εκχεαι), *pouring out* of blood. Instead of their feet moving them forward as ambassadors of peace (10:15), they propel them forward to inflict, wound, and murder (Acts 22:20).

16. ***"ruin and misery are in their ways,"***

The Greek noun translated "ways" (οδοις) means *paths, roads,* or *the courses which they travel.* The thought is that the shedding-blood feet leave the paths where they walk strewed with ruin and misery. The Greek word rendered "ruin" (συντριμμα) is derived from "συν" and "τριβω" and literally means *to rub*

together, to shatter, or *to break and destroy*. The word for "misery" (ταλαιπωρια) basically depicts *hard work, hardship*, hence, *bodily pain, distress,* and *affliction*. James uses this same word to describe the plight of sinners and the rich (James 4:9; 5:1). Paul is citing this verse as evidence - men's ways littered with shattered pieces and misery prove that they are all sinners.

17. ***"and the way of peace they have not known."***

This verse declares a historical fact which applies to all men; namely, their feet have not walked in the way of peace. The Greek noun translated "peace" (ειρηνης) means *tranquillity, concord*, and *harmony*, and the annals of history are devoid of men living in a condition described by such words. The statement that they have not "known" (εγνωσαν) this way means that they have not *experientially known* the path of peace. They knew that they should live in peace with one another, but they never knew this as a reality in their experience (Isa. 59:8). Natural men, left to themselves, have never experienced peace, but have proved that they are totally depraved sinners.

18. ***"The fear of God is not before their eyes."***

The key point of this verse is that they do not possess a "fear of God" (φοβος θεου). Paul is not talking about them not fearing God, but that they *do not have the fear, reverence, respect and awe which belong to God.* The genitive case makes it clear that this is a fear which belongs to God, hence, something which men left to themselves, bereft of God, do not possess. In as much as this is not a humanly generated fear, but a Divinely transmitted fear, men in their natural adamic state will be void of it. The fact that all men are devoid of fear, reverence and respect before God, that which God alone can implant in men, is further proof that all men are totally depraved sinners.

The evidence which Paul has presented in verses 10-18, citations from the Old Testament, conclusively proves that there is not a single person who is righteous, but that all men are sinners and under its condemnation (v. 23). Beginning with chapter 1, verse 18, through 3:18, Paul has one burden, to prove that both Jews and Gentiles, all men, are under sin (παντας υφ' αμαρτιαν ειναι).

19. ***"And we know that as much as the Law says, it says it to those in the law, that every mouth may be stopped and all the world may become guilty before God."***

In this and the following verse Paul tersely sets forth the underlying purpose of the Law of Moses. First, observe that the message of the Law was spoken to those "in the law" (εν τω νομω). Translating literally, the contents of the Law were directed to those who were *in the sphere of the Law, encompassed by the Law*, namely, to Israel, the Jews (3:1; 9:4). The only way for a Gentile to come within the sphere of the Law was to become a Jewish proselyte, and even then, his privileges were limited (Matt. 23:15; Acts 2:11).

Second, the phrase "as much as the law says" (οσα ο νομος λεγει) is a quantitative phrase. It means that *all, everything* the Law says is to be observed by those in or under the Law. The Law was a single package of stipulations and

commands; it had no options, but had to be kept in its entirety. If the Jew under it failed to keep every aspect of it he was deemed a sinner and came under its curse (Gal. 3:10).

Third, the Greek conjunction "ινα" used with the subjunctive mood indicates that the *purpose* of the Law was "that every mouth may be stopped." The Greek verb translated "stopped" (φραγη) means that every mouth may be *fenced in, closed up,* and *silenced*. Since those who have had the Law given to them have not perfectly kept all the requirements of the Law, they are under the curse of the Law and have no *excuses, alibis, nor basis for justifying themselves* (Gal. 2:16).

Observe further, beyond stopping every mouth, the Law puts men in a position that "all the world may become guilty before God." The phrase "all the world" (πας ο κοσμος) suggests that the Law impresses guilt on minds beyond those who are under it, namely, the Jews. This is in accord with what Paul says in First Timothy 1:8-11, where he speaks about using the Law lawfully in relation to lawless persons. The Greek word rendered "guilt" (υποδικος) is used only here in the New Testament; however, as used in the classical Greek it conveys the idea of *bringing the world to trial, accusing it,* and *making it liable for its sin.* This speaks of an extended significance of the Law, strictly limited to sinners (1 Tim. 1:9), beyond the Jews to whom it was specifically given (Exodus 20:1-22; 1 Cor. 9:20-21).

20. ***"Wherefore no flesh will be justified in his sight out of the works of the law, for through the law is a knowledge of sin."***

Negatively speaking, this verse tells us that the Law cannot justify anyone before God. Positively speaking, the Law reveals a knowledge of sin. To try to use the Law to acquire a justified position before God would be to use it unlawfully; but to use it to impress upon sinners that what they are doing is sin, this is to use it lawfully (1 Tim. 1:8-9).

The Greek conjunction translated "wherefore" (διοτι) literally means *on account of that* stated in the previous verse, it is impossible for any flesh to be justified by the Law. The Greek verb rendered "justified" (δικαιωθησεται) is in the passive voice, which means that as far as the Law was concerned it was unable to make one *right, upright, faultless,* and *just before God.* This utter failure on the part of the Law was due to the weakness of the flesh, i.e., the fact that all men are sinners in their nature (8:3; Eph. 2:1-3).

It is important to observe that the works of the Law are not able to justify in God's "sight" (ενωπιον). Human religions and humanistic perversions of Christianity revolved around justification in the sight of men. The Gospel of the Grace of God has one concern - to be justified *in the sight of, before the eyes of,* and *in the presence of God Himself* (2 Cor. 4:2).

The Law promised the Jews that *if they did it they would live by it* (10:5). Since no one perfectly did the Law, no one was made righteous nor justified by it, hence, lived by it (Gal. 3:21). Paul looked at the Law, not as having failed its mission, but as having accomplished a more profound purpose, proving to men their

inability to meet God's standards (7:7-13). Through endeavoring to keep the Law, but simultaneously breaking it, the elect Jews were forced to acknowledge that they were sinners (9:6-11). Through the inadvertent breaking of the Law came a knowledge of sin.

21. ***"But now a righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the Law, being witnessed to by the Law and the prophets,"***

Having pointed out that all men are totally depraved sinners, that there is not a single good thing in anyone (vv. 9-12), and that the real purpose of the Law was to give men a knowledge of this sin, Paul now proceeds to unfold the answer to the sinful dilemma in which all men are trapped. The heart of his answer, as we will see, is that God has provided His righteousness for sinners through their *identification* with Jesus Christ.

This verse opens with the adverb "now" (νυν) which calls our attention to *the present time, to a given point of time in history.* Prior to the now-time the Jews had been under the Law as God's program for them, but now God has ushered in a new apart-from-the-Law program (Gal. 3:19-25). Paul frequently uses the adverb now to indicate that what was *has passed away*, and now it has been *replaced by something new and different*. This change in God's method of dealing with His people is commonly called a change from one dispensation, administration, or economy to another. Failure to recognize these changes, and to drag passed-away truth into the present, is the major cause for the widespread confusion among God's people today.

The main point of this verse is that *a righteousness of God has been manifested.* In view of the fact that there is no article preceding the word "righteousness" (δικαιοσυνη), and in the background we have the concept of Law-righteousness, we prefer the less abrupt translation *a righteousness of God.* In contrast to the potential righteousness of the Law, a law which had been given by God, Paul introduces another righteousness of God, *a righteousness which belongs to God.* Even as what is right and wrong is determined by God, likewise, His righteousness *embodies all that is right according to His standard.* The righteousness of God is *absolute rightness.*

Now let us look at the fact that this righteousness "has been manifested apart from the law." The verb translated "has been manifested" (πεφανερωται) is in the perfect tense, which means that at a given point of time in the past it was *brought to light, revealed,* and *disclosed.* In determining when this righteousness was manifested, we need to keep in mind that Jesus Christ incarnate in human flesh is the *embodiment of this righteousness* (I Cor. 1:30). Furthermore, we can affirm that His death on the Cross made this righteousness available to all men (2 Cor. 5:21). On the other hand, *when was it actually revealed* that the crucified and risen Christ, in His very essence, was the righteousness of God?

It appears to me that the fact that this was an "apart from the law" (χωρις νομου), *separated from the Law*, and a *severed from the Law* righteousness, can aid us in determining *when* and *to whom* it was manifested. In the light of Acts 21:17-21, it doesn't appear that those in Jerusalem had com-

prehended this apart-from-Law righteousness (cf. 4:21-25). The biblical records suggest that the Apostle Paul was the first one to have revealed to him the fact that God's righteousness and redemption are in Jesus Christ (Acts 13:38-39; Gal. 1:12; 3:16). Since Paul and Peter were close friends, they must have mutually shared the truth revealed unto them (Acts 10:43; 1 Peter 1:18-21; 2 Peter 3:15-16). Even though we cannot be dogmatic as to when it was revealed that God's righteousness in Christ supplanted the Mosaic Law, one thing is certain: Paul is clearly teaching the Roman believers that their *righteousness is in Christ*, and that the Law has nothing to do with it.

Paul says that this righteousness of God is "being witnessed to by the law and the prophets." The principle of the righteousness of God being based upon faith was not a part of the Law; but it was not something new, for the prophet Habakkuk had said that "the just shall live by his faith" (Hab. 2:4; Rom. 1:17). Abraham is a supreme example of one who received righteousness on the basis of faith. In Genesis 14:6, we read of Abraham, "he believed in the Lord; and he counted it to him for righteousness (4:3; Gal. 3:6). David also speaks of the person who the Lord makes righteous apart from works (4:6-8; Psa. 32:1-2). Peter also affirms this same principles as he speaks to Cornelius and his friends (Acts 10:43). We would suggest that the principle of the righteousness of God was revealed to Paul and directly or indirectly to Peter, and they were given insight into this confirmation in the Old Testament (Gal. 1:12).

22. ***"even a righteousness of God through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ unto all those believing; for there is no difference;"***

In this verse Paul explains two things: (1) the person through whom this righteousness is channeled, and (2) those who are the recipients of this righteousness.

The most important truth in this verse, but at the same time the most misunderstood truth, involves *how* God has extended His righteousness to sinners. The key word in this verse, the meaning of which has been commonly misinterpreted in such contexts, is properly translated "faithfulness" (πιστεως). This word appears as "πιστις" in the nominative singular, and in most contexts is correctly translated *faith*. On the other hand, there are several contexts where it is necessarily or preferably translated *faithfulness* (Matt. 23:23; Rom. 3:3; Gal. 5:22; Col. 2:12; Phile. 5; 1 Tim. 4:12; 6:11; 2 Tim. 2:22; Titus 2:10). There are also several passages in which it is used in a manner similar to the verse before us. In each of these contexts the name of Jesus Christ is in the *genitive case*, indicating that it is a characteristic which He possesses (v. 26; Gal. 2:16; 3:22; Eph. 3:12; Phil. 3:9).

John the Baptist, through Divine revelation, declared that Jesus is "the lamb of God who takes the sin of the world" (John 1:29, 36). As the Eternal Lamb of God it was imperative that He be without blemish or spot, sinless (1 Peter 1:19). The righteousness of God is inextricably amalgamated with the perfect faithfulness of Jesus Christ. As the Son of God He was put through the most stringent testing. Yet he never wavered, but remained apart from sin and was

faithful even to the death of the Cross (Heb. 4:14-15). The faithfulness of Jesus Christ, which reached its zenith on the Cross, is the basis for our being made the righteousness of God in Him (2 Cor. 5:21).

To whom is the righteousness of God in Christ available? Paul's answer is "unto all those believing." The participle translated "believing" (πιστευοντας) is in the present tense which means that this righteousness is freely given to all those *trusting, relying upon,* and *exercising faith* in Jesus Christ (1:16). The real issue is - what is the source of this faith? If it is humanly generated, i.e., originates in the minds of sinners, isn't it in itself a work? If, on the other hand, this faith is implanted in the minds of those chosen in Christ (Eph. 1:4; 2:8), and exercised in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, isn't this necessary for salvation by Grace?

Finally, Paul says that there is no "difference" (διαστολη), *distinction*, nor *separation* between Jews and Gentiles. All are equally under sin and all are treated equal under God's sovereign purpose (1 Cor. 1:30; Rom. 8:28; 9:11).

23. ***"for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,"***

As we observed in the previous verse, God's offer of righteousness through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ is extended to all those believing. Whether Jews or Gentiles, there is no difference between them; they are all sinners, and they all need this righteousness *if they desire α right relation to God.* We must keep in mind that totally depraved sinners, when left to themselves, *do not desire* a right relation to a totally righteous God (John 3:19-20). Since *all* are totally depraved, this means that not a single depraved person would desire God's righteousness in Christ, unless he is efficaciously drawn by God the Holy Spirit (John 6:44). Furthermore, when we see individuals genuinely trusting Jesus Christ as their Savior, we can posit the fact that God, prior to their believing, *gave them the faith* with which to believe. If the sinner generates faith within himself, it is no longer salvation by grace but by human works (Acts 13:48; Eph. 2:8-9).

This 23rd verse, interspersed between verses 21-22 and that which follows, is an additional summary of the plight of the entire human race. This statement leaves no room for exception, "all" (παντες) have "sinned" (ημαρτον), *missed the mark, missed the way, erred,* and *failed God.* In keeping with what Paul has already said (1:18-3:18), this verse recapitulates the fact that sin is the major universal problem for the human race (5:12; 1 John 1:8, 10).

The consequence of the fact that all men have sinned is that they all "fall short of the glory of God." The Greek word translated "glory" (δοξνς) is rather elusive; therefore we will to try give you insight into how it is used in both the New Testament and classical Greek. In the classical Greek it basically refers to the *opinion* one may have of a thing or person, hence, it is a lofty opinion of one's person, character, or reputation. This same basic meaning predominates in the New Testament, i.e., it represents our *opinion, thinking, and presumption* of what a person is like. It is used most commonly in the New Testament of God the Father, the Son, and of human dignitaries such as kings.

In view of the truth God has revealed concerning Himself, we are able to form

a relatively accurate opinion of what He is like, i.e., pertaining to His glory. The sum total of whom He has revealed Himself to be - an omniscient, omnipotent, loving, merciful, and gracious God - and our rational opinion of it, constitutes our perception of the glory of God. To "fall short" (υστερουνται) of the glory of God is *to fail to attain, to lack,* and *to be devoid of God's characteristics.* We need to remember that man was created in the *image of God*, and in this respect shared in the glory of God; but sin deeply marred this image, causing him to fall far short of the glory which he was to share with God (Gen. 1:27).

24. ***"being justified freely by his grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus;"***

Against a background that all have sinned, God is now justifying those who believe by His grace, the epitome of which is seen in Christ's redemptive death on Calvary. The Greek participle translated "being justified" (δικαιουμενοι) is in the present tense and passive voice, which means that *God Himself* is continuously *justifying*, declaring righteous, and vindicating sinners in the present Church age. First, Paul spoke about the righteousness which God has provided through the faithfulness of Jesus Christ (v. 22). Second, *on the basis of* this Divinely provided righteousness, because of it, sinners are justified. The Greek adverb "δωρεαν" implies that believers are *freely justified ones by grace*.

The Greek preposition "δια" used with the genitive case specifies the *agent* through which this justification is effected. In order for God to be just, and at the same time to justify sinners, someone had to assume the penalty of the sinner's sin, namely, death (6:23). The fact that God freely justifies by His grace is inseparable from the "redemption" (απολυτρωσεως), *freeing for a ransom paid,* or *the liberation from sin procured by Christ's substitutionary death on Calvary* (Isa. 53:4-6; 1 Cor. 15:3). The Greek article prior to the phrase "in Christ Jesus" (της εν Χριστω Ιησου) clearly points to the fact that this redemption is in the Person of Jesus Christ (locative case) or by means of Jesus Christ (instrumental case). This statement *limits* redemption, hence, justification to God the Son incarnate in human flesh (Acts 4:12). There is no room for other self-styled, false saviors.

25. ***"whom God set forth a propitiation through faith in his blood, to show his righteousness because of the passing over of previously committed sins, in the forbearance of God;"***

Some translations include the phrase "in the forbearance of God" in the following verse, in accord with the United Bible Societies Greek text but on the basis of thought content, it blends in better with this verse. With reference to Jesus Christ, Paul says, "whom God set forth a propitiation." The Greek verb translated "set forth" (προεθετο) is derived from the preposition "προ" and the verb "τιθημι" and literally means that God *placed beforehand*, i.e., *previously purposed and determined* that Jesus Christ would be a propitiation (ιλαστηριον). This noun describes Him as *one who appeases, makes atonement,* and *who Himself is the mercy seat*, the only place where sinners can find mercy before a holy God (Heb. 9:5).

Having observed that God the Father made Jesus Christ the essence of mercy for sinners, we ask, on what basis is this mercy given? Paul says that sinners are identified with Christ, the mercy seat, "through faith in his blood." Those who exercise this faith thereby show that they have been chosen before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4), that their faith in His Blood has been *Divinely implanted* otherwise, the Blood shed on the Cross would be foolishness unto them (I Cor. 1:23-24). It is important to note the *object of the faith* given to sinners, namely, that their *confidence might be wholly* in the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ, not in anything that they might do in the flesh (Eph. 1:7; Col. 1:20).

A basic problem Paul is dealing with in this verse is: how can God patiently forbear sins which had been committed in the past and still be righteous? The answer to this problem is Jesus Christ's propitiatory death. The value of His Blood poured out on Calvary is adequate to cover all past, present, and future sins. Thus we see that Christ's propitiatory Blood, shed in due time in the process of history, made it possible for God to *pass over* (παρεσιν) or *to be beside* previously committed sins and to simultaneously be righteous (5:13-14).

In view of the basic meaning of the Greek verb translated "passing over" (παρεσιν), derived from "παρα" and "ειμι," and consistently used by Paul with the meaning of *present* or *presence*, a good translation would be, "to show his righteousness because of the presence of previously committed sins, in the forbearance of God." God purposed that Christ should be a propitiation unto the end to *point out His righteousness*, even though He forbore and put up with the presence of previous sins. Sins committed prior to the Cross were paid for on the Cross.

26. ***"to show his righteousness at the present time, that he might be just and the one justifying out of the faithfulness of Jesus."***

The premise upon which the truth in this verse rests is the fact that God predetermined that Christ should die as an expiator of men's sin (Acts 2:23). He died that God might "show his righteousness at the present time." The Greek word translated "show" (ενδειξιν) means that God might *point out, manifest,* and *publicly display* his righteousness during the present time (εν τω νυν καιρω). The righteousness of God has been publicly manifested to all men *in the death of His Son on the Cross.*

In dealing with this subject we must keep foremost in our minds the fact that the wages of sin are death, i.e., *sin equals death*. This is an inviolable Biblical principle (Gen. 2:17; Rom. 1:32; 5:12, 21; 6:16, 23). For God to declare that sin results in death, and to forbearingly and patiently put up with previously committed sins, this would be a challenge to the integrity of His righteousness. Jesus Christ assumed the penalty of mankind's sin, death, even the death of the Cross (Phil. 2:8). In Christ's substitutionary death God has made a full payment for men's sin. This payment is effectual for all those who exercise faith in Christ's Blood, and God is *free to simultaneously maintain his righteousness* and *to mercifully and graciously deal with sinners*.

Furthermore, the propitiatory death of Jesus Christ was necessary if God was going to be "just and the one justifying out of the faithfulness of Jesus." Of course, we recognize that God could not be other than "just" (δικαιον), *equitable, fair,* and *righteous* in His Divine Person. His justness demands strict adherence to the moral principles He has established for governing the universe. For example, sin leads to death. For God to arbitrarily recompense sin with life would destroy His integrity, which of course He would not do. There was absolutely no way for God to remain just and righteous, and at the same time to justify sinners, apart from an outside, acceptable, and perfect sin-substitute. Jesus Christ, the sinless God-man, was both qualified and willing to assume the sin of everyone believing (v. 22) and exercising faith in His Blood (v. 25). On the basis of His propitiatory death, God the Father remains just in His character and is also able to justify sinners.

Finally, let us take a look at the statement that God is "the one justifying out of the faithfulness of Jesus." This is a literal rendering of the Greek phrase "εκ πιστεως Ιησου." The preposition "εκ" indicates that the source which makes it possible for God to justify sinners is the *faithfulness of Jesus*. We recognize that grammatically speaking, this could be translated the *faith of Jesus*, but the intended thought is more accurately conveyed by rendering it the faithfulness of Jesus. This is in full accord with Paul's use of this grammatical construction (3:22; Gal. 2:16; 3:22; Phil. 3:9). The absolute faithfulness of Jesus Christ, including His life and death, is the essence of His righteousness which is imputed unto sinners, the reason God is able to justify them (2 Cor. 5:21). It is sheer folly to talk about God being just and the justifier of sinners apart from the faithfulness of Christ finalized in His death on Calvary.

27. ***"Where then is boasting? It is excluded. Through what kind of law? Of works? No, but through the law of faith."***

Granting that justification depends entirely on the faithfulness of Christ, epitomized in His substitutionary death on the Cross, there is no room for boasting as far as the provision for justification is concerned. What about *how* sinners think they appropriate this justification? If they self-generate the faith by which they presume to appropriate it, doesn't this leave room for human boasting? Obviously, the answer is yes. If, on the other hand, they acknowledge that God Himself gives them the faith to appropriate this justification, that both justification and faith are an integral gift from God, it follows that there is *no room for boasting*.

Paul now raises the question: "Through what kind of law" was boasting excluded? Expanding this question, Paul is asking, *Through what sort, type, and form* of law boasting was eliminated? There are many different laws and principles which govern human behavior. These fall into two general categories: (1) those which operate on the basis of *works* (εργων), and (2) those which operate on the basis of *faith* (πιστεως). Paul flatly denies that a law which functions according to works will exclude boasting; in fact, it will produce it (4:2). On the other hand, the law which operates according to faith, which links sinners

to the Savior through faith, definitely locks out all boasting. This verse eliminates every vestige of human effort and works from salvation; it is totally a free gift provided by God (Eph. 2:8-9).

28. ***"For we consider that a man is justified by faith apart from the works of the Law."***

The Greek verb translated "consider" (λογιζομεθα) means that Paul *counted, regarded,* and *concluded* that sinners are justified solely by faith (Gal. 2:16; Eph. 2:8). Again we remind you, the present passive infinitive rendered "justified" (δικαιουσθαι) means that God Himself is actively engaged in declaring men *just, right, approved, acquitted,* and *vindicated* in His sight. God's method of identifying the sinner with the Savior is "by faith" (πιστει), *trust, belief,* and *confidence* in the redemptive power of the Blood of Christ (v. 25).

This justification by faith is "apart from" (χωρις), *separated from,* and *totally independent* of the Mosaic Law (v. 20). Faith is an inextricable part of Grace. It is the medium through which the provision of God's grace is channeled to the sinner. Faith is a function of Grace. Law functions by works. Not only is a man justified apart from the works of the Law, but these two principles are *mutually exclusive* to the extent that if they are mixed they destroy each other.

29. ***"Or is God of the Jews only? Is he not also of the Gentiles? Yes, also of the Gentiles,"***

In the light of the historical background, that God had dealt with His covenant people, Israel, from Abraham on, this was a question which needed an answer. Paul doubly asserts, through the grammar he uses, that *God is also the God of the Gentiles*. True, God had given the Israelites some special privileges prior to this present Church age (3:1-2; 9:4-5), but now both Jews and Gentiles are equally dependent on the *mercy of God* for their salvation (11:28-32). Historically speaking, during the transition period, the Gospel was first preached to the Jews (1:16). Now, God is equally interested in justifying sinners, who have faith to believe, in all races.

30. ***"if indeed God is one, who will justify the circumcision out of faith and the uncircumcision through faith."***

This verse begins with the Greek word "ειπερ," which consists of the conjunction "ει" with the enclitic particle "περ" joined to it, which emphasizes the meaning of the conjunction "ει." This compound word is used six times in the New Testament, only by Paul (3:30; 8:9, 17; 1 Cor. 8:5; 15:15; 2 Thess. 1:6). In each of these passages it strengthens the condition posed, and it may be translated *if indeed, if truly,* and *if it's a fact.* There was no question in Paul's mind about God being one, He truly is, it is a fact (1 Cor. 8:6).

Paul's main burden in this verse is to explain *how the One True God will justify both Jews and Gentiles.* First, he says that God "will justify the circumcision out of faith." The Greek verb translated "will justify" (δικαιωσει) is in the future tense and means that God (*will esteem as righteous, just,* and

acquitted the circumcision, Israelites, or Jews.) Now will He effect this justifying? The answer is "out of faith" (εκ πιστεως). The preposition "εκ" used with the ablative case, as in this verse, points to *faith as the source* which lays hold of justification. If this faith was humanly generated it would be derived from works, not grace, but since it is the result of grace (Eph. 2:8-9), it is the *gift of God* freely imparted to those chosen in Christ (Eph. 1:4; 2 Tim. 2:10).

Speaking with reference to the Gentiles, the "uncircumcision" (ακροβθατιαν), Paul says that God will justify them "through faith" (δια της πιστεως). In this phrase we have the preposition "δια" used with the genitive case which points to *faith as the agency* through which justification is obtained. (This same phrase is used in Ephesians 2:8; cf. Rom. 3:25, 27, 31). On the basis of the manner in which Paul uses these two Greek phrases in his epistles (εκ πιστεως and δια της πιστεως) there is no justification for distinguishing between how God justifies Jews and Gentiles. Both are justified by exercising the faith which God implants in them (Rom. 10:17). For the sake of *variety and greater breadth of thought* he uses the two expressions, thereby giving us a more comprehensive view of faith as both the *source* and *agent* through which God justifies sinners.

31. ***"Therefore do we annul the Law through faith? Let it never be, but we establish the law."***

The main burden of this verse is to show that faith has not made the Mosaic Law ineffective, but has established the purpose for which it was given. Paul raises the question, "do we an the law through faith?" Since this verse is open to misinterpretation we need to carefully consider the meaning of the two leading verbs in it. First, the Greek verb translated "annul" (καταργουμεν) consists of the preposition "κατα" prefixed to the verb "αργεω" which means to be *inactive, in-operative,* and *idle.* This compound verb means to *downgrade the Law to a position of uselessness,* hence*, to abrogate, nullify,* and *make it void of any value.* According to Paul the Law was not an intrinsic part of God's eternal program, but was added for a given period of time, until Christ came and the ushering in of faith (Ga1.3:19-25). The Law was an essential forerunner of faith. It developed a consciousness of the exceeding sinfulness of sin, the prerequisite to incite sinners to be justified by faith (Rom. 3:19-20; 7:13). In view of what is written in First Timothy 1:8-10, the moral principles of the Law are still applicable to lawless sinners, condemning their abominable practices, but not to those who are just in Christ (6:14).

As far as faith annulling the Law was concerned, Paul says, "Let it never be" (μη γενοιτο), *absolutely not*. The Mosaic Law, in a preparatory sense, was in full effect until the faithfulness of Jesus Christ was consummated on Calvary. From that time on God has been justifying sinners who are identified with Christ through faith (Gal.3:22, 24-25; Phil. 3:9).

Second, now let us look at the statement, "but we establish the law," particularly, the verb translated "establish" (ιστανομεν). This verb basically means we *make the Law stand firm or confirm it.* If God's underlying reason for giving the Law was to make men righteous, He utterly miscalculated the

weakness of their flesh, for it never made any man righteous (Rom. 8:3). True, Moses wrote regarding the righteousness out of the Law, "that the one who has done it will live by it," but it failed because *no one ever did it* (3:20; 7:21-23). God's *ultimate purpose* in giving the Law was to make men righteous. This necessitated making them conscious of their sinfulness, that they might believe in Christ, who is the end of the Law unto righteousness (10:4).

Chapter 4

1. ***"What then shall we say that Abraham found, our forefather according to the flesh?"***

Our translation of this verse has followed the Greek word order. Even though the Jewish believers in Rome knew that Abraham was their progenitor, Paul refreshes their minds, and for the sake of the Gentile converts, explains that he was the father of the Jews. The perfect infinitive translated "found" (ευρηκεναι), as used in this context raises the question, What did Abraham *discover, light upon,* or *learn*? We need to recognize that Abraham simply believed what God said, and as a consequence, he learned that God counted it unto him for righteousness (Gal. 3:6). This verse indicates that Abraham did not believe God in order to become righteous, but having believed God, he discovered that God imputed it to him for righteousness.

2. ***"For if Abraham was justified out of works, he has boasting; but not before God."***

Continuing the thought of the previous verse, Paul says, if Abraham found that he was justified out of works, "he has boasting" (εχει καυχημα). In other words, if through his encounter with God, Abraham discovered that he was justified *out of the source of works* (εξ εργων), he had *reason and ground to boast and brag.* If the man Abraham produced his own righteousness, a prerequisite for justification before men, he would be entitled to boast according to human standards.

For the sake of argument, Paul says, if we grant that Abraham was justified out of works and had reason for boasting, we must *emphatically affirm* that this justification and boasting was "not before God." Men who haughtily brag about their so-called good works, justness, and humanitarianism should listen to this pungent statement - they are not justified "before God" (προς θεον), *with God*, or *in His presence.*

3. ***"For what does the Scripture say?* And Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him for righteousness.*"***

When the Old Testament Scriptures dealt with the subject at hand, Paul commonly appealed to them (Gal. 3:6-14), but with respect to *mystery truth* he could not, for nothing was written regarding it (Eph. 3:5, 3-9). Both the Old and New Testaments represented the final court of appeal for him in their respective spheres (2 Tim. 3:14-17). The authority of the Scripture settled the issue, *justification is by faith!*

Granting that Abraham was a totally depraved sinner by nature (Eph. 2:3), and as such was the recipient of Divine faith (Rom. 10:17; Eph. 2:8), it logically follows that his faith was counted for righteousness, for it was the *work of God* on his behalf.

4. ***"But to the one working the wages are not counted according to grace but according to debt."***

This verse clearly infers that Abraham's believing God was *an expression of the grace of God.* If God had required Abraham to do something for his righteousness, such as to self-generate a faith-mind-set or to do certain physical works, then the righteousness given to him would be considered *payment for what he had earned, hence, God paying His debt to Abraham.* The use of the conjunction "αλλα," the strong adversative, emphasizes that the reward for works, in contrast to grace, is figured as a *debt*. This verse *identifies* the act of believing God with grace. Inverting this statement, grace enables God-hating sinners to believe God (3:24; 11:5-6).

5. ***"But to the one not working, but believing on the One justifying the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness."***

Unlike the previous verse, this verse is dealing with the person not working, but believing on God. According to this verse there is absolutely no room for justification to be acquired through both works and faith. These two principles are *mutually exclusive, cannot be mixed*; works incur debt and grace incurs righteousness.

Paul refers to God as "the One justifying the ungodly." The Greek noun translated "ungodly" (ασεβη) depicts those who are *wicked, profane,* and *void of respect for God* (5:6; 1 Tim. 1:9; 1 Peter 4:18). It is irrational to think that such ungodly men have inherent in them either the desire or capacity to believe on God whom they despise (John 3:19-20; 6:44). The language used here portrays God as the *sole justifier* of the ungodly, which means that He convicts them of sin (John 16:8), and imparts to them faith in Himself (1 Tim. 1:14), on the basis of which He declares that they are righteous.

The Grace which God extends to believers includes both the substitutionary death of Christ, that which makes it possible for Him to be just and the justifier of the ungodly, and *the faith which identifies the sinner with this death.* As we have previously observed, the very essence of the righteousness of God is Jesus Christ (1 Cor. 1:30; Phil. 3:9). Finally, note that after God has given faith to a person it belongs to that person, i.e., it is designated as *his faith* (πιστις αυτου).

6. ***"Even as David also spoke about the blessing of the man to whom God counts righteousness apart from works,"***

In corroborating the fact that God counts sinners righteous on the basis of faith rather than works, Paul has already appealed to the example of Abraham in the Old Testament (v. 3). For further evidence from the Old Testament, he now appeals to that which the Holy Spirit has spoken through David (Psa. 32:1-2). The number of quotations from the Old Testament in the book of Romans certainly suggests that there were many Jewish believers in the church at Rome.

David spoke about "the blessing" (τον μακαρισμον) of the man whom God reckoned righteous apart from works. The Greek phrase translated "the blessing" conveys the idea that the person who has imputed righteousness apart from

works is a *happy, blessed,* and *felicitous man in an enviable position*. This happy state is the result of a sovereign act of God - a Divine declaration that sinners are accounted righteous "apart from works" (χωρις εργων), i.e., *distinct from, separated from,* and independent of works (3:28; Gal. 2:16; Eph. 2:9).

7. ***"Blessed are those whose iniquities have been forgiven, and whose sins have been covered."***

In this and the following verse Paul cites the evidence for what he said in the preceding verse (Psa. 32:1-2). He quotes David who speaks about a group (plural) of people who have an *enviable status*, who are *happy and blessed above others*. What have they done to obtain this status? The passive voice makes it clear that *they did nothing*. God is the one who is wholly responsible for their felicitous state (John 20:29).

According to David this happiness is the result of God sovereignly doing two things. First, those who have had their iniquities forgiven are blessed ones. The Greek verb translated "have been forgiven" (αφεθησαν) is in the aorist tense and the passive voice and means that their "iniquities" (ανομιαι), *lawlessness*, and *transgressions have been forgiven, sent away, dismissed,* and *pardoned*. Second, those who have their sins covered are blessed ones. The Greek verb translated "have been covered" (επεκαλυφθησαν) is also in the aorist tense and passive voice and means that their sins (αμαρτιαι), *missing the mark of God's standard,* and *errors have been covered, had a cover placed on them, or covered over.* We recognize that prior to the Cross God was able to forgive iniquities and cover sins in view of His foreordained redemptive purpose in Jesus Christ (Acts 2:23; 4:28; Rom. 3:25-26).

8. ***"Blessed is the man to whom the Lord never counts sin."***

In verse 6 we observed that Paul used the *singular number* instead of the plural. Since we have the singular, "man" (ανηρ) in this verse, we logically assume that its summary truth most accurately confirms the point Paul is making, that a man is counted righteous and justified apart from works. The forgiven iniquities and covered sins, spoken of in verse 7, are summed up as *not counted sin* in this verse. The verb which we have translated "counts" (λογισηται) may also be rendered to whom the Lord never *reckons, imputes,* or *calculates sin*. The use of the double Greek negatives (ου μη) in this verse suggests that David had in mind one of God's elect, a blessed man, when he said that the Lord *never counts or reckons sin* to him (Acts 13:48; Eph. 1:4; 2 Tim. 2:10). For God not to count a persons sin against him, on the basis of the redemption in Christ (1 Cor. 1:30), is an essential step in reckoning him righteous in Christ (2 Cor. 5:21). In summary, what David says negatively fully affirms what Paul says positively - where sin is not counted there is righteousness.

9. ***"Therefore, is this blessing upon the circumcision or also upon the uncircumcision? For we say, `faith was counted to Abraham for righteousness.' "***

Having cited examples of two Israelites, Abraham and David, who had been

blessed with the righteousness of God, Paul does not want the Romans to think that this righteousness is only for Jews. He deals with the issue by raising the question, has it been given to the circumcision (Jews) or also to the uncircumcision (Gentiles)? There was no question about its having been given to the Jews, which was obvious from the two examples, but was it "also" (και) given to the Gentiles?

Paul recognized that his statement, "faith was counted to Abraham for righteousness," would on the surface, at least, be interpreted to favor the Jews. However, the determining issue is whether Abraham's faith was counted for righteousness before or after he was circumcised.

10. ***"Therefore, how was it counted? While he was in a state of circumcision or in uncircumcision? Not while he was in a state of circumcision but in uncircumcision."***

This verse answers a simple historical question: faith was counted unto Abraham for righteousness while he was still an uncircumcised Gentile. Paul's argument is that if faith was counted for righteousness to Abraham while he was uncircumcised, as a Gentile, then it follows that this righteousness is also available to the rest of the Gentiles. Today, in this church age, God is reckoning both individual Jews and Gentiles righteous on the basis of faith (Gal. 3:6-7, 29).

11. ***"And he received circumcision as a sign, a seal of the righteousness of faith which he had in uncircumcision, unto the end to be the father of all those believing among the uncircumcised, unto the end to reckon to them righteousness,"***

This verse defines the spiritual significance of circumcision. It was given to Abraham as a "sign" (σημειον), *mark,* or *token*, or as a "seal" (σφραγιδα), *that which fastens and secures.* As a sign, circumcision sealed and secured the righteousness of faith which was given to Abraham while he was uncircumcised. God did this unto the end to make him the father of all believers among the Gentiles, that in turn He might give to them righteousness based upon faith (1:5; 16:26; Gal. 3:8).

That which Paul writes in this verse *pertains to Abraham*. Circumcision as a sign and seal was specifically given to him to mark and secure the faith-righteousness given to him while he was in a state of uncircumcision. It relates to him as the *father* of those believing among the Gentiles. Nowhere in his epistles does Paul make the slightest suggestion that circumcision, or substitutes for it, have spiritual significance for members of the Body of Christ.

12. ***"also the father of the circumcision, to those not out of the circumcision only, but also to those walking in the steps of the while-in-uncircumcision faith of our father Abraham."***

Having established the fact that Abraham is the father of the believing Gentiles, Paul now adds that he is also the father of the circumcision. He is not only the father of those who are not out of the circumcision, namely, the Gentiles, but he is also the father of those exercising the same faith he exercised when he

was uncircumcised like the Gentiles. In this verse Paul affirms that Abraham is the father of three groups: (1) the Jews, (2) the Gentiles, and (3) believers who follow the pattern of Abraham's faith.

The strong conjunction "αλλα," as used in this verse, emphasizes the importance of the third group. They are those "walking" (στοιχουσιν) *in a straight line, advancing in a row,* and *fashioning their conduct* according to the "steps" (ιχνεσιν), *footsteps*, and *tracks* of Abraham's faith. Since the Greek grammar is clear but awkward to bring over into English, we have translated this as "the while-in-uncircumcision faith of our father Abraham." The specific Abrahamic faith Paul wants this third group to follow is that which Abraham had before the rite of circumcision was given to him. This third group indiscriminately includes all who today are counted righteous on the basis of their Abrahamic faith.

13. ***"For the promise to Abraham or his seed, that he would be heir of the world, was not through the Law, but through the righteousness of faith."***

First, the Book of Genesis positively affirms that God promised to make Abraham and his seed a great nation in whom all the families of the earth would be blessed (Gen. 12:2-3; 18:18; 22:17-18). Second, what were the conditions and circumstances surrounding the giving of this promise? Paul says that it was not given "through" (δια) the law, i.e., through the agency of the law; and this is logical, for the Mosaic Law was not given until over 400 years later (Gal. 3:16-18). On the other hand, the promise was given "through" (δια) the righteousness of faith, i.e., God having infused faith into Abram, a Chaldean sun worshiper, counted him righteous on the basis of *his faith*, and through the agency of this faith gave him and his seed the promise. We must keep in mind that Abram in himself *had no faith* in God. When God infused faith in him, this faith became *his own personal faith,* which enabled him to be counted righteous, hence, qualified to be given the promise. If there is any good in any person it has its origin in God (Matt. 12:34; Luke 18:19).

14. ***"For if those out of the Law are heirs, faith has been made void, and the promise nullified."***

For the sake of argument, Paul says, if those "out of the law" (εκ νομου), out of the source of the Law are heirs, then we have a twofold conclusion. First, if the promise is given to those who are under the Law, faith "has been made void" (κεκενωται), *vain*, and *empty*. The Law is not of faith but of works (Gal. 3:12). It is not a teammate with faith. If it was possible for the Law of Moses, which is the opposite of faith, to make one an heir of the promise given to Abraham and his seed, then it would *cancel faith, make it void and empty.*

Second, if those under the Law were made heirs of the Abrahamic promise, then, Paul says, the Law would be "nullified" (κατηργνται), *made null and void, made of none effect,* and *abrogated.* The basic requisite was that the promise *had to be given to a righteous man* and his seed. God never takes into His confidence and gives promises to wicked men. Due to the weakness of the flesh,

the Mosaic Law utterly failed to make any man righteous (8:3; Gal. 3:21-22). Therefore, if the promise depended upon the Law to qualify men to receive it, *no righteous person would be found*, and the promise would be nullified and ineffectual.

15. ***"For the law works wrath; and where there is no Law, neither is there transgression."***

Instead of the Law producing righteousness, that which was necessary for the giving and functioning of the promise, it "works" (κατεργαζεται), *produces, effects,* and *yields* wrath. According to Paul the main purpose of the Law was to impress upon those under it the exceeding sinfulness of sin (Rom. 7:13). Using the same compound verb κατειργασατο he says that "sin having taken occasion through the commandment produced in me every lust" (7:8; cf. 7:17-19).

Also, beyond the fact that the Law stirs up a greater consciousness of sin, and even increases lustful desires, it also makes the sinner more subject to the wrath of God. The Greek noun translated "wrath" (οργη) has the idea of *anger, indignation,* and *punishment*. It is predominantly used in the New Testament to depict the wrath or anger of God. The person under the Law, who boasted in his knowledge of the will of God, but who blatantly disobeyed it, is a prime target for the wrath of the Law (2:5-8).

The statement, "where there is no law neither is there transgression," supports the thought that there is a *direct correlation* between knowing the law and the wrath of God. The noun translated "transgression" (παραβασις) is generally associated with the Mosaic Law. It means to *step beside, deviate from,* or *to violate the Law*. The Law was God's will; to disobey it was a transgression which resulted in God's wrath.

16. ***"Because of this it is out of faith, that it may be according to grace, unto the end to confirm the promise to every seed, not only to the [seed] out of the Law but also to the [seed] out of the faith of Abraham, who is the father of all of us,"***

In as much as the two previous verses point out the impossibility of the promise being given through the Law, Paul says, "Because of this it is out of faith." The Greek phrase translated "because of this" (δια τουτο) may also be rendered *on account of this,* or *for this reason* the promise is out of the source of faith. God's *purpose* for doing it this way was in order "that it may be according to grace." Even as law and works are inseparable, likewise, grace and faith are joined together. Grace makes faith available to sinners, thereby making it possible for God to count their faith for righteousness. Apart from the grace of God which has provided Jesus Christ as our sin-substitute, and the faith by which we are identified with Him, it would be impossible for God to count sinners righteous (2 Cor. 5:21; Gal. 2:16; Phil. 3:10).

The Abrahamic promise was given out of faith, according to the principle of grace, "unto the end to confirm the promise to every seed." The Greek word translated "confirm" (βεβαιαν) means to make the promise *firm, certain,* and *sure*

"to every seed" (παντι τω σπερματι), i.e., *to every single seed*. If the promise was out of the Law, it would have been limited to those under the Law, but since it is out of grace it includes every individual whether in or out of the sphere of the Law.

The Greek word for "seed" (σπερματι) is used only once in this verse; however, the article "τω" is used three times. Since the Greek language avoids unnecessary duplication where it is obvious what is meant, following the lead of the last two articles we have added the word *seed* in parenthesis. The first time it is used with reference to *every individual* to whom God gives faith to believe unto righteousness. The second time it is used with reference to *the Jews* who were under the Law, those to whom God gives faith (9:6-11; 10:16-17). The third time it is used with reference to those identified with the faith of Abraham (while in uncircumcision, v.12), hence, the Gentiles to whom God gives faith counted for righteousness (11:11-12, 15, 22, 24, 32).

According to the flesh Abraham was the forefather of the Jews (4:1). According to the principles of grace and faith wherein his faith was counted for righteousness, he is *the father of all of us* in this age of grace (Gal. 3:5, 29).

17. ***"even as it has been written,* that I have placed you the father of many nations; *before whom he believed God, the one making the dead alive and calling the things not being as being."***

There is seemingly an ellipsis in the grammatical construction of this verse. In wrestling with this, the United Bible Societies Greek text places the last part of the previous verse and the first part of this verse in parentheses, as follows, (who is the father of us all, even as it has been written, that I have placed you the father of many nations). Obviously, what is included in this parenthesis is a cohesive thought, but this does not solve the problem, for there still remains a break in the flow of thought between the beginning and end of the parenthesis. In view of this we have eliminated the parenthetic marks and used instead commas and a semicolon to help express the correct meaning.

The quotation pertaining to Abraham, "I have placed you the father of many nations" is from Genesis 17:5. The verb translated "placed" (τεθεικα) basically means that God *set, established,* and *made* Abraham the father of many ηations, i.e., of the Gentiles. This is a position which God sovereignly gave to Abraham after He had transfused Divine faith into him in Ur of the Chaldees.

Now let us look at the elliptical part of this verse where there seems to be an abrupt break in the thought flow. After having stated that God had made Abraham the father of many nations, Paul says, "before whom he believed God:" Κατεναντι is derived from the preposition "κατα" prefixed to the adverb "εναντι" and may mean *over against and opposite,* or *before, in the sight of,* and *in the presence of*. Paul uses it two other times with the latter meaning of before the face of God, in the sight of God, and in the presence of God (2 Cor. 2:17; 12:19). These passages set a strong precedent favoring the thought that in this verse Paul is talking about *Abraham in a position before the face of God or in His*

presence. The relative pronoun translated "whom" (ου) is in the genitive case agreeing in case and number with the Greek noun for God (θεου).

In view of the above data Paul is giving us a picture of Abraham standing before the face of God, in His very presence. In the light of what is written in the Book of Genesis God had been speaking to him about the role he was to play in God's eternal purpose. What was his reaction to what God had said? In spite of the physical circumstances surrounding him, and the seeming impossibility of what God had said, "he believed God" (επιστευσεν θεου), *had faith in God, trusted and had confidence in what God had said* (v. 3; Gal. 3:6; James 2:23).

Abraham believed God, "the one making the dead alive and calling the things not being as being." First, the God Abraham believed is "one making the dead alive" (του ζωοποιουντος τους νεκρους). The phrase "the dead" (τους νεκρους), as used in this context by Paul, probably refers to Isaac (Hebrews 11:17-19). It could refer to *those whom God resurrects* (John 5:21), or it very likely refers to the *reproductive deadness* of Abraham and Sarah (Heb. 11:11-12). The Greek participle translated "making alive" (ζωοποιουντος) is from a compound verb which means to *make alive* or *to give life*. It is used in the New Testament to describe the giving of both physical and spiritual life. Second, Abraham believed God, one who calls "the things not being as being." This phrase consists of two participles from the Greek verb meaning *to be* or *to exist* (ειμι). In addition to our literal translation, it may also be rendered "the things not existing as existing."

18. ***"Who believed on the basis of hope out beyond hope to the end that he became* the father of many nations *according to what had been spoken*, So shall your seed be."**

In adhering to the basic meanings of the participles "επι" and "καρα" in the forepart of this verse, hope served to stimulate Abraham's faith to believe that which was out beyond hope. Faith laid hold of a basic hope which spiraled to heights beyond hope. The result of this - he "became" (γενεσθαι), an aorist infinitive, the father of many nations, which means, the father of the Gentiles. The use of the aorist tense indicates that Paul is thinking about Abraham as the father of all the Gentiles who are now *identified with him in faith*, whose faith is counted for righteousness. Abraham has become the father of the believing Gentiles "according to what had been spoken." God gave him the promise, he believed what God said, and now occupies this prominent position, the father of all those to whom God gives faith to believe unto righteousness (v. 12; Gal. 3:7; Heb. 2:16).

19. ***"And as one who was not weak in faith, he considered his own body which already had been dead, being about a hundred years old, and the deadness of Sarah's womb,"***

In dealing with this verse we need to recognize that there is a slight difference between the reading of the United Bible Societies (UBS) text and the Majority Text, commonly referred to as the Textus Receptus. The UBS text does not have the negative adverb translated "not" (ου) before the verb rendered "considered"

(κατενοησεν). The Majority Text does have the negative adverb preceding this verb. The following is a good MR translation: "And as one who was not weak in faith, he did not consider his own body which already had been dead, being about a hundred years old, and the deadness of Sarah's womb."

A superficial glance at this verse might well lead a manuscript copier to inject a negative adverb before the verb so as to read "he did not consider" (κατενοησεν). We must keep in mind, however, that in textual criticism there is a principle which favors the most difficult reading as most likely the original reading. The logic behind this principle is that the copier would tend to *add words which made better sense to him.* In view of this principle we prefer the UBS reading, but hasten to affirm that as the truth in this verse flows into the next one we arrive at the same meaning. Those who emphasize the differences between the UBS and MR Greek texts render a disservice to the Divine Authority of the Word of God!

Now let us exegete the meaning of this verse. The key Greek word in the first part of this verse is the aorist participle "ασθενησας." It refers to Abraham's status, his faith in God, *which he had prior to considering* the physical condition of himself and Sarah. The thought is that Abraham, *not having been weak, feeble,* and *infirm* in faith, as one in this position might be, "considered" (κατενοησεν), *observed, reflected on,* and *contemplated* the circumstances surrounding him. He recognized that he was "about" (που) one hundred years old, and that "already" (ηδη), *before that time*, his body "had been dead" (νενεκρωμενον). This is a perfect participle and means that his sperm *had died in the past and continued in a dead condition*, i.e., he was sexually impotent. Furthermore, he observed that Sarah, his wife, did not have menstrual periods. In other words, as a man who was strong in faith, Abraham reflected on the odds - they were against him and Sarah producing progeny.

20. ***"but with respect to the promise of God he was not caused to waver in unbelief, but was made strong in faith, having given glory to God,"***

The Greek prepositional phrase translated "but with respect to the promise of God" (εις δε την επαγγελιαν του θεου) may also be rendered *but regarding the promise of God*. Even though Abraham observed the physical factors which militated against the fulfillment of the promise of God given to him, he was not "caused to waver in unbelief." The Greek verb and negative adverb translated "he was not caused to waver" (ου διεκριθη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that he did not permit Satan to cause him to *waver, vacillate,* and *fall into a quandary of unbelief.* Satan undoubtedly did everything he could to get Abraham to reflect on the obstacles which stood in the way of the fulfillment of the promise, such as the sexual deadness of him and his wife, but this *did not make him sway to and fro* in unbelief (James 1:6; 2:4).

Paul uses the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα," translated *but*, to emphasize that instead of wavering in unbelief Abraham "was made strong in faith." Again, it is very important to note that the Greek verb translated "was made strong" (ενεδυναμωθη) is also in the aorist tense and passive voice, which

makes it obvious that God was the one who made him *strong, powerful,* and *able* to excel in faith. Since God gave Abraham faith in the first place, it logically follows that He would be the strengthener of his faith (1 Tim. 1: 12-14).

The last Greek phrase in this verse speaks of Abraham as "having given glory to God." The key word in this verse is the aorist participle translated "having given," which means that Abraham gave glory to God prior to the time when God made him strong in faith. In spite of Satan's effort to destroy Abraham's confidence in God's promise, the very opposite resulted - Abraham was Divinely stimulated to give "glory" (δοξαν), *praise*, and *honor* to God. Subsequent to Abraham glorifying God, Paul says that God strengthened his faith. Generally, in Divine-human relations God is the *initiator*, the one who sovereignly calls, gives grace including faith, and who makes righteous and alive in Christ (Eph. 1:4; 2 Cor. 5:21; Eph. 2:4-9). After the believer is made alive and is capable of responding to God, it appears that this verse may be teaching *that in response to being glorified, God increased Abraham's faith.*

By carefully adhering to the significance of the two passive voices used in this verse, we have observed that Satan was vying against God for the control of Abraham. Sαtαn's strategy was to destroy Abraham's faith in God's word, the promise which God made to him. Abraham, however, did not succumb to this satanic device, but as one chosen and given faith by God he persevered and gave glory to God (Matt. 10:22; 2 Tim. 2:12). Abraham utilized his God-given faith, through it withstood the onslaught of Satan, glorified God, as a result of which God made him even stronger in faith. We observe the principle - when we use that which God has given to us He will increase it. Summarizing, even though the Majority Text adds the negative adverb in verse 19, the ultimate end is the same in verse 20, namely, that Abraham exercised his faith by giving glory to God and as a result God strengthened his faith.

21. ***"and being fully convinced that what he had promised he is also able to do."***

This verse gives us insight into the depth of Abraham's faith. The Greek aorist participle translated "being fully convinced" (πληροφορηθεις) is α compound verb derived from "πληρης" and "φορες." It literally means *to fully and completely bear or carry,* hence, as used in this verse, it has the thought of being *fully assured, completely convinced,* and *entirely persuaded.* Since this verb is in the passive voice it means that God was the one who had fully convinced Abraham that His promise was true. When we recognize that God was both the initiator and perpetuator of Abraham's faith, and that apart from God he would have fallen flat on his face before Satan, then it necessarily follows that God is the one who completely convinced him to believe His word. God not only gave Abraham the promise, but He also gave him the faith which fully persuaded him that it would be fulfilled.

Now let us look at what Abraham was convinced God could do, namely, "that what he had promised he is also able to do." The Greek phrase translated "what he had promised" (ο επηγγελται) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. It

refers back to the promise which God Himself had made to Abraham at a given point of time in the past and affirms that it is still in effect. Granting the validity of the promise, and that it is still in effect, Satan's argument was that God could not fulfill it due to physiological conditions. God's *ability* (δυνατος), *power*, and *might* was being challenged. In spite of this, Abraham was fully convinced that God did have the ability and power "to do" (ποιησαι) and *perform* what he had promised.

22. ***"Wherefore also* it was counted to him for righteousness*."***

This verse reverts back the truth introduced in verse 3, and restated in verse 9, namely, that Abraham's faith "was counted to him for righteousness." Having related the historical facts of how Abraham believed God against all odds in verses 18-21, Paul says "wherefore" (διο), *on which account, for this reason* it was "counted" (ελογισθη), *reckoned*, and *calculated* for righteousness. Paul gives his readers a glimpse of the circumstances involved in Abraham's believing God, how that in spite of Satan's efforts to get him to doubt the word of God, he persisted in his faith in God's promise. This verse gives us the grand conclusion, God's evaluation of Abraham's unswerving exercise of faith in His word, i.e., *faith is equivalent to righteousness*.

Finally, as we terminate this section dealing with the fact that Abraham's faith was counted for righteousness, we need to consider the *rationale* behind the principle that faith in what God has said to us equals righteousness. The very fact that Abraham believed the promise of his Perfect God is significant; it tells us something about Abraham himself. In view of what Jesus says in John 3:19-21, sinners within themselves do not seek the Perfect God; those who are in darkness do not seek God who is Light (1 John 1:5). This leads us to conclude: first, God infused in Abraham faith which identified him with the One who is Perfect Light, and second, as one made perfect by the gift of Divine faith (Eph. 2:8), Abraham had faith in God's word, the external evidence of his faith-righteousness.

23. ***"And if was not written on account of him only, that it was counted to him,"***

There is no question about it - the preceding verses have made it crystal clear, the faith given to Abraham was counted for righteousness. The main point of this verse is why did God cause this statement to be written in the Book of Genesis (Gen. 15:6)? Was it because of Abraham? Of course not, for Abraham was physically dead when this portion of God's Word was written. God obviously communicated this truth to Abraham; it was undoubtedly recorded in writings which were later incorporated into the Book of Genesis, for the sake of those who would read it.

The evidence is clear, the principle of faith-righteousness is latent in the Old Testament Scriptures, but it was buried under the Law, with the exception of a few (Isa. 53:5-6; Jer. 31:34; Acts 10:43; Rom. 4:6-8). On this side of the Cross this principle springs into full bloom; there is now immediate expiation of sins instead of atonement for sins, for faith identifies the elect with Christ our sin-substitute and with Christ our righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30; 2 Cor. 5:21). The fact

that this principle was clearly revealed to the Apostle Paul and Peter is both evident and emphasized in their writings (3:22, 26, 28; Gal. 1:12; 2:16, 21; 3:7, 11; 1 Peter 1:8-9, 19-21; 2:24; 3:18).

24. ***"but also of account of us to whom it was about to be counted, to those believing on the one who raised Jesus our Lord out from the dead,"***

This verse specifically says that the statement, *faith was counted to Abraham for righteousness,* was written in the Book of Genesis "on account of us" (δι' ημας). The context makes it evident, the pronoun us does not refer to the Jews who were under the Law, who had the Book of Genesis as a part of their Scripture, but *it refers to us who are being saved in this present age of Grace.* The fact that this verse begins with the strong conjunction "αλλα" emphasizes that this faith-righteousness statement was *not written for Abraham, but rather for us,* we who by faith are members of the Body of Christ. This statement was written for the sake of us to whom righteousness "was about to be counted."

The Greek word translated "about" (μελλει) commonly expresses the idea of *about, at the point of, on the brink of*, or that which is going to happen soon. The Jews looked for the imminent coming of the Messiah. He was always on the brink of coming to establish His Kingdom in their midst. As Paul writes the truth in this verse he recognizes that the Messiah did come, He offered His kingdom to Israel, it was rejected, and it was replaced with the Church, an unrevealed--secret-spiritual program. This program operates on the basis of Grace. God gives faith whereby He counts His elect righteous on the basis of the substitutionary death of Jesus Christ. As Paul looks back he reflects on this age of Grace as on the brink of coming, like the Messiah associated with it, even though it did not actually begin until over 1400 years after the statement regarding Abraham's faith-righteousness was written in the Book of Genesis.

Those to whom faith is counted, reckoned, and imputed for righteousness are "those believing on the one who raised Jesus our Lord out from the dead." The Greek phrase translated "those believing" (τοις πιστευουσιν) consists of the article and a present participle, and may also be rendered *those exercising faith, those trusting, and those fully persuaded.* The present tense implies that believing is a *continuous process*. Since faith is a gift of God given to those chosen in Christ (Eph. 1:4), and what God gives He does not withdraw, it follows that the elect will unswervingly have faith in God (Rom. 11:29; Heb. 11:6). According to this verse, the *object of our faith is God.* To have faith in the Person of God is to have faith in what He has said in His Word and in what He has and is doing. We have translated the preposition "επι" as faith on God, very literally it may be rendered *faith upon or on the basis of God*. We interpret this to mean that our faith should be fixed on *God's total Person*, the Almighty God who raised Jesus Christ out from the dead.

25. ***"who was delivered on account of our trespasses and was raised on account of our justification."***

This verse speaks of two things which God the Father effected for us through

Jesus Christ. First, He was "delivered on account of our trespasses." The compound verb translated "delivered" (παρεδοθη) comes from "παρα" and "διδωμι," and since it is in the passive voice it means that God the Father *delivered up, gave over,* and *handed over* His Son to the cruel death of the Cross (8:32; Acts 2:23; cf. Gal. 2:20; Eph. 5:2). Why did the Father make this supreme sacrifice of His Son? He was motivated by *love* and *mercy* (John 3:16; Eph. 2:4) "on account of" (δια), *because of, the reason was* our trespasses. For God to remain just, and to simultaneously justify sinners under the sentence of death, His *moral integrity* demanded that a sinless substitute assume our sin and death penalty (Rom. 3:23-26). Thanks be to God, Jesus Christ was willing to be made sin and death for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him (2 Cor. 5:21).

Second, we observe in this verse that Jesus Christ "was raised on account of our justification." The passive voice indicates that the Father was the one who "raised" (ηγερθη), *raised up*, and *resurrected* out from the sphere of dead men (Acts 3:15; 1 Cor. 6:14). According to this verse, why did God raise Him? It was "on account of" (δια), *because of, the reason* was our "justification" (δικαιωσυν), *to make us right, just,* and *vindicated.* Since the Living Christ is the very *essence of our righteousness* (1 Cor. 1:30), which is a prerequisite for our justification, it follows that no resurrection would mean no identification with the Living Christ - no righteousness equals no justification.

Chapter 5

1. ***"Therefore having been justified out of faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,"***

Beginning with chapter 3, verse 21, through chapter 4, Paul's thesis is that God has now, in this present Church age, manifested a righteousness apart from the Mosaic Law. The basis for this righteousness of God is *the faithfulness of Jesus Christ* which was consummated in His death on the Cross. Paul emphasizes that this righteousness is *obtained through faith* and not through works. In one sense it is a righteousness which has been manifested now (3:21), but in another sense it is evident in God's dealing with Abraham, David, and some of the prophets. By the way, Paul has incorporated the evidence from the Old Testament which is pertinent in this and his other epistles (cf. Gal. 3:6-29). He has done this under the Divine inspiration of the Spirit, and it is available to us as we study his epistles.

Having explained in the previous chapter how sinners are justified before God, Paul now seeks to enlarge the understanding of those who have been justified, particularly, with reference to their present and future privileges. The aorist passive participle translated "having been justified" (δικαιωθεντες) gives God the total credit for *making us right, just*, and giving us a *clean slate*. Now did God do this? Paul's answer is "out of faith" (εκ πιστεως), *out of the source of faith*. The emphasis of the preposition "εκ" used with the ablative case is on the *source, the origin*, and *the fountainhead* of our justification - it is derived from faith. Even as the justification is totally of God, likewise the faith, its source, is totally of God (cf. Eph. 2:8).

As a result of being justified out of faith, Paul says, "we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." The verb translated "we have" is in the present tense and indicative mood, and means that as justified ones *we continuously enjoy a peaceful relationship with or before God.* The preposition "δια" used with the genitive case affirms that Jesus Christ is the *agent* who has acquired this peace for us. His faithfulness, the Cross being its pinnacle, was an absolute requisite for reconciliation and peace between God and sinners (3:22; Eph. 2:14-17). We must keep in mind that sinners do not take the initiative in seeking peace with God (3:17), but contrariwise, God sovereignly takes the initiative in reconciling sinners to Himself (vv. 6-8).

2. ***"through whom also we have access by faith into this grace in which we stand, and we boast in the hope of the glory of God."***

Verse 1 declares that Christ is the *agent through whom we have peace with God,* likewise, this verse says that He is the *agent through whom we have access into this grace in which we stand*. The Greek word translated "access" (προσαγωγην) is derived from "προς" and "αγω" and basically means *to lead to*, hence, *access* and *admission*. The verb associated with this verse is in the

perfect tense, which means that subsequent to the Cross *we have had and continue to have the right to access, admission,* and *to enter into* "this grace in which we stand." According to the previous verse faith is the *source of our justification.* According to this verse faith is the *means by which we acquire our standing in grace.*

What does Paul mean by the statement, "this grace in which we stand?" Thus far he has used the word "grace" (χαριν) in three passages which help define its meaning. First, he says that we "are *freely justified* by his grace" (3:24). Second, grace is a gift, not something owed (4:4). Third, grace provides *faith as a free gift* to those chosen in Christ (4:16). These passages suggest that to stand in grace is to base our relation to God *on His free gift of faith-righteousness.* The opposite of this would be to stand in works, i.e., base our salvation on the works of the Law. The Greek verb translated "we stand" (εστηκαμεν) is in the perfect tense, which means that Paul is talking about grace in which *we have begun and continue to stand.* The language used here leaves no room for one to be separated from the grace, faith, and righteousness which God has provided (8:35-39; cf. Gal. 5:4).

As Paul stood in the grace of God, he said, "and we boast in the hope of the glory of God." The Greek verb translated "we boast" (καυχωμεθα) implies that Paul was continually *exulting, lauding, and rejoicing* "in" (επι), *on the basis of* the hope of the Glory of God. An amplified translation would be, "and we boast or rejoice on the basis of hope of the glory which belongs to God." As Paul looked out into the future he had a hope of being glorified together with Jesus Christ (8:30). This hope of being glorified with Christ was Divinely revealed unto him (Gal. 1:12; 1 Cor. 15:51-54). The phrase "the glory of God" implies that God is the one who gives us glorified bodies which conform to the glorified body of Christ (8:28; Phil. 3:21).

3. ***"And not only, but also we boast in tribulations, knowing that tribulation produces perseverance,"***

Paul opens this verse with the phrase, "and not only," for he wants to make it clear that the Gospel of the Grace of God is *more than* the fact that we will be glorified with Christ. There is no doubt about it - the prophetic destiny of believers is important, but this is only a *single aspect* of the total truth revealed for members of the Body of Christ, the Church. Also, Paul uses the strong adversative conjunction translated "but" (αλλα) to emphasize that his boasting isn't limited to that which is glorious, but that it also includes that which is inglorious, namely, tribulations.

The Greek word translated "tribulations" (θλιψεσιν) basically means *to squeeze, pressure*, hence, *oppressions and afflictions*. Paul certainly did not boast in the pressures and afflictions which befell him, as an end in themselves, but rather *in that which they produced* (12:12; 2 Cor. 1:4; 7:4). He knew (ειδοτες), *he was cognizant* of the fact that tribulation "produces" (κατεργαζεται), *works*, and *effects* perseverance. The Greek word rendered "perseverance" (υπομονην) is derived from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "μενω" and literally

means *to remain under*, hence, *endurance, steadfastness*, and *stick-to-itiveness*. The fact that Paul boasted in his tribulations, which produced greater endurance, proves that he did not consider himself to have arrived spiritually (Phil. 3:12-13).

4. ***"and perseverance approval, and approval hope;"***

Perseverance is a highly desirable trait in itself, but in this context it is primarily viewed as *a step toward approval*. The Greek word translated "approval" (δοκιμην) has the idea of *one who is proved through being tested and tried.* Through persevering in the midst of afflictions we prove that we have a genuine relation to God, that we are truly a part of His elect (2 Cor. 8:2; Phil. 2:22).

Again we observe that *approval* is not an end in itself, but *another step* toward the ultimate goal of "hope" (ελπιδα). If through tribulations we persevere, then perseverance produces approval, and as approved ones we have hope. Those whose God-given faith is counted for righteousness will persevere, prove that they are part of the elect, and as such, have a *certain, unwavering hope* (Col. 1:23; Heb. 3:6). Their faithfulness attests to the fact that they possess faith-righteousness, which has as its ultimate end the hope of sharing with Christ in glory (Col. 1:27).

5. ***"and hope does not put to shame, because the love of God has been poured out in our hearts through the Holy Spirit who was given to us,"***

Now let us briefly scan the context leading up to this verse. First, Paul says in verse 2 that he *boasted on the basis of the hope* of the glory of God. Second, in verses 3-4 he *boasts in the midst of his afflictions* because they produce two ingredients which are essential for a vibrant hope, namely, *perseverance*, and *approval*. The reality of our relation to God, given to us through faith-righteousness, is proved in the crucible of pressures and tribulations. The implication is that tribulations strengthen our hope to be glorified with Christ (8:23-25; Titus 2:13).

Paul begins this verse by saying that "hope does not put to shame." The Greek verb translated "put to shame" (καταισχυνει) is derived from the preposition "κατα" prefixed to the verb "αισχυνω" and literally means *to bring shame down on, to shame, disgrace,* and *dishonor*. This means that we who hopefully anticipate sharing glory together with Christ will not end up shamed, disgraced, and dishonored. Why can Paul be so positive and sure that we will not be put to shame? The reason is "because the love of God has been poured out in our hearts through the Holy Spirit who was given to us." The Greek conjunction rendered "because" clearly affirms that we will not be disgraced *on account of* or *in view of the fact* that the love of God has been "poured out" (εκκεχυται), *poured forth*, and *spread abroad* in our hearts. The implication is that God's abundant love will not permit His own, His elect, to be put to shame by not glorifying them with Christ. Their glorification is assured (8:18; 9:23-24; Eph. 1:18).

It is significant to note that God has poured out His love in our hearts

"through" (δια) the agency of the Holy Spirit. Furthermore, he uses the aorist tense and the passive voice to affirm that God had given the Holy Spirit to us. The language used suggests that God's love and the Holy Spirit who gave it to us are permanent entities and will not be withdrawn, thereby leaving us empty to suffer shame and disgrace (2 Cor. 1:21-22; Eph. 1:13-14). Summarizing, God's love intertwined with the indwelling Holy Spirit guarantees that we will share with Christ the glory of God (v. 2); therefore we will not be put to shame nor disgraced because we believed in an empty, false hope.

6. ***"for while we were infirm, in due time Christ died for the ungodly."***

Since verses 6-11 contain a closely knit context with a *single argument,* we will limit our exegesis to the salient parts which will help make the whole more meaningful. First, in this verse Paul takes us back to a time prior to the Cross when we were yet (ετι) "infirm" (ασθενων), *weak*, and *spiritually sick.* It was a time when we were ungodly, egocentric sinners. Second, during this particular time Christ died for the "ungodly" (ασεβων), *impious*, and *wicked*. The important thing we need to acknowledge in this verse is *our unattractive, sinful plight when Christ died on our behalf* (υπερ).

7. ***"For scarcely for a righteous man will one dare to die; for on behalf of a good man perhaps one might even dare to die;"***

In contrast to the fact that Christ died on behalf of ungodly sinners, Paul says, there is *no precedent for such a sacrifice*, for it would be hard to find one who would be willing to die for even a righteous man. It would be easier to find someone who would be willing to die for a good man. Paul does not describe the difference between the *righteous* and *good* man; however it is obvious that the good man would be more highly esteemed among men than the righteous man. The important thing this verse brings out is that there is *no precedent among men for what Jesus did*, dying for ungodly sinners.

8. ***"but God commended His own love unto us, that while we were yet sinners Christ died on behalf of us."***

The first part of this verse reverts back to verse 5, adding the thought that God "commended" (συνιστησιν), *placed with,* and *extended* His own love unto us at a time when we were still sinners. The extension of *God's own* (εαυτου) personal love unto us is seen in the fact that Christ died on behalf of us. In other words the death of Christ on Calvary is the *expression of God's own love*, the death of his beloved Son (Matt. 3:17; John 3:16; 1 John 4:9-10). It is important to observe in this verse that the death of Jesus Christ is *in essence the extension of God's love* unto us while we were yet rebellious sinners. Of course, there is no precedent for such love in the universe!

9. ***"Much more then, having been justified now by his blood, we shall be saved from the wrath through him."***

The thought flow here is that if God commended His love unto us while we were sinners, then much more He will save us who are justified from the coming wrath. The Greek phrase translated "much more then" (πολλω ουν μαλλον) may

also be rendered *much more therefore* or *to a far greater extent* He will save us justified ones from the wrath.

Since God lavished His love upon us as sinners, we can to a far greater extent expect Him to save us as justified ones from "the wrath" (της οργης), i.e., the coming wrath of God (2:5; Eph. 5:6; 1 Thess. 1:10). Keep in mind we have two distinct groups in this context, namely, those who are sinners and those who are justified. Since God has treated the sinners so good, by loving them to the extent of sacrificing His Son for them, we can logically expect Him to treat those who are justified *far better*; in fact, the least He can do is save them from the coming wrath. Even as our justification is made possible *by means of the Blood of Christ,* likewise, our being saved from the coming wrath is *through the personal agency of Christ*.

10. ***"For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God through the death of his Son, much more having been reconciled we shall be saved by his life."***

This verse reverts back to the time when we were enemies hating God (Titus 3:3). As indicated by the passive voice, God was not deterred by our enmity against Him, but sovereignly laid hold of us and reconciled us unto Himself. Of course, for God to maintain His just status and simultaneously reconcile us as enemies unto Himself, He had to do it through the substitutionary death of His Son. The inviolable principle set forth by God that *without the shedding of blood there is no remission* of sins cannot be violated by God Himself, otherwise He would be less than a moral God.

The last half of this verse deals with us as *those who have been reconciled.* In the light of *what we know* God did for us in the past when we were enemies of Him, *we can confidently affirm that He will do much more for us,* reconciled ones, in the future. In fact, Paul says, much more than now being reconciled ones, which in itself is a wonderful position to occupy before God, "we shall be saved in his life."

What does Paul mean by this last statement in this 10th verse, namely, that we who are reconciled to God "shall be saved by his life"? First, let us point out that the Greek used may be translated either *we shall be saved by His life* or *we shall be saved in His life,* i.e., in the sphere of or enclosed with His life. Second, as those who "have been reconciled" (καταλλαγεντες), who have a *changed relation to God,* who have been *restored into His favor,* and who are *no longer enemies but peaceful children,* we have much more awaiting us, for we will be perfectly saved from all sin (1 John 3:2) and *joined with Christ in resurrection life* (John 11:25; Phil. 3:20-21; 1 John 5:11-12).

11. ***"And not only, but also we boast in God through our lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received the reconciliation."***

The Apostle Paul has used the verb translated "boast" (καυχωμενοι) three times in this 5th chapter (vv. 2-3, 11). Its basic meaning is *boast, vaunt,* and *brag*, and secondarily to *exult* and *rejoice*. In the previous two verses he boasted

in the hope of the glory of God and *in tribulations,* while in this verse he is boasting "in God" (εν τω θεω). The opening phrase rendered "and not only" (ου μονον δε) clearly ties this boasting with that in verses 2-3, which emphasizes how closely this entire context is knit together, as we have already pointed out.

According to this verse Paul's boasting in God was "through" (δια) the agency of the Lord Jesus Christ. This may well be interpreted to mean that his boasting in God was *inseparable* from Jesus Christ, i.e., His name was constantly on Paul's lips as he boasted in God. On the other hand, it may be interpreted to mean that his boasting in God was *due to what God had wrought through Jesus Christ*. This latter interpretation would be supported by the final clause, which referring to Jesus Christ says, "through whom we have now received the reconciliation." This interpretation is supported by the two preceding verses, where we note that *we shall be saved through Christ* from the wrath and that we were *reconciled to God through the death of His Son*. Thus we observe, Paul is primarily boasting in God on the basis of that which He has and is going to accomplish through the Person of Jesus Christ.

In summarizing the truth in this paragraph, let us again take a look at what Paul says in verse 3, namely, that *hope does not put to shame, disgrace,* or *dishonor.* Hope is fixed on something which is to be realized in the future. As the word is used in this verse it speaks of that which cannot be verified in a test tube. The *evidence* Paul gives for the validity of the hope he is talking about is the fact that *the love of God has been poured out in our hearts* through the Holy Spirit. Through the following verses he points out what God's love has done in the past, i.e., caused Christ to die for the ungodly, for sinners; it effected justification by His blood, and it reconciled us through Christ's death. This is indeed a magnanimous record of what the love of God has wrought! On the basis of this past record, what the love of God has done, even on behalf of those who were ungodly, sinners, and enemies, Paul affirms that we who have been justified and reconciled will *to a much greater extent be the recipients of God's love.* He will save us from the coming wrath. He will save us in an inextricable union with the resurrected, living Person of Christ, an event commonly referred to as being glorified with Him. Yes, in the light of this evidence *we can confidently affirm that our hope is not empty,* and that it will not result in shame and disgrace, for our God has an unprecedented track record in the past which we know will doubly project into the future.

12. ***"On account of this even as through one man sin entered into the world, and death through sin, and so death passed through unto all men, on the basis of which all sinned - "***

First, we observe that "through one man sin entered into the world." This statement is based on the fall of man recorded in the Book of Genesis (Genesis 2:17; 3:6). Even though Adam did not initiate the original act of sin, he readily partook of its fruit, and, as the *head*, he is held responsible for it (1 Cor. 11:3; 1 Tim. 2:13-14). Eve was first deceived and penalized (Gen. 3:16), but from the viewpoint of the transmission of the guilt and penalty to their descendants, it is

traced back to Adam. The noun translated "sin" (αμαρτια) means *to miss the mark,* to fail to positively or negatively do or not do the will of God.

Second, we observe that "death (came] through sin." God explicitly stated the penalty for disobedience to His word - "in the day that you eat thereof you shall surely die" (Gen. 2:17). According to Genesis 3:22, it appears that God originally created man to *live forever*. The evidence suggests that man was created as both a *physical being* (Gen. 2:7) and a *spiritual being* (Gen. 1:27). Disobedience on the part of Adam and Eve cut them off from God, the source of life, resulting in their spiritual death (Gen. 3:23-24). Furthermore, this same act of disobedience subsequently brought physical death upon Adam and Eve (Gen. 3:19), and a curse upon creation (Gen. 3:17-18; Rom. 8:20-22). Sin brought death and the Law of Decay which continuously gnaws on all that has been created.

Third, we observe that "death passed through unto all men." Thus far we have considered the fact that sin entered the world at a given point in history, that it resulted in spiritual death and subsequent physical death, and now we want to examine the fact that it was transmitted to all men. The Greek verb translated "passed through" (διηλθεν) is derived from the preposition "δια" prefixed to the verb "ερχομαι" and means *to pass through, over, and along*, hence, *to spread and extend to all men.* It is not a matter of whether or not it was forensically fair and just for the progeny of Adam and Eve to be held accountable for the disobedience of their parents, the fact is that *what* Adam and Eve became through their sin and its curse is inherited by their offspring. If God had immediately enforced the principle that the wages of sin is death, there would have been no progeny, no human race. The fact that there is appears in itself to be an act of grace on God's part, particularly, when we consider the provision He has made for redemption (Gen. 3:15).

Fourth, we observe the final clinching statement, "on the basis of which all sinned." This is a literal translation which conforms to the basic meaning of the preposition "επι." On the basis of the evidence that death was passed on to all men, and that sin equals death, the inescapable conclusion is that all sinned. In other words, sin results in death, and where there is universal death the implication is that there is universal sin, i.e., all men have sinned. The Bible teaches that all men are *sinners in their very nature* (Eph. 2:3), and history verifies the same.

13. ***"for sin was in the world until the Law, but sin is not imputed when there is no Law."***

In view of what was said in the preceding verse, it is a foregone conclusion: sin was in the world from the time of Adam and Eve onward, the greatest malady that has ever inflicted the human race. The main point Paul is stressing in this verse is that sin is not "imputed" (ελλογειται), *entered into man's account, charged to man's account* when there is no law. The use of the present tense suggests that Paul is citing a commonly recognized principle which he applies to the Mosaic Law, namely, that sin is not imputed "not being a law" (μη οντος νομου). In the light of this principle Paul sees the main purpose of the

Mosaic Law that of impressing upon men's conscience the exceeding sinfulness of sin (7:13).

14. ***"But death reigned from Adam until Moses, even over those who had not sinned on the basis of the likeness of Adam's transgression, who is a type of the one coming."***

This verse begins with the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα" which generally is preferably translated *but*. Paul wanted to drive home a *strong contrast* between sin not being imputed before the Law, and the fact that *during the same time* death "reigned" (εβασιλευσεν), *ruled*, and *governed* in accordance with the curse. Death reigned even "over" (επι) or *upon* those who had not sinned "on the basis of" (επι), after, or according to the "likeness" (ομοιωματι), *form*, or *that which resembled* Adam's transgression. Since no one has ever been confronted with the same situation that confronted Adam and Eve, and since no one has sinned according to the likeness of their transgression, Paul is actually affirming that *death reigned from Adam until Moses over all men.*

Lastly in this verse, Paul refers to Adam as "a type of the one coming." The word translated "type" (τυπος) means that Adam is a *pattern, representation,* and a *figure* "of the one coming" (του μελλοντος) or *of the one about to come*, i.e., of the Messiah, Jesus Christ. We need to ask ourselves the question, in what way is Adam a type? In seeking the answer we must keep in mind that types may be limited to *one thing that is common*, and they may also be *positive* or *negative*. Even as by Adam's trespass *all men died;* likewise, by the free gift of God's grace *many abounded in life*.

15. ***"But not as the trespass, thus also is the free gift; for if by the trespass of the one many died, much more the grace of God and the gift by grace of the one man Jesus Christ abounded unto the many."***

Let us examine the statement, "But not as the trespass, thus also is the free gift." This verse begins with the strong conjunction "αλλα" *emphasizing the contrast* between the trespass of Adam and the free gift of Jesus Christ. In order to help you more fully grasp the significance of the adverb "ουτως" in this statement, I want to give you an expanded translation of it. Paul says, "But not like as or according as the trespass, *thus in the same way, in like manner* is the free gift." The thought is that there is definite *similarity, likeness*, and *identity* between the trespass and the free gift; however, the negative adverb "ouχ," translated not, puts these two similar phrases in a *reverse* or *opposite* relation, i.e., they are on the one hand alike, but on the other hand they convey opposite meanings.

In the second part of this verse Paul posits a condition: "for if by the trespass of the one many died" then it follows that "much more the grace of God and the gift of the one man Jesus Christ (has) abounded unto the many." In view of the preceding context we must grant that by the trespass of Adam many died; in fact, all died. Therefore, as night follows day, we must also grant that much more God's grace, even the gift of the one man Jesus Christ, has "abounded"

(επερισσευσεν), *been over and above*, and *has been richly furnished* unto the many. This statement implies that the redemptive work of Christ on Calvary is *unlimited*, it has the potential for saving all sinners. The undeniable argument of this verse is that even as the result of Adam's trespass spread to all men, likewise, the result of Christ's substitutionary death spreads to all men (1 Tim. 2:4; 2 Peter 3:9).

16. ***"And the gift is not as through one who had sinned; for the judgment was out of one unto condemnation, but the free gift is out of many trespasses unto justification."***

Again we observe that the statement "the gift is not as through one who had sinned" means that *the gift is the opposite of what came through the agency of the one who sinned*, the opposite of Adam's trespass. Since the particle "μεν" and "δε" are used in sequel in what follows in this verse, our explanation will incorporate their grammatical significance. Paul says, for on the one hand, the judgment was out of the source of one trespass unto the end of condemnation. On the other hand, the free gift is out of the source of many trespasses. This jars one; it is unexpected in the light of the preceding and following context. We would suggest that it may mean that the many trespasses *elicited* and *evoked* the free gift that is unto justification. According to this interpretation the desperate plight of sinners evoked God's mercy to provide the gift of Jesus Christ on the Cross, an act of righteousness unto the end of justification (vv. 6, 8, 10).

17. ***"For if by the trespass of the one death reigned through the one, much more those receiving the abundance of grace and the gift of righteousness shall reign in life through the one, Jesus Christ."***

This verse reverts back to the thought of verse 14, adding that death reigned *through the one*, namely, Adam. In contrast to this, those who have received God's abundant grace and gift of righteousness *shall reign in the sphere of life through the one,* Jesus Christ. Note that in this verse the contrast is between *death reigning through Adam* on account of that which he did, and *those who are righteous reigning through Christ* on account of what He did on Calvary. Beyond the contrast, it is significant to note that those who have been made righteous by the grace of God reign "in life" (εν ζωη), *in the sphere of Divine life* (John 6:57).

18. ***"Then therefore as through one trespass condemnation came unto all men, thus also through one act of righteousness came justification of life unto all men."***

All it took to bring the entire human race under condemnation was *one trespass*, one act of disobedience, on the part of Adam. Likewise, all that it took to bring justification, Divine life, to all men was *one act of obedience on the part of Jesus Christ*. Of course, this one act of obedience was His submission to the ignoble death of the Cross, His once and for all substitutionary death. Also, take note of the fact that this one act of obedience, His death on the Cross, is unto all men, unlimited. This one act of righteousness resulted in "justification of life" (δικαιωσιν ζωης), i.e., justification which belongs to life; the two are inseparable, justified believers are joined together with Christ in resurrection life (4:25).

19. ***"For even as through the disobedience of one man many were made sinners, likewise also through the obedience of one many will be made righteous."***

The Greek word translated "disobedience" (παρακοης) is derived from the preposition "παρα" prefixed to the verb "ακουω" and literally means *to hear beside*, and as used here it means *not to listen, not to pay attention to what is said.* The thought is that Adam let what God said about not eating of the Tree of Life go by the side, slide by, i.e., *his disobedience began with his failure to carefully listen to God's Word given to him*. When God confronted the first man Adam with the supreme test, which involved pleasing God versus the desires of his flesh, he heard askance, did not take God's message seriously, and performed the first act of disobedience.

As a result of Adams' disobedience "rnany were made sinners." The Greek phrase translated "many" (οι πολλοι) may equally well be translated *the many.* As used in this verse, and verified in all Paul's epistles, this means that the masses and multitudes "were made sinners." The Greek verb translated "were made" (κατεσταθησαν) comes from combining the preposition "κατα" and the verb "ιστημι" and literally means *to place down, to establish,* and *to fix* all men as sinners (3:9-12, 23).

Even as Adam's disobedience established many as "sinners" (αμαρτωλοι), *miss-the-markers*, and *depraved*, "likewise" (ουτως) *in the same manner and way* Jesus Christ's obedience will make many righteous. The contrast is between Adam's disobedience as against Christ's obedience and many being made sinners over against many will be made righteous. Adam and Christ are looked at as the heads of two distinct groups, namely, those who *are sinners* and those who will be made righteous. In the case of Adam the aorist tense and passive voice indicate that subsequent to his act of disobedience God fixed his progeny as sinners. In the case of Jesus Christ the future tense and passive voice indicate that God will establish many as righteous. The many who are identified with Adam represent all his flesh and blood progeny, the entire human race, whereas the many who will be associated with Christ are *those who will believe in Him* (1:16; 3:22; 4:3). For comparative reasons Paul uses the same phrases "the many" (οι πολλοι), but the context demands that the many with Adam are *all men* while the many with Christ are *all believers.*

Now let us examine the statement that "through the obedience of one many will be made righteous." The Greek word translated "obedience" (υπακοης) is derived from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "ακουω" and literally means *to hear under*, i.e., *to be under that which is heard, to be submissive and obedient to it* (Heb. 5:8). Jesus Christ's great single act of obedience was *His submission to death* on the Cross (Phil. 2:8). This act of obedience on His part made it possible for God the Father to maintain His just position and at the same time justify and make sinners righteous. Our position before God does not depend upon our obedience nor on what we have done, but it totally depends upon Jesus Christ, His obedience unto death on Calvary as our Sin-substitute.

Identified with Him through faith, His righteousness is our righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30; 2 Cor. 5:21). When we believed in Him God made, fixed, and established us as righteous ones.

20. ***"And the Law came in beside that the trespass might abound; but where sin abounded, grace superabounded,"***

In verse 13 Paul says that sin was in the world prior to the Mosaic Law, but that it was not imputed during that time. In this verse he clearly states the reason God gave the Law, i.e., it "came in beside that the trespass might abound." The triple compound verb translated the Law "came in beside" (παρεισηλθεν) is derived from the prepositions "παρα" and "εις" prefixed to the verb "ερχομαι," and literally means that the Law *came in beside the sin which was in the world, it occupied a place beside sin,* and in this *contiguous relation* to sin the Law amplified sin as sin (4:7-9, 13). The specific purpose for which God gave the Law was in order that the trespass "might abound" (πλεονασῃ), i.e., *that it might reveal the magnitude* of the consequences of Adam's "trespass" (παραπτωμα), *transgression*, and *defection* which is inherent in the nature of his progeny (5:14; 1 Cor. 15:22).

In this context the words *trespass* (παραπτωμα) and *sin* (αμαρτια) are used to describe the disobedience which the Law made obvious. The two are not necessarily used synonymously, but give a more comprehensive picture of the wrongdoing which the Law revealed, it was both a *falling beside* and *missing the mark* of God's standard. Where the Law served its purpose of making sin "abound" (επλεονασεν), of impressing its *exceeding greatness* on men's consciences, Paul says that "grace superabounded." The Greek verb translated "superabounded" (υπερεπερισσευσεν) is derived from the preposition "υπερ" prefixed to the verb "περισσευω" and literally means *to abound out beyond, over and above,* or *exceedingly.* Regardless of the excessiveness and greatness of the sin uncovered by the Law, the Grace of God far exceeded it (John 1:17; 1 Tim. 1:14).

21. ***"that even as sin reigned in death, likewise also grace might reign through righteousness unto eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord."***

In verses 14 and 17 Paul depicts death as reigning. In this verse he drops back to the cause of death, sin, as that which had reigned. The use of the aorist tense suggests that Paul is referring to the sin revealed by the Law, but not necessarily limited to it, sin which "reigned" (εβασιλευσεν), *ruled,* and *governed* in the sphere of death. In reality, failure to keep the Law developed a consciousness of sin, the consequences of which is death, hence, the sinner was caught in the jaws of death.

Even as sin had reigned in death, Paul’s desire is that likewise "grace might reign through righteousness unto eternal life." The reign of sin in death was normal during the 1400 years the Law was in effect, but in contrast, grace should now reign unto the end of eternal life. We note that this reign of grace is "through

righteousness" (δια δικαιοσυνης), *through the agency of righteousness*, and the end or result of this righteousness is eternal life. The sequential order is as follows: (1) God's grace is manifested in Jesus Christ, (2) He is the embodiment of righteousness, and (3) because we are righteous in Him we have eternal life. Even as sin equals death, likewise righteousness equals life (6:23).

Originally God created man in His own image and likeness (Gen. 1:26-27), as one who shared in His righteousness and life, but when man sinned he lost this righteousness and life. On the basis of His grace God has made it possible for man to be restored to righteousness and life "through Jesus Christ" (δια Ιησου Χριστου), i.e., through the agent, through the Person of Jesus Christ (1 Cor. 1:13; 2 Cor. 5:21). This righteousness and life is transmitted to us through our faith-relation to the living Christ (John 6:57; Rom. 3:22; 1 John 5:11-12).

Chapter 6

1. ***"What shall we say then? Should we continue to sin that grace may abound?"***

Having emphasized the purpose of the Mosaic Law, that it produced an awareness of what was trespassing and sinning, which was counteracted with superabounding grace, Paul feels that some may unwittingly or deliberately misread what he has written. Rather than allowing a misunderstanding to develop, or antagonists of the Gospel to pervert what he has said, he takes the initiative to preclude any misinterpretations. He does this by asking two questions. First, "What shall we say then?" (τι ουν ερουμεν). Following the word order in the Greek this may also be translated *What then shall we say* or *What therefore shall we say?* The thought is that in view of what Paul had previously said, therefore, what shall we now say or add?

Second, Paul asks, "Should we continue in sin that grace may abound?" We must keep in mind that in the preceding chapter (v. 20) *he is not affirming* that there is a direct correlation between a person's consciousness of sin and the amount of grace extended to him. The gist of his statement is that in contrast to man's sin *God's grace is far greater.* The magnitude of God's grace is static and fixed, and does not fluctuate with the degree to which a person is conscious of his sin. It reaches its highest expressions in the sacrificial death of the Son of God on Calvary.

The Greek verb translated "should we continue" (επιμενωμεν) in sin is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "μενω," it is in the present tense and subjunctive mood, and literally means should *we continue on, remain involved in,* or *persist in* sin in order that grace may abound? In asking this question and answering it with a resounding *no*, Paul is apparently fending against illogical adversaries who falsely say that the more one sins the greater grace he will receive.

2. ***"Let it never be, we who died to sin, how shall we still live in it?"***

Paul uses the strongest possible language to repudiate the thought that we should "continue in sin that grace may abound." The Greek phrase "μη γενοιτο" is in the aorist tense and optative mood, and may be likened to a prayer petition: *let it never be, may we never do it, or may it never come to pass.*

The reason Paul gives for believers not continuing in sin is because we "died to sin." The relative pronoun translated "who" (οιτινες) marks believers as a *special group* who have died to sin. The Greek verb translated "died" (απεθανομεν) is in the aorist tense which indicates that this death took place at a given point of time in the past. The following context will throw more light on the specific time believers died to sin.

The premise of Paul's argument in the first 11 verses of this chapter is the *fact that believers have died to sin*. In view of this, he says, "how shall we still live in it?" The Greek adverb translated "still" (ετι) may also be rendered how shall we *yet, longer,* and *further* live in it? When a person is dead in relation to anything, such as sin in this case, he is incapable of living and moving in the category of it. If, in an absolute sense, believers are dead to sin, then there would be no need for Paul to exhort them not to live in it. However, forensically with reference to the position of believers in Christ, God looks on them as having died to sin, the reality of which needs to be realized in their daily living (v. 11; Phil. 2:12-13).

3. ***"Or are you ignorant that as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus we were baptized into his death?"***

The Greek verb translated "ignorant" (αγνοειτε) means *do you not know, don't you understand,* and *aren't you cognizant of the fact* that we were baptized into the death of Christ? Observe that our literal translation contains the phrase "as many" (οσοι) which basically speaks of the *quantity* and *number* of those who were truly baptized into Christ's death. Paul does not know those who had been genuinely baptized into His death, but one thing he does know, *as many as had* were identified with His death. The verb rendered *baptized* speaks of an act which *tied* believers together with the death of Christ.

Now let us examine the meaning of the verb translated "baptized" (εβαπτισθημεν). It is closely associated with the verb "βαπτω" meaning *to dip*. As used in the classical Greek "βαπτω" means *to dip, to dip under*, hence, *to steep or saturate*. In the middle voice it means *to bathe*. Metaphorically it is used of those *soaked in wine* (inebriated), of those *over head and ears in debt,* and of a boy *overwhelmed with questions*. From these citations it is obvious that the primary meaning of to dip, immerse, and steep in is commonly used with a secondary metaphorical meaning.

As used in the Classical and New Testament Greek the allied words "βαπτω" and "βαπτιζω" definitely convey the *idea of to dip*, but not necessarily always the thought of immersion or submersion (Luke 16:24; Mark 1:4; 7:4). In the New Testament it depicts *washing*, apparently the hands (Luke 11:38), and of various utensils (Mark 7:4). The Greek verb "βαπτιζω" is commonly used in the New Testament in contexts in which there is *no water*. Jesus will baptize *in the Holy Spirit and in fire*, i.e., in judgment (Luke 3:16-17). Jesus asks the question, Are you willing to be baptized *into my impending death* (Mark 10:39; cf. Luke 12:50; Rom. 6:3). Paul speaks of true believers as those who have been baptized *into Christ* (Rom. 6:3; Gal. 3:27). He refers to the Israelites who came out of Egypt as having been baptized *into Moses* (1 Cor. 10:2). When the context obviously refers to baptism in water, it is never referred to as *into Christ* (εις Χριστον), but always as *in* or *into the name* (εις το ονομα) of either Jesus Christ or the Lord Jesus (Acts 2:38; 8:16; 10:48; 19:5).

In the light of this brief survey of the Greek verb "βαπτιζω" in the Classical and New Testament Greek, we are forced to recognize that it is often used with a

secondary *metaphorical* meaning. As we examine the various contexts in which it is used in this manner, analyzing them in search of a common-meaning denominator, one English word accurately describes its meaning as used in most contexts, namely, *identification*.

Now let us consider, in view of this metaphorical meaning, the statement that "as many of us as were baptized into Christ Jesus we were baptized into his death." The verb translated we "were baptized" (εβαπτισθημεν) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that at a given time in the past God the Holy Spirit baptized us into Christ, i.e., *identified us with the Body of Christ* (1 Cor. 12:13; Gal. 3:27). The phrase "into Christ Jesus" (εις Χριστον Ιησουν) is significant evidence which means that his baptism has identified us with the Body, the Church, and is apart from water.

As those who have been baptized into the Body of Christ, Paul says that his baptism has a double significance, we also have been baptized into His death, i.e., *identified with the death of Christ*. Those chosen in Christ before the creation of the world, destined to be identified with His Body, were identified with His death on Calvary's cross (Col. 2:20).

4. ***"Therefore we were buried with him through baptism into death, that even as Christ was raised out of the dead through the glory of the Father, likewise also we should walk in newness of life."***

The particle translated "therefore" (ουν) means that *as a consequence* of what Paul said in the previous verse then or now "we were buried with him through baptism into death." The compound verb translated "buried with" (συνεταφημεν) consists of the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "θαπτω" and means nothing more nor less than that we were buried, interred, and *entombed with Christ into death.* To my knowledge there is no evidence of the Greek verbs "συνθαπτω" and "θαπτω" being used to depict a burial in water. In other words, there is *no precedent* for affirming that our burial into the death of Christ was effected through water baptism.

For those who insist, in spite of the evidence to the contrary, that the reference here is to water baptism, please keep in mind that *this baptism produces a spiritual result,* namely, *puts us into the death of Christ.* To hold an interpretation, which indicates that God imparts spiritual grace through a physical act or ordinance, is totally foreign to the contents of Paul's Epistles. If the baptism in this verse involves water, then water identifies us with the death of Christ, but how could it, since the death of Christ took place nearly two thousand years ago. The preposition "δια" used with the genitive case says that *through baptism* (βαπτισματος), *through a sovereign identifying act*, God identified us with the death of Christ, a concept inseparable from identification with the Body of Christ (8:29; Eph. 1:4; 2 Tim. 1:9).

The Greek conjunction "ινα" used with the subjunctive mood indicates that the reason we were buried into Christ's death was for the *purpose*, "that even as Christ was raised out from the dead through the glory of the Father, likewise also

we should walk in newness of life." The Greek adverb translated "even as" (ωσπερ) means that *like as* and *just as* Christ was raised out of the dead we, are to live a new life. Paul affirms that the resurrection of Christ was accomplished "through the glory of the Father" (δια της δοξης του πατρος), i.e., *through the appearance, majesty,* and *glorious working* of the Father. All that Paul envisioned, conceived, and presumed respecting the majestic person of God was involved in effecting the resurrection of Christ (John 1:18).

Even as Christ was raised from death to life, to live to God (v. 10), "likewise also we should walk in newness of life." Since Paul has affirmed that we believers have been baptized into the death of Christ, which means that *we have been identified with His death*, it follows that we "likewise" (ουτως), in the same manner as He was raised out of the sphere of death, "should walk" (περιτατησωμεν), *live,* and *conduct ourselves* in "newness" (καινοτητι) of life, i.e., in the newness and freshness of the resurrection life which we have in Christ (2 Cor. 4:10; 1 John 5:11-12). In conclusion, identification with Christ in death is the *basis* for identification with Him in life, which should express itself in a new lifestyle.

5. ***"For if we have been planted together in the likeness of his death, but even more we shall be part of the resurrection,"***

Paul never claims any special insight into the relation of others to the Lord. He does, however, leave the question open as to whether or not certain individuals may know the Lord (1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23). His statement, "for if we have been planted together in the likeness of his death," does not vouch for anyone's identity with the death of Christ. The Greek noun translated "planted together" (συμφυτοι) is derived from the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "φυτευω" and basically means *planted with* or *planted together*. This is an agricultural figure of speech used to portray the thought of being *united together* in the likeness of Christ's death (Phil. 3:10). The verb used in conjunction with *planted together* is in the perfect tense, which means that if we have been truly planted with His death it is a *permanent relationship*.

Now let us examine the meaning of the Greek word translated "likeness" (ομοιωματι). In the Classical Greek it means *that which is like, an image,* and *a likeness.* Paul uses this word twice to describe Jesus Christ's incarnation in human flesh. He was made in the likeness (ομοιωματι), *like unto with the exception that He was apart from sin* (Rom. 8:3; Phil. 2:7; Heb. 2:17; 4:15). The fact is irrefutably stated in this context that believers are *solidly identified* with the death of Christ. It appears to us that the figure of speech, "we have been planted together," is the vantage point from which Paul uses the word *likeness*. We usually think of planted as something which is done in soil, not in death, but here he says that it is, as it were, in the likeness of death.

In contrast to most of the translations, observe our literal rendering of the last clause in this verse, namely, "but even more we shall be part of the resurrection." Young's Literal Translation also follows the Greek text. The Greek phrase translated "but even more" expresses both the ideas of contrast and emphasis.

In contrast to our identification with Christ's death, it is much more important to note that we will be identified with His resurrection. The main thought of this clause is that we shall be *part of and included in His resurrection*, i.e., it belongs to us, we will share in it if we have been truly planted with Christ. Of course, Paul is speaking here of Christ's physical resurrection and our present sharing in His resurrection life (Eph. 2:5-6; Col. 3:1-2).

6. ***"knowing this, that our old man was crucified with him, that the body of sin might be made inactive, that we should no longer be enslaved to sin;"***

As Paul opens this verse he continues to emphasize the fact that we believers have been identified with the death of Christ. His statement, “knowing this" (τουτο γινωσκοντες) implies that he had previously taught them this truth and that they continued to know it. They knew "that our old man was crucified with" Christ. What does Paul mean by the phrase "our old man" (ο παλαιος ημων ανθρωπος)? This same phrase is used two other times by him (Eph. 4:22; Col. 3:9). The Greek word translated "old" (παλαιος) has the idea of *that which has existed* in contrast to that which is new or recent. According to Paul’s use of this phrase in writing to the Ephesians and Colossians, *the old man* has the same characteristics as the unsaved man. The old man apparently had his origin in the fall of Adam, the resultant of the curse (Gen. 3:8, 22; Rom. 8:20-23).

Paul declares that the old man "was crucified with" (συνεσταυρωθη) Christ. This Greek verb is derived from the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "σταυροω" and it literally means, in the passive voice, *to be crucified* or *put to death with Christ*. The thought is that we were crucified together with Christ when He was nailed to Calvary's Cross. On the basis of our being identified with His death to sin, and for sin, forensically speaking our old man has been *once and for all crucified* with Christ. This must not be interpreted, however, to mean that the old man will no longer vie to control us in these flesh bodies.

From the forensic point of view our old man *was crucified* with Christ. From the practical point of view, as we live daily in this physical body, our old man is still vying for control. In speaking to believers, whose old man was forensically crucified, Paul says, "put off the former manner of life, the old man, the one being corrupted according to the lusts of deceit" (Eph. 4:22). According to Colossians 3:9, believers forensically crucified with Christ, are still ordered to put off the sins associated with the old man. These passages substantiate the fact that even though the old man has been crucified with Christ, yet the old man is still vying for the control of the lives of believers (Rom. 7:14-23).

The reason our old man was crucified was in order "that the body of sin might be made inactive." The Greek verb translated "inactive" (καταργηθη) is derived from the preposition "κατα" and "αργεω" and basically means that the body of sin might be *unemployed, idle,* and *inoperative.* The phrase "the body of sin" is not to be found elsewhere in the New Testament; however the principle that sin is resident in the body and the flesh is clearly taught in the 7th chapter (vv. 14, 17-

18, 20-21, 23). Granting that the old man was crucified with Christ forensically, and that this identity with the death of Christ is fully realized in our thinking and living, the body of sin would indeed be idle, unemployed, and inactive. This should be the goal of every believer, even though it has never been attained according to the New Testament record and the annals of history (1 Cor. 6:19-20; Phil. 3:12-15; 1 John 1:8).

If the first two conditions in this verse were fulfilled: (1) that we have been crucified with Christ, (2) that as a result the body of sin is completely inactive, then it follows "that we should no longer be enslaved to sin." The Greek infinitive translated "enslaved" (δουλευειν) means that we should no longer *render service as a slave to sin* nor should we be in slavery and subjection to sin (vv. 12-13).

7. ***"for the one having died has been justified from sin."***

Paul's flow of thought is that the old man who was crucified has died to sin, resulting in the believer being justified from sin. We must recognize that Paul has two men in mind here. First, the *old* crucified one, and second, the *new* justified one. The Greek phrase translated "the one having died" (ο αποθανων) is an aorist participle with the article, and as such it speaks of that which happened *prior* to that denoted by the main verb. This means that after the old man had died, then he, the new man, *was and continues to be justified from sin.* It is important to observe that the old man, the one through whom Satan energized, had to be put to death with Christ *before* the new man, the one through whom God's Spirit energizes, could be put on (Eph. 4:24).

The main Greek verb in this verse is properly translated "has been justified" (δεδικαιωται). The best English equivalent is the word *justified*, i.e., declared to be *just, right,* and *cleared of all wrongdoing*. When the believer is viewed from the standpoint of the old man, he has died forensically before God, but when he is viewed from the standpoint of the new man, he has been justified forensically before God. When we get the correct perspective of what Paul is saying in this verse, then the literal meaning of the Greek word "δεδικαιωται," *has been justified*, flows with the context.

8. ***"And if we died with Christ, we believe that also we shall live with him;"***

Here we observe that Paul is not pointing out those who have truly died with Christ - this was not his prerogative - but he is prodding the individuals associated with the church at Rome to consider their relation to Christ's death. If they were genuinely identified with the death of Christ, if as those chosen in Christ before the creation of the world they were sovereignly linked to Christ's death on Calvary, then they would believe that they will live with Him. Death with Christ is the prerequisite to living with Him. Our old man must undergo death before God makes us new-man creations in Christ (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15).

The Greek verb translated "we shall live with" (συζησομεν) Him is a compound word formed by combining the preposition "συν" and the verb "συν." It literally means *to live with, to live together with,* or *to co-exist in life.* The only

other time this word is used in the New Testament with reference to our life together with Christ is in Second Timothy 2:11, where Paul quotes, "for if we died with, we shall also live with." This suggests that the early believers knew this formula for true spiritual living, and as this fragment implies, may have put it in the form of a psalm, spiritual ode, or a song (Col. 3:16).

9. ***"knowing that Christ having been raised from the dead he no longer dies, death no longer dominates him."***

As Paul opens this verse, the implication is that those to whom he is writing already know what he is about to say. They know that Christ has been raised from the dead, they know that He is not going to continue dying as the Mass implies, and they know that death no longer has any mastery over Him. They knew (ειδοτες), on the basis of what they had been taught, not experience, that Christ's resurrection was final, that He would *not die again* as others who had been raised, and that as the sinless God-man *death had no claim on Him.*

The verb translated "having been raised" (εγερθεις) is in the aorist tense and passive voice. This means that at a *given point of time* in history *God the Father* raised Jesus Christ out from among the dead. The Greek phrase translated "he no longer dies" (ουκετι αποθνησκει) means that *not yet, not still,* and *no more* does He continue dying. The only reason He died once was because He assumed our sin (2 Cor. 5:21). The sin issue having been eternally settled, as the impeccable Son of God, He will never die again.

The statement, "death no longer dominates him," must be understood in the light of the *reason* why Christ died. When the love and mercy of God prompted Him to rescue sinners and bring them back into fellowship with Himself, there was a major obstacle (5:8; 9:16; Eph. 2:4). Now could God remain just and simultaneously justify sinners (3:25-26)? The answer is in the *substitutionary death* of the perfectly faithful Person of Jesus Christ. Death can no longer exercise mastery over Him, *once and for all time He paid the penalty for sinners* that God might freely justify them!

10. ***"For that which he died, he died to sin once for all; and that which he lives, he lives to God."***

In maintaining a literal translation, the first part of this verse may be translated "for that which he died" or just *for which he died*. In the light of the context it is obvious that the relative pronoun "ο" refers back to the word *death*. The thought is that the death Christ died, "he died to sin once for all" or *unto* or *for* sin once for all. Sin evoked His death, but His *one death* paid the penalty for the *sin of all men forever*. Paul is affirming here that Christ's substitutionary death is for the *sin of all men for all time*. Nothing can be added to it!

Having observed that the first part of this verse emphasizes the adequacy of the death of Christ for eternity, now our attention is turned to His post-resurrection life. Speaking with reference to Christ's life, Paul says, "that which he lives, He lives to God." Since the relative Greek pronoun "ο" obviously refers to the life of Christ (vv. 4, 8), we take the liberty of translating this statement *and*

the life He lives, He lives to God. Regardless of whether we are talking about the preresurrection or post-resurrection life of Christ His sole purpose was to please God the Father (15:3; John 8:29). Note the contrast between the first and last parts of this verse, namely, He died *to sin* and He lives *to God.* His death has broken the power of sin (Heb. 2:14-15), and His resurrection provides the dynamic for living to God.

11. ***"Likewise also you consider yourselves to be dead to sin but alive to God in Christ Jesus."***

Incorporating the significance of the Greek particles "μεν" and "δε" into a translation of this verse, the contrast becomes sharper. "Likewise also you consider yourselves on the one hand to be dead to sin, but on the other hand alive to God in Christ Jesus." This is the final, capstone verse of the first paragraph in this chapter. The main thesis of this paragraph has focused on the fact that all true believers have been *sovereignly identified with the death of Christ*. As the paragraph continues the emphasis increasingly includes the fact of Christ's resurrection and our identification with Him in resurrection life.

According to this paragraph the sole basis for true spirituality is the fact that our *old man has been crucified with Christ*, hence, dead to sin. Forensically speaking, as we stand before God, we are accounted as both dead to sin and righteous in Christ (2 Cor. 5:21). This is the premise on which genuine New Testament spirituality rests. Because we have died with Christ, and are dead to sin in Christ, we are to inculcate this thinking and subsequent acting into our daily living. Furthermore, as those who have been raised with Christ, who have been made righteous in Christ, and who have resurrection life throbbing in their spiritual vein, *with Him we are to live to God.*

Having given a resume of the thesis of this paragraph, now let us examine what this 11th verse says. It begins with the adverb translated "likewise" (ουτως) which means that *in the same way and manner* as Christ died to sin and lived to God, believers are to consider themselves dead to sin and alive to God. Addressing believers, and making them *responsible* for their spirituality, Paul says "you consider yourselves to be dead to sin, but alive to God in Christ Jesus."

It is important that we understand the meaning of the Greek word translated "consider" (λογιζεσθε). It is used of numerical calculating, hence, may be rendered *count, calculate, reckon,* and *regard*. As we have already observed, the believer's old man has been crucified with Christ; forensically speaking he is dead, but he still vies for control of believers in the body. Paul's argument is that even as believers have died together with Christ to sin, they should count, reckon, and regard themselves in their bodies dead to sin. We have the responsibility of seeing that our dead-to-sin position before God brings about death to sin in our bodies.

Furthermore, we are to count, regard, and reckon ourselves to be "alive" (ζωντας) to God in Christ Jesus. Since the word translated alive is a present participle we may render the last part of this verse as follows: we are to count

and reckon ourselves to be *continuously living to God in Christ.* According to the literal meaning of this verse a dual responsibility rests upon us: (1) to reckon that we have died to sin, consequently there is no room for its manifestation in our bodies, and (2) to reckon that we are to be continuously living to God in Christ.

12. ***"Therefore do not let sin reign in your mortal body, unto the end to obey its lusts,"***

The particle "therefore" (ουν) means that since we are to consider and count ourselves dead to sin and living to God, therefore and consequently we are not to let sin reign in our mortal body. The Greek verb translated "reign" (βασιλευετω) means that Paul is commanding believers not to allow sin *to rule, govern,* and *exercise authority* in the sphere of their "mortal" (θνητω), *dying,* and *liable to death* body. There are times when Paul seems to speak of the body as having inherent sin in itself (v. 6; Col. 2:11); however he generally looks at it as being a neutral vehicle through which either the Lord or sin may reign. The body is for the Lord (1 Cor. 6:13), it is the temple of the Holy Spirit (1 Cor. 6:19), and is not to be used as a sin-vehicle.

The result of allowing sin to reign in our bodies is "unto the end to obey its lust." The preposition "εις" used with the accusative case conveys the idea of *movement toward a given end*. As used with the infinitive in this verse it is preferably translated *unto the end*, i.e., the consequence of permitting sin to rule moves *unto the end of* obedience to its lusts. The Greek noun rendered "lusts" (επιθυμιαις) is derived from the preposition "επι" prefixed to the verb "θυμεω" and basically means to set the mind and heart on something, hence, *to earnestly desire, to long for,* and *to crave it.* When these desires, longings, and cravings are contrary to the Word of God, sinful, they are referred to as the lusts of sin.

13. ***"neither present your members instruments of unrighteousness to sin, but present yourselves to God, as alive from the dead, and your members instruments of righteousness to God."***

In the previous verse Paul told believers not to permit sin to govern in their body (σωματι). In this verse he becomes more specific, they are not to present their "members" (μελη), *limbs,* or *any part of their body* "instruments" (οπλα), *implements,* or *tools* of unrighteousness to sin. Here Paul is looking at the various parts of the human body as in themselves having the potential to be used in an "unrighteous" (αδικιας), unjust, and wrong manner to serve sin. Even as believers are not to let sin reign in their bodies, neither are they to "present" (παριστανετε), *place beside, make available,* nor *place their members at the disposal* of unrighteousness as instruments to serve sin.

The second part of this verse opens with the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα," which denotes a *strong contrast* between what Paul has said and is about to say. Instead of presenting their members to sin, they are to "present" (παραστησατε), *place beside,* and *make available* "themselves" (εαυτους), *all that they are, their total beings* and persons to God. They are to do this "as" (ωσει), as if, and *as though* they were "alive" (ζωντας) and *living* out from the

dead. Their members, "instruments" (οπλα), tools, and implements of righteousness, are to be made *available to God, placed at His disposal.* Summarizing, this verse certainly implies that believers, those who have been made alive in Christ, who are indwelt by the Holy Spirit, have it within their power *to determine their degree of spirituality.*

14. ***"For sin shall not dominate you, for you are not under Law but under grace."***

The thought in this verse possibly reverts back to the question Paul raised in verse one, namely, "Shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound?" Instead of grace encouraging sin, it frees believers from the mastery of sin. The Greek verb translated "dominate" (κυριευσει) means that sin shall not *lord it over, hold sway over,* nor *be master of believers* (Phil. 4:13; 2 Tim. 1:7-8).

The statement, "for you are not under law but under grace," implies that the Law was incapable to protect its adherents against being dominated by sin (8:3). It lacked the dynamic to make men righteous and to impart to them Divine life (Gal. 3:21). On the other hand, this declaration affirms that under grace believers have the necessary dynamic to enable them to ward off domination by sin. This dynamic is resident in the indwelling Holy Spirit who enables believers to put to death the practices of the Body (8:13). The epitome of the Grace of God centers in the *substitutionary death of Jesus Christ*, the fact that *we have died to sin with Him, and have been raised with him* to live unto God (vv. 4, 10-11).

15. ***"What then? Shall we sin because we are not under law but under grace? Let it never be."***

According to the United Bible Societies Greek text the verb translated "shall we sin" (αμαρτησομεν) is in the subjunctive mood (αμαρτησωμεν) and is literally translated *should we sin.* We must keep in mind that Paul's opponents were severely criticizing and maligning him, distorting his message of grace, and claiming that it gave license to sin. Recognizing that his readers were probably aware of what his Judaizing enemies were saying, Paul says, "What then" (τι ουν) or it may be translated *what therefore*? Combating their ignorant maligning of grace, he asks the question, "Should we sin because we are not under law but under grace?" His emphatic answer is, "Let it never be" (μη γενοιτο) or *may it not be*.

In dealing with this verse we need to get Paul's perspective of the Mosaic Law. Its Divine purpose was to *reveal sin, what it is, its true nature* (7:3, 11, 13; 1 Tim. 1:8-10). Also, it impressed upon men's conscience the fact that they are sinners, that their sin is exceedingly great, and that they are guilty before God (3:19; 7:7-11).

Did the Judaizers, who aggressively insisted that men were made righteous by keeping the Mosaic Law, have any basis for their position? When we consider what Paul says in the 10th chapter, "that the man who has done it [the Law] shall live by it," we can see why they took the position they did (10:5-6; Lev. 18:5). Contrary to Paul, the Judaizers looked at the *perfunctory keeping of the Law* as

that which made them righteous. Paul granted that the *exact keeping of the Law* would have made men righteous, but since no one even approached this meticulous standard in spirit and act, *the Law never made anyone righteous* (3:20; Gal. 3:10, 21-22). There was a time when young Saul of Tarsus, blinded by his religious conceit, arrogantly thought he was keeping the Law (Phil. 3:6), but later he refers to this as merely being *his own righteousness* (Phil. 3:9).

Through Divine revelation, God gave the Apostle Paul insight into the *real purpose of the Law*, and the role it played in His eternal program. The Law was to be in effect *during a given period of time*. It had a preparatory ministry, paving the way for the coming of the Messiah (Gal. 3:19, 25). Its purpose was consummated with the Cross of Christ (Gal. 3:19, 25). Summarizing, since the Law never made anyone righteous, its twofold real purpose was: (1) to reveal sin, and (2) to develop a sin-consciousness, a sense of guilt.

From Paul's point of view, the question he raises, "Should we sin because we are not under law but under grace" is irrelevant as far as the Law is concerned, for the Law was not given to prevent sin but to reveal it. As far as grace is concerned this question is very relevant, for under grace we are *dead to sin before God,* and we are to conform to this in our daily living. In view of the power of grace to change lives, and deliver them from slavery to sin, Paul's answer to the question he poses is the right one - may we never sin!

16. ***"Do you not know that to whom you present yourselves slaves unto obedience, you are slaves to whom you obey, whether of sin unto death or of obedience unto righteousness?"***

The crux of this verse is that you can tell who a person's master is by observing who the person obeys. The two masters mentioned are *sin* and *obedience*. The manner in which Paul introduces this verse suggests that some of those to whom he is writing must have been living inconsistently, for he says, "Do you not know that to whom you present yourselves slaves unto obedience, you are slaves to whom you obey." It appears that they should have known that their lifestyle was inconsistent with the Gospel of the Grace of God.

The Greek verb translated "present" (παριστανετε) is the same as used in verse 13, and it means to whom you make yourselves available as slaves unto the end to obey, you are slaves of the one to whom you render obedience. This means that a slave is a person who obeys or is in subjection to a given person or thing. One may be a *slave of sin*, the end of which is death, or he may be a *slave of obedience* (to the Word of God), the end of which is righteousness. Paul is frankly telling them, *that which you obey and serve is your master.*

17. ***"But thanks to God that you were slaves of sin, but you were obedient out of the heart unto the form of teaching to which you were delivered,"***

Paul reminds them that formerly they were slaves of sin, those who were obeying and in bondage to sin. But now he thanks God that He changed them - those who were once obedient to sin are now obedient to the teaching of the

Gospel. The Greek verb translated "obedient" (υπηκουσατε) is derived from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "ακουω" and literally means *to hear under,* hence, *to be under the influence of what is heard, submissive* and *obedient to it.* The Roman believers not only obeyed that which they heard, but Paul says, "you obeyed out of the heart" (υπηκουσατε εκ καρδιας). This statement emphasizes the *genuineness* of their obedience to the Gospel.

Now let us examine more closely that which they heard and believed. Paul says "you were obedient out of the heart unto the form of teaching" (τυπον διδαχης) may equally well be translated *pattern of teaching* or *type of teaching.* It obviously refers to the Gospel of God's Grace, the Truth of the Mystery, revealed unto the Apostle Paul (Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9; 1 Tim. 1:11). The Greek verb translated "you were delivered" (παρεδοθητε) is in the aorist tense and passive voice. This means that *God had sovereignly delivered them* to hear and obey this teaching. It speaks of God bringing them to the Word, not them coming to it.

18. ***"and having been freed from sin you were enslaved to righteousness;"***

In the preceding verse we observed that *God was the one* who had delivered the Roman believers over to hear and obey the Gospel. According to the passive voice, *God brought* those whom He had chosen in Christ unto the Gospel, they obeyed its message, and are designated as the elect (Eph. 1:4; Col. 3:12; 2 Tim. 2:10).

In this verse Paul refers to them as "having been freed from sin." The Greek verb translated "having been freed" (ελευθερωθεντες) is in the aorist tense and passive voice. This means that at a given time in the past *God Himself had freed, liberated,* and *released* them from sin. The Greek noun rendered "sin" (αμαρτιας) indicates that God had forensically liberated them from their past *missing the mark, erring,* and *offending* against His Divine standard (8:2; Gal. 5:2). In dealing with the issue of sin we must be careful to distinguish between our *righteous position in Christ and our daily living*. The latter, due to the weakness of our flesh (8:3), is always prone to lag behind our perfect position in Christ (Phil. 3:12, 15; 1 John 1:8-10).

Subsequent to having been freed from sin, Paul says, "you were enslaved to righteousness." The verb translated "you were enslaved" (εδουλωθητε) is also in the aorist tense and passive voice. The language implies that upon being freed from sin *God made them slaves, bondservants,* or *servants* to righteousness. The grammar used suggests that they were slaves whose object was to do righteousness, that which is right, just, and equitable.

According to the Greek language they were previously *slaves owned by sin,* but now they are slaves *to do righteousness*. In this new slave relationship they have a dual obligation: (1) *to know* what the Lord requires of them as members of the Body of Christ; (2) *to do* what the Lord requires of them by the empowering of the Holy Spirit (8:12-14; Gal. 5:16).

19. ***"I speak as a man because of the weakness of your flesh. For as you presented your members slaves to uncleanness and to lawlessness unto lawlessness, likewise now present your members slaves to righteousness unto sanctification."***

The statement, "I speak as a man" (ανθρωπινον λεγω) means that Paul was speaking in *human terms*, in language that was common to men, using human *illustrations* to teach how believers should be enslaved to righteousness. The reason he speaks in these human terms is *because of, on account of,* the "weakness" (ασθενειαν), *feebleness*, and *infirmity* of their flesh (8:3; Gal. 4:13). Apparently the spiritual condition of the Romans was such that Paul felt he could get through to them better by using the human illustration found in verses 16-20.

The adverbial phrase translated "for as" (ωσπερ) conveys the thought that *just as* or *like as* you "presented" (παρεστησατε), *placed beside*, and *made your members* as slaves available to uncleanness, likewise present your members slaves to righteousness. The other verses in this paragraph refer to *believers themselves* as slaves of either sin or righteousness, whereas this verse refers to *believers' members* as slaves of either uncleanness and lawlessness or of righteousness resulting in sanctification.

Prior to being freed from sin the Roman believers had presented their members to "uncleanness" (ακαθαρσια), *sexual impurity*, and *lewdness* (Gal. 5:19; Eph. 5:3). Also, they gave their members over to "lawlessness unto lawlessness" (ανομια εις την ανομιαν), i.e., *to violating the Law unto violating the Law, or to iniquity unto iniquity*. This Greek phrase apparently speaks of progressive, unending lawlessness.

Just as they had presented their members to sexual impurity and lawlessness "likewise" (ουτως), *in the same manner*, and *even so* they are to present and make available their members as slaves to "righteousness unto sanctification" (δικαιοσυνη εις αγιασμον). The Greek noun translated "sanctification" basically speaks of *that which is separated* from that which is common and unclean, hence, that which is holy. The complete thought is that they are to make their members available to *righteousness unto the end to be set apart in holiness.*

20. ***"For when you were slaves of sin, you were free to righteousness."***

Paul goes back to the time when they were slaves of sin, when they belonged to and were possessed by sin, and he says that at that time they were "free to righteousness." The Truth revealed for the members of the Body of Christ is never superimposed upon sinners. God never tells sinners how they are to live. They have no obligation to live righteously and holily. God's sole interest in sinners, those who are slaves of sin, *is their salvation* and not their lifestyle. After they are saved God's primary interest is in how the members of His Family live.

Both the nouns translated "slaves" (δουλοι) and "free" (ελευθεροι) are in the nominative case. The real issue in this verse is the difference between the responsibility of *slaves of sin to serve sin* versus serving righteousness and the

responsibility of *free-men to serve righteousness* versus serving sin. Slaves of sin, in view of their very nature, are obligated to render service to sin, but they have no obligation nor ability to render service to righteousness. Contrariwise, slaves of righteousness, in view of their new nature, are obligated to render service to righteousness, but they have no obligation to render service to sin. The fact that we have the righteousness of God through our in-Christ relationship is the *basis* for living righteously; in fact, as slaves of righteousness we are obligated to live to righteousness (v. 14; 1 Cor. 7:22).

21. ***"Therefore what fruit did you have then - on the basis of which you are now ashamed? For the end of those things is death."***

Looking back to the time when the Roman believers were slaves of sin, Paul asks the question, "what fruit did you have then?" Since Paul always uses the Greek noun for "fruit" (καρπον) with respect to that which is *good*, he is asking them about any good they may have done at that time. Actually, he answers his own question, they had produced *nothing good,* for "on the basis" (επι) of the things which they had done they are "now ashamed" (νυν επαισχυνεσθε). This verse leaves *no room* for the natural man in the flesh to produce anything that is good in the sight of God. Natural men, as their corrupt minds evaluate good and evil, will vociferously profess to do that which is good, but before God everything they do is as filthy rags (3:10-12; Eph. 2:1-3).

Speaking with reference to what the natural man does, the one designated a slave of sin, Paul says that "the end of those things is death." In view of the formula that the wages of sin is death, this means that everything the natural slave of sin does is *sin*, for it results in death. Due to the longsuffering of God men may think that they are getting away with their sin, but ultimately the "end" (τελος) is *death*.

22. ***"But now having been freed from sin and having been enslaved to God, you have your fruit unto sanctification, and the end eternal life."***

Having taken a look at their previous life, characterized by fruitlessness and death, Paul opens this verse with the adverbial phrase "νυνι δε" translated *but now* or *at the present time.* This is a favorite phrase which he uses to point out the contrast between the way it was, particularly under the Law, and the way it now is under Grace. In this verse the contrast is between *those who were enslaved to sin* and its consequences and *those who have been enslaved to God* with His rewards.

Now that the Roman believers have been freed from sin and enslaved to God they have two things, fruit and eternal life. The Greek word translated "having been freed" (ελευθερωθεντες) is an aorist passive participle and it means that the *first thing God did was to liberate, exonerate,* and *release* them from sin. The Greek participle translated "having been enslaved" is also in the aorist tense and passive voice and means that the second thing God did was to *enslave them, put them in servitude,* and *make them subservient to Himself* (cf. v. 18). These two

participles refer to sovereign acts which God performed on behalf of those whom He had chosen before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4).

As a result of God freeing them from sin and enslaving them to Himself, Paul says "you have your fruit unto sanctification, and the end eternal life." In a vital, living, subservient relationship with God believers have the Divine roots necessary for bringing forth good fruit (1:13; John 15:4-5). According to Galatians 5:22 fruit is produced in the lives of believers by God the Holy Spirit. This fruit is "unto" (εις), *unto the end of* "sanctification" (αγιασμον), *being set apart unto God,* and *being made holy* (1 Thess. 4:3-7).

The last thing mentioned that accrues to believers enslaved to God is *eternal life*. The statement that "the end (is) eternal life" must be interpreted to mean that the "end" (τελος), *the result, that which issues from* the subservient relationship to God is eternal life. As a free gift, eternal life is the possession of those who simultaneously believe and are enslaved to God (1 Tim. 1:16). It is based upon God's promise which He made before times eternal (Titus 1:2-3), and is extended to those identified with God the Son (1 John 5:11-12).

23. ***"For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."***

This verse is a brief summary of verses 20-22. The subject is death. It may also be translated, *death is the wages of sin.* Since the Adamic fall it can be affirmed that where there is sin there is death and where there is death there is sin. Paul refers to this as *the law of sin and of death* (8:2). This law speaks of a vicious dilemma from which man cannot extricate himself. He is totally dependent upon the Lord to *provide* his salvation and the *means* by which he can acquire it (1 Cor. 1:30; Eph. 2:8).

Now let us examine the fact that "the free gift of God is eternal life." The Greek phrase rendered "the free gift" (χαρισμα) depicts that which God has *freely graced, bestowed,* and *granted* to sinners. This is a gift "of God" (θεου) which belongs to God, which He has granted to those chosen in Christ (John 10:28). Jesus makes a statement in John 6:57 which throws light on the origin and transmission of this eternal life which belongs to God. He says to the Jews, "even as the living Father sent me, I also live because of the Father, and the one eating me shall also live because of me." God's free gift of eternal life *involves the sharing of His own life* with believers whom He has sovereignly brought into a relationship with Himself (Eph. 4:18; Col. 3:3-4).

It is important to observe that the life of God is transmitted *in Christ* to those endued with Divine faith. Paul says that God's free gift is eternal life "in Christ Jesus our Lord." This phrase may be translated either *in Christ Jesus* (locative case) or *by Christ Jesus* (instrumental case). It is our understanding that God the Father gave the Son life in Himself and the prerogative to give this life to those drawn to Him (John 1:4; 6:44, 57). This verse makes it very clear that God the Father has made His Son the *exclusive distributor* of eternal life (John 14:6). The person who is in Christ has life, but the person who is outside of Him is void of life (1 John 5:11-12).

Chapter 7

1. ***"Or are you ignorant, brethren, for I speak to those knowing the Law, that the Law has jurisdiction over a man as long a time as he lives?"***

In the preceding chapter there are two indirect references to the Law (vv. 14-15) - the fact that we are not under the Law but under Grace (vv. 14-15). In this chapter Paul uses the Greek word for Law some 20 times. This suggests that what he has to say in this controversial 7th chapter has a significant bearing on the Mosaic Law. It is very important, as we endeavor to grasp the literal-intended meaning of what is said, to be *correctly identified with the vantage point* from which Paul is speaking. In other words, we need to look at what he says from the *same point of view* that he says it, i.e., we must have the *same perspective*. We must not only *stand with him*, but we must also look at the same thing with him.

Having cautioned against rashly approaching this chapter, we need to recognize that getting the right perspective begins with accurate exegesis, leading out the correct meaning of each verse. In this first verse Paul raises the question: "Or are you ignorant, brethren, for I speak to those knowing the law?" This statement implies that Paul is specifically speaking to the Roman believers who have had a Mosaic Law background, particularly to Jews. The Greek participle translated "knowing" (γινωσκουσιν) is in the present tense and points toward those who continue to have an *experiential knowledge* of the Law. Furthermore, the fact that he calls them "brethren" (αδελφοι) indicates that he is addressing a segment of believers with Jewish background.

The main point of Paul's question is, "Are you ignorant . . . that the law has jurisdiction over a man as long a time as he may live?" The Law was given to control the lives of men living upon the earth. When a man ceased to live, i.e., died, the Law had no further control over him, he was *nonexistent* as far as it was concerned. This is a very important principle which Paul uses to explain how believers, out of a Lawkeeping background, are freed from the Law *when they died with Christ* (v. 4, 6; Col. 2:12-14).

Summarizing, according, to chapter 6 the fact that believers have died with Christ is the basis for living separated-from-sin lives. According to this chapter the identification of believers with the death of Christ is the basis for living separated-from-Law lives. Believers are 100% separated from the Mosaic Law. They are totally under grace (6:14; Gal. 3:13, 24-25).

2. ***"For the married woman has been bound by the Law to the husband while he is living; but if the husband might die, she is absolved from the Law of the husband."***

The Greek adjective translated "married" (υπανδρος) is derived from the preposition "υπο" and the noun "ανηρ" and it literally means the *under-husband* woman. This statement does not infer that the woman is inferior to the husband,

but merely that she occupies a *subordinate position,* a lower rank with respect to authority. The husband is head of the wife (1 Cor. 11:3).

The statement that the wife "has been bound by the law" (δεδεται νομω) has its verb in the perfect tense and passive voice. This means that at a given point in time she was *bound, tied, fastened,* and *confined* to her husband and this binding *continued in full effect*. Paul is talking about the marital contract of the Mosaic Law which controlled the relationship between a husband and his wife. All those who lived under the Law, both Jews and proselytes, were governed by this contract for some 1400 years. Members of the Body of Christ are not under the Law, hence, are not under this same contract, but operate under a much higher spiritual contract typified by Christ's relationship with His Church (Eph. 5:22-33).

According to this verse the wife was bound to her husband as long as "he is living" (τω ζωντι). This is a present participle and conveys the thought that she is bound *for the duration or span of his physical life, i.e., while he is a living man*. Note, the Mosaic Law contract was not terminated by the physical or mental state of the husband, such as virility or sanity, but *only by his death*.

Now Paul deals with the wife's status if her husband "might die" (αποθανη), *expire*, or *be deceased*. In this case, he says that according to the Law "she is absolved from the law of the husband." The Greek verb translated "absolved" comes from combining the preposition "κατα" and the verb "αργεω"; as used in this verse it means that she is *freed, severed,* and *loosed* from the law of the husband. In other words, as this verb is commonly used, it means that under such circumstances the law of the husband is *nullified, abrogated,* and *abolished* (v. 6; 2 Cor. 3:12-14; Eph. 2:15). The implication is that if the husband might die, he is nonexistent as far as the Law is concerned, and the widow he leaves behind is just as free as a woman who had never been married (1 Cor. 7:39).

3. ***"Then therefore if while the husband is living she be [joined] to another man, she will be warned that she is an adulteress; but if the husband might die she is free from the Law, so that she is not an adulteress having been [married] to another man."***

In view of what Paul has said in the two preceding verses, and as a *consequence of it*, he says, "then therefore" (αρα ουν), *consequently, thereupon* "if while the husband is living she be [joined] to another man, she will be warned that she is an adulteress." Paul again emphasizes that as long as a woman's husband is living she is bound to him, she must be monogamous, she cannot simultaneously be the wife of two men. Keep clearly in mind, he is speaking of the stipulations of the Mosaic Law *as they apply to a wife*, for this is what is essential for the point he is about to make.

Now if the woman may "be" (γενηται) joined to another man while her husband is still living, she is warned that she is an adulteress. The Greek verb translated "be (joined]" basically means *be, become,* or *assume* a given role. This may convey the thought of her being *married* to another man or of

committing adultery with another man. Regardless of which interpretation we may prefer, she was "warned" (χρηματισει), *instructed*, and *informed* that any such relationship with another man made her an adulteress.

On the other hand, "if the husband might die she is free from the Law." The marital contract was valid and controlled the wife's relationship to her husband *only during his physical life span*. This contract was necessarily between two persons, and if one of them might die, such as the husband in the illustration before us, it *invalidates the contract*. This left the woman totally "free" (ελευθερα), libe*r*ated, and *released* for she had no one to fulfill the contract obligations to. She again became as free as she was prior to her marital contract.

Paul looks at her as a free woman, as "having been (married)," since her husband died. The aorist participle translated "having been" (γενομενην) is obviously speaking of the woman as *having been married* even though the Greek verb for *married* is not in the context. The reason for this omission is probably due to Paul's application of this illustration to Christ in the next verse. He wanted to use the general verb "γινομαι" the meaning of which would flex with the context. Even though she is now married she is *not an adulteress* because her former husband has died and left her free to marry another man (1 Cor. 7:39).

4. ***"So that, my brethren, you also have been put to death to the Law through the body of Christ, unto the end that you might be joined to another, to the one who has been raised from the dead, that we might bear fruit to God."***

The key emphasis of the preceding verses is that the *death* of the husband *frees* the wife to marry another man. Paul moves from the above illustration to this verse with the adverb translated "so that" (ωστε), *even as,* or *like as* the above; they have been put to death to the Law that they might be joined to Christ. The Greek phrase translated "my brethren" (αδελφοι μου) perhaps signifies that he is particularly addressing believers with Jewish backgrounds (v. 1; 9:3; 2 Cor. 2:13).

The statement "you also have been put to death to the law through the body of Christ" also suggests that he is veering in on those who were once under the Law. The Gentiles were not under the Law unless they were proselytes. The Greek verb translated "you have been put to death" (εθανατωθητε) is in the aorist tense and the passive voice. It means that at a given point of time in history, at the Cross, God, who had sovereignly chosen them in Christ (Eph. 1:4), put them to death with Christ (6:3-6; Col. 2:20; 3:3). Identification with the death of Christ *annulled the Law*, hence, put them to death to the Law (Eph. 2:14-16). Note, it is specifically stated that they were put to death to the Law *through* (δια) the agency of the body of Christ. Their identification with the crucified body of Christ nullified their previous relation to the Law, i.e., made them dead to it (6:6; Eph. 2:16; Col. 1:22).

Even as the above wife had to die to the Mosaic-Law marriage contract, through the death of her husband, before she could be married to another man;

likewise the Lawbackground Roman believers had to die to the Law before they could be joined to another. Paul's thesis is that they *could not be simultaneously joined* to the Law and to "the one who has been raised from the dead," namely, the Living Christ.

The reason God demands *unqualified death to the Law* and a *Divine union with Christ in this age of Grace* is "that we might bear fruit to God." Those who have died to sin with Christ, who have been made righteous in Him, and who have been raised spiritually with Him have the necessary basis to "bear fruit" (καρποφορησωμεν) and *bring forth fruit pleasing to God* (6:14; Gal. 5:22; Phil. 1:11).

5. ***"For when we were in the flesh, the passions of sins, that were through the Law, were working in our members to bear fruit unto death."***

In contrast to bearing fruit to God under Grace, Paul says that "when we were in the flesh the passions of sins . . . were working in our members to bear fruit unto death." In this verse Paul goes back to the time when he and other Law-keeping Jews and proselytes *were in the flesh* (ημεν εν τη σαρκι), i.e., continuing to exist in and for the flesh.

During the time when Paul and others were still under the Law, he says that "the passions of sins, that were through the Law, were working in our members." The Greek word translated "passions" (παθηματα) *speaks of the affections of the mind, strong emotional feelings,* and *intense cravings* of sins. The Greek noun rendered "sins" (αμαρτιων) is a plural genitive and literally means *the passions which belong to the sins*. Bringing these thoughts together and grasping the significance of the two plural nouns, Paul is affirming that the *many passions* which belong to the *many different sins* actively energized and worked in our members through the Law.

According to this verse those who were under the Law are designated as being in the flesh (Phil. 3:6). Instead of the Law delivering those under it from sin, Paul says that the passions of the many sins, *through the agency of the Law*, were "working in our members to bear fruit unto death." This might be interpreted to mean that the Law, as an agent, was actually making those under it worse. There is no question about it, the Law seemingly made men more self-righteous, haughty, and proud. As a result of it stimulating the passions of sins to energize in the members of those under it, it brought forth fruit unto death.

Whether, in an absolute sense, the Law made its adherents more or less moral is an open question. One thing it did was to *shift the nature of sins* committed, such as stimulating religious pride, sectarianism, etc. (2:17-24). The all-important thing that it did, according to the Truth revealed to Paul, was to impress upon men the *exceeding sinfulness of sin* (3:19-20; 5:20). In connection with it serving as a mirror, to reflect man's sin, Paul says that it acted as a pedagogue to lead the Jews to Christ (Gal. 3:24).

6. ***"But now we have been released from the Law, having died to that in which we were held down, so that we serve in newness of spirit and not in***

oldness of letter."

The Greek verb translated "released" (κατηργηθημεν) is a compound verb constituted of "κατα" and "αργεω." In the passive voice it basically means that Paul and associated company were *idled down from, severed from,* and *freed from* the Mosaic Law. Looking at what is said here from the standpoint of the Law, it was made *ineffectual, nullified*, and *cancelled out* - it had no further relation to them.

The little Greek adverb translated "now" (νυνι) plays a significant role in Paul's epistles. When he says, "but now we have been released from the law," he is drawing a *demarcating line between* the time when God governed His people Israel by the Law and the present time when God is governing His people via Christ and His Church by Grace. In this *now dispensation of Grace*, Paul and those formerly under the Law are *completely severed* from the Law, that they might jointly live with Christ and bear fruit to God (v. 4).

Now did Paul and his Law-comrades get released from the Mosaic Law? The answer is in his statement "having died to that in which we were held down." The Greek aorist participle translated "having died" (αποθανοντες) is in the nominative case, and as such indicates that Paul and company *died with Christ to the Law*. In other words, their identification with the death of Christ was the *prerequisite* to their being freed from the Law (v. 4). Paul refers to the Law as that in which "we were held down" (κατειχομεθα), *restrained*, and *kept* secure (Gal. 3:22-24). It served as a *standard* for Israel's conduct, which, when violated, developed a *consciousness of sin* (5:20).

According to this verse the object of being freed from the Law is "that we [might] serve in newness of spirit and not in oldness of letter." We have already observed that Paul refers to being under the Law as being *in the flesh*. In this verse he refers to it as "oldness of letter" (παλαιοτητι γραμματος) or *obsoleteness* and *antiquatedness of letter.* These are not complimentary descriptions of the Law, but, when looked at from the vantage point of this present age of Grace, indeed the Law is antiquated and obsolete! It has fulfilled the purpose for which it was given - preparing a sin-consciousness in the elect unto faith in Christ (9:11-12).

In contrast to when he was under the Law, serving in oldness of letter, Paul is now free to serve in the *newness* and *freshness of the Spirit.* In Second Corinthians 3:3-8, he gives a more complete description of the superiority of the ministry of the Spirit in this present age of Grace. Whereas the Law operates according to the letter, Grace operates according to the Spirit of the Living God.

7. ***"What shall we say then? Is the Law sin? Let it never be; but I had not known sin except through the Law, for I had not known coveting except the Law said, You shall not covet."***

In view of what Paul has said about the Law, and that it has no relevance for members of the Body of Christ, he says, "What shall we say then?" or "What therefore shall we say?" He raises the question: "Is the law sin?" In other words,

is the Law in itself and in its essence sin? His emphatic answer is, "Let it never be" (μη γενοιτο), "May it never be."

Having refuted the idea that the Law is sin, Paul proceeds to point out that it has been a *revealer of sin*. He says, "I had not know sin except through the law." What he means is that apart from the Law, without its value standard of right and wrong, he could not determine what was and what wasn't sin before God. The Law specified what a person *shall do* and what he *shall not do.* To act contrary to these stipulations was sin. The Greek word translated "sin" (αμαρτια) in this verse basically means *to miss the mark, deviate,* and *trespass* from the standards set forth in the Law.

Paul illustrates how the Law revealed sin; he says, "for I had not known coveting except the law said, You shall not covet." The Greek word translated "coveting" (επιθυμιαν) basically means to have an *earnest desire, craving,* and *longing for something*. When it is a strong desire for that which is evil, it is commonly translated *lust* or *lusting*.

Since Paul's example from Exodus 20:17 is commonly translated *covet* from the Hebrew, and the Greek translation from the Septuagint is "επιθυμησεις." We have preferred to translate it covet, giving the Greek translation *lust* a close second place.

8. ***"But sin having taken occasion through the commandment produced in me every kind of coveting; for apart from the law sin is dead."***

Paul sets forth the key to this paragraph in verse 7, where he says, "I had not known sin except through the law." The main thesis of this context is that *sin is disobedience to God, and that the Law revealed the nature of this disobedience* (the thoughts and acts included in it); therefore the Law gave those under it *a knowledge of sin.*

Now let us examine the statement that "sin having taken occasion through the commandment produced in me . . . coveting." The Greek word translated "occasion" (αφορμην) conveys the idea that sin had *a starting place, α base of operations,* and *an opportunity* to manifest and express itself through the Law. The Greek word rendered "having taken" (λαβουσα) is an aorist participle. It means that the initial thing the Law did was to serve as a starting place, a base of operations, and a reference point for *determining what is sin*. As implied by the aorist participle, the Law revealed sin as sin *prior* to sin producing every kind of coveting.

When the Law made it obvious that certain thoughts and acts were sin, the result was that sin "produced" (κατειργασατο), *worked down, effected,* and wrought in Paul "every kind of coveting" (πασαν επιθυμιαν). Since this phrase is in the singular it means that sin *worked* and *energized* every conceivable act of *coveting, lusting,* and *craving for evil* in Paul. As the Law acted as a mirror, reflecting back to him his true nature, he saw himself as exceedingly covetous, lustful, and greedy.

Lastly, let us consider the statement, "for apart from the law sin is dead." The Greek noun translated "sin" (αμαρτια) basically means *to miss the mark,* hence*, to be in error,* or *involved in wrongdoing.* Since the basic meaning of this word for sin is to miss the mark, the implication is that there is α mark to be hit, and in this verse that mark was the Law, the *Divine Standard* for those who were under the Law. Paul declares that sin is "dead" (νεκρα), *not counted, not reckoned,* and *not imputed* (5:13) apart from the Divine standard embodied in the Law.

9. ***"And I was living apart from the law once; but the commandment having come sin revived, and I died;"***

The word translated "living" is an imperfect verb. Paul is literally saying that "once" (ποτε), *at one time,* or *formerly* I was living apart from the Law. The grammar used here does not point out the specific time in the past when Paul *was living* apart from the Law, but it does indicate that there was a time in his former life *when his living was not controlled by the Law.* The Greek adverb rendered "apart" (χωρις) means that he was once living *without, void of,* and *separated from* the Law.

Since by both birth and training Paul was a Jew (Acts 22:3; Phil. 3:5), when could he possibly have lived apart from the Law? If we take the language used here literally, which we prefer to do when feasible, the most viable interpretation is that he is *referring to his childhood* when he was unaware of the real purpose of the Law (1 Cor. 13:11). If we look at this statement as being hypothetical, that which illustrates a direct correlation between knowing the Law and a consciousness of sin, there would be no need of a historical point of reference to his past life.

Regardless of when Paul might have been living apart from the Law, he says that "the commandment having come sin revived." The Greek noun translated "commandment" (εντολης) means a *charge, injunction,* or *precept.* The Mosaic Law is constituted of many commandments and injunctions. Generally speaking, the word for Law (νομος) would be considered more comprehensive than the word for commandment (εντολη), but in this context they appear to be used interchangeably.

At one time Paul was living, then the commandment having come sin "revived" (ανεζησεν), *lived again,* and *regained vitality*. Our preferred interpretation of this is that the phrase "the commandment having come" (ελθουσης δε της εντολης) refers to the time when he became aware of the demands of the Law. As a youth, unaware of sin and its consequence, death, he thought he was living and alive. On the other hand, the phrase translated "sin revived" (η αμαρτια) refers to the point in time when he became aware and cognizant of what the Law designated as sin.

Summarizing, we may not be able to dogmatically assert whether this verse is to be interpreted literally or hypothetically; however, what it actually teaches is clear. Apart from the Law there is no knowledge of sin, there is no recognition of death which results from sin, and one erroneously thinks he is living before God

(5:13).

This verse opens with the statement that Paul was once *living* apart from the Law and it closes with the statement that under the Law he had *died*. The reason he was living apart from the Law was because the Law *had not revealed his sin*, and the reason he had died under the Law was because the Law had revealed his sin. Unaware of his sin he conceived himself as living; whereas aware of his sin he considered himself spiritually dead (6:23).

10. ***"and the commandment which was unto life, this was found to be unto death;"***

As we continue exegeting this 7th chapter we need to observe that Paul uses the word "law" (νομος) 23 times and the word for "commandment" (εντολη) 7 times. When referring to the Mosaic Law the word for law (νομος) is always used in the *singular, the Law*. When the Greek word translated "commandment" (εντολη) is used in contexts in conjunction with the Mosaic Law, it is commonly used in the *plural*, i.e., *many commandments* make up the Law (13:8-9; 1 Cor. 7:19; Eph. 2:15; Heb. 9:19). In this chapter the word "commandment" (εντολη) is consistently used in the singular, apparently with reference to specific commandments, but *its overall meaning is synonymous with the word Law* (νομος). In view of this we feel free to use the translations of these words interchangeably in this chapter.

Paul's reference to "the commandment which was unto life" undoubtedly points back to that which God had commanded in Leviticus 18:5, namely, "you shall therefore keep my statutes, and my ordinances; which if a man do, he shall live by them: I am Jehovah" (10:5; Gal. 3:12). The command was to keep God's statutes and ordinances. The result - no man kept them, therefore, no one ever lived by them (Gal. 3:21-22).

Paul declares that instead of this commandment giving life it resulted in death. His exact statement is that "this was found to be unto death." The Greek verb translated "was found" (ευρεθη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice and implies that in process of time it was *found, discovered,* and *recognized* that this commandment was not being kept, that God's statutes and ordinances were being broken, and that instead of there being evidence of life there was *evidence of sin everywhere*. Since the wage of sin is death this means that the ultimate result of the broken commandment was death. Summarizing, the commandment promised life to the one keeping it, but since no one kept it the result was sin, and the consequence of sin was death.

11. ***"for sin having taken occasion through the commandment, deceived me and through it killed me."***

With the exception of a slight deviation in the Greek word-order in the forepart of this and verse 8, the thought is identical. Sin took occasion through the commandment: (1) according to verse 8 it produced every kind of *coveting*, and (2) according to this verse it *deceived* and, through the commandment, killed. In both of these verses the commandment acted as the *starting point, the Divine*

point of reference, and *the measuring rod* by which the sins of coveting and deceiving were determined.

The Greek word translated "deceived" (εξηπατησεν) is derived from the preposition "εκ" prefixed to the verb "παταω" and means that the sin which the commandment made obvious *thoroughly deceived, deluded,* and *misled* Paul. As he writes this letter to the Roman believers, and reflects on the time when he was under the Mosaic Law, he says that at that time he was thoroughly deceived and deluded. As a spiritually proud young Jew he erroneously thought he had his own righteousness which is out of the Law (Phil. 3:9). He was thoroughly beguiled with reference to the Law, for instead of it making him righteous and giving him life, it revealed the exceeding greatness of his sin (13).

Paul also adds that through the sin which the commandment brought to the surface he was "killed" (απεκτεινεν), *put to death, and suffered spiritual demise.* As one who had considered himself alive apart from the Law (v. 9), and who had been utterly deceived under the Law into thinking it was giving him life, Paul now looks back and sees the sin it revealed as the very thing which *killed him spiritually*. Instead of giving him life, it confirmed that he was a sinner, which resulted in his spiritual death. Of course, Paul did not recognize his spiritual plight under the Law until after he had been delivered from the Law by the Grace of God manifested in Christ (Eph. 2:4-9; 2 Tim. 1:9-10).

12. ***"So that the Law is indeed holy, and the commandment is holy and right and good."***

As Paul approached this paragraph he emphatically said that the Law is not sin (v. 7). His main burden in the paragraph is to point out that the commandments contained in the Law *reveal sin* such as coveting (lusting) and deceiving which results in spiritual death. There is nothing wrong with the Law in itself, but it does reveal *what is wrong with those under it,* that they are *sinners who are dead* as a result of their sin (6:23).

Having made it clear that the problem is not with the Law, but with those under the Law (8:3), Paul says, "so that the law is indeed holy, and the commandment is holy and right and good." The Greek particle "μεν" translated indeed emphasizes the fact that the Law is "holy" (αγιος), *set apart*, and *sacred*.

Furthermore, Paul also affirms that the commandment is "holy" (αγια), *set apart and sacred.* In describing the commandment he adds two adjectives: (1) it is "right" (δικαια), *just*, and *fair*; and (2) it is "good" (αγαθη), *virtuous*, and *beneficent*. In as much as the Law was given by God we naturally expect that it was holy, *right*, and *good* (Acts 7:38, 53; Gal. 3:19-20).

Paul's lofty description of the Mosaic Law is qualified, i.e., "if anyone uses it lawfully" (1 Tim. 1:8). God gave the Law for the governing of His people Israel over some 1400 years, to serve as a pedagogue to lead them unto Christ (Gal. 3:24; cf. 3:19). During this time it was God's holy, right, and good vehicle *to stimulate α consciousness of sin* that they might recognize their need of α Saviour. To apply the Law to the present age of Grace is to use it unlawfully, and

under such circumstances it is designated as the "commandments and teachings of men" (Col. 2:22). To drag the Mosaic Law into this present age of Grace is *very serious disobedience to the Truth* deposited with the Church (6:14-15; 11:5-6; Eph. 1:7; 2:4-9; Titus 3:5).

13. ***"Therefore did that which is good become death to me? Let it never be; but sin that it might be manifest to be sin, through that which is good it produced death to me; that sin through the commandment might be exceedingly sinful."***

The Greek particle translated "therefore" (ουν) indicates that as α *consequence* of what Paul said in the preceding verse, *therefore, then,* and *consequently* "did that which is good become death to me?" Of course, the Greek phrase rendered "that which is good" (το αγαθον) refers to the commandments of the Law. In the light of what Paul said previously, "that he had known no sin except through the Law" (v. 7) and that the Law/commandments are good (v. 12), does this mean that the Law is intrinsically tied to sin and death? Does it mean that the Law in its very essence is sin (v. 7)? Paul's answer is "Let it never be" (μη γενοιτο), *May it never be*, or if we emphasize the optative prayer mood, *God forbid* that the Law in itself is sin/death.

Having denied that the Law had anything to do with producing death, Paul uses the strong adversative (αλλα) to emphasize *what it did do,* its real purpose - "but sin that it might be manifest to be sin through that which is good it produced death to me." We recognize that it is one thing for sin to be in the world, which it was from Adam on (5:12-13), and another thing *to know what it is.* Instead of the Law being sin and death, its purpose was in order that sin might be "manifested" (φανη), *caused to appear,* and *made visible*. This verb is in the aorist tense and passive voice which means that the *Law itself* was to act upon sin, at a *time in the past when the Law was still in effect*, to make sin obvious as sin. Keep in mind that Paul is speaking here about how the Law related to him, a Jew, in his early life. The Law is not serving this purpose today in relation to God's people who are under Grace and disciplined by Grace (6:14-15, 18, 21; Eph. 2:8-10).

Paul says that through the agency of "that which is good," namely the Law, sin "produced death to me." The Law, as a good Divine standard, revealed the thoughts and acts which were sin. Negatively, it said you shall not think or do certain things. Positively, it said you shall have a certain mind-set and do certain things. Failure to refrain from engaging in the negatives and failure to do the positives *resulted in sin* (Deut. 27:26; Gal. 3:10). This sin in turn "produced" (κατεργαζομενη), *worked down, brought forth,* and *resulted in death.* Since when Paul wrote this he was alive under Grace the implication is that when he was under the Law it resulted in *spiritual death* for him.

Finally, in this verse which seems to be redundant, but purposely so for emphasis, Paul adds, "that sin through the commandment might be exceedingly sinful." Again we observe that it was "through" (δια) the agency of the commandment, with its negative and positive stipulations, that sin *became* (γενηται) "exceedingly" (καθ' υπερβολην), *extremely and utterly sinful*. The adverbial

phrase "καθ' υπερβολην" is preferably translated by an English adverb such as exceedingly or extremely (cf. same adverbial phrase in 2 Cor. 1:8 and in Gal. 1:13). The Greek verb translated "might be" (γενηται) is in the aorist tense which suggests that the Law revealed sin as exceedingly sinful *when it was in effect prior to the Cross* (Gal. 3:24-25).

14. ***"For we know that the Law is spiritual; but I am carnal, having been sold under sin."***

On the basis of Divine revelation, not experience, Paul affirms that "we know" (οιδαμεν) the Law is spiritual. This verb is in the same family as the Greek verb "οραω," translated see, and in its etymological development conveys the idea *mentally seeing, visualizing,* and *perceiving.* On the basis of what God had said about the Law, and its derivation, Paul had a clear mental picture of its nature, he knew that it was spiritual.

It may seem strange that Paul describes the Law as spiritual in view of what he says in Second Corinthians 3:3-8. This is the *only time* he uses this Greek word "πνευματικος" with reference to the Law. In this immediate context he is endeavoring to put the Law in as good a light as possible: it is holy, right, good, and spiritual. He does not want his readers to misconstrue what he has been saying about sin and death, and blame it on the Law, for all it has done is *reveal the presence of sin/death.* He is using the word "spiritual" (πνευματικος) here in contrast to the word "carnal" (σαρκινος; cf. 1 Cor. 15:44). The Law is spiritual in that it *was given by God* and *is directed to the minds of men* but its precepts and ordinances relate to an earthly people in contrast to Grace which relates to a heavenly people (Exodus 20:12; Phil. 3:20; Col. 3:1-4).

As Paul affirms that the problem of sin and death is not produced by the Law, he points to the guilty culprit, saying, "I am carnal, having been sold under sin." According to the Greek word translated "carnal" (σαρκινος) Paul is saying he is of *flesh, fleshly,* hence*, sensual*. In Galatians 5:18-21 we have a sordid picture of the works of the flesh, that which the lusts of the flesh produce (1 Cor. 3:1-3; Eph. 2:3). It is important to note that Paul uses the *present tense* of the verb "ειμι," i.e., he says *I am carnal, at the present time I am carnal*. He is not talking about what he was when he was under the Law, but *what he currently is under Grace.*

As one who is carnal, Paul describes himself as "having been sold under sin." The Greek participle translated "having been sold" (πεπραμενος) is in the perfect tense and passive voice and means that through the sin of another, namely, Adam, he had been *sold under sin, sold to be a slave of sin,* hence*, enslaved under sin* (5:12-14, 19). The language Paul uses here depicts him as *still having the Adamic nature*, a propensity to sin (7:24-25; 8:13), as still having to struggle against the old man (Eph. 4:22), and as still being *a sinner by nature* (Eph. 2:3; 1 John 1:8, 10).

15. ***"For that which I work I know not; for not what I will, this I practice, but what I hate, this I do."***

In translating this verse we have retained the Greek word order, adding two commas for thought clarity. The conjunction "γαρ" translated *for* indicates that what Paul is saying in this and the following verses *proves* that he is carnal and enslaved to sin in the flesh sphere of his being. Regardless of one's spiritual status, all of Paul's epistles teach that *the flesh is bad news* (v. 18; 1 Cor. 15:50; Gal. 5:19; Eph. 2:3; Phil. 3:3; Col. 2:13).

Now let us examine the meaning of the statement "for that which I work I know not." The verb translated "I work" (κατεργαζομαι) is derived from the preposition "κατα" prefixed to the verb "εργαζομαι" and literally means *to work down, produce, effect,* and *do.* Since it is in the present tense Paul is saying that I do not know what *I am working, producing,* and *doing*, i.e., as a continuous lifestyle.

What does Paul mean by the phrase "I know not"? The verb rendered "I know" (γινωσκω) is also in the present tense and means that Paul was not able to *perceive, ascertain,* or *understand* why he was doing what he was doing. At this point in his dialogue he is a conundrum to himself, he hasn't fully grasped the reason for the inconsistency between his thinking and living, but later on in this context he does unravel it (vv. 21, 23).

Paul now goes on to explain that there are *two opposite forces* at work in his being. he says that "not what I will, this I practice, but what I hate, this I do." The verb translated "I will" (θελω) is in the present tense and means that he does not practice that which he *chooses, prefers,* and *wants to* practice. The implication is that he has the ability to will and choose that which is good, but there is a breakdown between this and transferring it into "practice" (πρασσω), *doing,* and *actual performance.*

Frustrated with his inability to convert what he willed and chose into practice, Paul emphatically says, "but (αλλ') what I hate, this I do." In actual life he finds himself doing that which is diametrically opposed to the good he determined to do, in fact, he says that which "I hate" (μισω), *detest,* and *abhor* I do. The verbs translated *hate* and *do* are both in the present tense, which means that Paul was *continuously* and *persistently* doing that which he continually hated.

16. ***"But if that which I do not will, this I do, I agree with the law that it is good."***

Recognizing that some might misinterpret what he was saying about the Mosaic Law, back in verse 12 Paul began to *defend* it as being *holy, just,* and *good*. In verse 13 he added that it is *spiritual*. As a result of analyzing his own person, prodding the reason for his ability to will that which is good and his inability to transfer it into practice, he interprets this as further evidence that *the Law is good*.

Now does the statement, "but if that which I do not will, this I do," confirm the Law as being good? Previously we observed that *what the Law said* and *what Paul did* conflicted, were opposites. This refers to the time when Paul was under the Law and existing *in the flesh.* The commandments which constituted the Law

were holy, just, good, and spiritual. On the other hand, as a sinner in the flesh, dominated by the lusts of the flesh, there was a *sharp contrast* between what Paul did and what the Law said he should do (vv. 7-11).

As we move to verse 15 the use of the present tense in the Greek makes it very clear that *Paul is referring to himself under Grace.* Even as under the Law he was existing in the flesh; likewise under Grace he is also *existing in the flesh*. The common denominator that describes the condition of all men in all dispensations, since the fall of Adam and prior to the Millenium, is that they are *in the flesh* (εν τη σαρκι). Under the stipulations of Grace, which contain the principles of nine out of the ten commandments, Paul experienced the same conflict and diametric opposition as he did when he was under the Law. Experiencing the same inconsistency between his Grace-governed will and his living as under the Law, *Paul logically deducts that the Law is good.*

Paul's statement that he "agrees" with the Law that it is good, conveys the thought that he *says the same thing, gives his assent,* and *affirms* together with the affirmation of the Law that it is good. He gives an additional assent to its goodness.

17. ***"But now no longer I work it but the sin dwelling in me. "***

In verses 15 and 16 Paul pointed out the *inconsistency* between what he *wills* and what he actually *does*. He has the ability to will and choose to do that which is good, but when he ends up doing that which he hates instead, he disclaims personal involvement. If you, the reader, are prone to interpret this as a cop-out, we urge you to refrain from such a hasty judgment, for this is only *a part of the findings* resulting from Paul's self-analysis, it is not the resolution of his inner conflict.

In this verse Paul begins to distinguish between two forces which are simultaneously pulling in opposite directions in his person. Speaking with reference to doing that which he hates, he says, "but now no longer I work it." His reasoning is straightforward - he did not will, choose, and determine to do the evil he hates; therefore he did not do it. His real person is resident in his *inner man* (v. 22), *mind* (vv. 23, 25), and *spirit* (1:4; 8:16). He denies that his real person is the one promulgating sin is his life. The Greek verb translated "work it" (κατεργαζομαι) means that he isn't the one *producing, working out,* and *effecting* sin.

In strong contrast to what Paul has just said, that he himself is *not the source* of the sin in his life, he affirms that "the sin dwelling in me" is producing it. The strong adversative conjunction "αλλα" translated but, emphasizes that it is *not Paul but sin* which is producing evil. In other words, Paul is looking at "sin" (αμαρτια) as the *subject* producing the action in this verse. Mr. Sin is *distinct* from the real Paul, however, their place of dwelling is contiguous. The real Paul dwells *in his body* and Mr. Sin dwells *in his flesh* (v. 18). Keep in mind, what Paul says here describes his *then present status as a Christian,* and as such applies to all believers in this Church age (cf. 1 Cor. 11:1; Phil. 4:9; 1 Tim. 1:16).

18. ***"For I know that it does not dwell in me, that is in my flesh, good; for to will is present with me, but to work the good is not."***

Our translation conforms to the word order in the Greek. We prefer to follow the original word order where clarity is not sacrificed, for it helps the reader grasp the feeling in the Greek. Paul's statement "for I know that it does not dwell in me . . . good" implies that on the basis of Divine revelation he *knew* (οιδα), had been given insight, and *perceived* that he was destitute of good. The Greek verb translated "dwells" (οικει) indicates that no good *inhabits, lives,* or *makes its home* in him. Paul uses the Greek phrase translated "in me" (εν εμοι) three times in this context, and he defines it as meaning "in my flesh" ((vv. 17, 18, 20). This definition is very important for it enables us to positively identify where the sin resides and where the good does not reside (v. 18).

Having declared that nothing "good" (αγαθον) *beneficial, profitable,* and *virtuous* inhabits his flesh, Paul adds, "for to will is present with me." As we have already observed, the Greek infinitive rendered "to will" (θελει) means that he had the ability of *volition, to determine,* and *to choose.* The Greek verb rendered "is present" (παρακειται) is derived from the preposition "παρα" and the verb "κειμαι" and means volition *lies beside, is at hand,* or *is available* to be used for good. As one of God's elect, one chosen before the creation of the world, and as one made alive in Christ; Paul had the ability and responsibility to *volitionally live according to the Gospel of Grace* (2 Tim. 2:10; Eph. 1:4; 2:5, 10).

Even though Paul had been justified from sin and declared righteous in Christ, *his sin in the flesh status never changed*. Sin occupied his flesh prior to his awareness of the Law, while he was under the Law, and now under Grace. He again reiterates that he is in a position to choose that which is good, "but to work the good is not" possible due to sin in the flesh. In this context Paul looks at himself as a saved man, and as such he desires to do that which is good in God's sight, but *within himself* apart from the Holy Spirit he is unable to put his good desires into practice (8:7-8).

19. ***"For I do not do the good which I will, but the evil which I do not will, this I practice."***

Again in this verse we see Paul willing and determining to do good, but he fails to accomplish it. On the other hand, the evil which he wills and determines not to do, this he ends up practicing. Here we have a picture of Paul doing the opposite of what he wants to do. The implication is that he had an *absolute knowledge* of good and evil in the Word, but instead of practicing the good and shunning the evil, the sin in his flesh produced the opposite. Paul describes himself as being frustrated in a dilemma.

As we move through this context may I remind you again that Paul is not talking about how he *actually lived under Grace*. He is merely drawing aside the curtain and allowing us to listen to the *rational process* through which the Lord led him to an *understanding of himself*. He is dealing with fundamental anthropological principles, which must be thoroughly understood before we can

lay a sound basis for true spirituality. Paul is giving us believers insight into the fact that we have *two natures*: (1) through faith in Jesus Christ we have the Divine nature (2 Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15; 2 Peter 1:4), and (2) through Adam we are sinners in our nature, i.e., sin dwells in our flesh (vv. 17-18; Eph. 2:3). This 7th chapter points out the *Great Problem* which stands in the way of believers doing the will of God. The 8th chapter gives us the *solution* to this problem.

20. ***"But if what I do not will, this I do, no longer I work it but the sin dwelling in me."***

In verses 15-19 Paul has, from different angles, dealt with the conflict between what he wills and what he does. In this verse, on the basis of the foregoing evidence, he *draws a conclusion* regarding the presence of indwelling sin. He says that "if what I do not will, this I do" then it follows that I am not doing what I will. The premise Paul postulates is that *volition is the initial ingredient in doing*. It therefore follows that where there is no volition, no willing, there is no doing. According to this premise if Paul did something which he did not will to do it could not be attributed to him. He would not be responsible for doing it.

With respect to that which Paul did, which was contrary to his will, he says, "no longer I work it but the sin dwelling in me." Paul recognized two superhuman forces in the world: (1) *the Triune God* (2 Cor. 13:13), and (2) *Satan* (2 Cor. 4:4). On the one hand, God made him alive in Christ hereby enabling him to will to do that which is good. On the other hand, that which the real Paul did not will to do, but yet was done through his members, was produced by Satan via Sin in his flesh (the old nature).

21. ***"I find then the Law that while I am willing to do good, that evil is present with me."***

The Greek verb translated "find" (ευρισκω) means *to light upon, to come upon,* and *to discover.* The use of the present tense suggests that Paul was in the process of discovering, via human experience confirmed by Divine revelation, that what was happening in his life was so consistent that it could be stated as a law. He observed that every time he willingly determined to do good, the evil lurking in his flesh stymied its fulfillment.

Prior to this verse, with only one exception (3:27), Paul has consistently used the Greek noun translated "law" (νομον) with reference to the Mosaic Law. In this verse and following he uses this noun with its general meaning, i.e., as a *principle* or *rule* (vv. 22, 23, 25; 8:2, 4, 7). The law or principle Paul discovered was that *while* or *during the time he determined to do good* (θελοντι εμοι ποιειν το καλον) *he was plagued with the presence of that which was evil and bad* (κακον). According to the foregoing context this evil was resident, he says, "in me" (εν εμοι), i.e., "in my flesh" (εν τη σαρκι μου). We interpret this as meaning that when he wanted to do good he was thwarted by his sin nature (Eph. 2:3).

22. ***"For I delight with the Law of God according to the inner man,"***

This is the only time the Greek verb translated "delight with" (συνηδομαι) is

used in the New Testament. On the basis of its derivation from the Greek preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "ηδομαι," plus the manner in which it is used in the classical Greek, Paul is saying that *I rejoice together with* and *am pleased with* the law of God. In contrast to the Law of Moses (Acts 28:23), he is speaking here of "the law of God" (τω νομω του θεου), the principles and rules of God pertinent to the present dispensation of Grace (8:7). This law is not a takeoff from the Law of Moses, but is *distinct from it*, involving *a special revelation of Truth* given to the Church (1 Cor. 2:6-10; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:2-9).

Paul says that he delights together with this law, this Truth for the Body of Christ, "according to the inner man." This means that from the vantage point of the "inner man" (εσω ανθρωπον), *inside man,* and *internal man*, his mind and spirit concurred with the Gospel of God's grace (Acts 20:24). This inner man is the same as Paul's *real self,* the one able to will that which is good (vv. 18-19), and his new nature (2 Peter 1:4). Paul also identifies the inner man with his "mind" (voof) with which he serves the law of God (vv. 23, 25).

23. ***"but I see another Law in my members, warring against the Law of my mind, and leading me captive by the Law of sin being in my members."***

According to verse 21 Paul discovered the law – that when he wills to do good, evil is present to counteract it. According to verse 22 his inner man is delighted with the law of God, the Gospel of Grace. In this 23rd verse he refers to the same law as in verse 21, adding that the *sin in his members utterly defeats him.*

In contrast to the Law of God in verse 22, Paul sees "another law" (ετερον νομον) in his members. The Greek noun translated "members" (μελεσιν) refers to the various *parts of the body* through which it expresses itself such as the limbs, etc. In the latter part of the verse he describes this other law as "the law of sin" (τω νομω της αμαρτιας), i.e., *as the Law which belongs to sin.* Paul uses the designations of *sin in his members* and of *sin in his flesh* synonymously to depict his sin nature (Eph. 2:3) and his *old man* (Eph. 4:22). With respect to this law of sin, Paul says that it is "in my members." In as much as he uses the *present participle* to describe the relation of the law of sin to his members we have translated it "being in" (οντι εν) his members. The thought is that the law of sin *continued to exist in his members.*

Now let us look at what Paul calls "the law of my mind" (τω νομω του νοος μου). According to the context we see the law of the mind in action in verse 22. The *inner man* and the *mind* designate *Paul's real person* as one who has been saved by Grace. The fact that he rejoices together with the law of God, with the Gospel of Grace, is an expression of how the law of the mind works. As the name of this law implies, the redeemed mind delights to function in accordance with the law of God, the special revelation of *Truth given to the Church*. All of Paul's statements in the above context regarding *his ability to will that which is good* are evidence of the law of the mind in operation (vv. 18-19, 21).

Finally, let us examine Paul's statement, "I see another law in my members, warring against the law of my mind." The Greek word translated "warring against" (αντιστρατευομενον) is a compound, present participle derived from the preposition "αντι" prefixed to the verb "στρατευω." It literally means that the law of sin is *continuously waging war* against the law of Paul's mind. This indicates that the sin which indwells his flesh is continually attacking *the relation between his mind and the Word of God.* Satan, working through the sin nature of the flesh, focuses his attack on the juncture where *the minds of believers submit to what God has said*. To the extent that this juncture is weakened, disobedience will result as it did with Eve (Gen. 3:4).

24. ***"A wretched man I am; who will deliver me out of the body of this death?"***

In view of the fact that the Greek words for "wretched" (παλαιπωρος) and for "man" (ανθρωπος) are in the nominative case, *the subject case,* and the verb for "I am" (εγω) is in the first person singular, this phrase may also be translated "I am a wretched man." The Greek word rendered "wretched" (ταλαιπωρος) basically speaks of one who is *suffering hardship* or *enduring trouble*, hence, one who is *wretched, miserable,* and *pitiable.* As we reflect on Paul's dialogue in the foregoing context it is not surprising that he uses this word to describe his miserable defeat by sin in the flesh (v. 23).

Paul cries out, in the midst of his wretchedness, "who will deliver me out of the body of this death?" For the benefit of the Roman believers and us Paul has drawn aside the curtain in this chapter and shared with us some choice tidbits from his spiritual pilgrimage. Thus far we have been listening to a man who became exceedingly conscious of his sin. He sees it deeply rooted in his flesh, in the very nature of his physical being, engaging and defeating him on the moral battlefield. In the midst of continually being defeated he dramatically cries forth the question for the sake of his readers, "who will deliver me out of the body of this death?" For him personally this question had been answered many years before he wrote this epistle, but for all his readers they must still wait for the answer, not in the next verse, but in the following chapter (8:1-17).

25. ***"But thanks to God through Jesus Christ our Lord. Then therefore I myself with the mind serve the law of God, but with the flesh the Law of sin."***

If we incorporate the significance of the Greek particles "μεν" and "δε" the translation would be as follows: "But thanks to God through Jesus Christ our Lord. Then therefore I myself, on the one hand with the mind serve the law of God, but on the other hand, with the flesh the law of sin." The latter translation makes the *contrast more distinct* between with *the mind serving the Law of God* and *with the flesh serving the law of sin.*

Now let us examine the meaning of the statement, "but thanks to God through Jesus Christ our Lord." The Greek word translated "thanks" (χαρις) is used some 24 times in this epistle. In 22 contexts it clearly means *grace*, i.e., it is used with

reference to the *Grace of God.* The same phrase as used here is also used in 6:17, namely, "χαρις δε τω θεω" and may be translated *but grace to God, but gratitude to God,* or *but thanks to God.* The Majority Text has the compound Greek word "ευχαριστω" instead of "χαρις" in this verse. It basically means to have *good grace*, hence, *to be grateful and thankful to God*.

This statement appears to be *a short prayer* to God the Father "through" (δια) the agency of Jesus Christ. On the other hand, in this context, it could be interpreted to mean that Paul is *grateful to God for the potential victory over sin* which he is about to discuss in the next chapter. In the light of chapter 8, it would be inconsistent for Paul to thank God for what he says in the last sentence in this chapter. This sentence merely recapitulates the dilemma between his will and the sin in his flesh. It does not resolve nor offer a solution to his dilemma, but leaves him as a wretched and miserable man.

Finally, let us briefly look at this last sentence. Paul says, "Then therefore I myself with the mind serve the law of God, but with the flesh the law of sin." The Greek particles rendered *then* and *therefore* imply that what Paul is about to say is the consequence of what he has said in the previous context (vv. 15-24). The Greek phrase translated "I myself" (αυτος εγω), together with the present tense verb, suggests that his dialogue refers to a time when he himself was still frustrated and losing the war against sin in his members (v. 23).

Summarizing, why does Paul spend so much time on the issue of sin in this 7th chapter? The most feasible answer is because we believers *must know* the strangle hold sin has on us, that the sin-nature is in our flesh, and that we *in ourselves cannot conquer or subdue it.* When we know that the strength of our enemy is such that we cannot personally cope with it; then we will be ready to flee to God the Holy Spirit for help (Eph. 6:12).

This entire 7th chapter deals with three key issues. First, how was one who was under the Mosaic Law freed from it (vv. 1-6)? Second, the Law, which was good in itself, revealed how exceedingly sinful sin is (vv. 7-14a). Third, a saved person is able to will to do that which is good, but if void of the power of the Spirit, the sin in his flesh thwarts him from doing good, leaving him as one who is wretched, miserable, and pitiable (vv. 14b-24).

Chapter 8

1. ***"Then there is now no condemnation to those in Christ Jesus."***

This is a translation of the United Bible Societies Greek text. On the other hand the following is a translation of the Majority Text: ***"Then there is now no condemnation to those in Christ Jesus, who walk not according to the flesh but according to the Spirit."*** The first sentence in this verse is identical in both Greek texts. The fuller reading in the Majority Text is *primarily explanatory* and not additive.

Now let us examine the statement, "Then there is now no condemnation to those in Christ Jesus." Translating this as accurately as possible, Paul is saying, *now then there is not one (a single) condemnation* (ουδεν αρα νυν κατακριμα), *nothing to condemn, no sentence* for those in Christ Jesus. This no-condemnation status applies to a particular group of people, and is limited to them, namely, those in Christ Jesus.

The crux of this verse pivots on the meaning of the phrase "those in Christ Jesus" (τοις εν Χριστω Ιησου). Nothing more nor less than *to be in Christ* is needed for a no-condemnation standing before God. According to Paul our position in Christ is *totally dependent upon God's Grace* and not human works. Some of the characteristics of those in Christ are: they have *Divine life* (6:11, 23); they have been *sanctified* (1 Cor. 1:2); God is the *source* of their being in Christ (1 Cor. 1:30); they are *new creatures* (2 Cor. 5:17), *sons of God* (Gal. 3:26), and *saints* (Col. 1:2). As these citations indicate, our no-condemnation position in Christ *has been provided for us on the basis of Grace.*

We have suggested that the longer Majority Text reading crept in as an *explanation*. When it is viewed as *merely defining those in Christ*, who are not condemned, it does not appear to rob the shorter text of its main point. On the other hand, if the emphasis shifts to our *walk according to the Spirit* instead of on our *position in Christ*, then our nocondemnation would appear to result from our lifestyle rather than from our grace-provided position in Christ.

We do not accept this longer reading as being in Paul's original letter to the Romans for two reasons: (1) it is not in accord with the way he has been *gradually* preparing to reveal the Spirit as the answer to his dilemma, for it *precipitously jumps* to the conclusion; (2) it leaves too much room for this verse to be misconstrued as teaching that no condemnation depends upon good works rather than on our position in Christ. We recommend that you follow the short United Bible Societies Greek text.

2. ***"For the Law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus has freed me from the Law of sin and of death."***

Paul's big problem in chapter 7 was that the law of sin was engaged in battle with the law of his mind - continually making him a captive of sin (7:23). As he

continues in the same context, for there were no chapter divisions in the original, the prime requisite is to *subdue and defeat the law of sin*. He now begins to reveal the Divine strategy for doing this by introducing the superior "law of the Spirit" (ο νομος του πνευματος). The only thing sin respects is the *sheer superiority of God the Holy Spirit.* Mere knowledge, apart from the Spirit, cannot produce a God-pleasing lifestyle.

Paul speaks of the Spirit as being "the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus." He is very literally saying that the Spirit *belongs* to the life which is in Christ. The Spirit is inextricably tied to Divine life and this life is resident in the Person of Jesus Christ (John 6:57; 1 John 5:11-12). Paul's main point here is that the Spirit who imparts life in Christ is the Superior Being who "has freed me from the law of sin and death." As Paul comes to the final part of his dialogue he uses the aorist tense; as an accomplished fact he has been *liberated, released,* and *unfettered* (ηλευθερωσεν) from the law of sin which results in death (6:23; 7:10-11).

3. ***"For the impotency of the Law, in that it was weak through the flesh, God, having sent his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and concerning sin, condemned sin in the flesh,"***

The Greek phrase translated "the impotency of the law" (το αδυνατον του νομου) may also be rendered *the inability of the law the lack of power of the law,* or *the weakness of the Law.* As we have already observed Paul uses the Greek word for "law" (νομος), in different contexts, with reference to *many kinds of laws*. A law may be merely *a rule, regulation, stipulation,* or *standard*. If the word "νομος" is used in a comprehensive manner, as the Mosaic Law, it contains many rules, regulations, and individual commandments.

We must keep in mind that the noun "law" (νομος), as it is dependent upon human beings in the flesh for fulfillment, has *a common denominator* even though used differently. For example, what is said about the impotency of the law in this verse could be equally applied to the *Mosaic Law* or to the *law of the mind* (7:23, 25). In both cases these laws were impotent due to the weakness of the flesh, i.e., because sin indwells the flesh (7:17).

Why were the Mosaic Law and the law of the mind impotent? Was it on account of an inherent problem in these laws themselves? Paul's answer is definitely *no*; these laws are not intrinsically evil (7:7, 25), but *holy, just,* and *good* (7:12, 16, 21). The Mosaic Law was good for the accomplishment of God's purpose *during the time* for which it was given (Gal. 3:23-25). The law of the mind is used by Paul in this 7th chapter in conjunction with the Truth given to the Church; thus when used within *this Church age,* this dispensation of Grace, it is good. The problem is not in these laws but *in those they seek to govern*, in their totally depraved sinful nature (Eph. 2:3).

Paul pinpoints the reason the law is impotent, because it is "weak through the flesh." The Greek word for "weak" (ησθενει) is in the imperfect tense and means that in the past the law was powerless because it was *infirm, sick,* and *void of strength* through the flesh. In as much as the law depended upon the *agency of*

the flesh (δια της σαρκος) for its fulfillment, and this agent was weak, sick, and infirm, it follows that instead of preventing sin the law revealed sin (7:7, 13).

In view of the impotency of the law due to the weakness of the flesh, "God having sent his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh and concerning sin, condemned sin in the flesh." We have properly translated the aorist participle "πεμψας" as *having sent*, for it was God's first step in dealing with the issue of sin. Next, we note that He was God's "own" (εαυτου) Son in the "likeness" (ομοιωματι), *resemblance*, and *similitude* of sinful flesh, or more literally *flesh of sin* (σαρκος αμαρτιας), i.e., He resembled *flesh possessed and owned by sin.* Keep in mind that the reason God sent His Son in flesh that appeared to be identical to sinful flesh, *but that was apart from sin* (Heb. 2:17; 4:15), was "concerning sin" (περι αμαρτιας), *respecting sin,* or *for sin* (Luke 19:10; 1 John 2:2).

Having observed that God dispatched His Son into this sin-cursed world concerning and respecting the sin issue, we raise the question, "What did He do about it?" Paul's answer is that "he condemned sin in the flesh." The context, which deals with the likeness of the Son's incarnate flesh to that of sinful men, makes it clear that he is saying that *God condemned sin in the flesh of the Son.* His sovereign purpose involved the assumption of our sin, the result being that he was condemned unto death on the Cross (Acts 2:23; Rom. 5:6, 8; 1 Cor. 15:3; 2 Cor. 5:21). God settled the issue of sin once and for all time through His Son assuming its penalty and dying on Calvary (Heb. 9:26, 28). As those who have been chosen in Christ we have died with Him to sin (Eph. 1 4; Rom. 6:2-6).

4. ***"in order that the right acts of the Law might be fulfilled in us, those not walking according to the flesh but according to the Spirit."***

God had a given reason for condemning sin in the flesh of Jesus Christ on the Cross, "in order that the right acts of the law might be fulfilled in us." The Greek phrase translated "the right acts of the law" (δικαιωμα του νομος) may also be rendered *the just and equitable acts of the law.* It refers to the *just commands, stipulations,* and *exhortations* of the law. As used here, is Paul referring to the Mosaic Law or to the law of the mind? The Greek noun "δικαιωμα" translated *right acts* could refer to either one of these laws. Since the present tense indicates that he is talking about a law which pertains to the *present* walk of believers in this Church age, *this precludes the Mosaic Law,* for he has already made it crystal clear that the Mosaic Law has no place in this age of Grace.

Since many have and continue to drag the Mosaic Law into the present dispensation of Grace, the most logical thing we can do is allow Paul's epistles to give us God's Word on this subject (1 Cor. 2:7-10; Gal. 1:12; Eph. 3:3-4; Col. 1:25-27; 1 Thess. 2:13; 2 Tim. 3:16-17; 2 Peter 3:15). As the evidence makes it obvious, there is *no room for the Mosaic Law* in either ceremonial or moral form in God's Church program, for it functions strictly on the basis of Grace.

Believers are justified by faith *apart* from the Law (3:28). Believers are *not under* the Law but under Grace (6:14-15). Believers have been *put to death* to

the Law so as to be joined to Christ (7:4). Believers have been *freed from* the Law (7:6). The *end* or *consummation* of the Law is Christ (10:4). Men are *not justified* by the works of the Law (Gal. 2:16; 3:11). Those led by the Spirit are *not under* the Law (Gal. 5:18). Christ has *annulled* the Law (Eph. 2:15). Paul had thrown off the so-called righteousness out of the Law (Phil. 3:9). The Law has *no relevance* for those justified and righteous in Christ (1 Tim. 1:9).

Also in dealing with the law of the mind Paul identifies it as the *law of God* in verse 7. He makes this same identification in 7:22 and 25. As we have already observed the Mosaic Law is never referred to as the law of God in this epistle. In the light of the above evidence, on the one hand the law mentioned in this 4th verse cannot possibly be the Mosaic Law. On the other hand the contextual identification of this law with the law of God (v. 7) strongly suggests that it is *the law of the mind* (7:22, 25).

The thought here is that the right acts or stipulations of the law, *the Truths revealed for regulating the Church,* are to be "fulfilled in us, those not walking according to the flesh but according to the Spirit." Considering what Paul says in Second Corinthians 3:3-8, to have the Mosaic Law and the Spirit in this verse would be most *incongruous, incompatible bedfellows*. Summarizing, God having condemned our sin in the flesh of His Son on the Cross (Eph. 2:14) and having given to us the message of Grace for controlling the mind, we are *to walk according to the Spirit* and not complete the lusts of the flesh (Gal. 5:16).

5. ***"For those being according to the flesh think on the things of the flesh, but those according to the Spirit the things of the Spirit."***

In translating from the original Greek text we endeavor to *limit* our translation to what is actually said in the Greek. There are times, however, such as in this verse, when we feel that a more elaborate thought-translation may be beneficial in conveying the spirit of the original text. The thought that Paul is expressing in this verse is that those who have their being according to the flesh continually think on the things of the flesh, but those who have their being according to the Spirit continually think on the things of the Spirit.

In this verse Paul deals with the characteristics of two different groups: those according to the flesh and those according to the Spirit. Who are those according to the flesh? A key word which helps identify them is the Greek participle translated "being" (οντες). They are those who have *their being, existence,* and *subsistence* according to the flesh, i.e., *in keeping with and conforming to the flesh*. This participle implies that in their nature and essence they are solidly identified with the flesh. Furthermore, the fact that they continually "think" (φρονουσιν), *set their minds on,* and *cogitate* on the things which belong to the flesh categorizes them solely as *flesh beings* void of the Spirit (v. 9).

The present participle translated "being" (οντες) is not repeated but it is inferred that it applies to the last half of this verse. Paul says that those who have *their being, existence,* and *subsistence* "according to" (κατα), *in keeping with* and *conforming to* the Spirit will continually "think" (φρονουσιν), *set their minds on*, and *cogitate* on the things which belong to the Spirit. In contrast to the previous

group, who are dead in trespasses and sins (Eph. 2:1), those who have their being and existence in the Spirit have a single mindset fixed upon the things which relate to the Spirit. They are interested in being controlled by the Spirit (Eph. 5:18), sharing the Word of God with others and giving thanks (Eph. 5:20-21; Col. 3:16-17), and in having the Spirit produce His fruit in their lives (Gal. 5:22-23; Eph. 2:10).

6. ***"For the mind of the flesh is death, but the mind of the Spirit is life and peace,"***

The Greek word translated "mind" (φρονημα) is used in conjunction with both the flesh and the Spirit. The only times it is used in the New Testament are twice in this verse and in verses 7 and 27. It conveys the idea of *that which is thought, the frame of mind, mind-set,* or *that which is willed*. Since the Holy Spirit is a Divine Person it is natural that He should have thoughts and a mind-set which focus on life and peace. It is strange, however, to hear Paul talking about the flesh as animated and alive, capable of thinking and willing that which is evil. When we consider what he said in chapter 7, we really shouldn't be surprised, for sin dwells in the flesh and actively wages war against the law of the mind (vv. 17, 23). In fact, he describes this phenomenon as the *old man*, one who has an evil frame of mind (Eph. 4:22).

What does Paul mean by the statement that "the mind of the flesh is death"? Apparently he is saying that all that the mind of the flesh cogitates on, thinks, wills, and determines is *in the sphere of death*. It *confirms* that a person who has such a mind-set is dead in trespasses and sins (Eph. 2:1). This is the status of every descendant of Adam apart from Christ, he is living on spiritual death-row, and what his mind produces confirms it (1:32).

In contrast, let us look at the statement that "the mind of the Spirit is life and peace." As already observed the phrase "the mind of the Spirit" (το φρονημα τουπνευματος) is also used in the 27th verse of this chapter. This passage makes it obvious that the word "mind" (φρονημα) means the *thoughts* or *thought patterns* which belong to the Spirit. This passage also indicates that the mind of the Spirit is in perfect alignment with the mind of God. Paul specifically mentions two things which the mind of the Spirit produces, namely, life and peace. In verse 2 he says that "the law of the spirit is life in Christ Jesus" (cf. v. 10; 2 Cor. 3:6). The Holy Spirit is the one who changes forgiven sinners into *new, living creations* in Christ (John 3:5; Titus 3:5). Also, the Spirit imparts *peace* to those who are in the Body of Christ (Rom. 14:17; Gal. 5:22; Col. 3:15).

7. ***"because the mind of the flesh is enmity against God, for it is not subject to the Law of God, for neither can it be"***

Paul's thought here is that the mind of the flesh is death "because the mind of the flesh is enmity against God." The Greek conjunction translated "because" (διοτι) is derived from "δια" prefixed to "οτι" and means *because that, for the reason that,* or *since*. The reason that the mind of the flesh is death is because it is at "enmity" (εχθρα), *in a state of hostility and hatred* against God. Disobedience to God, and the subsequent enmity, is that which brought about

both spiritual and physical death to the human race (Gen. 3:3-6; Rom. 5:17). Carefully observe, the mind of the flesh is death because of a *faulty relationship with God,* i.e., because of "enmity against God" (εχθρα εις θεον), hostility toward God, and man shaking his fist in God's sight.

Paul goes on to say that man in his enmity against God is "not subject to the law of God." The Greek phrase translated "not subject to" (ουχ υποτασσεται) basically means that the mind of the flesh is *not lined up, arranged,* and *subordinated under* the law of God. Of course the phrase "the law of God" (τωνομω του θεου), since it is never used with reference to the Mosaic Law in this epistle, does not refer to that Law which was fulfilled at Calvary. On the other hand it does refer to *stipulations revealed for this dispensation of Grace*, Truth which is directed to the mind, for which reason it is also referred to as the law of the mind (7:23, 25). In First Corinthians 9:21 Paul is speaking of this same law when he says, "not being without the law of God but in the law of Christ." As we previously noted Paul has a *strong antipathy* against any effort to add the Law of Moses to this grace period of time (Phil. 3:2-9).

In this verse Paul affirms that the mind of the flesh is not subject nor arranged under the Gospel of the Grace of God (Acts 20:24). Since the mind of the flesh is an *unsaved man* this fully concurs with what he says in First Corinthians 1:18, namely, that "the word of the cross is to those perishing foolishness." The mind of the flesh, the sinner by nature, looks at God's Grace message for today as foolish and is not subject to it. Furthermore, with respect to the mind of the flesh, Paul says that "neither can it be" (ουδε γαρ δυναται) subject to the law of God, the message of God's Grace. This phrase may be rendered *neither is it possible, neither does it have the ability,* or *neither does it have the dynamic or power to be subject*. This is in full accord with First Corinthians 2:14.

8. ***"and those being in the flesh are not able to please God."***

In the preceding verse Paul said that it is *not possible* for the mind of the flesh to be subject to the law of God. In this verse he speaks of the individuals "being" (οντες), *having their being,* and *existing* in the flesh. Those who are saved have their being and existence in the Spirit, but the unsaved, those referred to here, exist entirely in the sphere of the flesh. Jesus told Nicodemus that what "has been born out of the flesh is flesh" (John 3:6). The flesh is incapable of generating anything other than flesh, i.e., it cannot produce other than its own kind. The flesh cannot, by its falsely-called good works, elevate a sinner into the spiritual dimension.

Now let us look at the *impotency* of those who are in the flesh, they "are not able to please God." The Greek phrase translated "not able" (ου δυνανται) means that they do not have the *power, strength,* and *ability* to please God. The Greek infinitive rendered "please" (αρεαι) indicates that they are not able to do anything *acceptable* to God or that would gain His favor. A person in the flesh, left to himself, is in an inescapable flesh-quagmire. There is absolutely nothing he can do in himself to cause God to react favorably toward him. As a sinner by nature he is *dead to God* and is incapable of the slightest response to God (Eph.

2:1-3; 1 Thess. 2:15). In view of the sinner's inability to please God, his total depravity, God has to take the initiative in saving him.

9. ***"But you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit, if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you. But if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, this one does not belong to Him."***

Paul's statement to the Romans, "but you are not in the flesh but in the Spirit," if it stood by itself, would suggest that he considered all those to whom he is writing as saved. The following statement, however, adds the condition "if indeed the Spirit of God dwells in you." The Greek word translated "if indeed" (ειπερ) may also be rendered *if it be so*. Generally speaking, Paul *assumes* that those who were identified with a given church were saved, hence, he addressed them as saints (1 Cor. 1:2; 2 Cor. 1:1; Eph. 1:1; Col. 1:2). This was logical, for early believers were commonly persecuted which would have discouraged feigned believers.

Granting that it was not a popular thing to assemble together with believers, that it made one a potential candidate for persecution, Paul justifiably took for granted that those in the various local assemblies were saved. On the other hand, he never unequivocally vouched or attested the salvation of any person. Since the relationship between God and a human being is a *personal matter*, in a verifiable sense known only to God and the person (1 John 5:13), Paul always left room for the *if clause* (cf. 1 Cor. 15:2; Col. 1:23).

Paul did not know, he could not see, *if indeed, if truly, if it was so* that the Spirit of God was dwelling in all of them. The *if question* here revolves around the presence of the Holy Spirit in them. If the Spirit of God was dwelling in them, they would be classified as *being in the Spirit.* If the Spirit of God was not dwelling in them, they would be classified as *being in the flesh*. The line which divides between believers and unbelievers, according to this verse, is whether the Spirit is present or absent from a person (v. 4; 1 Cor. 3:16; Gal. 5:16-24).

10. ***"And if Christ is in you, the body is dead because of sin, but the spirit is life because of righteousness."***

In this verse Paul postulates the *consequences* of Christ being in a person. First, on the one hand "the body is dead on account of sin." Second, on the other hand "the Spirit is life on account of righteousness."

Observe, this postulation is *conditional*, for it depends upon Christ being *in* the person. It is interesting to note that in the preceding verse Paul designated the indwelling One as the "Spirit" (πνευμα), the "Spirit of God" (πνευμα Θεου), and the "Spirit of Christ" (πνευμα Χριστου). In this verse he refers to the same One as "Christ" (Χριστος). When we grant the fact that the Spirit, the third person of the Godhead, dwells in a person, then it is possible to conceive of Christ indwelling a person. In John 14:17, Jesus having declared that the Spirit is *in believers*, on the basis of this truth proceeds to say, "If anyone loves me and keeps my word, also my Father loves him, and we shall come to him and make our abode with Him" (v. 23). Posit the indwelling Holy Spirit and you have the

necessary premise for the indwelling Christ.

As a result of Christ dwelling in a believer through the Spirit, Paul says that "the body is dead because of sin." The preposition translated "because of" (δια) means that *on account of, as a result of,* and *due to sin* the physical body is dead. Since sin dwells in the body, and the wages of sin is death, it logically follows that the body is dead (7:24).

On the other hand, "the spirit is life because of righteousness." The thought here is that the *human spirit is living, alive,* and *throbbing with Divine life.* The life cycle is as follows: God the Father is living, God the Son lives because of the Father, and believers live because of the Son (John 6:57). Our spirits live because of righteousness, i.e., as a result of the righteousness which is "through the faithfulness of Christ, the out-of-God righteousness based upon faith" (Phil. 3:9). While we were sinners we were spiritually dead, but now that we are righteous in Christ, the one who dwells in us via the Spirit, our spirits are engulfed in the flow of Divine life.

11. ***"But if the Spirit of the one who raised Jesus out from the dead dwells in you, the one who raised Christ out from the dead will make alive also your mortal bodies through his indwelling Spirit in you."***

Again, what Paul says in this verse depends upon the fact that the Holy Spirit is dwelling in us. He describes the Spirit as the "one who raised Jesus out from the dead." This indicates that God the Holy Spirit played an active role in the resurrection of Jesus Christ. According to John 10:17-18 God the Son was active in His own resurrection. The predominate number of references favor God the Father as the one who had the major role in the resurrection (6:4; Acts 13:30, 37; Gal. 1:1).

Granting that the Spirit dwells in us, then "the one who raised Christ out from the dead will make alive also" our mortal bodies. This clause refers to *God the Father* as the one who will make alive our mortal bodies. This speaks of our *dying, dead* bodies - God is going to make them alive through the agency of His indwelling Spirit. The implication is that this does not refer to our resurrection bodies, which are *changed* and *different* (1 Cor. 15:42-49, 51-53; Phil. 3:21). The context implies that God is going to breathe life into these mortal bodies through the Spirit and use them as *channels* through which to accomplish his will. Paul is not talking about reforming the flesh in this verse, for it is hopelessly mired down in sin (8:7), but he is emphasizing *God's provision through the Spirit to occupy and utilize* our bodies for the glory of God (6:12; 2 Cor. 4:11; 1 Cor. 6:19-20).

12. ***"Then therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh to live according to the flesh;"***

The Greek particles translated "then therefore" (αρα ουν) indicate that what Paul is about to say is a *consequence* of what he has just said. The noun "brethren" (αδελφοι) denotes a sense of personal warmth and comradeship with them. He doesn't say you are debtors, but "we are debtors" (οφειλεται), i.e., we as brethren have a *joint debt, a mutual responsibility,* and *are all obligated* not to

live according to our old man.

Behind the scene in this verse we see the *new man*, the new creation in Christ, and the old man, the one resident in the flesh. The new man in Christ is *not indebted and obligated* to the flesh, the sphere in which sin energizes (7:5, 18, 25). Instead of being obligated to the flesh, to live according to it, Paul says that we should sense our obligation to love one another (Rom. 13:8). Husbands are obligated to love their own wives (Eph. 5:28).

13. ***"For if you live according to the flesh you will die, but if by the Spirit you put to death the practices of the body, you shall live."***

In this verse Paul presents two options: (1) a life according to the flesh which results in death, and (2) living according to the Spirit which results in life. One's relationship with the Holy Spirit or nonrelationship determines his eternal destiny.

The person whose life is governed by the flesh is void of the Spirit, he does not belong to Christ, he is an unbeliever (v. 9). The link through which Satan dominates the unsaved world is the flesh (Eph. 2:3; 1 John 2:16-17). In Galatians 5:19-21 Paul gives us a brief list of the works of the flesh. Those who live in accord with the flesh thereby manifest that they are under Satan's control, and as such, will die.

On the other hand, those who by means of the Spirit "put to death the practices of the body," they shall live. The noun "Spirit" (πνευματι) is in the instrumental case, which indicates that He is the means by which the practices of the body are put to death. Observe that these "practices" (πραξεις), *actions*, and *deeds* have their origin in the flesh and are expressed through the body. The Spirit does not endeavor to reform the flesh for it is hopeless (8:7), but He attacks the expression of the flesh through the body. The Greek verb translated "put to death" (θανατουτε) means *to kill, mortify,* and *subdue* the deeds of the flesh prior to their expression via the body (cf. Gal. 5:24).

The person who is engaged in putting to death the practices of the flesh by means of the Spirit hereby manifests the fact that the *Spirit dwells in him and that he belongs to Christ.* He doesn't possess eternal life because the Spirit has been subduing the practices of his body, but this confirms the fact that he has a *genuine relationship with Jesus Christ* (Rom. 5:21; 6:23; 1 John 5:11-12). We need to be careful to distinguish between the signs that indicate one has life and the source of this life. The source is GRACE and the sign is a GODLY LIFESTYLE.

In the last half of this verse Paul finds the *key to victory* over the dilemma and defeat that he wrestled with in chapter seven. Here the Holy Spirit of God is presented as the one who is able to make us *victorious conquerors* over every vestige of sin in our lives. He Himself, in conjunction with our spirit, flays, mutilates, kills, and puts to death the evil practices and deeds seeking expression through our bodies. Truly, at this point in Paul's dialogue we can say, *Thanks be unto God who has given us the victory over sin by means of His Spirit!*

14. ***"For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are the***

sons of God."

The Greek word translated "as many as" (οσοι) conveys the thought that *everyone* or *all* who are led by the Spirit are God's sons. In the light of what Paul has said in the previous context this is an excellent summary statement. Only those who have the indwelling Spirit *belong* to Christ (v. 9). God Himself makes our mortal bodies *alive* through His indwelling Spirit (v. 11). As the Spirit puts to death the practices of our bodies, *evidence* that we are spiritually living appears (v. 13).

The Greek verb translated "led" (αγονται) is in the present tense and the passive voice. It speaks of those who are continuously being *led, guided,* and *conducted* in their Christian walk by the Spirit. It refers to those who are being guided by the Spirit in accordance with the Word of God given to the Church (1 Cor. 2:10). This verse speaks of *God's desire* for all believers, that we might continuously be submitted to the leading of His Spirit according to the Truth given to us in His Word. This is God's ideal lifestyle for His sons, it *marks us out* as being His sons, but it is *not the way we become sons*.

Let us examine more closely the clause "these are the sons of God." Paul speaks of believers as sons some ten times in his epistles. According to Ephesians 1:5 *God sovereignly*, on the basis of His Grace, places those whom He has chosen in Christ in the position of sons (cf. Gal. 4:5). As those who occupy the exalted position of being sons of God, as those who are partakers of the Divine nature, we are to put to death the evil deeds of the body (2 Peter 1:4).

15. ***"For you did not receive the spirit of bondage again unto fear, but you received the spirit of adoption, in whom we cry Abba, Father."***

The Greek noun translated "bondage" (δουλειας) is used by Paul to depict conditions under the Mosaic Law (Gal. 4:24; 5:1; Heb. 2:15). The Law of Moses operated on the principle that "the man who did it shall live by it" (Lev. 18:5; Rom. 10:5; Gal. 3:12). Those under the Law were incapable of keeping it due to the *weakness of the flesh.* Instead of the Law making men righteous it impressed upon their conscience the greatness of their sin (3:20; 7:5, 7-11). As the Law produced a sin-laden conscience in those who were in bondage under it, the obvious result was the *fear of judgment* (Heb. 2:15; 1 John 4:18).

Paul says that they did not receive the spirit and bondage of the Law, which left them in a state of fear, "but you received the spirit of adoption, in whom we cry, Abba, Father." To emphasize the contrast between the bondage and fear which existed under the Law and the new Grace sonship relation with the Father, Paul uses the *strong adversative* rendered "but" (αλλα). The Greek word translated "adoption" (υιοθεσιας) is derived from the noun "υιος" and the verb "τιθεμι" and literally means *to place* or *set in the position of sons* (Eph. 1:5; Gal. 4:5-7). The phrase the "Spirit of adoption" suggests that the Spirit is involved in bringing about this adoption into God's Family (Eph. 2:19). As a result of this adoption the sons cry out, "Abba, Father." The Aramaic noun *Abba* means *Father*. Those who are made sons doubly recognize God as their Father.

16. ***"The spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are the children of God."***

It is important to observe that even though the Greek language categorizes the word for *Spirit* in the neuter gender, it should be carried over into English in the masculine gender. The Greek word for a *child* is likewise in the neuter gender, but we recognize it as a language peculiarity and translate it into English as though is was in the masculine gender. The word Spirit should be transferred from Greek to English according to *equivalent thought content*, and not according to slavish adherence to grammatical technicalities. The Holy Spirit is a Person, as is emphasized by the phrase "the Spirit himself" (αυτο το πνευμα), and He should always be referred to by the pronouns He, Him, who, and whom.

Now let us consider the statement that the Person of the Holy Spirit "bears witness with our spirit that we are the children of God." What makes it possible for the Spirit of God to communicate with us? To answer this question we must go back to God's original purpose in creation. He created man in His own image and likeness, as one with whom He could *communicate*, that He might have *fellowship* with man and that via man He might exercise dominion over the earth (Gen. 1:26-28). Beyond the animal world God gave man an *eternal spirit* (1 Cor. 2:11-12; Gal. 6:18). God is in *spirit form*, He is the Majestic Eternal Spirit (John 4:23-24; 2 Cor. 3:17). The fact that man has been created in His image and likeness necessitates that man have a spirit like Him.

Thus we note that God the Holy Spirit has a Divinely created juncture via which He communicates with man, namely, the spirit of a man. According to this verse the Spirit "bears witness with our spirit." The Greek verb translated "bears witness with" (συμμαρτυρει) is a compound word derived from the preposition "συν" and the verb "μαρτυρεω" and literally means *to bear witness with, to testify together with,* or *to add another witness.* The thought is that as a result of having been placed in the position of sons we recognize God as our Father (v. 15), but beyond this, the Spirit adds His testimony, that *we are children of God* (1 John 3:1-2). Both our sovereign adoption and the witness of the Spirit *confirm the fact* that we are children in the family of God (9:8; 1 Cor. 4:14-15; Gal. 4:19; Eph. 5:1).

17. ***"And if children, also heirs; heirs indeed of God and joint-heirs of Christ, if indeed we suffer with that also we may be glorified with."***

An amplified translation conforming to the *thoughts* presented in this verse is as follows: "And if children, also heirs; heirs on the one hand of God, and on the other hand joint-heirs of Christ, if so be that we suffer with Him in order that also we may be glorified with Him."

Paul is not vouching that those to whom he is writing are true children of God but if indeed they are, then it follows that they are "heirs" (κληρονομοι). The Greek noun translated "heirs" (κλερονομοι) is derived from combining the words "κληρof" and "νεμομαι" and means *an heir, a possessor,* or *one who receives an allotted portion*. The fact that we are children of God gives us the privilege of inheriting what He has for us (Gal. 4:6-7). According to Titus 3:7 we have been

made heirs of *eternal life.* According to Ephesians 1:18 Paul wants believers to know "what is the *riches of the glory* of His inheritance in the saints."

Furthermore, Paul says that we are *joint-heirs of Christ*. The Greek noun translated "joint-heirs" (συγκληρονομοι) means *an heir with, a fellow-heir,* or *one who inherits-together-with*. In as much as the name of Christ is in the *genitive case*, denoting possession, we have rendered it joint-heirs *of Christ*, i.e., *who belong to Christ*. In view of what follows it may be interpreted to mean *fellow-heirs of what belongs to Christ.*

This joint-heirship appears to be contingent on our suffering with Christ. The implication is that suffering with Christ is a prerequisite to being glorified with Him. The complete thought is that we are joint-heirs of that which is Christ's if we truly suffer with Him that we might be glorified with Him. The context makes it clear that we are *joint-heirs of the glorification which belongs to Christ* (Rom. 8:30; Phil. 3:19-20; Col. 1:27; 3:4). As "heirs of God" it may be that Paul has in mind inheriting this same glorification together with Christ. On the other hand, as we have pointed out, there is also a precedent for being heirs of eternal life.

18. ***"For I consider that the sufferings of the present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory about to be revealed unto us."***

The fact that this verse continues to emphasize the greatness of the glory which is to be revealed unto us is additional evidence favoring the view that the phrase "heirs of God" also refers to our glorification. According to Philippians 3:14 this is "the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus." Glorification together with Christ is the ultimate object of all believers in this present Church age (Rom. 8:30). The Apostle John confirms the same truth, for he says, "we know that whenever he may be manifest we will be like him, for we shall see him as he is" (1 John 3:2).

As Paul looked at the sufferings which he was going through for Christ, and as he contemplated the glory which is to be revealed unto all believers, he considered his sufferings insignificant in comparison. The Greek word rendered "considered" (λογιζομαι) means that he counted, reckoned, and regarded the things he was "suffering" (παθηματα), *his afflictions,* and *his evil treatment* as not worthy to be compared with the future glory to be revealed unto him. The Greek word for "worthy" (αξια) indicates that these sufferings were *not of equal value, do not have the same weight, hence, are not worth enough* to be compared with the believer's future glory.

Again Paul emphasizes the fact that *glory* is going to be revealed unto all believers. With respect to the time when this will take place, he says that it is "about to be revealed unto us." The Greek word translated "about" (μελλουσαν) conveys the thought of being *about to happen, on the brink of coming to pass,* hence, it is commonly translated by the verbs *will* or *shall*. It certainly portrays the idea of the imminent coming of Christ, that which precedes glorification with Christ (Phil. 3:20-21; Col. 3:4). It was not revealed to Paul nor any other New Testament writers when Jesus Christ would come (cf. Matt. 24:36 regarding His kingdom coming), however, Paul believed that He could return at any time

(13:11-12; Heb. 10:25).

19. ***"For the earnest expectation of creation looks for the revealing of the sons of God."***

The Greek word translated "earnest expectation" (αποκαραδοκια) means *to watch for with the head stretched out* or *to eagerly hope and anticipate* the time when the sons of God will be revealed. This earnest expectation *belongs to creation*, i.e., the creation itself "looks for" (απεκδεχεται) *expects, anticipates,* and *waits* for the great event Paul has been speaking about. This event, the next thing to take place on the prophetic horizon, is the "revelation" (αποκαλυψιν), *uncovering, disclosing,* and *manifesting* of the sons of God. This manifestation of the sons of God is to be identified with their glorification (v. 18; 1 Peter 4:13).

20. ***"For the creation was subjected to vanity, not willingly but because of the one who subjected it, based on hope"***

As a result of the Adamic fall the creation was subjected to vanity (Gen. 3:17-19; 5:29; Eccl. 1:2). The word translated "vanity" (ματαιοτητι) has many potential meanings, but in this passage is feasibly translated *emptiness, uselessness,* and *futility*. The implication is that the curse greatly devastated that which God has originally created. We logically assume that the original earth was highly productive and free from useless and harmful weeds which rape the cursed ground (Matt. 13:24-30).

Now let us examine what was entailed in the subjection of creation to vanity. The verb translated "subjected" (υπεταγη) is in the aorist tense and passive voice, which means that at a given point in time, soon after Adam and Eve sinned, God subjected creation to a state of emptiness and futility. He did this for *Adam's sake*, i.e., as partial punishment for his rebellion (Gen. 3:17). As for creation, it did not "willingly" (εκουσα) or *voluntarily* become subjected to vanity. It had no choice in the matter, but was a victim of Adam's rebellion against the Creator.

The creation had nothing to say about its subjection, but (αλλα) was subjected by the sovereign Creator of the universe. This subjection was "based on" (εφ') or *on the basis* of hope. Originally, a man in harmony with his Maker was placed in an environment concomitant with his perfect status. Likewise, after having sinned, man was out of harmony with his maker; he was a rebel, and God provided for him an environment concomitant with his depraved nature. In as much as God gave man the *hope* of redemption from his sinful plight (Gen. 3:15; Acts 2:23), He also subjected his environment to vanity that it might have the hope of deliverance. We have two depraved entities, man and creation, reinforcing the hope of each other as they look forward to a simultaneous redemption.

21. ***"because also creation itself will be freed from the bondage of corruption unto the freedom of the glory of the children of God."***

We have already observed that those out of Adam's lineage who have

believed, who are sons and children of God, are looking forward to being glorified together with Christ (vv. 15-17). We note also that creation itself, on the basis of hope, "will be freed from the bondage of corruption unto the freedom of the glory of the children of God."

The Greek verb translated "will be freed" (ελευθεροθησεται) is in the future tense and passive voice which means that in God's appointed time in the future He will *set free, liberate,* and *unfetter* creation from the bondage of corruption to which He subjected it subsequent to Adam's sin. The phrase "the bondage of corruption" (δουλειας τες γθορας) means the *slavish, servile,* and *abject* conditions which accompany the *corruption and ruin* to which creation was subjected. This phrase affords us additional information on the sad plight of creation today as compared to its original state.

When God's due time arrives, creation will be freed "unto the freedom of the glory of the children of God." The Greek preposition rendered "unto" (εις) is most commonly used with the accusative case to express the idea of *unto the end of.* When God frees creation from the condition to which He subjected it, *the end* or *object* will be unto a state wherein the "freedom" (ελευθεριαν), *liberty*, and *unrestrictedness* of the glory of the children of God reigns. This context depicts the liberation of the creation as *belonging to the glory*, i.e., associated with the glory of the children of God. This means, as we have already affirmed, that the glorification of the sons of God and the liberation of creation *will take place simultaneously*.

22. ***"For we know that all the creation groans-with and travails-with until the present."***

Paul uses the Greek verb for "know" (οιδαμεν) which implies that he is referring to knowledge given to him rather than that gained through experience. We assume that he is speaking of knowledge which was given to him via Divine revelation (Gal. 1:12). According to this knowledge "all the creation" (παρα η κτισις), *every aspect of it, the whole,* "groans-with" (συστεναζει) and *sighs-with* as well as "travails-with" (συνωδινει) and is *in pain-with*. As used in this verse, these two compound verbs may refer to: (1) that there is groaning and travailing going on within the whole of creation itself, i.e., that this is speaking of an *imminent* groaning and travailing; (2) on the other hand, it could be referring to the whole of creation groaning and travailing *together with believers* in their imperfect prior-to-glorification state.

This process of creation groaning-with and travailing-with has continued from the time creation was cursed "until the present" (αχρι του νυν), which literally means *until the now*. We need to acknowledge that creation will be subject to vanity during the span of time from the curse (Gen. 3:17-19) to the Millennial Kingdom (Acts 3:19-21). This present age of Grace, the last age before the establishment of the Millennium, is a time when Satan is referred to as the god of this age (2 Cor. 4:4; Gal. 1:4). This is a time when the results of the Adamic Fall hang heavy upon all men *leaving them totally depraved in a cursed environment.* In the midst of misery and wars, there is hope for those who are identified with

Jesus Christ *through faith* in His substitutionary death on Calvary's Cross.

23. ***"And not only, but also ourselves, those having the first fruits of the Spirit, even we ourselves in ourselves groan, waiting for the adoption, the redemption of our body."***

Paul's emphasis in the preceding four verses has been on the condition of creation as a result of the curse. In this verse he says that not only creation is groaning as a result of the curse, but even we who have the first fruits of the Spirit groan as we wait for our adoption. What does Paul have in mind when he speaks about those who have the first fruits of the Spirit? The Greek word translated "first fruits" (απαρχην) is from "απο" and "αρχη" and literally means from the first, hence, *the first fruits, first portion, or the first thing in a chain of events.* The first thing the Holy Spirit does, His first fruit, is to *seal believers*, to guarantee their inheritance, and this is effective unto the day of redemption (Eph. 1:13-14; 2 Cor. 1:22; 5:5).

Even we who belong to Jesus Christ groan; those who are sealed by the Holy Spirit, for "we ourselves in ourselves groan." If we reflect back on what Paul had to say in the seventh chapter, as he gave us a glimpse into the struggle between his two natures, we can better understand why even believers groan. If it wasn't for the Holy Spirit we would be utterly defeated. Only by putting to death the practices of the body, by means of the Spirit, are we able to live for Christ.

This groaning, on our part, takes place while we are "waiting" (απεκδεχομενοι) to be glorified together with Christ (v. 17). This is also referred to as the *redemption of our body*, a time when it will be redeemed to conform to Christ's body (Phil. 3:20-21).

24. ***"For in hope we were saved, but hope that is being seen is not hope; for who hopes for that which he sees?"***

The concept of hope was introduced in verse 20. There Paul said that creation was subjected to vanity *on the basis of hope* (εφ' ελπιδι). The thought is that creation, in a vain state of subjection, would, on the basis of hope, be looking forward to a time when it would be freed. In the light of the grammatical construction of this verse it is most accurately translated "in hope" (τη ελπιδι), the thought being *in the sphere of hope*. Confining what is being said here to the preceding context, Paul is saying that as saved ones we are surrounded with the hope of the "glory to be revealed unto us" (v. 18).

Now let us look at the statement that in hope "we were saved" (εσωθημεν). This verb is in the aorist tense and the passive voice. The aorist tense means that we were saved at *a given point in the past.* There would have been the prevenient calling of the Holy Spirit toward salvation, but the act of salvation was *instantaneous*. The use of the passive voice indicates that "we who were saved" were *passive*. As those who were spiritually *dead* in trespasses and sins (Eph. 2:1-3) we could not make even the slightest movement toward God. According to the passive voice *an outside agent does the acting,* which in this case was God. He both instilled in us saving faith (cf. Rom. 10:17) and regenerated us by the

Holy Spirit (Titus 3:5-6). Since salvation is by Grace, totally the work of God, it follows that it is perfect and eternal.

Having briefly dealt with the verb "saved" (εσωθημεν), due to misunderstanding surrounding it, now let us observe that "hope that is being seen is not hope." We have translated the Greek participle in this statement "that is being seen" (βλεπομενη) since it more accurately brings out the passive voice meaning. Paul's point is that hope that is continually being seen, being looked at, and being observed by a person is not hope to that person. More specifically, if we see ourselves in our redeemed glorified bodies, then the hope of obtaining this position is no longer hope. If our hope depends upon seeing something which is unseen, then when the unseen is seen *the hope is obliterated* and nonexistent.

Finally, Paul raises the question, "for who hopes for that which he sees?" To get the right perspective on this verse we need to grasp the basic meaning of the Greek word for "hope" (ελπις). The best English equivalents for this verb are *to hope, to look for,* or *to expect*. By substituting these last two equivalents for the word *hope* in Paul's question, it reads, "for who looks for that which he sees?" or "for who expects that which he sees?" The insertion of these equivalents for hope make it very obvious - no one *looks for* or *expects* that which he sees. If one sees glorification with Christ as an accomplished fact, he will no longer hope or look for it. This would be contrary to the principle of the Gospel, namely, that we were *saved in the sphere of hope.*

25. ***"But if we hope for that which we do not see, through patient endurance we eagerly wait for it."***

Having established the fact that we only hope for, expect, and look for that which is not yet seen, then it follows that "through patient endurance we eagerly wait for it." The Greek word translated "patient endurance" (υπομονης) is derived from the preposition "υπο" prefixed to the verb "μενω" and it literally means *to remain under*, hence, to endure, to be steadfast, and patient. As used in the genitive case with the preposition "δια" (through) in this verse, the thought is that *through patient endurance*, a positive discipline in itself, we eagerly wait for the fulfillment of the promise in this context (vv. 17-23).

The word translated "we eagerly wait for it" (απεκδεχομεθα) is from a triple compound Greek verb. It comes from the prepositions "απο" and "εκ" prefixed to the verb "δεχομαι." The second preposition and the verb constitute a new word which literally means *to receive out of* or *from.* In actual usage it has the meaning of to look for, expect, or to wait. The first prefixed preposition, instead of altering the meaning, *intensifies the meaning* of this new verb. Paul's thought is that we are to *eagerly expect and wait* for the time when we will be glorified together with Christ (v. 17). Other passages which help us better understand the meaning of this triple compound verb are: 1 Cor. 1:7; Phil. 3:20; and Heb. 9:28.

26. ***"And likewise also the Spirit helps in our weakness; for we do not know what we should pray for, even as it is necessary, but the Spirit***

himself intercedes for us with unutterable groanings."

The adverb with which Paul opens this verse is "ωσαυτως" in the Greek, and it may be translated *likewise, in like manner,* or *in the same way.* It refers back to that which the Holy Spirit has already done for believers, such as leading (v. 14), assuring us of our relationship with God (v. 16), and acting as a guarantee of our future glorification with Christ (vv. 17, 23). In the same way the Spirit now helps us in our weakness.

The Greek verb translated "helps" (συναντιλαμβανεται) comes from the three words "συν, αντι" and "λαυβανω" and basically means *to take a place with another person,* hence, *to help, aid,* or *assist another.* Here we note that the Spirit is the one who aids us in our *lack of spiritual health*, *feebleness*, and *weakness*. The specific weakness Paul has in mind here is our *inability to know what we should pray for,* not how we should pray.

Paul says that "we do not know" (ουκ οιδαμεν), perceive, or *see with our minds* "what" (τι), *what thing* "we should pray for" (προσευξωμεθα). This verb is in the present tense and subjunctive mood and implies that we should always be in the prayer-relation-sphere with God. In other words, it is not a matter of whether or not we are to pray, but the strong suggestion is that *we should pray*. Prayer should be a normal part of our lifestyle.

Let us observe that the statement *what things we should pray* for is qualified by the phrase "even as it is necessary" (καθο δει), i.e., *binding*, and *imperative*. According to this phrase there is a proper and improper way to pray. As finite human beings limited to our own minds *we do not have the ability to mentally see and perceive what* we really need to pray for. The implication of this passage is that *what* we pray for is exceedingly important. To fail to pray for that which is proper, for that which is necessary, is probably what Paul would call "beating the air" (1 Cor. 9:26).

In view of our weakness and inability to pray as it is necessary, "the spirit himself intercedes for us with unutterable groanings." Paul's use of the strong adversative "αλλα" plus the reflexive pronoun rendered "himself" (αυτο) emphasizes the importance of the Spirit's role in our praying. He "intercedes for us" (υπερεντυγχανει), *pleads our case*, and *expresses our true needs to* the Father.

The Spirit does this with "unutterable groanings" (στεναγμοις), *unspoken groanings*, or *mute sighs*. Both in the New Testament and in the Classical Greek the Greek phrase "στεναγμοις αλαλητοις" means nothing more or less than *unutterable sighs and groans or unexpressed sighs and groans.* These non-language sighs and groans are produced by the Holy Spirit, and even by the wildest stretch of the imagination, have absolutely nothing to do with so-called speaking in tongues.

27. ***"And the one searching the hearts knows what is the mind of the Spirit, because according to God he intercedes of behalf of the saints."***

According to the context "the one searching the hearts" is God the Father. The Greek participle translated "searching" (ερραυνων) means that He is the one *seeking out, tracking down,* and *investigating* what is in the hearts. The Greek noun for "hearts" (καρδιας), as used here, has a meaning similar to the English word *minds* or reasoning faculties (cf. 10:9-10; Eph. 1:18; Heb. 4:12).

Not only does God search the rational sphere of believer's hearts, but He also knows what is "the mind of the Spirit" (το φρονημα του πνευματος). This indicates that God knows *the frame of mind, the thought patterns,* and *the thoughts* which the Spirit has as He intercedes on behalf of the saints. He knows the meaning of the unutterable groanings and unspoken sighs involved in the Spirit's interceding.

The reason God knows what is the mind of the Spirit is "because according to God he intercedes on behalf of the saints." The fact that the Holy Spirit's intercessory ministry for the saints is "according to God" (κατα Θεον), *conforming to God*, and *in keeping with God* is certainly α logical reason why God knows the mind of the Spirit. In other words, since a unified mind-set exists between God the Father and God the Holy Spirit, and because the Holy Spirit's interceding for believers conforms to the mind of God the Father, it is a foregone conclusion; God knows the mind of the Spirit.

28. ***"And we know that to those loving God all things work together unto good, to those being called according to his purpose."***

In this verse Paul is speaking of a specific group of people and describes them in two ways: (1) those loving God, and (2) those being called according to His purpose. Let us look at the events mentioned in this verse in their chronological order: first, there is *God's purpose*; second, individuals are *being called* in accordance with this purpose; and third, those who have been called *love God.*

Paul affirms that "we know" (οιδαμεν) - not on the basis of experience but through *Divine revelation* - that "all things work together unto good" for those called and loving God. Even though not specifically stated, the context makes it clear that *God is the one* who causes all things to work together unto the end of that which is good.

What does Paul mean by the statement, "those loving God"? Is he speaking about those who have a professed emotional relationship with God, which is merely an expression of the flesh? Definitely not! For Paul love expressed itself in *obedience to the Word of God* (1 Cor. 13:4-7; cf. 1 John 2:3-6). Natural men in the flesh *cannot* initiate a love relationship with God, for they are *dead* in sin to God, and if such a relationship is to be established, God must take the initiative (1 John 4:7-11). This is exactly what God did; He devised a five point "purpose" (προθεσιν), *a predetermined plan* based upon His love in accordance with which He restores sinners into fellowship with Himself (cf. 9:11; Eph. 1:11; 2 Tim. 1:9). A part of this plan involves God sovereignly calling sinners unto Himself by means of the Holy Spirit (John 6:44). In this verse Paul refers to these as "being called" ones (κλητοις), who, having been called, constitute those who love God.

Now let us examine more closely the clause translated "all things work together unto good." The Greek verb rendered "work together" (συνεργει) is derived from the preposition "συν" prefixed to the verb "εργω" and means to work with, *to work in conjunction with, or cooperate with.* Regardless of whether we interpret the Greek noun translated "all things" (παντα) as being in the nominative (making it the subject) or objective case, *God is the one producing the actions* in this clause.

To what does the Greek neuter noun rendered "all things" (παντα) refer? Is Paul using it with a general meaning to include all details in the lives of those whom He calls? This could be interpreted to mean that *everything God works* in the lives of those who love Him is unto the end of good (5:5-10). This would not necessarily exclude Satan and his cohorts from attempting to work unto the end of evil in the lives of believers (Eph. 4:27; 6:11; 1 Tim. 3:7). Regardless of whether that which comes our way is intended for good or evil, we are to be "giving thanks always for all things in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ to God even the Father" (Eph. 5:20; Col. 3:17).

In the light of the following context we believe that Paul's *primary meaning* of "all things" (παντα) *involves the five points which constitute God's purpose*. According to His purpose He chooses us as sinners and each stage works together unto good until we are ultimately glorified with Christ (Eph. 1:4; 1 Peter 1:20). God's sovereign purpose is indeed good - the making of sinners into glorified saints.

29. ***"For whom he foreknew, he also foreordained as conformed ones to the image of his Son, that he might be the firstborn among many brethren;"***

This verse begins with the Greek conjunction "orr," translated *that*, but it may equally well be rendered *because, in that,* or *since*. The thought is that God works all things together unto good for those called in accord with His purpose, *because, in that,* or *since* "whom he foreknew, he also foreordained as conformed ones to the image of his Son." The reason Paul says that God works all things together unto good in verse 28 is *because* he was about to reveal God's good redemptive purpose in verse 29. There is a single thought flowing through these two verses, the latter explaining the manner in which all things are working together.

The Greek verb translated "foreknew" (προεγνω) is in the aorist tense which means that at a given time in the past *God knew beforehand, He previously acknowledged,* and *He took prior recognition* of those He chose in Christ before the creation of the world (Eph. 1:4). The Greek pronoun for "whom" (ους) refers To certain individuals whom God *knew as His own, predetermined to be His children,* and *elected to be His family* (cf. 11:2; 1 Peter 1:20; 2 Peter 3:17).

The Greek word for "foreordained" (προωρισεν) is also in the aorist tense, and it literally means that God *set bounds, marked out,* and *limited beforehand,* hence, *predestined, predetermined,* and *foreordained* whom He foreknew "as

conformed ones to the image of his Son." This speaks of a prior-determined-act by God to conform certain individuals to the image of His Son. The word for "conformed" (συμμορφους) is a noun; it refers to those whom God sovereignly *forms with* or *forms like* the "image" (εικονος) or *likeness* of His son. The language used here excludes the humanistic concept that man is the one who conforms himself to Christ's image.

What is the ultimate object of God's sovereign purpose, that is, conforming individuals to the image of His Son? It is unto the end that Jesus Christ might be "the firstborn among many brethren." This means that He might be *the first generated one, the first of a new genus or class* of resurrected beings with glorified bodies. Christ will occupy this first born position "among many brethren," i.e., among the redeemed ones, particularly those who are members of His Body. The noun "brethren" (αδελφοις) speaks of those who are spiritually related to Christ (cf. Luke 8:21).

30. ***"and whom he foreordained, these he also called, and whom he called, these he also justified; and whom he justified, these he also glorified."***

We have already observed that the first thing in God's sovereign purpose of bringing sinners into a relationship with Himself was that He "foreknew" (προεγνω) them, i.e., *He knew them as His own beforehand.* Second, we noted that those whom He foreknew He also "foreordained" (προωρισεν). At this juncture Paul briefly deviates to explain the *position* they were foreordained unto and the *reason* - that Christ might be "the firstborn among many brethren."

Having completed this deviation, which verges on being a parenthetic thought, Paul now proceeds to the third point in God's sovereign purpose. He says that "whom he foreordained, these he also called." The Greek verb translated "called" (εκαλεσεν) means that God *summoned, ordered to come,* and *invited* certain individuals to come to Himself (vv. 9:11, 24-25; 1 Cor. 1:9; Gal. 1:6, 15-16; Eph. 4:4; Col. 3:15). This is an *effectual call*, wrought by the Holy Spirit, which assures that the one called will come. Unlike the two former aspects of God's sovereign purpose, this call is enacted in the process of history, i.e., those who are foreordained are called by the Spirit *during their lifetime* here on earth.

As God sovereignly brings sinners to Himself, the fourth step is that "whom he called, these he also justified." The Greek verb rendered "justified" (εδικαιωσεν) means that God declared them to be *right* and *just* He esteemed them as *cleared and acquitted,* and *guiltless* and holy in His sight. In order for God to be a *just God*, and at the same time justify sinners in His moral universe, the issue of sin had to be squarely faced. It is an inviolable Divine principle that the consequence of sin is death (6:23; 8:3). Before sinners could be justified, their sin had to be obliterated. This required the sacrifice of one who was perfect, the Lamb of God, to be a substitute for sinners (John 1:35-36).

According to Second Corinthians 5:21 the perfect Person of Jesus Christ was

nailed to the Cross as the sin-substitute for sinners. Paul says, speaking of Christ, that "the one not knowing sin he [God] made sin on behalf of us, in order that we might be made the righteousness of God in him." On the basis of the fact that Jesus Christ bore the death penalty for our sin, and imparted His righteousness to us, God is able to simultaneously remain just and freely justify us (3:24).

We believers who are living today are enjoying the benefits of the fourth step in God's sovereign purpose - we are righteous and justified in Christ. Even though we know the liberty of having a conscience freed from the guilt of sin (Heb. 9:14), and even though all things are presented unto us to enjoy (1 Tim. 6:17), yet we look forward to a far more wonderful state in which we will exist in the future. Speaking of what the future holds for believers, Paul declares that those whom God justified, "these he also glorified." The Greek verb translated "glorified" (εδοξασεν), as used in this context, refers to believers being *exalted together with Jesus Christ in resurrection-body form* (vv. 17-19, 23; Phil. 3:20-21; 1 Cor. 15:51-53).

All the verbs used to depict God's five-step sovereign purpose, via which He brings sinners into a relationship with Himself, are in the aorist tense. Of course, we would expect God's foreknowing and foreordaining of sinners, that which He did before the creation of the world, to be in the aorist tense. At first glance, we might expect His calling, justifying, and glorifying, that which takes place in the process of history, to be in the present tense. However, when we look at God's sovereign purpose from the *viewpoint of the past* the use of the aorist tense is most logical. Furthermore, when we recognize that the aorist tense *most dynamically* describes these five things God has done, and that *the ingressive aorist form* allows for the strong aoristic action to ingress into the present and future, then we more fully appreciate this *positive affirmation* of God's sovereign purpose. It is so *certain* that every step is looked at as though it has already taken place.

31. ***"What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who is against us?***

The Greek particle rendered "then" (ουν) takes us back to what Paul has said in the previous context. *As a consequence of* and *in view of* God's sovereign purpose on behalf of us, what shall we say? With the foregoing sequence of Divine transactions extended toward us even while we were yet sinners, manifesting the fathomless depth of God's love and mercy toward us (Eph. 2:4), our relationship with God is certainly solid, firm, and unmovable. The least we can say to these things is: Thank you Lord for foreknowing, foreordaining, calling, justifying, and for your strong affirmation that you will glorify me in a new heavenly body (2 Cor. 5:1-2).

The second question Paul raises in this verse is: "If God is for us, who is against us?" The emphasis here is not on whether or not we are genuine believers, and hence God being for us, but it is *on the conclusion.* The thought is that since God is for us, as clearly stated in the previous verses, then *who can*

prevail against us? When God sovereignly makes us His own, those against Him are against us; His enemies become our enemies (Matt. 10:22; 24:9). In view of the following context the Greek phrase translated "against us" (καθ' ημων) must be interpreted to mean that *no one is able to prevail against us,* no one can conquer us (v. 3?).

32. ***"He who did not spare his own son, but delivered him up for us all, how will he not also with him freely give us all things?"***

The Greek phrase rendered "his own son" (του ιδιου υιου) speaks of the Son who *singularly and uniquely belonged* to God the Father. The Greek word "ιδιου" (own) indicates that just as a person's mind (Rom. 14:4), body (1 Cor. 7:4), and conscience (1 Tim. 4:2) belong to him, likewise the Son is *possessed by God.* God the Father and God the Son are of the *same essence and substance* (Heb. 1:3). This implies that the Son is a *distinct part* of the Godhead (Col. 2:9). Paul's point is that God did not "spare" (εφεισατο), *draw back from, turn away from,* nor *refrain* from giving His own Son over to death.

Instead of sparing His own Son, Paul says, but He "delivered him up for us all." The compound Greek verb rendered "delivered" (παρεδωκεν) literally means that God *gave His Son over, handed Him over, delivered Him up,* or *abandoned Him* to death for us (Matt. 27:46). In contrast to sparing His Son, the strong Greek conjunction translated "but" (αλλα) emphasizes that God delivered Him "for us all" (υπερ υμων παντων), i.e., *on behalf of* or *for the sake of* us all. The thought is that God delivered up His Son on behalf of our sin, that He might assume and die for our sin, and thus clear the way for God to justify us (Matt. 26:28; 1 Cor. 15:3; Rom. 5:8).

In view of the fact that God did not spare His own Son, but delivered Him up for us, Paul says, "how will he not also with him freely give us all things?" The Greek negative "ουχι" (not) indicates that the answer to this rhetorical question is positive. Paul answers his own question - God will "freely give" (χαρισεται), *freely grace* unto us all things in Christ. There may be those who will try to accuse us, condemn us, and separate us from Christ, but because God has freely given us all things in Christ *we will prevail*.

33. ***"Who will bring an indictment against God's elect? God is the one justifying."***

Again we need to remind ourselves that what Paul is saying in this verse is in the light of what he has said in verses 28-30. Those whom God Himself has foreknown, foreordained, called, and justified are certainly not subject to being indicted. The Greek word translated "indictment" (εγκαλεσει) has the basic idea of *calling in question,* hence, *to bring a charge against,* or *to accuse*. On the basis of the fact that God is the one who has been *solely responsible* for the first four steps in our salvation, an indictment against us would be an indictment against God (1 Cor. 1:30).

In answering the question, "who will bring an indictment against God's elect?" Paul pertinently replies, "God is them one justifying." The Greek participle

rendered "justifying" (δικαιων) means that God is the one making us *just, upright,* and *vindicated*. The believer's innocence is not dependent upon himself, what he may have done, but it depends entirely on *what God has done for him*, namely, that God has declared him just, upright, and beyond reproach, hence, *unindictable*.

34. ***"Who is the one condemning? Christ Jesus is the one who has died, but rather has been raised, who is also at the right hand of God, and who also intercedes for us."***

The Greek participle translated "condemning" (κατακρινων) basically means *judging down* or *against*, hence, who is the one *giving judgment against,* or *who holds believers guilty*? Again observe, Paul does not appeal to the personal merits of believers for the reason why they are not condemned, but rather *to the death* of Jesus Christ (8:1). He says that "Christ Jesus is the one who has died." The Greek aorist participle translated "one who has died" (αποθανων) refers back to a definite point in time when Jesus Christ was condemned to die for our sins (Isa. 53:4-6; Mark 14:64). God the Father condemned our sin in Jesus' flesh when He was crucified on the Cross (v. 3; 2 Cor. 5:21). In view of this fact, no one can condemn us because He assumed our condemnation (Gal. 3:13).

Having given Jesus Christ's substitutionary death as a reason why no one can condemn God's elect, Paul adds the statement, "but rather has been raised." The adverb "μαλλον," which we have translated *rather*, may also be rendered *more, moreover,* or even *beyond this* He has been raised. The apparent thought is that in addition to the death of Christ His resurrection also precludes any condemnation of believers. According to Romans 4:25, Jesus Christ "was delivered because of our trespasses and was raised because of our justification." This makes our justification, that which frees us from condemnation, *inseparable* from both the death and resurrection of Christ (1 Cor. 15:14, 17; 2 Cor. 5:15).

Furthermore, subsequent to His resurrection, Paul says that Jesus Christ is "at the right hand of God, and who also intercedes for us." The important point to note here is what He does while sitting at the right hand of God; He *intercedes for us.* The Greek verb for "intercedes" (εντυγχανει) is derived from the preposition "εν" prefixed to the verb "τυγχανω" and literally means *to fall in with* or *to converse with.* As used in the present tense, it means that Jesus Christ *continually intercedes, pleads,* and *entreats on our behalf*. It is used of the intercessory work of the Holy Spirit in verse 27. It is also used of Jesus' intercessory ministry in Hebrews 7:25. Jesus Christ's continual conversing with God the Father *on our behalf* (υπερ ημων) *further confirms that no one can condemn us.*

35. ***"Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?"***

The truth in this verse is based on the assumption that the love of Christ is what binds believers to Christ. In 2 Corinthians 5:14 the *love of Christ constrains*

us to count ourselves dead to self and living for Christ. Ephesians 3:19 speaks of the "surpassing knowledge" love of Christ. In this passage we certainly have a strong precedent for the dynamic love of Christ (cf. 1 Tim. 1:14; 2 Tim. 1:13). According to verse 39 there is α blending of the love of God into the love of Christ; therefore, as in this verse, they may be looked at as synonymous. The love of God in Christ is the basis for God's sovereign five-step purpose (Eph. 1:4-5; 2:4-9) which secures us in Christ for eternity.

The Greek verb translated "separate" (χωρισει) conveys the idea of *who shall part, put space between,* and *break* our relationship with Christ? Having raised this question, he poses another one dependent upon it, which involves seven things which could seemingly have the potential for separating one from Christ. First, shall "tribulation" (θλιψις), *being tightly squeezed, severe pressure,* and *affliction* separate us from the love of Christ?

Second, shall "distress" (στενοχωρια), being crowded into a *narrow place, dire straits,* and *mental anguish* separate us from the love of Christ?

Third, shall "persecution" (διωψμος), *being pursued to harm*, or being violently chased, separate us from the love of Christ?

Fourth, shall "famine" (λιμος), *shortage of crops, lack of food, hunger* and *starvation* separate us from the love of Christ?

Fifth, shall "nakedness" (γυμνοτης), *the lack of proper clothing* needed to keep the body warm, separate us from the love of Christ?

Sixth, shall "peril" (κινδυνος), *danger*, and that which is *risky* and *hazardous*, separate us from the love of Christ?

Seventh, shall the "sword" (μαχαιρα), *large knife,* saber, or that which represents the power of life and death, separate us from the love of Christ?

In conclusion, none of these things negatively affected Paul's relationship to Jesus Christ as attested in verses 37-30. This is also verified by what he says in Second Corinthians (6:4-10; 11:24-29).

36. ***"Even as it has been written that,* For your sake we are being put to death all the day long, we were counted as sheep for the slaughter."**

In the previous verse Paul raised the question as to whether hardship, dangerous situations, and persecution shall separate us from the love of Christ. In this verse he calls to our attention what David said about suffering in Psalm 44:22. His purpose in citing this Psalm is to affirm that the people of God have suffered in the past, and the implication is that they will suffer in the future.

According to David the reason for suffering is "for your sake" (ενεκεν σου), i.e., it is *on account of, by reason of,* and *as a result of our relationship to God.* The use of the passive voice suggests that due to his relationship with God, David was "being put to death" (θανατουμεθα), *killed*, and *slain* during each day by the devil. Also, as he reflects on the past, he says, "we were counted" (ελογισθημεν), *accounted*, and *considered* as sheep belonging to the slaughter,

who are in the category of the slaughter. Regardless of the dispensation in which God's people may live, they all have one thing in common, they will be afflicted and persecuted (Phil. 1:29).

37. ***"But in all these things we more than conquer through the one who has loved us."***

In verse 35 Paul throws out the question, "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ?" Following this he lists seven things which some may think would have the potential to separate one from Christ. In this 37th verse he flashes back with the cry of victory - in the midst of all these things we super-conquer.

This verse opens with the strong adversative conjunction "αλλα" which is properly translated *but*. It emphasizes the contrast between the potential things which might separate in verse 35 and the overwhelming victory over all of them mentioned in this verse. The Greek word translated "we more than conquer" (υπερνικωμεν) is a *verb* which is derived from the preposition "υπερ" prefixed to the verb "νικαω." It literally means to be *super-victorious, to hyper-conquer,* and *to abundantly prevail* over everything which might come against us.

The Greek preposition "δια" used with the genitive case indicates that this super-conquering is accomplished *through the agency* of "the one who has loved us." Since the Greek participle translated "the one who has loved us" is in the aorist tense, and as such points back to Christ's act of love epitomized on Calvary, it appears that Paul primarily has in mind the conquering power resident in the Cross. Through the Cross we have been *reconciled* unto God (Eph. 2:16), we have been made *righteous* (2 Cor. 5:21), and we have peace with God (Col. 1:20). Since the Cross is the supreme manifestation of Christ's love, and since through it we have been brought into an *inseparable relationship with God*, it logically follows that none of the things mentioned in verse 35 will break this relationship.

38. ***"For I have been persuaded that neither death nor life, nor angels, nor rulers, nor things present, nor things coming, nor powers,"***

The main verb in this verse translated "I have been persuaded" (πεπεισμαι) is in the perfect tense and passive voice. This means that Paul *had been*, from a given point of time in the past, and *continued to be persuaded, convinced, and confident* that the things he mentions in this and the following verse are not able to separate us from the love of God in Christ. In view of the passive voice, it appears that the Truth revealed to Paul through the Spirit was what persuaded him of his inseparable relationship with Christ in God. In as much as God had drawn him to Himself according to His five-point sovereign purpose, he was thoroughly convinced that *God's work* was for eternity (vv. 28-30).

Now let us take a brief look at some of the things which Paul was convinced could not separate him from God's love in Christ. First, he was persuaded that "death" (θανατος), the extinction of natural life or physical death, could not separate him from the Lord. In fact, rather than separating, it prepared the way for a closer spiritual relationship (Phil. 1:23).

Second, he was persuaded that "life" (ζωη), *living* and *existing* in the physical sphere could not separate him from God. Since this noun may refer to either physical or spiritual life, and the concepts of separation and spiritual life are incompatible, Paul's thought is that no aspect of physical life can separate him from God's love.

Third, Paul was persuaded that "angels" (αγγελοι), *messengers of God, intermediary spirits* between God and men, particularly in the Old Testament, could not separate him from the love of Christ (Psa. 34:7; 91:11).

Fourth, he was persuaded that "rulers" (αρχαι), *first ones, authorities,* and *principalities* could not separate him from his fixed position in Christ. It is not that these diabolical forces existing in the heavenlies did not try to effect this separation, for they did, but through the Spirit of God he had the ability to stand against them (Eph. 6:10-20; cf. 3:10).

Fifth, Paul was persuaded that "things present" (ενεστωτα), *standing close, at hand,* and *impending* could not separate him from his God-given position in Christ. In First Corinthians 7:26 he uses this same word to describe the *present distress* at that time. In Galatians 1:4 he uses it to depict the *present evil age*. In Second Timothy 3:1 he says that in the last days *grievous times will be present*. Regardless of the satanic things promulgated in this evil age (2 Cor. 4:4), none of them could separate him from his relationship with God.

Sixth, he was persuaded that "things coming" (μελλοντα), *things about to be, things on the brink of being,* or *future things,* that they will not be able to separate him from the fulfillment of God's sovereign purpose in his life. This word is used of Christ's *future judgment* of the living and dead in Second Timothy 4:1, but since Christ was judged for him on Calvary (v. 34; John 16:8-11; Heb. 2:14), this judgment does not affect him nor is it able to separate him from what God's love has provided for him (5:9-10).

Seventh, Paul was persuaded that "powers" (δυναμεις), *those who exercise power, mighty ones,* and *strong men* will not be able to separate him from Christ. Even though this word may refer to miracle workers, here it apparently speaks of *powerful persons* (Eph. 1:21; 2 Thess. 2:9; 1 Peter 3:22) who lack the power to separate him from the love of God in Christ.

39. ***"nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord."***

This verse continues the series from the preceding verse. Eighth, Paul was persuaded that "height" (υψωμα), *a high position, that which is elevated and towers over* could not remove him from this sovereignly given relationship with Christ. This word is used only one other time in the New Testament, in Second Corinthians 10:5, where it speaks of a *high, towering, haughty* attitude that is lifted up against the knowledge of God. Satanic opposition, even in the heights of heaven, cannot separate Paul from what God has graced unto him (Eph. 3:10; 6:12).

Ninth, Paul was persuaded that "depth" (βαθος), *the opposite of height, that which is deep,* could not separate him from what God had done for him. The four other times Paul uses this word it has the idea of that which is deep, profound, and immense. There is nothing in the sphere of the depths that is profound and deep enough to separate Paul from Christ.

Tenth, Paul is persuaded that there is not "any other creature" (τις κτισις ετερα), *any other created thing*, that is able "to separate" (χωρισαι), *put space between*, and to *part* from what God's love has accomplished for believers. This tenth statement is comprehensive - there is no creature nor created thing in the universe which is able to separate, part, and draw away one who is the recipient of the love of God in Christ. The phrase "the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord" conveys the thought of the love of God which was *manifested in Christ Jesus*, particularly, in His death on Calvary's Cross. The ultimate expression of God's love is seen in the historical fact that *He gave Him up to die for us sinners* (John 3:16; Rom. 5:5-8).